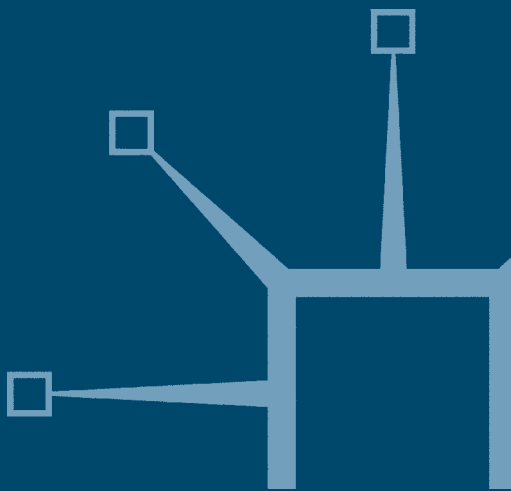
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Oswald Mosley and the New Party

Matthew Worley



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Also by Matthew Worley

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Oswald Mosley and the New Party

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Reader in History, University of Reading

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For Amelia, Rosa and Sid
Now My Heart Is Full …

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Introduction
Failures: The New Party in History

Let us begin where we end. On 1 October 1932, Sir Oswald Mosley approached his offices in Great George Street, London. He unlocked the doors, paused briefly for a photograph, and welcomed in a small band of supporters, at least some of whom were dressed in distinctive black shirts.[1] Before them, Mosley unveiled a ceremonial banner emblazoned with a silver fasces: a bundle of sticks with projecting axe blade. This, Mosley would explain in the opening pages of a book published that very same day, symbolised strength in unity and the supreme authority of the organised state.[2] It was also an emblem of Italian Fascism.[3]

The occasion for such display was the foundation of the British Union of Fascists (BUF) and the publication of its first programme, *The Greater Britain*. It also signified the moment when Mosley stepped forever beyond the political mainstream and into a world of extremes. Within a few years, as the British people prepared to do battle with fascism abroad, so Mosley would be interned under Regulation 18B and condemned to a life of ridicule and rejection. On this grey autumn day in 1932, however, Mosley asked the 32 founder members of the BUF to set out with him on a 'great and hazardous adventure', to 'sacrifice all', and to 'dedicate their lives to building [...] a movement of the modern age'.[4]

Almost exactly two years earlier, Mosley had found himself in a somewhat different situation. In Llandudno, on 7 October 1930, the young baronet stood before the Labour Party conference. He had recently resigned from James Ramsay MacDonald's Labour government, having seen his proposed solution to the economic crisis of the time rejected by cabinet. Come October, following a resignation speech regarded by many as a parliamentary *tour de force*, Mosley sought to

appeal to the wider labour movement.[5] The government had to act, Mosley insisted, pointing to the worsening unemployment afflicting Labour's heartlands by the end of 1930; it had to be realistic and practical; it had to understand that the economics of the Edwardian era were no longer viable. According to Mosley, nothing less than a policy of 'permanent national reconstruction' was needed, for which parliament would necessarily have to be reformed. The crisis, he concluded, was an opportunity for the Labour government. 'With courage, vigour, decision and a policy, they could use that situation to remodel the whole structure of the country. Let them not shrink before a great opportunity; let them not shrink in fear before it; let them seize it and use it and give the country a lead.'[6]

Those present recalled Mosley leaving the platform to thunderous applause.[7] George Catlin, who worked as a researcher for Mosley and watched the speech from the balcony, remembered it as a 'triumph', and the same conference re-elected Mosley to Labour's National Executive Committee (NEC).[8] Nevertheless, the resolution to which Mosley was committed – requesting that the NEC assess and report on the 'Mosley memorandum' first presented to the prime minister in January – was defeated by 1,251,000 votes to 1,046,000. Almost, but not quite, Mosley had rallied sufficient trade union support to challenge the prevailing policy and perspective of the Labour leadership. For a brief moment, Mosley appeared to have a significant section of the labour movement on his side; for a brief moment, he really did appear to be the 'coming man'. And then the moment passed …

Born to lose: The story of the New Party

This book is designed, in part, to help understand the transformation alluded to above. How was it that a man purportedly of the left, a former Labour government minister recognised by some as a future premier, could so seamlessly become a would-be Führer cast on the margins of what is usually perceived as the far right?[9] As we shall see, there is no easy explanation. Rather, a combination of social-political circumstance and context, intellectual reflection, personal psychology and strategic naivety conspired to lead Mosley 'beyond the pale'.[10]

But although Mosley remains a fascinating character, it is not intended to make him the sole focus of the present study.[11] After all, he did not set out on his journey alone. On 28 February 1931, he launched the New Party in the company of a handful of fellow dissident socialists drawn mainly from the Independent Labour Party (ILP) and the

Commons backbenches. Alongside Mosley and his wife Cynthia (Labour MP for Stoke-on-Trent) stood their parliamentary friends John Strachey (Aston) and Dr Robert Forgan (West Renfrewshire). They were joined, too, by Bill Allen, the Unionist MP for West Belfast, the diplomat-turned-journalist Harold Nicolson, and the Fabian philosopher Cyril Joad. In both London and Birmingham, a small coterie of friends, acquaintances and admirers rallied in response to Mosley's personal appeal. Around the New Party, moreover, flitted an array of personalities from whom Mosley sought to win commitment to his cause, among them Lord Beaverbrook, John Maynard Keynes and George Bernard Shaw. As this suggests, Mosley's desire to move beyond the amorphous but inclusive boundaries of Britain's three main political parties was not wholly unique in the context of 1930–32. Nor was his the only voice to raise itself against prevailing economic orthodoxies and the cumbersome nature of British parliamentary government. True, at the 1931 general election, the electorate rejected the New Party and Britain's political structures once more revealed their flexibility and resilience to challenge. Briefly, however, as Wall Street's crash reverberated across the world, so political certainties were at least questioned, loyalties were tested, and talk of crisis and collapse, revolution and dictatorship, reached a peak not known since the tumultuous period that accompanied the end and immediate aftermath of the Great War (1914–18).

The New Party itself emerged from within the Labour Party. Although Mosley had first been elected to parliament as a Unionist MP for Harrow in 1918, his political priorities – the League of Nations, Ireland, unemployment and, most importantly, the reconstruction of Britain in the wake of the Great War – soon led him to cross the floor in 1920 to find a more congenial home alongside the non-coalition Liberal and Labour members of the Commons. Aged just 22 on his election, Mosley cultivated a generational politics that consistently sought to transcend the party divide. In 1919, he was instrumental in the formation of a cross-party New Members' Parliamentary Committee comprising of young MPs keen to forge a 'centre party' gathered behind the prime minister, David Lloyd George. When this came to nothing, Mosley stood as an Independent candidate in 1922 and 1923, before finally joining Labour in 1924. In so doing, he claimed to have aligned himself with the 'forces of progress in their assault against the forces of reaction', an indeterminate but assertive formulation indicative of Mosley's politics.[12]

Once inside the Labour Party, Mosley moved quickly to establish his reputation as an effective platform speaker and an innovative political

thinker. Having left Harrow to contend Birmingham Ladywood at the 1924 general election, he narrowly lost to Neville Chamberlain and so took advantage of his enforced sabbatical to cultivate a political base in and around Britain's second city. He also contributed to the ILP's on-going debate as to future Labour policy, joining with Strachey in seeking to bridge the intellectual gap that separated socialism in theory from socialism in practice. To this end, the two men conspired a 'revolution by reason' that fused J. A. Hobson's liberal-socialist thesis of underconsumption with Keynes' monetary theories and Labour's implicit but undeveloped notion of economic planning. The objective was to 'weave these various aspects of modern thought into one comprehensive whole'.[13]

In Strachey, whom Fenner Brockway described as 'a tall seemingly overgrown boy, arms and legs spreading all over table and floor', Mosley found an able and willing collaborator.[14] He, too, boasted a privileged upbringing; where Mosley's landed ancestry had led him to school at Winchester and Sandhurst, so Strachey's more intellectual bent took him through Eton and Oxford. Both, however, felt the need to challenge the political mores of their families and class in the aftermath of the Great War. As it was, Strachey joined Labour in late 1923, finding his way with Mosley to Birmingham as the prospective parliamentary candidate for Aston. From thereon, and despite the fact that he would for some time be cast in the shadow of his friend's more expansive personality, Strachey's breadth of knowledge, particularly his reading of Keynes, greatly informed Mosley's political thought.[15]

As this suggests, Mosley and Strachey presented an original and relevant contribution to the Labour Party's internal debate. Concentrating far more on the control and flow of capital than the ownership of the means of production, they proposed the 'socialisation' of the banking system and the establishment of an Economic Council to direct (or plan) industrial development in the service of the community. Precedence, too, was given to the promotion of working-class purchasing power as a means of stimulating growth, creating employment and alleviating poverty. To concentrate on supply ahead of demand, they reasoned, would lead all too easily to an 'all-wise' economic dictatorship determining what people *ought* to buy.[16] As such, Mosley and Strachey redirected their socialist ire away from the industrialists ('producers') and towards the financiers ('lenders'), retaining a belief in the market but keen to ensure that it more fairly reflected the demands and needs of the people.[17]

Mosley cut an unusual figure in the Labour Party. His joining was certainly something of a *cause célèbre*; such a combination of aristo-

cratic demeanour and avowed socialism provoked the wrath of the Tories, the imaginations of Labour supporters, and stimulated the creativity of cartoonists and columnists in the press. Put bluntly, Mosley's class and lifestyle placed him a long way from the typical Labour voter, affiliate or MP.[18] Jaunts to the Riviera did not generally figure on the calendar of the average trade union official, factory worker or working-class housewife. Nevertheless, 'Tom' and 'Cimmie' became popular Labour speakers over the 1920s, and their conduct during the 1926 General Strike earned Mosley the respect of many in the Birmingham labour movement and, nationally, the Miners' Federation of Great Britain (MFGB). It was with the miners' support that he was elected to Labour's NEC in 1927, 1928 and, again, in 1930.

More generally, however, Mosley stood somewhat aloof from his Labour colleagues. True, he served as a member of the ILP National Administrative Council (NAC) and soon gathered around him a small band of admirers attracted by his energy and drive. But he remained unpopular among the bulk of the Parliamentary Labour Party (PLP) and wider labour movement leadership. Dalton loathed him; Bevin distrusted him; Attlee, meanwhile, famously described Mosley's manner as reminiscent of 'a feudal landlord abusing tenants who were in arrears with their rent'.[19] Despite the well-received speech to the Labour conference described above, Mosley's Labour associates included relatively few with either trade union or working-class credentials. Far more typical of Mosley's Labour group were men such as James ('Frank') Horrabin, Oliver Baldwin and Morgan Philips Price, young middle-to-upper class Labour MPs first elected to parliament in 1929 and sponsored by independent, constituency or ILP means. Beyond the PLP, Mosley's social circle was more likely to include young Conservatives and Liberals than it was working-class foot soldiers from the Labour heartlands. Although Anuerin Bevan admired Mosley and became a good friend to Strachey, it was with Bob Boothby, Walter Elliot and Oliver Stanley, up-and-coming Tory radicals, that the New Party founder more candidly discussed his ideas and set the world to rights into the early hours after dinner.[20]

Despite this, few doubted Mosley's ambition and potential. Over the course of the 1920s, Mosley became close to MacDonald, regularly hosting, dining and travelling with the Labour leader. In 1928, he was appointed to the sub-committee charged by the NEC to draw up the Labour Party programme (*Labour and the Nation*). Simultaneously, having returned to the Commons as the Labour member for Smethwick in 1926, Mosley further cemented his reputation as an effective parliamentary

speaker. Ultimately, however, Mosley's relationship with the Labour Party began to break down following the election of the second minority Labour government in 1929. Not only was he somewhat piqued to receive a non-cabinet position, becoming chancellor of the duchy of Lancaster with instructions to assist the lord privy seal, J. H. Thomas, in finding a solution to the worsening problem of unemployment, but he soon grew disillusioned with the cautious nature of MacDonald and, more specifically, the lassitude of the government in the wake of a deepening economic depression. Having resigned his position in May 1930, Mosley set about winning support for a radical set of policies outlined first in a memorandum and then developed in a manifesto issued at the end of 1930. In the face of Labour's apparent ambivalence, Mosley thus made the fateful decision to secede and establish the New Party in early 1931.

The New Party's stated objective was to influence government opinion and to rally support behind an innovative programme of economic and governmental reform. This built on the concepts outlined in Strachey's *Revolution by Reason* (1925), with an added emphasis on executive government, state direction and the need to 'insulate' the British economy behind select tariff barriers and empire-preference.[21] Its rationale was that the three established political parties – 'the old gang' – had proven unable to adapt to the new world forged by the Great War, thus creating the need for a modern, vibrant and youthful alternative.[22] Over time, the party programme evolved towards the construction of a corporate state and 'a movement which aims not merely at the capture of political power', but which 'grips and transforms every phase and aspect of national life to post-war purposes; a movement of order, of discipline, of loyalty, but also of dynamic progress; a movement of iron decision, resolution and reality; a movement which cuts like a sword through the knot of the past to the winning of the modern state'.[23] In other words, the New Party transformed from a temporary organisation with an immediate programme designed to avert an economic crisis into a permanent movement geared towards far more ambitious political ends. In between, it served as a political crossroads for those disillusioned or unconvinced by the political *status quo* and keen to find a radical but practical alternative.[24]

The New Party had an inglorious beginning. Rumours of its formation arguably forced Mosley's hand before proper preparations for such a venture were in place, while the expected rallying of disenchanted young radicals from across the party spectrum simply failed to occur. Having plotted a staggered series of resignations from the PLP over the last week of February 1931 and into March, only Bill Allen joined from

the non-Labour corners of the House. As disappointingly, the bulk of those committed to the so-called 'Mosley manifesto' likewise failed to take the decisive step and leave the Labour fold. As it was, only Cynthia Mosley, John Strachey, Robert Forgan, W. J. Brown and Oliver Baldwin resigned, and only Cynthia, Strachey and Forgan joined the New Party. Mosley himself was expelled from Labour on 10 March 1931.[25]

The party's problems did not end there. First, Mosley was struck down with pneumonia and pleurisy on the eve of the party's launch, meaning that he was unable to attend the inaugural meeting held on 5 March 1931 at the Memorial Hall in Farringdon, London. Second, Brown succumbed to pressure from his trade union sponsor, the Civil Service Clerical Association, thereby ensuring that the New Party was further left without its second most high-profile advocate beyond the party leader.[26] So the story goes, even a visit from a stretcher-bound Mosley was not enough to convince the unsettled Brown to forego his union loyalties.[27] As it was, Cynthia Mosley, Strachey, Forgan and Baldwin (then still a 'fellow-traveller') undertook a tour of their constituencies and a number of industrial localities in the face of mounting labour movement hostility but devoid of their party's principal focus. Finally, the New Party's launch coincided with the Westminster St. George by-election campaign, during which Lord Beaverbrook's assault on Stanley Baldwin's Conservative leadership reached its acrimonious peak. On the very day that the New Party was founded, the Tory candidate, John Moore-Brabazon, a fixture in Mosley's circle who had previously lent support to his friend's policy, resigned his candidacy.[28] But although Moore-Brabazon toyed with joining the New Party, his refusal to represent Baldwin more readily opened the way for three weeks of Tory in-fighting that all but eclipsed Mosley's more definitive gesture. Simultaneously, with Beaverbrook's attention and finance focused on his Empire Free Trade Crusade, and with his candidate's eventual defeat at the polls on 19 March doing much to dampen his spirit of political adventure, so the hopes harboured by Mosley that he may have found a way to channel the press baron's media and monetary support all but dissolved.[29]

The first real test of the New Party's potential came at the Ashton-under-Lyne by-election in April 1931. Allan Young, an erstwhile ILP member from Glasgow who served as Mosley's political secretary from the mid-1920s, was appointed as the party candidate in a Labour seat that had suffered acutely amidst the worsening economic depression. In a town based primarily on the textile industry, the spectre of

unemployment haunted Ashton by early 1931.[30] In the event, and with Mosley making a belated appearance to rally support, Young finished third, polling 4,472 votes, ostensibly enough to help defeat the Labour candidate.[31] Certainly, in the eyes of Labour supporters, the New Party had served to facilitate a Tory victory, paving the way for rowdy (and infamous) scenes at Ashton Town Hall on polling night. As insults were hurled at the New Party contingent, and as the crowd jostled amidst the furore, so Mosley purportedly remarked that '[that] is the crowd that has prevented anyone doing anything in England since the war', a comment Strachey later pinpointed as the moment when fascism was 'born' in Britain.[32]

The Ashton by-election marked the high point of the New Party's progress. From there on, neither the press nor the mainstream parties regarded the party as a serious political force. From within the party, too, political tensions began to publicly manifest themselves. Most obviously, disagreement over the future direction of the party cut across the leadership, precipitating an embarrassing split. While Mosley's commitment to cultivating a youth movement and his growing interest in the 'corporate state' led to disquiet among a section of the party, so Strachey struggled to retain at least a semblance of the party's socialist origin. The breaking point came in the summer, when Mosley rejected Strachey's draft proposal on relations with the Soviet Union. Days later, on 23 July 1931, Strachey and Young resigned, followed quickly by their friend and confident Cyril Joad, then the party's director of propaganda.

Amidst such division, the New Party appeared to turn inwards over the summer of 1931. A weekend congress was held at Mosley's Denham home in early June, and a party rally was organised at Renishaw Park in North-East Derbyshire, the ancestral estate of Osbert and Sacheverell Sitwell, both of whom complemented their rising literary profiles with support for the New Party. Come early August, and Mosley retreated to the South of France to ponder the party's future, returning to Britain only after the political crisis that he had so long predicted descended on the Labour government. As unemployment continued to rise, and as Britain's economy shuddered from the financial shockwaves emanating from the continent, so opposition pressure mounted for cuts in public spending. As a consequence, the Labour cabinet split, the government resigned, Labour returned to opposition, and MacDonald seceded from the party that he had helped found to head a national coalition government dominated by the Conservatives.[33]

As we shall see, the ramifications of the August crisis did not quite play out in the way that Mosley envisaged. Nevertheless, the party did

manage to launch its own weekly paper, *Action*, in the days immediately prior to the general election of 27 October 1931. This was edited by Harold Nicolson and was supposed to form part of an 'autumn push' by the party in preparation for the forthcoming parliamentary season.[34] Nicolson liked to see himself as a cultured man, and he brought to the New Party notable literary connections. These found their way into *Action*, nestling next to a regular call to arms from Mosley and an array of articles on economic policy, film reviews, medical advice, and the latest scientific discoveries. But despite attracting a relatively impressive roll-call of contributors, among them Christopher Isherwood, Gerald Heard, Peter Quennell and Vita Sackville-West (Nicolson's wife), the paper soon ran into difficulties. Its 32 pages were cut to just 24 after four editions, while its circulation dropped from 160,000 to 60,000 in the same period.[35] Come the final issue, its 16 pages were attracting less than 20,000 readers.[36] As such, a lack of advertising revenue combined with broader economic concerns to ensure that *Action* was wound up at the turn of the year. The paper had become too big a drain on party resources, Mosley admitted. It was better 'to keep dry the remainder of our powder for the real day of battle'.[37]

To describe the New Party's performance at the 1931 general election as poor is to underplay the severity of its mauling at the polls. Although the party issued a manifesto in early October, it was evidently ill-prepared for such a contest and suffered accordingly. The New Party stood 24 candidates, comprising three sitting MPs (Mosley in Stoke, Forgan in West Renfrewshire, and the recently recruited Major Dudgeon in Galloway), one erstwhile MP (Sir John Pratt in Hulme), and an array of party hopefuls scattered across the country.[38] Cynthia Mosley was, by this time, too ill and too emotionally ravaged by her husband's sexual philandering to stand for the party; Bill Allen had become too entangled in the complexities of Belfast's Unionist politics to find an available seat.[39] Over the course of the campaign, only the violent skirmishes that broke out in Birmingham and Glasgow brought the New Party coverage in the national press. As disarmingly, the party was largely ignored by the National candidates and those of the Labour Party. As this suggests, the New Party's moment appeared to have well and truly passed, with its candidates receiving a lowly 36,377 votes (0.2 per cent overall). Only Sellick Davies (who ran in a straight fight with the ILP in Merthyr) and Mosley polled anything resembling a respectable total; only James Stuart Barr finished higher than bottom of the poll, and that because the National Labour candidate's withdrawal from the contest came too late for his name to be removed from the

ballot paper. All in all, the 1931 general election was a disaster for the New Party. Having campaigned to become a 'ginger group' in parliament, the party found itself banished to the political wilderness.

Mosley's response to the general election result was ambiguous. Publicly, he began to talk more openly about the benefits of a corporate state and the New Party's affinity to fascism. The National government comprised a coalition of failures, he reasoned, watching as the 'old world' crumbled before their eyes.[40] Simultaneously, he considered both Labour and Conservative offers of a prospective parliamentary seat, and even hinted at his support for the national government should it adopt a sufficiently radical policy. He also continued to muse on the possibility of aligning with Winston Churchill and Lloyd George in some form of united opposition.[41] Realistically, however, Mosley had all but burnt his bridges to Westminster, convincing himself that Britain stood on the brink of economic collapse and, potentially, a bloody class war. In January 1932, he visited Italy with Nicolson and Christopher Hobhouse, meeting Mussolini and viewing from close quarters the sacrelising displays of a fully-realised fascist politics. Suitably impressed, and convinced that only fascism offered a viable and modern alternative to communism, he began to set in motion the final transformation of the New Party. The last remnants of the party apparatus were disbanded at a meeting on 5 April 1932, the party's youth organisation (Nupa) completed its evolution into a New Movement, and Mosley concentrated his mind on writing *The Greater Britain*. In the meantime, he and Forgan began to negotiate with other fascist groups in Britain, paving the way towards a rather ramshackle union and the subsequent formation of the BUF.

Such trajectory marked a tragic fall from grace. In the space of just three years, Mosley had moved from the centre of British politics to a marginal world that included both sociopaths and extremists beneath its disaffected umbrella. Where, in 1929, he had sat in the offices of Westminster with access to the prime minister, in 1932 he found himself host to Arnold Leese and Henry Hamilton Beamish, two of Britain's most vehement anti-Semites.[42] A man of conviction, Mosley was nevertheless a naïve political tactician. Having provoked and contributed to debates that would shape the future of Britain over the 1930s and beyond, his vanity and egocentricity served only to blight his ambition, leading him away from the political mainstream and towards a politics of evermore violent expression.

Placing the New Party

This basic 'story' of the New Party is relatively well known.[43] Our objective, therefore, is not simply to chart again the events that led Mosley from Labour to the BUF and Strachey from socialism to communism (and back again). Rather, it is to study a political failure that was nevertheless peculiarly resonant of its time. In so doing, we may test Michael Biddiss' assertion that 'prevalent error may be not infrequently more accurately representative of an age than ultimately more profitable ideas'.[44]

This, then, is a subterranean history, delving beneath the surface of mainstream politics to seek relevance in the cross-currents of political allegiance and social interaction. It is also a snapshot of history in transition, concentrating on ideas, concepts and opinions in the process of formation. In 1930–32, we must remember, terms and references that are now charged with very particular political connotations – such as 'fascism' and 'economic planning' – remained ill-defined. Our subjects were caught in an ideological flux, drawing from and responding to an array of influences and stimuli as they struggled to comprehend a shifting socio-political landscape wracked by economic depression. That Mosley gravitated towards fascism should not obscure the contested and relevant politics to which his New Party was originally dedicated.

Certainly, the New Party's contemporaries were unsure as to how best understand Mosley's programme and purpose in early 1931. This, after all, was a time of minor political dislocation. The traditional parliamentary balance of power had already been overturned by the Great War, with Labour eventually supplanting the fractured Liberals as the principal alternative to Conservatism. The extended franchise and the redrawing of constituency boundaries further served to unsettle established patterns of support and political custom. Although, by 1929, the two-party system appeared to have re-established itself, Labour proved able to form just two short-lived minority governments in the 1920s. If the Tories dominated British politics from 1918, then they did so in coalition for 12 of the 21 years that separated the two world wars. Between 1929 and 1932, moreover, all three main political parties were subject to internal tensions, splits and division.[45] Looked at in this way, the New Party was an acute expression of a short but notable period of political uncertainty and realignment.

As importantly, perhaps, the political concerns raised by the New Party were pertinent ones. Britain's sluggish economic performance since 1919, compounded by depression from 1929, ensured that the

fiscal orthodoxies that had guided treasury policy since the nineteenth century were open to challenge. Similarly, the political changes noted above rekindled an on-going debate as to the viability of parliamentary democracy and party politics, particularly during a period of economic instability. Into this, Mosley and the New Party injected salient and relevant contributions before a combination of events, ego and poor political choices served to discredit both.

Initially, therefore, politicians and political commentators appeared bamboozled by the New Party. They were, by turns, both intrigued and repelled by Mosley's initiative. For the *New Statesman and Nation*, the New Party represented but 'another sideshow' akin to Beaverbrook's empire crusade.[46] Nevertheless, the journal empathised with Mosley's motivation in producing his manifesto and his impatience with parliamentary procedure.[47] *The Spectator*, *Morning Post* and *Week-End Review* all doubted the viability of the New Party, yet each claimed to admire Mosley's spirit and appreciated elements of the party programme.[48] *The Economist*, meanwhile, objected to Mosley's call for greater state intervention into the economy but sympathised with his plans to reform parliament.[49] Conversely, the ILP's *New Leader* criticised the party's cross-class appeal and nascent imperialism but acknowledged Mosley's commitment to economic planning.[50] More presciently, the *Saturday Review* regarded the New Party as a 'sign of the times' and a symptom of a wider dissatisfaction with the existing parliamentary system. The validity of Mosley's policy, the review argued, was less important than its attempt to give practical expression to ideas that 'have long been gaining ground'.[51]

Quite where the New Party fitted into the political spectrum also remained a bone of contention. Ostensibly, the party claimed to have put 'questions of the ultimate goal of society' to one side; its programme was presented without 'prejudice or preconception of party'.[52] It was, Bill Allen suggested, a party of action rather than a party of theory.[53] Few were convinced by such claims, though they disagreed as to what the New Party in fact represented. Some, including many of its early members, continued to place the party within a radical, leftist tradition. So, for example, the *Manchester Guardian* described the New Party as the 'spiritual child' of the ILP, while Ellen Wilkinson later remembered the New Party as a 'rival socialist party' to Labour. For Francis Meynell, the New Party was a 'grand idea' that sought to forge 'a quicker way to true socialism'.[54] At the same time, however, the *Daily Herald* dismissed Mosley's programme as little more than a form of 'insidious propaganda' for the Tory party.[55] Talk of tariffs and

empire was enough, it seems, to convince many a Labour member that Mosley was simply revealing his true class colours. For Herbert Morrison, the New Party comprised 'swell heads not of working-class origin' replete with 'Tory blue blood running in their veins'.[56] To complete the picture, the Communist Party of Great Britain (CPGB) immediately recognised the New Party as the 'first concrete form of Fascism in embryo we have had in this country'.[57] Others, too, claimed to detect an Italian or Bavarian flavour amidst Mosley's recipe of economic nationalism and executive government.[58]

Diverse interpretation did not preclude accurate premonition, however. Nearly all those who commented on the New Party's formation in early 1931 agreed that it was doomed to failure. According to the *Daily Herald*, the party served only to reveal Mosley's lack of political judgement; both the *Week-End Review* and the *New Statesman* suggested – rightly – that its programme was too much of a mismatch to offer a viable political alternative.[59] Beatrice Webb, in typically acidic fashion, described the New Party's formation as a 'political abortion', while Hugh Dalton could only wonder at his erstwhile colleague's 'amazing folly and miscalculation and mad pride'.[60] Even Strachey was pondering as to whether they were not about to commit 'political suicide' in late 1930, before adding – in a manner that reveals much about his mood at the time – 'who knows and who cares'.[61]

As this suggests, we are looking here at an absolute political failure. The New Party never remotely threatened the basic pattern of British politics and remained largely ignored during the 1931 general election. Its support was minuscule and its achievements none. Yet, the vagaries of the New Party only add to its pertinence in the context of 1931. As the battle lines between left and right were being redrawn, as the doctrines of the pre-war age finally gave way to revised modes of political thinking, so politicians and activists manoeuvred behind their barricades. In the process, some found themselves temporarily in the wrong place at the wrong time. Some, like Strachey, even found themselves entranced by the 'attractive entrance' that led ultimately to fascism.[62] Others, meanwhile, began to consider both new arguments and radical solutions in response to a global economic crisis that led many erstwhile moderate politicians to at least conceive an end to liberal capitalism and the dawning of a new political era. In such a way, the New Party – briefly but erroneously – encapsulated the concerns and uncertainties of the early 1930s. It is for just such a reason that it deserves our attention.

1
Here are the Young Men: The New Party in Context

'The old order changeth, yielding place to new'.[1] Although the in-house journal of the New Party's London-based youth movement only existed for three editions, its strapline was well chosen. The quote, from Tennyson, ran across the top of *The New Times,* embodying the spirit of those who, just over a year earlier, had set out to challenge the perceived orthodoxies of Britain's political establishment. It also captured both the intent and the contradiction inherent within Sir Oswald Mosley's troubled initiative. On the one hand, it alluded to the New Party's objective of forging a new politics based on an increasingly radical programme of economic planning and government reform. On the other, it belied the fact that this was also a 'new movement' led by a baronet and wedded to an authoritarian doctrine fired as much by a fear of social and political change as by a commitment to it. While aspiring to a brave new world, the New Party more readily found home for those cut adrift amidst the changes affected in and around the Great War.

To understand the New Party, it is essential to place its members in their socio-cultural and political context.[2] The objective of this chapter is therefore twofold. First, to outline the ways in which the New Party founders perceived the world around them; second, to underline the extent to which their vision was informed by the social and political milieus of which they were part. The New Party was not formed in a vacuum, and Mosley was not – in 1930–31 at least – an isolated maverick wholly detached from the political mainstream or the cutting edge of political debate. As we shall see, Mosley displayed a talent for picking up on emergent moods and currents of intellectual thought. Typically, however, he tended to pursue them to a logical but ultimately unconvincing extreme, failing to recognise that the received wisdom of his own drawing room was not necessarily that of the nation as a whole.

Coups and canapés

The New Party was cut from a very refined piece of the social fabric. Sir Oswald Mosley was the sixth baronet of Ancoats, raised in the feudal surroundings of Rolleston Hall, Staffordshire. His wife, Cynthia, was the daughter of Lord Curzon, a former viceroy of India and foreign secretary (1921–24); John Strachey was the son of John St Loe Strachey, the editor of *The Spectator* from 1887 to 1925. Bill Allen, who attended Eton with Strachey, was a wealthy businessman and husband to Lady Phyllis Edith King (daughter of the third Earl of Lovelace). Harold Nicolson, meanwhile, was a former member of the British diplomatic service, a graduate of Balliol College, Oxford, and a stalwart of London's elite social circles.[3] Even Robert Forgan and Cyril Joad, though born into relatively less cosseted middle-class surroundings, had made their respective ways to Cambridge University and Balliol by the outbreak of the Great War. Of the initial New Party hierarchy, only Allan Young boasted a working-class background, though he too was deemed to have 'succumbed to his environment' once he joined Mosley's payroll in 1927.[4]

As this suggests, those who formed the New Party came primarily from a narrow and exclusive milieu, from wealthy and well-connected families ensconced within the higher echelons of British society. Theirs was a world of luncheons, clubs, parties and weekend retreats, where shoulders rubbed against those of leading politicians, landed families, preening socialites and members of an often self-appointed cultural elite. Their weddings, holidays and livelier *soirées* were featured in the newspapers; their private lives and professional careers were channelled through a complex network of old school friends, social acquaintances and exclusive institutions. A quick glimpse at Nicolson's diary sets the scene. A typical entry would see him dining with Mosley, Keynes, H. G. Wells and James Garvin (editor of *The Observer*), tripping up to Oxford alongside Harold Macmillan, meeting Wyndham Portal in the Embassy Club, or spending the weekend with Lord and Lady Astor in the company of young Conservatives such as Bob Boothby and Brendan Bracken. In amidst all this, tales of societal gossip would give way to theories as to the whys-and-wherefores of Britain's various woes; to imagined coups and reconfigured cabinets; to new movements that transcended established party boundaries.[5]

Crucially, however, British 'society' in the 1920s was both labyrinthian and shot through with fractures and fissures. Not least, the Great War had thrown up a symbolic barrier that appeared to separate the generations, providing the context for the familial tensions and 'cult of

youth' resonant of the period. For those children of the British middle-to-upper classes born in the 1890s and early 1900s, the physical experience of war combined with its political ramifications to deny them the socio-economic certainties of their parents. In response, many rebelled against the perceived orthodoxies of the Victorian and Edwardian age, seeking solace in *jouissance* and the embrace of moral and political creeds pertaining to explain the changing world around them. Most famously, perhaps, the 'bright young people' emerged as a cultural totem to describe the new generation of rich and irreverent heirs to the establishment.[6]

The New Party was very much bound to this cultural expression. Most of its principal founders were under 40 as 1930 turned to 1931, and Mosley's social circle had long overlapped with those in and around the 'bright young people'. For Martin Green, the New Party may even be best understood as an attempt to mobilise those 'types' so indicative of the time: the 'dandy-aesthetes', 'naifs' and 'rogues' emerging from the closeted world of Britain's elite public schools and Oxbridge over the 1920s. In the New Party, Green argues, it was possible to fuse the dandy's celebration of the young male hero with the radical idealism of the naif and the rebellious but visceral masculinity of the rogue.[7]

Such argument is instructive. Ultimately, Green's 'children of the sun' (*sonnenkind*) comprised too diverse a set of interests and characters – and too narrow a social constituency – to offer a viable political base. More to the point, the concept of a distinct 'war generation' is problematic, dividing between those who fought and those too young to have fought in the war, and giving rise to varied and multifaceted responses that cannot be reduced into a neat political schema.[8] That said, the New Party did attract those who fitted into Green's rather flexible paradigm, including Osbert and Sacheverell Sitwell (aesthetes), Strachey and Joad (naifs), Mosley and Randolph Churchill (rogues). It was, moreover, formed with the expressed intention of giving voice to the fears, concerns and aspirations of the so-called 'war generation'. The New Party perceived itself to be unashamedly modern and committed to the possibilities opened up by the advances of science. Equally, of course, the New Party's founders were well-attuned to the simmering generational tensions of the time. In the words of 29-year-old Bill Allen, writing in 1930, 'we have no respect for the grey hairs, grey theories, methods and traditions' of the pre-war age. 'Ours is a world of aeroplanes, wireless, talkies, speedboats, of all things new and wonderful'.[9]

Given all this, the New Party's politics would contain an incongruity comparable to that noted by John Carey with regard to the cultural and literary modernism of the early twentieth century.[10] Behind their radical veneers, both represented a reaction to those forces which threatened their exponents' privileged socio-cultural position. Both claimed to be on the side of progress and modernity whilst exhibiting a fear of the 'masses' and the levelling effect of democratisation. Both responded by reasserting principles of hierarchy, leading to a penchant for authoritarianism and a fascination with forms of dictatorship. As we shall see, there was some convergence between Mosley's circle and London's cultural aristocracy during the 1920s and early 1930s. In the meantime, it is enough to note that a sense of elitism regularly revealed itself in the New Party. If Mosley appeared to view the British working class with a mix of paternal compassion and disdain, then Nicolson was less circumspect in confessing 'how profoundly I loathe the working classes', whom he found 'suspicious, ignorant, stupid, resentful, unenlightened and unhappy'. Though he pledged to devote his energy to their 'betterment', he felt that 'the submerged classes are in fact foreigners', suggesting that 'the "British common sense and fair play" theory appears only to the educated and possessing classes'.[11] 'The people,' Nicolson and Mosley concluded, 'must be treated humanely but firmly'.[12]

For this and many other reasons, the New Party would have limited appeal to the majority of British people. To a select few, however, Mosley appeared as a visionary. To young middle and upper-middle class men such as Peter Howard, 22-years-old and captain of the England rugby team, Mosley offered an assertive and practical solution to Britain's ailments. The New Party, Howard reasoned, formed the basis of a political movement that stood for 'youth and getting on with it', so much so that his contemporaries recorded him 'sneaking out of Oxford into the Big World in search of adventure. He's gone to romp, taking [with him] a knuckle duster, the *Pro-Milone* and a nice new pair of trousers'.[13] On such initiative, and in such a socio-cultural context, was Mosley's brave new world to be built.

Twilight of the idols

On 26 January 1931, Mosley met Robert Bruce Lockhart and Harold Nicolson for lunch. They discussed politics as usual, recounting the problems blighting the mainstream parties and the bunglings of parliament. Lockhart reported on the progress of Lord Beaverbrook's empire

crusade, to which he was committed, while Nicolson pledged his allegiance to Mosley. All were convinced that the established patterns of British politics were in a process of realignment. All believed that parliament was in need of major reform. For Mosley, Nicolson recalled in his diary, 'democracy is dead [...] and so it is for me'.[14]

Mosley's disillusionment stemmed, in part, from personal experience. As a member of the Labour government elected in May 1929, he had seen his initiatives for economic reform buried beneath the fiscal orthodoxies of the treasury, the Liberal sensibilities of Philip Snowden (the Labour chancellor), and the loyal disinterest of the PLP.[15] More broadly, as the unemployment figures increased and the economy slipped further into depression, so Mosley saw a government seemingly content to drift towards an inevitable crisis. What was needed, Mosley outlined in a private memorandum of November 1930, was a government with 'the will, the capacity, and the power to govern'. Parliament had to be transformed from a 'talk shop' to a workshop; it had to be reconstructed to ensure that decision and authority triumphed over weakness and vacillation.[16]

Of course, such complaint was not the sole preserve of Mosley, and nor was it new. The onset of nineteenth-century liberalism, the rise of Labour and the suffrage campaigns prior to the 1918 Representation of the People Act had long struck fear into the more fusty corners of British society. For Sergeant A. M. Sullivan, writing in the ultra-conservative *English Review*, the parliamentary system was but 'a clumsy attempt to govern by mob emotion'. Where once men of 'genius, learning and experience' had led the country, now the 'tyranny of the party' reigned supreme.[17] The left, too, had previously complained of parliament's ability to frustrate reform and maintain the interests of the ruling class; by 1933, Sir Stafford Cripps' Socialist League would insist on the need for emergency powers to enact socialist policy in the face of capitalist resistance.[18] By 1930, however, anxiety as to the efficiency of parliament was receiving more concerted attention, paving the way for a Commons select committee to report on parliamentary procedure in 1931. Moderate journals, including the *Political Quarterly*, featured regular articles on the problems of parliamentary government in the post-war age, holding a symposium on the 'failure of political parties' in early 1932.[19] Churchill, famously, used his Romanes Lecture in Oxford to argue that the complexities of modern economics required a parallel parliament 'free altogether from party exigencies' and comprised of experts dedicated to the management of economic matters.[20] Not dissimilarly, Commons debate began to reflect on the limits of the

existing parliamentary system, while several politicians mused on the future prospects of British democracy in a changing world.[21] Even the broadsheets began to question parliament's ability to confront the growing economic crisis. Thus, on the eve of the New Party's launch, *The Observer* proposed the formation of a cross-party national government with Mosley as a potential member.[22] It would, therefore, be going too far to concur with Mosley that there was 'popular demand' for an overhaul of the parliamentary system in 1930–31, or that there was 'complete disillusionment with all the older parties'.[23] Nevertheless, there was undoubtedly widespread concern as to parliament's ability to respond to the pressures of so severe an economic depression.

As this suggests, Mosley's critique of parliamentary democracy ran deeper than his own bruised ego. His complaints and frustrations found echo among many of his political contemporaries and social acquaintances. It was with other impatient – and often young – MPs, including Walter Elliot, Bob Boothby and Leslie Hore-Belisha, that Mosley discussed the 'decay of democracy' and the need for more authoritarian government.[24] It was with fellow Labour backbenchers, such as C. J. Simmons and David Kirkwood, that Mosley and Strachey conspired to 'ginger up' a parliament that seemed more concerned with procedural etiquette than dealing with unemployment.[25] It was Harold Macmillan who predicted to Nicolson the complete breakdown of the party system as he contemplated his future in the Conservative Party.[26] It was with James Garvin, Oliver Stanley and Philip Kerr that a debate on parliament and the depression concluded that 'unless the economic situation can be dealt with on undemocratic lines, i.e. independent of votes, we shall go smash'.[27]

In the wake of such discussion, the New Party's argument for parliamentary reform drew from a range of complaints. First, many of those who found their way to Mosley recalled the expectations raised in the aftermath of the Great War. The promise of a 'land fit for heroes to live in' had suggested that a new and better world could be built on the ruins of the old. Not only had the war appeared to invalidate the politics, perspectives and values of the previous generation, but it had demonstrated the worth of a galvanised nation, of state intervention, of cross-class co-operation and common sacrifice. Thirteen years on, however, and little appeared to have changed. The same generation of 'old men' remained in power after the war as had ruled before, and they remained bound to the same out-dated doctrines. 'Is it any wonder,' Joad argued in an early New Party pamphlet, 'that the national economy is in hopeless disorder, and that English trade and industry seem

at times to be as senile as those who have allowed them to become so'.[28]

Second, the parliamentary impasse was seen to be compounded by the stringencies of party affiliation.[29] According to critics of the party system, loyalty to party ensured that political hegemony remained the preserve of the established leaderships. Dogma and principle – 'the bulwark behind which old men shelter themselves from the questioning of the young' – had ossified the party machines and thereby paralysed the parliamentary process.[30] Inside the Commons, the party whips discouraged cross-party relations, hindered constructive argument and prevented change. Not dissimilarly, Joad argued that the consolidation of political organisation encouraged a class approach to politics by which sectional interests were forever placed before the interests of the nation as a whole.[31] Mosley, of course, had already worked his way through the parties, while a number of his closest companions (Nicolson, Joad) and influences (Keynes, Shaw, Wells) perceived themselves to exist 'above' the bear pit of party politics. By 1930, as Robert Skidelsky has noted, Mosley was firmly committed to George Bernard Shaw's logic of 'dissimulation', that is the notion that ideas and actions were neither right nor wrong, but either useful or useless.[32] Put crudely, the colour of a politician's rosette was seen only to distract from the real issues.

Third, the New Party agreed with those who argued that the parliamentary apparatus was too cumbersome and out-dated for modern government, especially in a period of economic crisis. Such critics included early Mosley supporters such as W. J. Brown and John McShane (Labour MP for Walsall), who felt parliament was too 'slow, cumbersome and inefficient', as well as more acerbic political commentators such as Shaw and Wells.[33] For Joad, '[a] cabinet of Caesars, each of whom was endowed with the energy of Napoleon and the vision of Lenin, could not get through the present House of Commons one-tenth of the measures which an adequate treatment of the present crisis demands'.[34] A broader democracy, the New Party came to argue, necessitated that parliament be streamlined and drastically restructured. In other words, a government should be allowed to govern without being 'checked, harassed and interminably delayed by parliament'.[35]

This fed into a fourth concern: that the complexities of the modern age rendered MPs ill-equipped to deal with the problems confronting them. Not only were politicians inexpert with regard to many of the matters that they discussed, but the business of government was carried out by 'men with tired brains and exhausted energies, whose inspiration has been sapped and whose vision had been dulled by the multi-

tudinous routine duties of their department'.[36] To quote McShane again, 'the problems confronting citizens today are so complicated that even specialists have a difficulty in understanding them. Democracy is comprised of people who rave over Mary Pickford or a boxer, yet are asked to pronounce judgement on [...] the gold standard and big international questions'.[37] For many attracted to the New Party, politics had become little more than a 'game' in which parliament served as a medium for 'professional players divorced from reality'.[38] In response, the New Party joined with Wells, Keynes, Max Nicholson, Churchill and others in recommending the appointment of experts to initiate policy and to inform government and economic direction.[39]

As should be obvious, the New Party's critique of parliamentary democracy was infused with a generational perspective. Mosley's contempt for the 'hard-faced men' on the Commons benches was long-standing, stretching back to his earliest days in parliament.[40] For Strachey and Joad, their conclusion that democracy had reached a 'stalemate' was formed partly in response to the 'elderly trade union officials, superannuated veterans of the industrial battlefield, moderately unsuccessful businessmen, and retired colonels, generals and diplomats' that they perceived as dominating the Commons.[41] By late 1930, those gathered around Mosley regarded parliament and the existing party leaderships as relics of the past. In response, they conspired against the 'old men', colluding across the party lines to conceive of a new politics better equipped to deal with the complexities of the post-war world. Only the sons, it seemed, could amend for the sins of the fathers.

Planning for the future

For young minds keen to solve the riddles of the modern world, one thing was obvious: a new age required new economic thinking. 'The real dividing line of British politics today,' Mosley wrote in early 1931, 'lies between acceptance or rejection of the view that the old basis of British trade has gone forever, and that a new basis must be built'.[42] To this end, both Mosley and Strachey dedicated much of their time to developing a practical response to the complexities of the post-war economy. First came their 'revolution by reason', before their experience of Labour government combined with the economic depression to provoke a more radical solution.[43] Throughout, they argued that neither the Liberal 'shibboleth' of *laissez faire* nor the old Tory cry of protection offered an answer to the problems of the post-war period. Times had changed. To the question of 'free trade or tariff reform',

Mosley replied that 'we might as well be asked whether we are cross-bowmen or archers'.[44]

Several reasons were posited as to why Britain's former economic basis had 'gone forever'. Put simply, Mosley and Strachey recognised that the conditions that facilitated Britain's economic growth over the nineteenth century had been lost to the war and subsequent peace settlements. Growing competition – including 'local industrialisation' in less developed countries – had ensured that Britain could no longer retain so dominant an economic presence worldwide. Both America and Japan had impinged on British markets during the war, while France and Germany offered significant competition within Europe. Tariffs and the problem of 'dumping' interfered with price levels, meaning that the 'free play of economic circumstance' proved impossible. The onset of mechanisation, too, allowed cheap 'foreign' labour to eclipse that of the skilled British worker.[45] And while emerging 'new' industries would serve eventually to counter the pressures forced upon Britain's old staple industries of coal, iron and cotton, they were in no position to do so in the 1920s.

In response, Mosley and Strachey set about challenging the basic assumptions of established British economic policy. Rather than prioritising exports, they emphasised the need to build up the domestic market; in opposition to *laissez faire* they favoured state intervention, particularly with regard to the distribution of capital; against balanced budgets and the gold standard, they advocated public investment and a fluid exchange rate; rather than highlighting problems of production, they concentrated on problems of demand.[46] From 1930, following the Wall Street crash, Mosley introduced the notion of insulating the British economy from the 'shocks' of a faltering global capitalism, utilising selective tariffs and trade agreements across the empire to provide a captive and expanding market. Most importantly, he and Strachey further developed the concept of a planned economy wherein the state oversaw and directed industry in the national interest.[47]

Again, Mosley and Strachey did not conjure their ideas from thin air. The influence of Keynes on the New Party founders has been well documented, both in terms of their understanding the development of the post-war economy and with regard to the possibility of a managed solution.[48] Equally, of course, their ideas built on a basic – if undeveloped – premise of socialism. More generally, economic anxiety and concern as to the failure of successive governments to provide an adequate solution paved the way for a far more wide-ranging debate over the 1920s and into the 1930s. This was not party specific. Those groping towards a managed economic approach included politicians of

all political stripes, not to mention a coterie of businessmen, intellectuals, economists and journalists.[49] Consequently, the evolving concept of planning took on a variety of forms, provoking questions of purpose, application and ownership that cut across a basic desire to control the development of the national economy.

We shall look at the substance of New Party policy in Chapter 2. In the meantime, three observations are worth noting. First, as suggested above, Mosley's embrace of economic planning was innovative but not wholly original. His ideas were informed by on-going debates within and without each of the three mainstream parties. Alongside sections of the labour movement and the Liberals' inquiry into Britain's industrial future, Mosley's young Conservative friends were busy developing their own form of managed economics, while Lord Beaverbrook's empire crusade brought a new dimension to the old tariff reform debate.[50] Arguably, however, Mosley did introduce the concept of economic planning to the political mainstream in 1930, providing what Daniel Ritschel describes as a 'gateway to the rest of the planning debate of the decade'.[51]

Second, the fact that opposition to *laissez faire* was mounting across the social and political divide in 1930 gave Mosley the impetus to call for a cross-party solution to the economic crisis. As the businessmen gathered in the newly-formed National Council of Industry and Commerce (NCIC) publicly bemoaned the 'slavish adherence to economic theories which have lost all relation to the facts of modern business life', and as the TUC opened up the question of tariffs and recommended the development of tighter economic relations across the empire, so Mosley looked to find a political consensus.[52] In so doing, he proved perceptive in recognising an important ideological shift. Simultaneously, he underestimated the contentious nature of any planned alternative and the broader political loyalties that bound the parties together.

Third, while Mosley accepted the plaudits of those such as William Morris and Lord Beaverbrook who welcomed his turn to empire and a form of protection, he and his future New Party allies continued to coat their ideas in a very modern sheen. The policies that later fed into the New Party were, said Mosley, imbued with a 'scientific spirit'. He was committed to mobilising the 'best brains' of the country in order to 'bring Britain up to date'.[53] Economically, this entailed the appointment of experts to manage state policy and industrial redevelopment alongside the implementation of a 'scientific protectionism' that could be distinguished from Tory tariffs by its conditional application.

Basically, Mosley argued that tariffs should be introduced only if they benefited the country as a whole; if they benefited worker, consumer and industrialist alike; and if they enabled industry to modernise and rationalise production.[54]

Such application of science to economic policy was controversial. For Ramsay MacDonald, Mosley's proposals amounted to little more than 'old protection set to a jazz tune'.[55] Nevertheless, the notion that a national plan could be born from the cutting edge of economic theory remained important for those who formed the New Party. It complemented their perceived modernism and represented a break from the outmoded doctrines of the nineteenth century. Initially, of course, socialism had promised to provide the means by which to build a new Jerusalem. In the midst of a worsening economic depression, however, and with a Labour government lacking 'the energy to devise or the courage to apply any positive policy', new measures and new means were required.[56] Before revisiting debates as to the ultimate ownership of production, Mosley reasoned that it was first necessary to ensure that the world was made safe for theorists to wrangle in.[57] To this end, Joad explained, the New Party was formed 'not to introduce Utopia but to prevent collapse'.[58]

The new mind

The limited objective that Joad ascribed to the New Party was somewhat disingenuous. In an article published simultaneously, entitled 'Prolegomena to Fascism', he outlined certain tendencies that he felt defined Britain's 'politically-minded' youth. These comprised a loss of political faith in the democratic process in favour of concerted political action and the desire to see a strong lead given to the country. Fascism was 'in the air', Joad claimed, and its 'modern' methods were beginning to coalesce with the socialist aims of those he met at the ILP's weekend schools.[59] As this suggests, Joad perceived a shift taking place in the political culture and outlook of the younger generation. Passivity and moderation were giving way to more assertive activity; social concerns (and class-based politics) were being overtaken by national considerations. If the New Party was to be truly *new*, it would have to do more than just provide the tools to avert the immediate economic crisis.

Mosley also began to make reference to a 'new psychology' developing in the war and post-war generation at this time.[60] By late 1930, any residing commitment that Mosley felt towards socialism as defined by

the wider British labour movement had all but disappeared. In a private memorandum distributed to those he hoped were like-minded souls in November 1930, he called for a new movement based on a new ideology and a new psychology. Precise details were sketchy. On the eve of the New Party, Mosley was evidently still finding his way towards what would later become a recognisable form of fascism. Nevertheless, he called for a post-liberal movement comprised of men of action who 'live like athletes for the exacting purposes of a great age'. They were to be disciplined, imbued with a social conscience, and willing to make sacrifices for the 'national effort'. It was, Mosley insisted, to be the British variant of those movements thrown up on the continent in the wake of the Great War: Bolshevism, Fascism, the Young Turk movement and the Kuomintang.[61]

We shall examine the political implications of Mosley's vision elsewhere. First, however, we must outline some of the intellectual impulses that fed into this 'new psychology'. The notion of a post-war mind had long informed the generational outlook of the New Party's founders over the 1920s. Mosley, for example, regarded himself as one of the 'young men, the new men, the men of the war'.[62] He talked often of the difference between the pre-war and the modern age. In mid-1930, he informed readers of the *Sunday Express* that the modern mind was 'a hard, realistic type, hammered into existence on the anvil of great ordeal'. He went on:

> For this age is dynamic and the pre-war age was static. The men of the pre-war age are much 'nicer' people than we are, just as their age was much more pleasant than the present time [...] The types which have emerged from the pre-war and post-war periods are so different that they can scarcely understand each other's language when they face the economic and administrative problems of the present time.[63]

Politically, the Labour Party and, for some, the CPGB had provided a focus for young middle-to-upper class radicals keen to build a modern world on the war-strewn rubble of the old. In the immediate aftermath of the war, socialism appeared to offer a modern creed geared towards the systematic rebuilding of a nobler and better society. By 1930, however, disillusionment had set in. For all its radical promise, Labour remained tied to a gradualist conception of social change and a Liberal economic policy ill-suited to the circumstances of the age. The 'delusive simplicity of the old socialism' was yielding to a new and 'unbending force',

Jimmie Macdougall explained in 1931. The utopian dreams of a 'Labour fairyland' were being replaced with a 'knowledge of the complexity of the facts of the industrial situation'.[64]

There were cultural parallels to such perspective. Indeed, the New Party's political vision was imbued with the spirit of modernism in that it sought to bring a mutual sense of order and transcendence to the political, social, cultural and economic dislocations facilitated by the processes of modernisation.[65] Thus, on the eve of the Great War, Wyndham Lewis had blasted all around him into a self-made vortex of spleen and invective, celebrating the vitality of modernity and youth in rejection of the past. And Lewis was still firing in 1930, castigating the idiocies and vanities of his and every generation while cultivating a fascination for fascism. He was, moreover, to be one of the first to draw comparison between Hitler and Mosley. But although Lewis was close to some who joined the New Party, his worldview was far too esoteric to find solace in any movement other than his own personal crusade.[66]

More relevantly, the Sitwells spearheaded a modern movement to supersede and challenge the traditionalism of their father's generation in the wake of the Great War. They labelled their enemy the 'Golden horde', signifying the ruddy-faced men of the British upper class who had blustered their way into the death and destruction of 1914–18. That said, the Sitwells' scorn took in everything from the popular press to the priggish provincialism of the middle classes and the oafish bullies of Eton. At root, however, their 'movement' was modernist and generational in both focus and temper. Not only did it dismiss the conventions and sensibilities of the pre-war age, but it celebrated much that was avowedly modern, from film and radio to the radical subversions of the cultural *avant garde*.[67] Not surprisingly, it was to the Sitwells' circle that Green's *sonnenkind* aspired once they made their way to London in the early 1920s.

The Sitwells, of course, came from a similar stock to the Mosleys, Strachey and Nicolson. Born into a suitably gentrified and eccentric family, Osbert and Sacheverell made their way from the ancestral home to Eton, before Osbert headed for Sandhurst and 'Sachie' to Oxford.[68] Politically, both Osbert and Sachie bore temperaments that complemented the outlooks converging towards the New Party in 1930–31. They regarded themselves as progressive and committed to the building of a just society, but each doubted the efficacy and validity of democracy. They were elitist, fearful of class conflict, and both nurtured an early admiration for Mussolini.[69] As a result, the Sitwells' circle had begun to coalesce with those of Mosley and Nicolson over

the late 1920s. Sachie and his wife Georgia became regular guests at Denham; Sitwell prodigies such as Peter Quennell would later write for *Action*. In such a way, the dying embers of the 'bright young people' and the cultural assassins of the Sitwell circle formed a rather tenuous alliance with Mosley and, eventually, the New Party. Quite what influence the one had on the other is hard to say. Arguably, the Sitwells' knowledge of – and appreciation for – all things Italian may well have pushed Mosley towards *Il Duce*. Similarly, the political 'turn' notable from 1930 amongst those who had previously busied themselves with more playful, cultural and aesthetic concerns may have provided Mosley, Joad and others with evidence of their 'new psychology'. Going the other way, Mosley's relative youth and political adventurism no doubt triggered comparisons with a long-standing Sitwell favourite, Gabriele d'Annunzio. Mosley personified, more than most, the aristocratic hero so emblematic of the *sonnenkind*, while the New Party provided a fittingly modern – but simultaneously elitist – alternative to the 'old men' of Westminster.[70]

An even more direct influence on the New Party founders was wielded by George Bernard Shaw and H. G. Wells. Both men were sufficiently 'young of mind' to retain an attraction for those seeking to understand and shape the modern world, and both men formed part of a progressive milieu that fed into social circles close to the New Party. Shaw and Wells wined, dined and holidayed in the same places as the Mosleys and Nicolson, they were regularly canvassed for their opinions and support, and both seemed to exist above the realm of standard party politics. Shaw, in particular, seems to have had much sympathy for Mosley's vision, if not always his strategy.[71] Joad, whose philosophical writings bore an openly Shavian influence throughout the 1920s and 1930s, all but hero-worshipped Shaw, and he was only slightly less enamoured with Wells. On his departure from the New Party, Joad was instrumental in the founding of the Wells-inspired Federation of Progressive Societies and Individuals (FPSI) in 1932.[72] Nicolson, meanwhile, would admit in late 1931 that 'until Mr Wells joins us [the New Party], I shall retain a nasty feeling that somehow we have failed to get the whole business straight'.[73]

The influence of Wells and Shaw expressed itself in a number of ways. First, their critiques of democracy and conception of a powerful modern state informed the New Party's analysis of the parliamentary process.[74] Second, Mosley, Joad and others evidently responded to Shaw's vitalism as a means of explaining the potential for historical and social progress.[75] Third, Wells' 'open conspiracy' – that is, the

coming together of 'people of our sort' in order to 'make over the world into a great world civilization that will enable us to realize the promises and avoid the dangers of this new time'[76] – tallied with Mosley's initial conception of the New Party, as he acknowledged on sending Wells a copy of the party programme.[77] Fourth, as Strachey later explained in his *The Coming Struggle for Power* (1932), their work – along with that of Lawrence, Huxley, Nietzsche and others – clearly expressed 'the agonies of the epoch in which we live', unveiling the failings of capitalist society and the contemporaneous process of cultural decay.[78] Finally, Wells and Shaw were among the most articulate exponents of a modern world that married notions of progress with a technocratic tendency that bled into authoritarianism. Thus, Wells had already pre-empted Joad's prolegomena to fascism in 1927, writing that:

> There is an immense fund of unsatisfied seriousness in the young people of our western communities today, and not only in the young. These movements of Communism and Fascism may be mere first attempts of that unsatisfied seriousness to make a new world out of our present disorders. What is called the decay of faith and the discrediting of and fading of many old loyalties have not destroyed the serious type; they have merely let it loose for new experiments. These experiments seem to show already quite new possibilities of concentrated directive power. If once we get control of our present obsession about votes, we may discover that it is not necessary to convert a majority of the "electorate" before a new world begins.[79]

Of course, other influences soon fed into the intellectual melting pot that was the New Party. Those harbingers of fascist theory, Spengler, Bergson, Nietzsche and Sorel, would all be accredited with informing Mosley's political thought by 1932–33.[80] Arguably, however, Shaw and Wells exerted a more decisive influence on the original founders of the New Party in 1930–31, providing the basis for a suitably modern, technocratic and statist vision that tallied with Mosley's own definition of socialism as 'the conscious control and direction of human resources for human needs'; that is, a form of socio-economic organisation rather than a means for the redistribution of power and ownership.[81] As importantly, both Shaw and Wells began to look to the continent for signs of their new civilisation. In so doing, they revealed an ambivalence to the rise of fascism and dictatorship, subscribing to the view,

expressed most succinctly by Mosley's friend Walter Elliot, that 'the twentieth century state is the totalitarian state'.[82]

Into the black

In late October 1929, the United States' stock market crash reverberated across the world. In Britain, Wall Street's collapse served to compound and exacerbate an economic downturn evident from at least 1928. Unemployment rose to some 2,500,000 over the course of 1930, exports fell, share prices dwindled, credit was strangled, and government revenue contracted as the national income declined.[83] Across Europe, the post-war settlement – already unravelling – was plunged into turmoil as the treaties, loans and reparations that loosely held the peace together fell into disrepair. Most obviously, the German economy went into meltdown, precipitating the socio-economic and political crisis that paved the way for Hitler's rise to power.

For Mosley and Strachey, as for many other people, the Wall Street crash was a defining moment. Once the depth of the global depression became clear, so their understanding of just what was needed to recover and develop Britain's economic basis was changed forever. Parliament, they soon reasoned, was incapable of responding to the unfolding crisis without major reform. Its traditions, structures and procedures rendered it incapable of devising and implementing the policies necessary to avert the economic slump. The party leaders, too, Mosley concluded following the cabinet's rejection of his memorandum in May 1930, were too old or too hamstrung to act decisively. In the somnolent atmosphere of Westminster, neither the will nor the inclination existed to confront a situation that those gathered around Mosley began to see in evermore devastating terms. New men and new measures were needed. A national effort would have to be mobilised to cut across the class and political divides. A radical solution was required to answer a global question.

The international dimension of the great depression was important in shaping the New Party's eventual development. As Europe shuddered from the aftershocks of an American crash, so Mosley and his companions began to place Britain's future within a broader geographical and political context. The roots of the crisis, as Keynes had forewarned, were bound up in the post-war peace settlements.[84] To recover, Britain would need to learn from the wider continental experience and adapt to the complexities of the post-war period. Just what this entailed remained ill-defined in 1930. But as Mosley and Strachey looked out

across Europe they saw the steady disintegration of the democratic structures put in place from 1918 and a global economic depression that cut deep into the social fabric of nation after nation. If the politics of the 'old gang' appeared outmoded in Britain, then they appeared wholly crushed when viewed in a wider European context.

For Strachey, his intellectual instincts told him to look left in response to the shortcomings of Labour socialism and the inadequacies of parliamentary democracy. Like many in the labour movement, Strachey was intrigued by the Soviet experiment and broadly sympathised with its objectives. Yet, the upheavals of the Bolshevik revolution and the bloody consequences of the Russian civil war had served to prevent him embracing the 'good old cause' during the 1920s. Simultaneously, the isolation of the CPGB combined with the boorish dogmatism of many a communist party stalwart to dampen Strachey's Marxist ire. Having visited Russia in 1928 and 1930, however, and as he warmed to the CPGB's stinging critiques of the ILP and Labour Party, so Strachey began to appreciate the doctrinal certainties of communism.[85] In the meantime, he continued to align with Mosley whilst working closely with Nye Bevan and Allan Young to help shape the direction – and articulation – of the policies that eventually fed into the New Party.[86]

Mosley's inclinations were quite different. Always prone to apply an overtly patriotic tone to his socialist rhetoric, Mosley sought to recast the 'soul of England' beyond the labour movement and onto a broader constituency.[87] In so doing, he found no use for Marxism. If Soviet planning appealed in its basic premise, then Bolshevik methods offended Mosley's sense of inclusivism; the notion of class war was anathema to him. Indeed, Mosley had been far more influenced by economic developments in the United States than in the Soviet Union prior to the Wall Street crash, where he found evidence enough to suggest that high wages and private enterprise could be merged into a form of managed capitalism akin to his definition of socialism.[88] As the appeal of Labour socialism faded, therefore, so Mosley's premonition of national collapse and civil strife found a more ready audience beyond the mainstream labour movement. Similarly, as his economic programme acquired an increasingly empire-centric core, so Mosley began to attract the attention of those formerly on the opposite side of the political barricades.

But Mosley's call to arms was not simply patriotism recast. As noted above, his approach was linked to a belief that Britain needed to forge a 'modern movement' equivalent to those already established by a 'new generation of men' on the continent.[89] The parameters of such a move-

ment were initially broad. Alongside Bolshevism and Italian Fascism, Mosley and the New Party would list the Kuomintang, the Viennese social democrats, King Alexander's Yugoslavia, the Nazi movement, and 'even [...] the strange dynamics of the Ghazi Pasha [the Young Turk movement]' as examples of a modern political force committed to challenging the anachronistic systems of the pre-war age.[90] Their objective, Mosley believed, had been to force a political and psychological break from the past, cutting through 'the old men and the old systems [...] like steel through butter' on their march towards a 'victorious reality'. To this end, Mosley insisted, 'the eternal recurrencies [sic] of history' would soon 'find on these Islands the eternal analogies'.[91]

To properly understand the New Party, however, we must tread carefully. If Mosley had exhausted the political possibilities of Britain's three mainstream parties by 1931, he did not simply look to transplant a foreign variant in their place.[92] Similarly, if Mosley rejected both Marxism and social democracy, he did not thereby adopt fascism as an immediate alternative. Rather, he initially saw Italian Fascism, alongside but distinct from German National Socialism and the other movements listed above, as but a prominent example of a broader post-liberal current sweeping across Europe and beyond.[93] After all, little was really known in Britain about either Fascism or National Socialism in 1930, and what was known led mainly to blunt caricature or, less typically, vague inquisitiveness.[94] On the left, most instinctively recoiled from and condemned Fascist suppression of the labour movement, though there were some who remained intrigued by Mussolini's approach.[95] Unlike Soviet communism, which boasted a Marxist theory and articulated a clearly defined objective, fascism proved to be a far more amorphous creed. Its political and ideological basis remained elusive, its objectives vague. Where Mussolini appeared to follow his own internal logic as he manoeuvred to augment his place at the head of the Italian state, so Hitler's emergence from the margins of German politics was only just making itself manifest as Mosley planned his own modern movement.[96] Even those who had already adopted the fascist label on the fringes of British politics, primarily the British Fascists (BF) and the Imperial Fascist League (IFL), continued to disagree amongst themselves as to fascism's purpose – not to mention how best to pronounce the word, 'fash-ism or 'fac-ism' – long into the 1920s.[97]

The New Party, then, was built on the back of a protracted debate that touched on a variety of continental responses to the economic and political crises that followed in the wake of the Great War. Equally, its programme, perspective and approach drew from the broader political

experiences of its founders and the intellectual currents circulating within the social-cultural milieu of which they were part. With hindsight, we can clearly discern the party's future direction. While Strachey and others, including Cynthia Mosley, genuinely claimed to 'surrender nothing' of their 'socialist faith', Mosley's first attempt to articulate the nature of his modern movement revealed just how far he was moving towards an as yet unspecified fascist end. 'Our movement', he wrote, must call on 'sacrifice and a national effort'. It 'will not tell you what you will get, but [...] what you must do'. 'Individual liberty', Mosley continued, would be 'subject to the overriding demands of national service'; 'efficiency' would be 'instilled by the ideology and the example of a movement of national renaissance'. A 'modern democracy', Mosley insisted, would have to choose between two rights, the 'right to live' and the 'right to blather'.[98] Nevertheless, in the political flux of early 1931, the exact character and direction of the New Party remained ill-defined and open to interpretation. The old order was changing, but there remained some debate as to what the future would yield.

2
From Reform to Revolution: New Party Policy

Before there was a party there was a programme and a plan. Indeed, the roots of the New Party may be traced back to the policies outlined in a *Revolution by Reason*, or even to the 'socialistic imperialism' proffered by Mosley on his election as MP for Harrow in 1918. Therein, after all, with its deliberate echo of Chamberlain's 'social imperialism' and its nod to socialism, lay the basis for a state-directed economy committed to an improved standard of living and a greater Britain built on imperial preference.[1] Ultimately, however, it was the memorandum presented by Mosley to Ramsay MacDonald on 23 January 1930 that really set in train the events that led to the New Party's formation.[2] This had been drafted by Mosley over the turn of the decade with input from John Strachey (then Mosley's parliamentary private secretary) and Allan Young. It also drew from discussions with Thomas Johnston and George Lansbury, both of whom had been appointed – with Mosley – to assist J. H. Thomas in devising proposals to alleviate unemployment.[3] Its purpose was to offer an assertive response to the worsening economic problems of the day; to challenge the basic presumptions upon which the government's economic policy was based. To understand the New Party, we must first understand its politics. The party was formed as a vehicle to propagate a comprehensive programme of economic reform drafted in response to the deepening depression. Its evolution related to Mosley's failure to secure a pre-existing means of realising his radical plan of action.

Plan A …

The Mosley memorandum was divided into four parts. First and foremost, it proposed a new state organisation headed by the prime minister and

equipped with sufficient resources to plan and direct Britain's industrial reconstruction. This was followed by two sections detailing a number of practical long- and short-term measures, and a fourth section that essentially revisited the monetary theories contained in a *Revolution by Reason*. To this end, the memorandum recommended a planned, state-directed economic policy that prioritised the development of the home market in preference to Britain's traditional reliance on export trade. As is well known, the memorandum was put before the cabinet on 3 February 1930, only to be rejected later in May on the advice of the treasury and an appointed cabinet committee.[4] In response, Mosley resigned his government position and thereby sowed the first seeds of the New Party's gestation.

Mosley's resignation gave him both the time and the inclination to develop his ideas along what Strachey later described as 'far more ambitious lines'.[5] Free from the responsibilities of government, he continued to adapt his programme over the course of the year. Soon after his speech to parliament on 28 May 1930, in which he proposed utilising import control boards to 'insulate' the British economy from the shocks of the global economy, Mosley began to apply a far more empire-centric focus to his basic programme. In particular, the concept of 'insulation' was extended across the British commonwealth via a series of recommended trade agreements, price controls and mutual assistance.[6] As controversially, Mosley turned his attention to the efficiency of parliament, suggesting the need to facilitate a strong executive government free from obstruction and the machinations of parliamentary procedure and tradition. Thus, from July 1930, Mosley began to utter what would become a familiar refrain as to the need to transform parliament from a talk-shop into a workshop, and to envisage the relationship between the government and the Commons as equivalent to that between a board of directors and its shareholders.[7]

Such a combination of economic planning, empire preference and parliamentary reform began to alert a broader – if not necessarily larger – audience to Mosley's ideas. It was from the summer of 1930 that Lord Beaverbrook and William Morris made more direct overtures in Mosley's direction.[8] Simultaneously, Mosley began to discuss his policies in more concerted fashion with his friends in the Conservative and Liberal parties, paving the way for a co-ordinated cross-party assault on the cautious and outdated politics predominant on both sides of the Commons.[9] Within the PLP, meanwhile, Mosley retained a small but active circle of support – widely known as the 'Mosley group'

– who met regularly to discuss the detail and the best means of propagating their chosen policy. According to Hugh Massingham:

> In those days, Mosley's drawing room was an exciting place. The gay Bob Boothby flitted in and out. There was John Strachey who could be relied upon to give the talk a Marxist twist. C. E. M. Joad, a philosopher of sorts, could be discovered cowering in a corner occasionally letting out a squeak of protest whenever the necessity of violence was mentioned, as it usually was. Harold Nicolson gave a final blessing with some irrelevant remarks about the views of Talleyrand. Walter Elliot was there and so was the sad and brilliant Oliver Stanley.[10]

The results of such debate were published in December 1930. Titled 'A National Policy for a National Emergency', the Mosley manifesto was written with one eye on the Labour Party from which it came and the other on securing far wider support for Mosley's basic programme. While due reference was made to the working class and the retention of a 'socialist faith', the manifesto also made clear its appeal to 'the nation'. The 'immediate question', the manifesto insisted, was not one of 'ownership but of the survival of British industry'. To this end, it recommended the formation of an executive government headed by an 'emergency cabinet of not more than five ministers without portfolio' and invested with sufficient 'power to carry through the emergency policy'. Such a government would be subject to parliamentary recall and would exist for 'a stated period' only. Even so, the proposal was sufficient to provoke accusations of dictatorship. In terms of actual policy, the manifesto once more recommended the formation of a national economic planning organisation charged with overhauling British industry and resetting its focus towards the development of the home market. Alongside import controls and tariffs issued on condition of efficiency, domestic demand would be facilitated by 'sheltered' wages, price controls and the initiation of constructive public works to employ the unemployed. In addition, trade within the commonwealth would be co-ordinated to ensure that Britain (and the empire) was insulated against the 'wrecking forces' of the wider world.[11]

By the end of 1930, therefore, the basis for the New Party programme was in place. Come the new year, and Mosley appeared ready to sever the last remaining ties that bound him to the Labour Party and, subsequently, to any semblance of mass-based support. This would prove crucial in terms of both his immediate and long-term future. If

the labour movement proved unwilling or unable to provide the means by which to ensure the 'conscious control and direction of human resources for human needs', then new methods and new sources of support would be sought. Without the ballast of the Labour Party, Mosley was free to lose his socialism and find an alternative will to power.

… Plan B

The New Party claimed to offer a programme that fused the best elements of left- and right-wing thinking. It was, Bill Allen insisted, ready to take ideas from 'Gladstone, Marx or Joseph Chamberlain' so long as they were 'realist' and offered a potential solution to the economic crisis confronting Britain and the wider capitalist world.[12] Such eclecticism, however, would provide a clue to the party's eventual failure. The ideological tensions that cut across socialism, Liberalism, Conservatism, incipient fascism and all stages in between soon ruptured any illusory consensus occasioned by a commitment to economic planning and an agreed need for assertive government action. Rather fittingly, therefore, two very distinct programmes emerged from within the Mosley group during the months prior to the New Party's formation. Both were based on the policies summarised in the 'Mosley manifesto', but both suggested rather different political inclinations.

The first was written by Mosley with, it seems, some input from Walter Elliot, one of the sharper Conservative thorns in Stanley Baldwin's side by 1930, and from George Catlin, a sympathetic Labour intellectual whom Mosley employed as a researcher.[13] Possibly, too, the memorandum retained aspects of a document drawn up by Mosley with Oliver Stanley in September 1930, which Cuthbert Headlam remembered as being full of 'boards and public utility companies […] it really is tripe'.[14] Whatever, the 33-page memorandum was completed in November. It remained untitled and unpublished in its original form, though it quite probably served as a draft for the subsequent 'Mosley manifesto'. In the meantime, Mosley dispatched the draft programme – marked 'private and confidential' – to a number of potentially sympathetic persons beyond the Labour fold, including Lord Beaverbrook and Gerald Barry (editor of the *Week-End Review*).[15]

The second programme, entitled *A National Policy: An Account of the Emergency Programme Advanced by Sir Oswald Mosley MP*, was written at the turn of the year by four core members of Mosley's Labour group: Allan Young, John Strachey, William Brown and Aneurin Bevan. This, in turn, would become the New Party's official programme from its

launch in February 1931, despite the fact that only two of the authors actually joined with Mosley on his new political venture. In terms of format, the published pamphlet followed a soon-to-be familiar pattern, summarising first the extent and reasons for the 'crisis' confronting Britain. Part two then outlined what would become the central economic policies of the New Party (insulation and national planning), followed by a relatively short section on government reform. A list of 'immediate' measures designed to alleviate the worst of the unemployment problem was then offered, concentrating on housing schemes, agriculture, electricity, transport and reducing 'unproductive expenditure' in the form of war debts and armaments.

The basic premise of the two programmes was the same. Britain was in crisis, the changes affected by the Great War had led to Britain's relative decline, Britain's outdated political institutions only compounded the problem, and the established party leaderships offered no solution. Both proposed that the way out of the crisis was to be achieved not by cutting wages or social services but by investment and facilitating consumption 'at home'. Both insisted that the policies put forward should be seen in practical rather than ideological terms; that a common – or national – effort was required to prevent Britain's further demise. Finally, both outlined political solutions based on national planning, economic insulation and an overhaul of the government machinery.

Despite this, the two programmes contained notable differences. Most obviously, *A National Policy* struck a far less schismatic tone, seeking to combine a cross-party appeal with due respect given to the labour movement of which its authors were then still part. Thus, an emphasis was placed on the historic struggle of British labour (and its progressive forebears), accrediting the 'standard of life' built up in Britain to the 'generations of Trade Union effort, [and] the Social Services established by decades of political work'.[16] Its policy suggestions were worded in such a way as to placate its Labour readership, referring directly to workers in industry and emphasising trade union involvement in the proposed commodity boards.[17] Although the programme was deliberately inclusive – it called for a 'national effort' to avoid disaster for 'employers and workmen alike' – it bore clear evidence of the caveat included at the end of the 'Mosley manifesto' with regard to retaining a 'socialist faith'. In short, Young, Strachey, Brown and Bevan forged an 'immediate' policy programme acceptable to those outside of the Labour Party but clearly devised from within it. *A National Policy* did not obviously suggest a work of secession.

By contrast, Mosley's draft reads very much as a prelude to the formation of a new political organisation. Reference was made to a 'new psychology' and a 'contemplated movement' that 'approaches power in a period of complete disillusionment with all the older parties, their programmes, and their pledges'. This, moreover, was openly compared to the development of 'modern movements' elsewhere in Europe and beyond. Far more than *A National Policy*, Mosley's programme suggested a decisive break from the existing political norms. Its proposals for parliamentary reform came complete with tentative musings as to the relationship between a modern state and the individual. 'It will demand from the individual a sense of public service', Mosley insisted. 'A certain surrender of political liberty as now understood may be an essential corollary of such a movement and such an achievement.'[18] Indeed, Mosley would later revamp and recycle much of his 1930 text for inclusion in *The Greater Britain* (1932) and his 1933 lecture on 'The Philosophy of Fascism'. Quite evidently, Mosley was in the process of conceiving – albeit somewhat vaguely – a wholly transformed British polity.

Second, Mosley's programme ranged further than that of Young *et al*. Far greater attention was given to how the case for parliamentary reform and an insulated economy would be interpreted across the political divide, while its discussion as to the nature of the modern state and the forces of history shaping Britain's destiny revealed a prophetic undercurrent absent in *A National Policy*. Similarly, the sections dedicated to foreign policy, empire defence and India disclosed an imperial vision that extended beyond mere economic agreement. Although Mosley concurred with his companions' objective of reducing arms expenditure and pursuing a proportionate disarmament agreement with other nations, he also ruminated on a Caesarist solution to the 'Indian problem' that included methods of 'discipline and civilization' applied, if necessary, with 'ruthless severity'.[19] This, given the importance of India to British politics between the wars, would soon help drive a wedge between Mosley and those – including Strachey – who harboured more liberal (or socialist) sensibilities towards the empire. Over time, both Mosley's and the New Party's rhetoric would shift in emphasis from that of 'commonwealth' to that of 'empire'.[20]

Finally, the two programmes revealed differing priorities. Where Mosley insisted that the central theme to his programme was the need for stronger government and greater state intervention, *A National Policy* included a relatively short section on 'the machine of government' only after its broader economic plan had been outlined in far

greater detail. This, perhaps, suggests disagreement within Mosley's Labour group as to the nature, extent and viability of such reform; alternatively, it may have been a precautionary move designed not to alarm those who supported the economic policy but deemed parliamentary reform unnecessary. Whatever the reason, Mosley's draft reads far more determinedly in its call for an overhaul of government and parliamentary practice.

But what does the existence of these two very different expositions of Mosley's programme reveal about the New Party? In terms of its approach, one interpretation may be that the Mosley group and, later, the New Party sought deliberately to speak with two (or more) voices at once, recasting their politics to appeal across the socio-political divide in order to mobilise the widest possible support. Where *A National Policy* was written to woo Labour and broadly liberal backing, so Mosley's draft was directed at a more obviously Conservative milieu, including the proud imperialist to the right of the political spectrum. Similarly, if *A National Policy* was made public whilst Mosley's draft remained solely for private eyes, then the former may be understood as a moderated foretaste of the real intent concealed in the latter.

Alternatively, and more accurately, the existence of two different drafts points us towards a dichotomy that lay at the heart of the New Party project. Both programmes were written before talk of a 'new party' had progressed beyond anything other than its most rudimentary stage; the first of them had already been moderated in the form of the 'Mosley manifesto'. But where Young and his co-authors appeared to conceive their politics retaining a continuity with existing political identities, so Mosley's draft foreshadowed a wholly realigned political and ideological context. The two programmes therefore represent the beginning of an open divergence in the political and personal trajectories of Mosley and Strachey, the substance and consequences of which will be explored in due course.

In the short term, the eventual publication and higher profile accorded to *A National Policy* corresponded with a number of factors. First, the practicalities of Mosley's plan to form a 'new party of younger nationalists' remained obscure, even by November 1930. 'If I could have £250,000 and a press I should sweep the country', Mosley told Nicolson with an eye on Lord Beaverbrook's bounty. Three weeks later, and he had mentally enlisted William Morris, Keynes, Stanley, Macmillan and others to his imagined 'Nationalist Party'.[21] But all this remained, for the most part, wishful thinking. As things stood, the basis for what became the New Party continued to be concentrated in

Mosley's Labour group. Secondly, therefore, the fact that the New Party emerged from the Labour Party – with primarily erstwhile Labour support – ensured that the more circumspect language of *A National Policy* proved far more suited to the party's initial composition and stated *raison d'etre*. Thirdly, Mosley's falling ill on the eve of the New Party's launch meant that the impetus shifted towards Strachey's conception of the manifesto. Although Mosley had already set about bullying Cynthia into repudiating 'all the things he has taught her to say previously', as Nicolson confided to his diary in February 1931, Strachey continued to believe that he could 'have a hand' in shaping the direction in which Mosley's politics were heading.[22] Ultimately, however, if *A National Policy* encapsulated the outlook of the Mosley *group* in late 1930 and early 1931, then it was to be Mosley's unpublished draft that offered the more prescient glimpse of the ambitious baronet's own political future.

Planning for the future

That the New Party was a political failure there can be no doubt. Even so, a case may be made for the party's contribution towards the subsequent development of British economic policy. In particular, the 'Mosley manifesto' and *A National Policy* proved integral to the provocation and extension of the debate on economic planning that took place over the 1930s. Although Mosley typically embellished his ideas with extreme language and imagined scenarios of socio-economic collapse that eventually fed into fascism, others with whom he shared similar precepts and concerns – from Keynes to Elliot and Macmillan – went on to practice their politics in a far more moderated way. In Philip Williamson's account, reflecting Nicolson's observation of the time, the national government formed in 1931 realised 'in diluted form' key aspects of the Mosley programme.[23] Before moving onto the practical experience of the New Party, therefore, let us first be clear as to what it proposed. The following section will examine the three cornerstones of the New Party programme as it evolved over 1931–32: economic planning, parliamentary reform, and the construction of a corporate state.

National planning and national development

At the heart of the New Party's politics lay the concept of economic planning. This was conceived to offset the inequities of the free market and to enable the reconstruction of British industry in the context of a

changing and volatile global economy. The objective was to control, manage and direct the British economy, to 'insulate' it from fiscal pressures and foreign competition, and to transfer power away from the banking sector and towards the domestic producer and consumer by way of a state-sponsored apparatus equipped with recognised experts and committed to serving in the national – rather than the sectional – interest.

Not surprisingly, the means by which to execute such a plan were complex. Thus, the New Party proposed the formation of an extensive and overlapping series of boards, committees and departments functioning under the auspices of a National Planning Council (NPC). The composition of the NPC was not made clear in *A National Policy*, though Mosley's draft and other subsequent New Party documents suggested that it would be tied into the government and staffed by the 'ablest economists of the day'.[24] These, in turn, would sit alongside appointed experts from across the financial, technical, scientific and industrial field; their brief was to devise and co-ordinate an overarching national plan administrated through a National Investment Board (NIB).[25]

The NIB, therefore, represented the 'chief executive instrument' of the NPC and its remit was wide-ranging. First and foremost, it claimed responsibility for directing, facilitating and locating industry, issuing government licenses to new enterprises 'before they established works, mines or factories'. This, *A National Policy* reasoned, would prevent economic dislocation and the onset of associated problems relating to housing, social services and local government. In addition, the NIB was to be charged with managing investments, stabilising currency and prices, guaranteeing loans to industrialists for 'approved plans of capital re-equipment', supervising an Industrial Bank to provide short-term capital, and working closely with a Department of Industrial and Scientific Research to enable cutting-edge inquiry into the development of new industries and methods.[26] As this suggests, the proposed formation of the NIB encroached on the authority of the existing banking system, which the New Party deemed unfit for the task of either planning or redeveloping British industry. Although Mosley later claimed that the NIB was designed to 'supplement rather than supplant' the City's financial houses, it was clear that the New Party sought to shift responsibility for the extent, nature and focus of British investment away from the private banking sector and into the realm of the state.[27] Finally, the party reaffirmed its intention to establish an Import Control Board to correlate tariffs and to organise the bulk purchase of imported goods necessary to the country.

The point and purpose of such structural innovation informed much of the debate surrounding Mosley's statist vision. In particular, the 'tariff question' clung to the New Party throughout its brief lifespan. In reply, *A National Policy* rejected both the Labour Party's traditional antipathy to protection and the 'general tariff' associated with a section of the Conservative Party.[28] In their place, the party proposed a system of 'insulation' – later referred to as 'scientific protection'[29] – that claimed to better reflect the complexities of modern industry. As such, tariffs and investment would be offered where necessary to those industries that could guarantee efficiency and provided that agreed wage rates and price levels were met. Where tariffs were deemed inappropriate – and the New Party regularly reminded its audience that the depression had not spared those countries that had hidden behind a tariff wall, most obviously Germany and the United States – the party proposed to co-ordinate the import and export of, for example, foodstuffs and raw materials via bulk-buying or through the issuing of licenses and quotas set to secure the best deal for the British economy.

With regard to individual industries, the New Party envisaged regulation via a series of commodity boards. To ensure parity, and to prevent industrial rancour, these were to comprise worker, employer and consumer representatives, and were to be given responsibility for the management, marketing and rationalisation of their respective industry.[30] Of course, such a nod to self-regulation was compromised by the commodity boards' subordination to the NPC, reliance on the NIB, and the expectation that they would each work within the parameters of a broader national plan. More pertinently, perhaps, the composition and remit of the commodity boards raised questions of power and autonomy that served to fracture the ostensible similarities shared between advocates of economic planning.[31] It was the devil in the detail of Mosley's planned economy that served to loosen the ties that bound him to both Keynes and those young Conservatives wishing to better manage capitalism.[32]

Given the New Party's Labour origins, Mosley's vision of an insulated economic unit contained within the British Empire was a further source of contention. Such an arrangement, *A National Policy* presumed, would assure Britain of stable markets and a steady supply of foodstuffs and raw materials. But although the New Party claimed 'imperial planning' to be mutually beneficial, enabling industrialisation to occur throughout the empire in a co-ordinated manner and providing the trading countries with a regular customer in Britain, such an emphasis served to raise alarm within both Labour and Liberal internationalist circles,

supplying evidence – for those who wished to see it – of Mosley's jettisoning socialism in favour of Tory reactionism.[33] Beyond the empire, *A National Policy* suggested that similar arrangements be made with individual countries. So, for instance, export credits could be granted to Russia in return for the 'orderly import' of raw materials.[34]

Taken generally, the New Party proposed a major structural overhaul of the British economy. More immediately, however, there remained the problem of unemployment, to which *A National Policy* – along with later party statements – urged a series of short-term measures beneficial to Britain's redevelopment and to those workers condemned to the ever-lengthening dole queues. These included the raising of government loans to invest in a variety of housing, agricultural, electricity and transport schemes, as well as the alleviation of German reparations and Britain's own war debt.[35] The party also committed to maintain social services. On such a principle, the party's resident economist and Keynesian *protégé* Rupert Trouton later insisted, 'we are in agreement with the most uncompromising members of the Labour Party'.[36]

This was all heady stuff, rubbing against the grain of much established political and economic thinking. In its firm commitment to planning and the detailed provision for state intervention into the far reaches of the economy, *A National Policy* was an original and stimulating document. Nevertheless, the New Party programme simultaneously drew from a range of pre-existing ideas that criss-crossed the political spectrum. In its basic economic analysis, not to mention its proposals for an investment board and the utilisation of appointed experts, *A National Policy* shared much with the policies outlined by Keynes and other stalwarts of the Liberal summer school in *Britain's Industrial Future* (1928); its public work schemes built on those put forward in Lloyd George's *We Can Conquer Unemployment* (1929).[37] The concept of an import control board was adapted from the economic arsenal of the ILP; the possibilities of a centrally directed economic plan were undoubtedly informed by events in Stalin's Soviet Union. Equally, the idea of 'imperial planning' was to some extent an amalgam of Beaverbrook's empire crusade and the TUC's 1930 economic committee report recommending the development of closer trading relationships throughout the commonwealth. Given all this, New Party policy was contentious but contemporary; it was original in its synthesis but liable to be caught in the ideological crossfire that informed the emergent debate as to the practical politics of planning. If, as Mosley himself later claimed, the 'germ of the corporate idea' was developing in his proposals for commodity boards and the NIB, then it was also evident beyond the New

Party in the ideas of Sir Alfred Mond, Sir Arthur Salter and the 'National Plan' issued by Max Nicholson in February 1931.[38] *A National Policy* was not a proto-fascist programme in terms of its economics. Rather, it was to be in the New Party's plans for parliamentary reform that the corporate germ would transmute into the fascist virus.

In praise of Guy Fawkes

For Mosley, the message was to be clear: 'We want stronger government, not less action by the state, but more action'. Having witnessed the relationship between parliament, government and the civil service at close quarters, Mosley was convinced that the British parliamentary system served only to hamper and prevent effective leadership. What was needed, he argued, was a 'strong executive, armed with great powers and prepared ruthlessly to deploy them'.[39] To this end, the 'Mosley manifesto' called for an emergency government headed by the prime minister and a small executive committee of ministers without portfolio. Its objective would be to draw up and implement whatever policies were necessary to meet the 'needs of the present situation'.[40]

Three months later and *A National Policy* reaffirmed Mosley's vision with further detail as to just how a 'twentieth-century parliament' would be constituted.[41] Once again it recommended that the existing cabinet system be replaced by a small 'inner cabinet committee' of 'five or six men' headed by the prime minister and comprising ministers without departmental responsibility. This would be charged with devising the general policy of government; its decisions would be binding on all departmental ministers gathered in a larger but subordinate cabinet answerable to the executive. With regard to parliament, *A National Policy* proposed that the Commons retain the power of censure over the government. But although parliament would be granted the right to debate and, ultimately, reject government policy, its main function would be to facilitate rather than prevent legislation. Summing up, Young, Strachey, Brown and Bevan asked the British people to elect whatever government they liked, but to then let it get on with the job in hand without being frustrated by administrative and legislative procedure.[42]

Not surprisingly, perhaps, such a policy brought with it charges of dictatorship.[43] For the *New Statesman,* which claimed to sympathise with Mosley's impatience in the existing parliamentary system, the five-man executive was 'more than we can swallow'. '[We] know of dictators who have begun with parliaments', the paper reminded its readers with a prophetic nod to Italy; some had 'even kept them and been dictators none the less'.[44] On the right, accusations of dictator-

ship related more to state interference in the economy than the political process. Both *The Economist* and *The Spectator* raised concern over Mosley's insistence on state planning, which in turn drew unfavourable comparison with Russia and Italy.[45] Max Nicholson's plan for the *Week-End Review*, too, was partly designed as an alternative to Mosley's more statist model, and to the 'five dictators' in particular.[46] *Punch*, meanwhile, simply printed a cartoon 'Moslini' marching past a quizzical *Il Duce* perplexed as to why Mosley would want five dictators rather than one.[47]

In response, both Mosley and the New Party proved consistent: a strong executive government was not a dictatorship because an elected parliament retained the right to reject its policy and to dispose of it via a vote of censure.[48] Nevertheless, the charges were such that the party soon sought to clarify its position in an 'official statement' published in the *Political Quarterly*. This was written in a suitably defiant tone by Strachey and Joad: 'Parliament is dying,' they insisted, 'and dying discreditably.'[49] Although democracy had been perfected to the extent that governments changed in accord with the public vote, Strachey and Joad argued that it had proven 'impotent' with regard to enacting policy. The 'remedy' was to relinquish parliament of its governing function. In its place, an executive cabinet would initiate legislation by 'order in council'. Policy would then be put before parliament for a period of seven days, in which time it could be challenged or vetoed if 'not less' than 200 MPs (or a party leader representing 200 MPs) petitioned the speaker. If unopposed, the policy would become law.

In accord with such a streamlined approach, the New Party further suggested changes to the day-to-day procedures of parliament. Thus, Strachey and Joad recommended that half-an-hour of each day be set aside for questions to the prime minister; the regular questioning of ministers would be permitted, but neither 'statements' nor 'speeches' would be allowed. Parliament would retain its function of granting money to the government, but debate over the budget would be limited to a distinct number of days ('say fifteen'). The submission of private bills would be abolished, although a separate body representing local authorities and public organisations would be able to present proposals to the government, which could then issue an order in council if approved. In such a way, the New Party sought to remove parliament's right to formulate policy by limiting debate, forbidding private members' bills, and by scrapping the committee and report stages through which proposed legislation traditionally passed. Instead,

policy would be directed by government and formulated by appointed experts in agreement with the relevant government department.

As for the government itself, the New Party planned to retain the five-year statutory term of office. In the future, however, Strachey and Joad proposed that governmental authority reside in an executive cabinet of five ministers without portfolio known as the prime minister's committee. This, in turn, was to be responsible for planning a comprehensive policy based on the nation's needs. In other words, the New Party wished to separate the work of cabinet from the various government departments. The five cabinet ministers would concentrate all their efforts on national policy, meeting daily and attending parliament to answer questions on general policy and specific legislation. The prime minister would be responsible for expounding and defending the details of government policy; heads of department would meet regularly with the executive but serve more as a 'liaison body' than a decision-making committee. Even more controversially, Strachey and Joad suggested that up to two of the prime minister's committee need not be elected members of the Commons. Rather, recognised experts – scientists, technicians or industrialists – could be appointed to cabinet position. In such a way, those who did not boast the 'rather specialised qualities which commend candidates to electors' could still serve the nation's interests.[50] Finally, Strachey and Joad promised to dismiss the House of Lords 'bed and baggage' if it interfered in the government's business.

As should be clear, Mosley and his colleagues' disillusionment with existing government mechanisms led them to envisage a fundamental reform of the British political system. This was first intended to be a temporary but necessary means of dealing with a national crisis, before it coalesced into a permanent solution to the supposed inadequacies of an outdated parliament. That the proposals were flawed cannot be in doubt. The concentration of power, the by-passing of parliamentary debate, the extension of state authority and the appointment of non-elected members to government all gave substance to the accusations of dictatorship raised against the New Party. Off the record, moreover, Mosley was willing to admit that the restriction of political liberty was a necessary but worthwhile requirement on route to the 'extension of economic and personal liberty' imagined as a consequence of his political schema.[51] As the New Party founders drifted ever further from the centre of power, and as their vision of the future hardened into one of impending crisis leading to devastating collapse, so their plan to reform parliament began to transmute into a radical and distinct alternative. This, ultimately, would be known as the corporate state.

A twentieth century state

The first issue of *Action*, published on 8 October 1931, unveiled a decisive shift in New Party policy. The timing was important. Following the collapse of MacDonald's Labour government and the formation of a national coalition in August 1931, a general election was called for 27 October. According to Mosley, the electorate faced a choice between the failed remnants of a Labour Party whose supporters were turning to class warfare, and a cobbled together coalition comprising the discredited leaders of the 'old gang'. It was an 'old man's battle', Mosley insisted, a 'sham' which would serve to compound the already deepening crisis.[52] Proletarian revolution was on the horizon, and the only 'protection against such a disaster' was the construction of a 'corporate state'.[53]

Mosley's adoption of the corporate state as an alternative to the British parliamentary system all but sealed his conversion to fascism. Some equivocation remained. The corporate state did not form part of the New Party's general election manifesto; Mosley continued to explore alternative routes back to the political mainstream and to ponder different outcomes to the 'crisis'. But when he coyly admitted in late 1931 that the Italian experience may well 'repay study' as a model for his own future vision, he was clearly understating the influence that Mussolini's example had begun to exert on those in and around the New Party hierarchy.[54] If, by late 1931, the New Party considered that the 'two great modern experiments' were 'Italy and Russia', then their further constituting 'opposite realities' of what Trouton called an 'irresistible dictatorship' ensured that choices had to be made.[55] Was Britain to take the Russian path of class-based revolution, or was it to 'overcome class war by constituting a continually functioning machinery which reconciles the conflict of interests, and arbitrates and harmonises differences of class'?[56]

New Party thoughts appear to have turned towards a corporate conception of government some time during the spring of 1931, soon after the Ashton by-election. This, no doubt, was a product of the party's on-going research into the various 'modern movements' formed amidst and in the aftermath of the Great War. Initially, however, the party had little to work with. In 1931, Mussolini's own corporate state remained more concept than reality, though the 1930 formation of a National Council of Corporations began to suggest institutional substance to complement the repressive legislation of the preceding period.[57] Equally, English-language studies on the subject were relatively few. If Strachey's 1933 claim that 'no book or pamphlet which gives the reader any clear description of the corporate state' existed beyond Mosley's own *Greater*

Britain was rather contentious given that one of his relations – and a New Party member – had written extensively and favourably about Italian Fascism, then it was only slightly so.[58] In all probability, books such as Major James Strachey Barnes' *The Universal Aspects of Fascism* (1928*), Fascism* (1931) and Harold Goad's *What is Fascism?* (1929) – not to mention the growing interest shown by the *Saturday Review* in Mussolini, the translation of Tomaso Sillani's *What Is Fascism and Why?* (1931), and the steady influx of BF members into the New Party orbit – served to provide grist to the mill of Mosley's already pronounced corporate tendencies.[59] Even so, there continued to be only rudimentary detail as to just how a corporate state would function. For this reason, perhaps, it was at the New Party congress and summer school held at Denham in June 1931 that Mosley 'and others' spoke of the corporate state to a less than wholly convinced audience.[60]

Come the autumn, and the New Party position had hardened. Strachey, Young and Joad no longer remained to provide an intellectual objection to Mosley's borrowing from the Italian example; the collapse of the Labour government amidst a deepening economic crisis seemed to reaffirm Mosley's belief in the need for a radical overhaul of Britain's faltering political system. Even then, however, the New Party's public endorsement of the corporate state continued to lack precision. Rupert Trouton's essay on the 'creation of a corporate state' served primarily to restate the New Party's economic policy, offering little explanation as to the structure or function of the corporate state beyond the basic assertion that it would be 'run in such a way as to affect a balance between the various interests – the consumer, the worker, the proprietor, and the state'.[61] Mosley, too, initially appeared concerned more with the corporate state's theoretical distance from the class politics of communism than its functional mechanism. Both he and Nicolson tended towards presenting an idealised concept of what the corporate state represented rather than a detailed explanation of how it would actually work. For instance:

> The Corporate State is the conception of society working with the precision and the harmony of a human body. Every interest and every individual is subordinate to the overriding purpose of the nation, yet within the limit of that purpose the individual and the legitimate interest is free to operate, and thus to serve the community.[62]

Some clues were given. Beneath the corporate umbrella, individual enterprise and initiative were to be maintained for so long as they

functioned in the interests of the wider community. Whenever and wherever conflict occurred, a permanent part of the state machinery – based on the commodity boards of *A National Policy* – would intervene. The corporate model would thereby bind trade unions, employers and financiers into the state apparatus and commit them to the national, rather than the sectional, interest.[63] At the same time, the corporate state's remit was described as being 'not to conduct industry' but to provide the 'conditions within which industry can operate successfully'.[64] Generally, however, the New Party appeared preoccupied with the *principle* of the corporate state, with its sense of purpose, sacrifice and discipline. It was to be a state in which 'the bungler and the sluggard must go to the wall'; it would require 'the maximum direction from above' and 'the maximum self-sacrifice below'; it would replace political liberty (meaning parliamentary democracy) with economic and social liberty (broadly defined as the right to leisure and freedom from material want).[65]

There remained, too, some ambiguity as to exactly how a corporate government would be formed in the New Party literature of 1931. Although the party suggested that an 'occupational franchise must be considered', it took the absorption of key members of the BF – not least E. G. Mandeville Roe – to provide greater detail as to the structure and remit of the corporate state, culminating in the policy unveiled by Mosley in *The Great Britain* late in 1932.[66] In the meantime, Mosley's attention returned to the organisation of his evolving movement. If the corporate state was to be the twentieth-century state, then new men with new minds were required to 'raise the standard of youth' and so build the movement of the 'modern age'.[67]

3
Visions of the Near Future: New Party Ideology

Notions of modernity were integral to the New Party's self-perception. From the outset, it combined the expediency of *A National Policy* with a projection of youthful vitality and a 'scientific spirit' that suggested something more than the limited objective outlined by the party on its formation.[1] Quite what this was remained open to question. For some time, the New Party appeared uncertain as to its ideological and practical remit. While it claimed to be a vehicle to propagate an emergency policy designed to meet the needs of the immediate situation, its members' ruminations on the nature of the economic crisis and the inefficiencies of parliamentary government hinted towards a more permanent scheme of change. Their rejection of the 'old ideas' embodied in the 'old gangs' drew a symbolic line in the political sand. In the words of John Strachey, writing in June 1931, the New Party was not out to save the nation, but 'to make a new nation worth saving'.[2]

But what was this 'new nation' to be? How was it to come about? To what ends was it perceived? In attempting to answer such questions, the New Party exposed the ideological and practical contradictions that hampered its progress from the beginning. Most obviously, its approach was based on the premise of a national consensus that buried class and ideological distinctions beneath a linguistic veneer of mutual sacrifice. Yet for all the New Party's claims to be in the vanguard of a changing world, its vision of the future was blurred. Among both its leadership and membership, disagreement reigned as to the future purpose of the party.

Ultimately, the collapse of the Labour government and the election of a National government in August–October 1931 helped to clarify matters. For Mosley, Britain was poised on the verge of national humiliation and, *in extremis*, a bloody civil war. The antidote, he reasoned,

was the construction of a corporate state that combined 'the dynamic urge to change and progress with the authority, the discipline and the order without which nothing great can be achieved'.[3] Fascism, he determined, was to provide the ideological and practical means to realise a greater Britain. In so deciding, he took only a section of the New Party with him. Others who passed through and around the party foresaw a rather different future. Put bluntly, their paeans to modernity and progress imagined a world that existed some way beyond the fascist barrack room.

New Party or new movement?

Any 'new' or self-professed 'modern' party would be expected to boast an original policy and perspective. Certainly, the New Party programme provided an innovative response to the very real economic pressures experienced by Britain in 1930–32. What brought the party together – in its embryonic and realised form – was a shared belief in economic planning and the need for immediate action to avert the unfolding economic crisis. Yet the formation of a new political party also raised questions of purpose and motive. Almost immediately, the wider meaning of the New Party came under discussion, revealing vastly different conceptions within the party ranks.

As this suggests, uncertainty as to what the New Party signified, what it aspired to, and in whose interest it was committed, soon began to challenge the rather simplistic premise on which it had been founded. Just as the notion of economic planning could hold wide appeal but the means by which any such plan would be initiated and disseminated could provoke varied interpretation, so a party seeking to cut a swathe through the 'old' politics of the 'old gang' could be understood in a variety of different ways and assigned an array of different motives and objectives. From its inception, the New Party appeared caught between its immediate purpose and its desire to forge a more permanent political movement attuned to the realities of the post-war world.

The source and substance of such tension was revealed, in part, by Cyril Joad in his aforementioned 'Prolegomena to Fascism', written before but published after the formation of the New Party. In this, Joad sought to outline those 'tendencies which seem […] to be operating' in politically active young men born immediately prior to or during the Great War.[4] These amounted to a general dissatisfaction at the rule of 'old men', at the existing system of government, at political appeals to 'class' rather than 'nation', and at the futile 'game' of party politics.

According to Joad, the younger generation wanted to reform the parliamentary system, assign more power to a central executive government, and to ensure that the complexities of modern economics were overseen by appointed experts rather than MPs incapable of understanding the problems before them. In short, they wanted what the New Party would later purport to offer.

The problem for Joad was that many of the 'tendencies' to which he referred had 'a markedly fascist complexion', yet the young men to whom he had spoken were nearly all part of the labour movement and claimed a socialist background. As such, Joad concluded that there existed amongst the younger generation a conflict between 'vestigial socialism' and 'incipient fascism'. At present, the appeal of 'vestigial socialism' retained a hold, leading Joad to predict that any future movement seeking to reflect the interests of youth would be 'fascist in method' but aspiring to aims similar to those of the ILP. If, however, 'incipient fascism' ever got the better of 'vestigial socialism', then 'we shall have to deal with the castor oil men pure and simple'.

Such analysis reveals as much about Joad and his own social circle as it does about British politics in the early 1930s. His prognosis derived from a paper on generational difference given by an Oxford graduate and a young man's admission – at a socialist summer school – that he had recently transferred allegiance from the ILP to the empire crusade in search of a strong man with a strong policy. Nevertheless, it offers valuable insight into the thinking behind the New Party's formation and the attitudes of its founders, particularly as it found echo in a *Fortnightly Review* article written by Melville in the spring of 1931. This, too, drew comparison between the New Party and fascism while simultaneously concluding that it remained 'for the most part a socialist movement which, not being bound to the tenets of orthodox Labour socialism, seeks to combine elements from both right and left in a new kind of progressive centre party'.[5] Rather crudely, therefore, we may posit that there existed throughout the New Party a tension between those who wished to channel emergent political tendencies along an ostensibly socialist path and those who understood the onset of a 'new movement' as necessitating the beginning of a decidedly different creed. This, in turn, lay at the basis of the Mosley–Strachey split of July 1931.

For Strachey, far more than Joad, it was imperative that the party be seen to act in the interests of the British working class. On his resignation from the PLP, Strachey made clear that he had regarded Labour as the instrument through which socialism could be achieved, meaning the

'emancipation' of the working class from poverty and the realisation of 'educational, social and economic equality of opportunity'.[6] His joining the New Party was not, therefore, a rejection of socialism, but a realignment of his approach towards achieving it. As this suggests, the hostile reception accorded to the New Party, especially on polling night in Ashton-under-Lyne, weighed heavy on Strachey's mind, pushing him eventually to suppress those reservations he had harboured as to the viability of communism and the CPGB.[7] Within a year, he could assert – in line with then current communist thinking – that social democracy had 'passed over almost completely to the side of capitalism', and that communism offered the only salvation for the British working class.[8]

With hindsight, Strachey's anxiety as to the direction in which the New Party was heading can be discerned in his report on the progress of the party published in June 1931. In this, Strachey responded to the *Daily Herald*'s accusation that the New Party was plagiarising Hitler by insisting that 'neither I nor any other of the men and women who founded the New Party would ever, or will ever, be connected with any organisation which can ever be suspected of being anti-working class in character'. He also sought to defend, rather unconvincingly, the party's financial resources. Whilst it was true, Strachey admitted, that rich men provided funds for the New Party, their generosity had no impact on party policy or its commitment to the 'principle of collective action … [and] the overriding "right" of the community as a whole over the "rights" of any individual'. Throughout, Strachey asserted the party's leftist credentials, aligning the collective principle of socialism with that of progress, insisting that Conservatism and reaction were the 'ultimate confession of defeat', and contending that New Party policy provided the means for a new social structure acceptable to the working class. Even the proposed party youth clubs were given a socialist 'spin' by Strachey, who suggested that they would be formed in industrial centres (to comprise a largely working-class membership) and serve as a meeting place for the unemployed.[9]

Back at Great George Street, Strachey looked to ensure that New Party policy retained a socialist connection. Most provocatively, he drafted a resolution proposing close economic and political co-operation with the Soviet Union.[10] This was rejected by the party executive, prompting Strachey to break with Mosley and seek a new guide to lead him through the political labyrinth. By mid-1931, Strachey had established contact with the CPGB and its leading theoretician (Rajani Palme Dutt), was making his way through Marx's *Das Capital*, and was preparing to

stand as an Independent Workers' Candidate in Aston with communist support.[11]

Of course, Strachey's disillusionment with Mosley was based on more than a conflicting approach to the Soviet Union. On resigning from the party, he and Young released the following statement:

> We have resigned from the Council and from membership of the New Party owing to differences of opinion with Sir Oswald Mosley on the question of youth organization of the party and on the policy to be adopted in regard to unemployment insurance, India and Russia. On all of these questions, Sir Oswald Mosley appears to be attempting to depart from the agreed basis on which we all entered the New Party and to be leading it in a Conservative or Fascist direction.[12]

As they saw it, Mosley's stance on the Unemployment (Anomalies) Bill had been ambivalent; his attitude to India – as may be discerned from Mosley's unpublished November memorandum – too imperialistic; and his designs for a youth movement too militaristic. Both, too, had become alarmed at the social constituency to which Mosley now seemed to give priority. According to Strachey, both he and Young quizzed Mosley as to whose side the proposed party youth movement would rally in the crisis: the workers or capital? 'Neither', Mosley supposedly replied, preferring instead to recommend that it bang together the heads of a 'supine' government and the 'disorderly' workers.[13] In light of all this, Strachey and Young concluded that Mosley had all but embraced fascism, going so far as to quote an internal New Party circular purportedly declaring that the 'New Party will be the British equivalent of the Nazi movement'.[14] Days later, Cyril Joad followed their lead and resigned in protest against the 'growing fascist tendencies' within the party.[15]

At this point, Mosley denied that his aims and methods were fascist. Rather, he continued to aspire to a new 'centrum' in British party politics, appealing to members of all three mainstream parties to unite behind the economic policies contained within his emergency programme. A statement released in the wake of the July split declared:

> The New Party is a party neither of the right nor of the left. It puts the interests of the country first. Its appeal is addressed to all those who, irrespective of class or political allegiance, believe that a social

> and economic crisis is imminent, and that this crisis can only be averted and controlled by organised national effort.[16]

To this end, the theoretical premise of Mosley's politics remained ill-defined prior to October 1931. While he was happy to rid the New Party of its 'vestigial socialism', his fascist tendencies continued to be 'incipient' for much of 1931.

There is, however, an intriguing 'sub-plot' to all this. According to Melville, a 'secret' had always existed at the heart of the fledgling New Party, to which all but a select few were privy. While drawing its initial support from the fringes of the ILP and the 'non-political intelligentsia', Melville suggested that the party had from the outset been committed to a form of 'national socialism'.[17] Was this the case? Does Melville's claim prove that Mosley had set his sights on fascism even before he formed the New Party? Not quite. Although Melville attributed to the New Party 'a kind of National Socialism which combines a practical socialistic appeal to the workers with an equally practical, economic appeal to the industrialists', he did so in the vaguest of terms, drawing only tentative parallels with Hitler's German movement. So, for example, Melville's comparison was based on the fact that both parties supported industry (owners and workers) over the financial sector, that both challenged parliamentary orthodoxy and sought national rehabilitation, and that both parties were largely defined by the personalities of their leader. But he simultaneously ignored the racial dimension of Nazism and denied that the New Party was a definitively fascist organisation. As in Mosley's unpublished November memorandum, Melville placed Nazism alongside both Bolshevism and Fascism as an example of a post-liberal modern movement.[18] His 'secret', therefore, referred more to the New Party's general relationship with the modern movements emergent on the continent than to a specific variant of German National Socialism or fascism. As with Strachey's use of the term (see below), Melville initially understood 'national socialism' in a literal rather than a specifically Germanic sense.[19]

That said, Melville's 'secret' is revealing. First, it suggests that the New Party leadership always regarded the party as having more than a temporary purpose. In claiming otherwise, Mosley and Strachey were both guilty of being somewhat disingenuous. Second, it reveals a snapshot of an early stage in the party's transformation and, like Joad's 'Prolegomena', sheds light on the nascent contradictions that lay at its heart. For if Mosley and Strachey were agreed that the old liberal democratic world was dying, and that a new post-liberal world was

emerging in its place, then they soon came to disagree on the form of the latter. Melville's original article reads like someone just getting to grips with the Nazi phenomenon, as if uncertain as to its real character and purpose. In similar fashion, as the New Party leaders began to cast their eye over the various continental movements to which they claimed an affinity, so they began to discern the differences between them. The modern world, it seemed, would not necessarily be born from consensus.

This is the modern world

The struggle between 'vestigial socialism' and 'incipient fascism' was played out across the New Party. Most obviously, as we shall see in Chapter 6, it fed into the troubled public persona presented by the party in early 1931. Simultaneously, it informed the party's internal discussion as members at all levels endeavoured to realise the party's objective within the context of what was a shifting and tumultuous political terrain. Over time, those in and around the party began to foresee a socio-political future defined by class conflict. 'Whether we like it or not,' Nicolson suggested to Joad in September 1931, 'affairs are rapidly pushing the left towards communism and the rest towards fascism'.[20] Given such a scenario, choices had to be made. This section will consider the contested nature of the party, tracing the slow realisation of an ideological position that precipitated its turn to fascism.

Soon after the party's formation, if not before, Mosley, Nicolson, Strachey, Joad and others began to look beyond the immediate economic crisis to which they sought to rally the nation's resources. All, it seemed, agreed that the politics of the 'old parties' had had their day. All concurred that new measures, new means and new men were needed to both 'save' and reconstitute Britain for the modern age. All perceived the state to be integral to this; all sought a consensual solution to the problem. Collective responsibility and collective sacrifice would replace the individualistic aspirations and vested interest of the liberal democratic age. A new psychology, and a modern movement, would forge a new Britain equipped to retain its place at the forefront of civilisation. But what did this mean in practice? What would form the guiding principles and characteristics of the new age?

The New Party congress, held on a wet weekend at Mosley's Denham home on 6–7 June 1931, was called to better define such questions. Between 60 and 70 people attended, including the party's regional organisers, propagandists and members of the fledgling youth move-

ment. According to the few accounts we have, the debates were wide-ranging and often interesting.[21] Mosley's keynote speech focused on the party's populist appeal, which he believed lay in its critique of the old parties and the inanities of parliamentary procedure. Sellick Davies spoke on protection, while Joad gave a paper on 'The New Party and Democracy', arguing that the 'average Englishman, while talking of liberty and conscience and thought', really 'disliked having to think for himself'. It was, Joad maintained, in the 'younger people of the post-war generation' that a 'reservoir of unexpended seriousness' existed for the New Party to ignite a 'revivalism of ideas'.

Overall, Nicolson found the event 'encouraging'. He was relieved to see that those coming to the party from beyond London did not exude the aura of 'cranky disaffection' that he feared or, perhaps, had encountered nearer to home. That said, the congress served mainly to reveal differences that cut deep into the heart of the party, especially as it coincided with the *Daily Herald*'s revelation that two New Party emissaries had been dispatched to Germany to study Nazi methods and organisation.[22] As such, the speeches varied widely in both style and content. According to Herbert Hodge, the ex-Conservatives took a 'beer and skittles' approach, the ex-Labourites and Liberals came over all 'Ramsay MacDonaldish', while the ex-communists were pure 'Hyde Park'. Predictably, too, such disparity sparked disagreement. In particular, the form and purpose of the youth movement provided an early point of friction as speakers argued between offering a primarily 'athletic' or 'intellectual' appeal to the nation's young. There was, moreover, a long discussion with regard to party strategy. This, it seems, revolved around whether to concentrate on by-elections or to take time to build the party organisation at the grass roots. As for the party's objective, there was division as to whether the New Party desired dictatorship or merely democratic reform. In each case, the majority of those present favoured the latter position, suggesting that the tenor of the congress was far closer to that of a gathering of erstwhile ILP intellectuals than it was to a proto-fascist rally. Nevertheless, as Bill Allen later noted, the effect was to demonstrate to Mosley that the New Party comprised affiliates who had 'agreed to agree in principle' but could 'not agree in detail'.[23] If the party was to have a future, then it would have to be assigned a far more determinate agenda.

Though far from dominant, the forces that would decide the fascist transformation of the New Party were gathering at the June congress. In amidst the debates, Peter Winkworth's call for 'absolute dictatorship' and wider talk of the need for 'sensational activities' to overcome

press indifference combined with speeches conceiving a new movement that embodied the 'heads of thinkers on the bodies of athletes'.[24] No doubt the presence of a rowdy group of Oxford hearties lent a further sense of foreboding to the proceedings. Mosley, meanwhile, chose to introduce the concept of a corporate state, thereby providing a stark alternative to Strachey's more obviously socialist inclinations. To use Jones' oft-quoted account:

> Strachey delivers his 'good old fashioned Marxian speech', which is applauded by Allan Young, Cyril Joad and others. A young man named Winkworth speaks on the need for a revival of what he called 'The Attic Spirit', and on this Mosley and others build the 'Corporate State'. Rival 'ideologies', someone said. Cynthia Mosley looks troubled, so does Mrs Strachey. Harold Nicolson smokes his pipe diplomatically, and later speaks like a diplomat [...] Dr Forgan, MP, speaks non-committedly – for they are all friends. 'Our Mr Box', the new broom, stands in the background with a smile on his face as he watches Allan Young squirming impatiently whilst Mosley is speaking soulfully of the Corporate State of the future.[25]

Young's squirming would continue thereafter. Just three days later, he confided in Nicolson his fear that the party would 'swerve to the right and be forced into Hitlerism'. This, it seemed, stemmed from the youth movement debate's raising the question of social conflict and the need to form a bulwark against communism. 'Should a revolution break out in England, it would mean that the whole aim and object of the party will have failed', Young insisted. As such, he disapproved of any idea that involved meeting communist force with fascist force, and so opposed the youth movement's developing in such a way.[26]

Mosley's corporatism, alongside Strachey's 'Marxian speech' and Young's reference to revolution and Hitlerism, clearly demonstrate the extent to which competing visions of the near future had formed inside the New Party by the summer of 1931. First and foremost, the extent to which Mosley and Strachey foresaw the unfolding economic crisis had evidently intensified; neither *A National Policy* nor Mosley's unpublished November memorandum made reference to potential revolution or the need to choose between communism and fascism. By the summer of 1931, both appeared to conceive the economic crisis as precipitating a major socio-political collapse; a tendency that would only gain momentum with the fall of the Labour government in August. Second, therefore, Mosley began to understand his conception of the

modern movement as a direct alternative to communism. Along with most others in the New Party, Mosley had long rejected communism as a viable route for Britain to follow. As Russia appeared to demonstrate, Bolshevism, Marxism and communism were synonymous with class conflict, civil war and hardship. In Mosley's terms, communism was 'destructive' where the corporate ideal was 'constructive' in its appeal to – and application of – national unity.[27] Put another way, a 'national' solution would prevent the social division that Marxism required as a prerequisite to its stated aim.[28]

Despite such reasoning, fascism was not the only option open to Mosley. Young, for one, continued to think in terms similar to many others who believed that *laissez faire* capitalism had run its course but that capitalism in general remained far from exhausted. An alternative to the communist solution, Young suggested, was a capitalist state in which all wage-earners were 'raised to the position of capitalists'. This would be achieved by economic planning in order to ensure that 'when the boom comes [...] profits are extended to all'.[29] Subsequently, Young's post-New Party career saw him work with Harold Macmillan on finding a 'middle way' between state socialism and liberal capitalism.

Mosley, too, would prevaricate for some time before raising the fascist standard. Although we can discern signs of his anticipating a future struggle between communism and fascism, he remained cautious and kept his options open, fumbling for a British variant of the modern movement that did not simply mimic those formed on the continent.[30] In the meantime, other more exotic ideals entered the ether. On 16 June, Nicolson, Strachey, Sellick Davies and Douglas Paul gathered at Joad's Hampstead home to discuss the 'real aims' of the New Party. While they agreed that a new politics of 'integration' was needed, they differed on its 'formula'. Strachey proposed a form of 'national socialism', which Joad dismissed as amounting to little more than a restyled Fabianism. Davies, a former Liberal candidate to Evesham whose father was a baptist minister, next argued for the party's making a religious appeal. This, however, received scant support from around the drawing room. Nicolson, meanwhile, argued that the younger generation hankered after a new and patriotic concept of the state based on values of sacrifice, discipline, service, courage and 'energy of thought'. Quite how these would be articulated remained a moot point. Both Nicolson and Joad recognised that the premise of 'people like us' proclaiming a patriotic revivalism was likely to appear both trivial and embarrassing to the great mass of the British public.[31] As it was, Nicolson tended to understand the New Party's politics as a form of

'Tory socialism', committing to a corporate state but continuing to distinguish it from fascism.[32]

Beneath the party hierarchy, similar differences were displayed in the pages of *Action*. Certainly, the letters to the party weekly ran the gamut of opinion. For J. N. Bamforth, who urged the party to provide 'nourishment' in the form of Marx and socialism, it was essential that the party should not 'cut itself off from its most live forerunner – the labour movement'. By contrast, Norman Holliday urged the party to use the label 'Fascist' with honour.

> You know as well as I do that the Corporate State is the system under which the Italians live today, whilst with reference to the Nazis, you apparently dare not copy anything from them but a good deal of glamour, and the sports organisations which were, in the case of many, the foundation of the Storm Troops [...] I hear that you have quite a number of Jews in your party, and, for a movement that supports Hitlerism, I fail to see the reason for their presence, unless they wish to see that your policy is conducted on proper lines![33]

As this suggests, *Action*'s letters pages did not contain a consistent vision of the party's purpose. On occasion, extreme policy suggestions nestled next to an array of finicky complaints. Thus, calls for voluntary eugenic sterilisation jostled for space alongside objections to pub opening hours; letters deriding 'loafing' unemployed workers accompanied rants against the price of divorce and the noise made by children in cinemas. Intermittently, however, correspondents provided a more pertinent understanding of what eventually informed the party's mission. R. B. Miller, for example, captured the party's modern spirit in his call for 'a party to reflect our desires, to enable us to live beautifully, to erect the steel and concrete of the modern state'.[34] Similarly, 'a member of Nupa' stepped in to diffuse a debate between Edward Gray, who despaired of the 'worthless' people standing on 'our street corners', and S. G. Sanders, who defended the unemployed against capitalism's immorality and called for a nationalised economy similar to Russia. Both were wrong, the Nupa member insisted. 'Today is the day of controlled individualism, by which the state gets the best for everyone, whether capitalist or worker, and at the same time allows complete freedom of thought and action to those people who serve the state well and truly.' Under the modern state, there would be no time for outdated 'chatter' about the class war; both the capitalists and the workers would be made to 'toe the line'.[35]

Of course, the launch of *Action* coincided with the 1931 general election and Mosley's public endorsement of the corporate state as an alternative to parliamentary democracy. This, in turn, helped clarify both the New Party's conception of itself and its vision of the future. Most obviously, the collapse of the Labour government and the formation of an interim coalition government that presaged the national government elected in October 1931 necessitated a re-evaluation of the New Party's place within Britain's shifting political alignment. Thereafter, with the party's crushing defeat at the polls, and Mosley was forced to consider a political future beyond Westminster.

Such re-evaluation was captured by Nicolson in his 'Notes on the Future of the New Party', dated 25 September 1931.[36] The New Party, Nicolson reasoned, had been formed to meet a crisis. With the collapse of the Labour government taking place against a backdrop of worsening economic forecasts and wider European upheaval, the crisis had seemingly arrived. This, in turn, justified the New Party's formation. The question now, Nicolson suggested, was did such a situation justify the party's continuation?

Nicolson began to answer his question by analysing the political realignment caused by Labour's fractious abdication of power. To this end, he perceived the 'old parties' to have consolidated into two groups in preparation for the forthcoming general election: a national coalition that would go to the country as a National Party, and a Labour Party that would face the electorate as an openly socialist party. Both would cut across the New Party, Nicolson predicted. The nationals would 'take from us' slogans of unification, patriotism, insulation and planning; Labour would eclipse the New Party's anti-capitalist position and, similarly, base its programme on an economic plan. Consequently, the New Party had 'no platform left on which to appeal', leaving it all but cut adrift from the political mainstream and with few choices left before it. In Nicolson's estimation, the party could fight the general election as an independent party and contest a select number of seats, abstain completely, align with either the nationals or the Labour Party, or create an 'action' group with other malcontents (Lloyd George, Churchill) to form a 'national opposition'. Nicolson's preference was to contest a very select number of seats as an independent party, though he kept an open mind with regard to joining the national coalition on condition of retaining the party's identity and independence. In no instance did he foresee a fortuitous outcome for the New Party.

Looking further ahead, Nicolson flirted with the crisis scenario that informed the disagreement between Mosley and Strachey. Any return

to the two-party system would, Nicolson reasoned, be based on the politics of class. But given capitalism's apparent malaise and the failure of Labour socialism, the most dynamic socio-political force was likely to be communist. As such, to prevent communism – which Nicolson believed would be a disaster for Britain given its limited internal market and national character – it was necessary to develop something 'equally dynamic' on 'the other side'. The 'obvious' answer to this was fascism, and Nicolson felt there was much to learn from both the Italians and the 'Nazi experiment'. However, he did not think fascism applicable to Britain. Not only did fascism lead to violence, but 'we are too individual to submit to dictation of opinion unless that opinion is based on some great emotion such as class hatred'. Patriotism and imperialism no longer resonated, Nicolson mused, while the technocratic nature of any plan-based policy could only fail to interest the electorate. Accordingly, Nicolson concluded that it was necessary for the New Party to 'review our whole attitude and our whole policy'.

Nicolson's solution was far from convincing. First, he recommended that the party 'cease to be empirical' in terms of both its policy and its 'attitude of mind'. In other words, the party required a 'definite theory' to complement what Nicolson perceived to be a 'centrifugal' tendency in British politics; it needed, he believed, to define its own 'particular brand of the extreme'.[37] The 'organic state' – meaning the corporate state – was a good starting point, Nicolson suggested, but did not go far enough. Second, therefore, he argued that the party must present itself as something more than a political *party*. To challenge the CPGB in 'inflaming the youth of England', it was necessary to offer a politics that was 'supra-parliamentary'. Again, however, Nicolson felt that the party's fledgling youth movement went only part way to achieving this. As such, he concluded that the country was not really 'ripe' for the New Party's espoused values of 'pride, energy, self respect, renaissance, [and] vigour'. Outright socialism on the 'Austrian model' was therefore one possible alternative. More appealing, for Nicolson at least, was to join the nationals in a National Party through which the New Party could be 'immediately effective and ultimately dominant'.[38]

In time, Nicolson would indeed join with the nationals, becoming the National Labour MP for West Leicester in 1935. Mosley, meanwhile, agreed with much of Nicolson's reasoning, confessing that he was 'not optimistic' about any single New Party member being elected to parliament at the forthcoming election. Consequently, he began to prefer a more radical response to the New Party's isolation, bringing the question of '*fascismo*' to the forefront of his agenda.[39] Not only had its

methods provided an effective counter to communism on the continent, but Mosley's embrace of the corporate state had already brought him ever closer to Mussolini's Italian model. Though he recognised the possibility of Britain's economic and political crisis having reached its apotheosis, Mosley chose to foresee a future of intensified conflict. Just as communism would 'quickly supersede the woolly-headed social democrats of Labour', so its 'inevitable and historic opponent' would arise 'to take the place of a flabby Conservatism'.[40] As this suggests, the modern movements that had inspired the fledgling New Party had by late 1931 been distilled into two irreconcilable opposites, the struggle between which would decide the nature of Britain's future civilisation.[41]

Back to the future

Prior to Mosley's embrace of fascism, there were only scattered clues as to the type of future society envisaged by the New Party. These were far from developed; the party programme had, after all, been devised to meet an immediate economic crisis. Questions such as those relating to the public or private ownership of industry were supposedly placed to one side in the pursuit of a practical solution to the problems afflicting the British economy.[42] That said, the party's progressive heritage ensured that its members did at times project a future vision that proposed to complement their spirit of modernity.

For Nicolson, the New Party formed part of a recognisably new era. The modern period, he suggested in June 1931, had passed through two stages: the 'reign of convention' (1870–90) and the 'reign of individualism' (1890–1931). These had been expressed, respectively, through regal and liberal democratic forms of government. Next, therefore, was to come the reign of 'community individualism' and the corporate state.[43] Although party members would quibble at the label applied, all concurred that the new age would be characterised by an evermore extensive and interventionist state apparatus. This, Joad explained in an early party pamphlet, was to be resolutely modern, meaning that it was to be overarching and staffed with 'scientific statesmen' ready to recant ideology and political dogma in order to apply 'scientific methods to public affairs to determine precisely what are the things to be done'. In such a way, the modern society would control its destiny, ensuring that the 'resources of the community [...] may be utilised in the best interests of the community'.[44]

Such an emphasis on expertise had wider political ramifications. Most importantly, it fed into the New Party's growing distrust of democratic

government. Rousseau, described in *Action* as the 'prophet of modern democracy', was deemed a 'degenerate little man' whose theoretical appeals to sentimentality had served only to compound the ever-deepening political and economic crisis of the age. According to Nicolson, the 'average elector conceives politics in the shape of a series of labels or pigeon holes'. They liked their easy categories, he complained, their 'free trade' or 'protection', and resented 'fiddling with partitions which differentiate these pigeon holes'. As such, the New Party came to envisage a new civilisation – youthful, cultured, healthy and assertive – in which personal and economic freedom was assured in exchange for dedicated service to the state and the transferral of political responsibility (or 'political liberty') to those intellectually equipped to deal with the complexities of modern life.[45]

This, as we have seen, was first stated in the unpublished memorandum drawn up by Mosley in November 1930.[46] Here, as he would do again in 1933, Mosley wrote of reviving the morality of Greek civilisation, which he interpreted as meaning 'individual freedom in so far as this does not impair his mental or physical capacity to serve the state'.[47] Quite how this would be measured in practice remained open to question, though Mosley did attempt to elaborate his theory in a December issue of *Action*. 'Freedom', he reasoned, should not be defined by the right to vote, but by the right to 'leisure, work and service'. This, moreover, was facilitated by an economic system designed to lift 'the individual above the poverty line' and so enable the 'social freedom to enjoy the fruits of such organisation'. As things stood, Mosley insisted that liberal democracy had failed to provide liberty so defined, preferring instead to impede the 'natural impulses of man' with its economic anarchy and 'mumbo-jumbo of taboo and repression'.[48]

As this suggests, the New Party's ruminations on the relationship between the state and the individual read like an inversion of the *status quo*, with the perceived stringencies of the wartime Defence of the Realm Act (DORA) being revoked in return for greater state control over the economic and political sphere. In a moral sense, the party also tended to cut against the Victorian grain of its members' 'shabby grandfathers', who – Nicolson complained – had failed to understand that 'political liberty is no alternative for social liberty'. In place of the 'sedative Anglican doctrine' of *laissez faire* and the 'gradually extended franchise', which had led only to workhouses, inequality and a belief in 'ginger beer and eggs for the poor, mahogany furniture and silk lampshades for the rich', the New Party posited a new age based on a sense of service and community.[49] According to Nicolson, the party

wished to balance its 'pragmatic attitude on all economic questions' with the 'utmost liberalism on all points of religious and moral conduct'. As a movement, Nicolson insisted, 'we stand for free speech, no censorship, free divorce, birth control, no drink restrictions, no established church, no DORA or wet blankets, no closing hours and complete sexual liberty'.[50]

The 'new morality' envisaged by the New Party tended to be articulated in unashamedly masculine terms, something we shall explore further in Chapter 8. Broadly speaking, its values were defined as 'sound patriotism', self-sacrifice, loyalty, public service and courage. Intellect and physical prowess were regarded in equal measure; *Action* claimed to appeal 'directly to the thought of man' but to 'punch with muscle'.[51] The 'test' of this new morality, meanwhile, was to be found in 'the efficiency of the individual in mind and body for the service he had to perform for himself and for his country'. As a consequence, Mosley predicted that the 'ordinary taboos and restraints' of a liberal democratic society 'would vanish' to be replaced by 'disciplined moderation or athleticism in life'.[52]

The vehicle by which this revived social consciousness would enter the public domain was to be the new movement spearheaded by the New Party. Such a movement, Mosley predicted, would permeate 'every institution of daily life', leading by example and dealing 'severely' with instances of excess and inefficiency. Ostracism and contempt would provide a deterrent for the 'tippler and the weakling', with 'the village pond rather than the law courts' serving as a 'remedy for the drunkard [...] and the decadent'.[53] All of which began to sound like a synthesis of barrack life and a civic interpretation of the codes engrained within the public school dormitories and universities through which many a New Party member came of age. The British public school system was – from the late nineteenth century, at least – defined by its ethos of discipline, hierarchy, loyalty and service, by its mixture of high-brow culture and athleticism, and by its implicit cult of masculinity. As Jon Savage has noted, the model public school type was a 'muscular Christian who combined self-discipline, physical prowess, religious observance, and the spirit of service into a new kind of moral manliness'.[54] This, with the overt religiosity refocused towards a political end, could almost represent an idealised New Party member. It may also help explain the regular articles featured in *Action* dedicated to elite education and Nicolson's regret that 'there is only the public school spirit and so few humans have been at a public school'.[55] In a sense, therefore, there was a section of the New Party who appeared to interpret

the proposed 'new movement' as a means by which to project the values of the British public school onto a post-democratic society.

Mosley, on the other hand, had preferred his Sandhurst experience to that of Winchester. He, alongside others such as Allen, Box, Wilfred Risdon and many of the younger recruits drifting into the fledgling youth movement, were looking for something far more hard-headed and militant. Their moral code began to clash with that put forward by Nicolson and his fellow party intellectuals. They understood their inherent 'Britishness' to have deeper roots, drawing both from the *esprit de corps* of the wartime trenches and, later, the feudal surround of an Elizabethan England. Just as Bill Allen recalled an age of medieval aristocrats who 'lived and died magnificently' before an emergent bourgeoisie moved to stifle such a spirit of adventure, so Mosley recalled the feudal ideal of his childhood home in Rolleston, where an almost 'self-contained' economy and 'classless society' led to the 'warmest and most intimate friendships […] between us [the landowners] and these people [the workers on the land]'.[56]

But if New Party members occasionally made recall to the past in pursuit of an idealised future, then they tended to do so in a decidedly modernist fashion. As its name suggests, the New Party sought a new beginning; it strived to find new meaning amidst the perceived chaos of the time. Reference to the past was but a search for lost certainties to be recast onto the future's gaping abyss; not surprisingly, these related to the life experiences of party members. In its fetishisation of youth and its affinity to science, the New Party sought to forge an alternative modernity based on a set of inherited but necessarily reasserted values that could combat the supposedly degenerative forces of history whilst simultaneously laying the foundations for a new civilisation.[57] In so doing, Mosley and his comrades soon found themselves poised at the door of fascism. Their choice was whether or not to take the decisive step: to wholly reject the present and to cross over to the other side.

4
A Party of a New Type? New Party Organisation

The New Party set out to break the mould of British politics. On its formation, the party foresaw a nation poised on the brink of a 'grave industrial crisis', drifting in 'helplessness and despair to industrial failure and unemployment, followed by wage cuts and an all round reduction in the standard of life'. No salvation was expected from the 'old parties'. Hamstrung by a decrepit leadership and an outdated parliamentary system designed to prevent rather than facilitate effective government, both the Labour and Conservative parties were accused of offering little more than a string of broken promises. What was needed, Mosley and his colleagues insisted, was a new political organisation armed with a modern solution to a modern problem. It was to this end that the New Party appealed to youth, to those fighting for the working class, and to all those 'who love their country', to mobilise each and every ounce of the 'energy, vitality and manhood' necessary 'to save and rebuild the nation'.[1]

But if the New Party had the answers, then it appeared to lack the means. In other words, the New Party boasted a programme but neither the membership nor the organisational wherewithal by which to achieve its objective. This, initially at least, did not appear to concern Mosley. Arguably, the party's potential resided more in its links to influential persons within establishment circles and the press than it did to a groundswell of popular feeling or support. Though people were invited to join and to serve the party, its purpose and its policy were to remain the preserve of its founding elite. As such, only rudimentary attempts were made to forge a functioning party organisation in the early days of the New Party's existence, before Mosley's growing isolation convinced him of the need to cultivate a more permanent political presence in the form of a broader and distinctly *new* movement. This

chapter will outline the form and character of the New Party's evolving organisation, working its way through the thin layers of apparatus to the dark heart that came to beat at its core.

Follow the leader

The basic facts are simply put: the New Party existed in some form or other from 28 February 1931 to 30 September 1932. It briefly considered changing its name to the New National Party on way to becoming a National Party;[2] after flirting with red and black, it adopted orange and black as its official colours. A marigold was chosen as the party's insignia in time for the 1931 general election.[3] From the outset, the New Party was a top-down organisation. Internal authority rested with its leader, Sir Oswald Mosley, and those in his immediate circle. No formal party constitution existed; decisions were made at the centre and disseminated to all members and supporters. Mosley insisted that the 'maximum of centralisation and discipline' should be concentrated in the 'executive central office'. As this suggests, the New Party was both hierarchical and resolutely undemocratic. 'The whole spirit of the party is one of oligarchic control', Mosley explained at a party meeting in June 1931, subject only to an 'initiative mandate being given'.[4]

The executive central office, alternately referred to as the executive committee, central council, inner council and governing council, met almost daily at Mosley's offices in Great George Street. Its remit was never publicly defined, though it presumed to deal with all matters of day-to-day policy and party direction. There also existed, less coherently, an overlapping organisation committee that discussed questions relating to the party's contesting by-elections and finance. Membership of the executive was fluid and selected by appointment. Initially, at least, the New Party leadership comprised Mosley, Strachey, Forgan, Allen and Young (national secretary), before the split of July 1931 necessitated its reorganisation. Harold Nicolson had already been co-opted onto the executive in June; soon after, F. M. Box joined with Leslie Cuming to combine his position as chief agent with Young's former secretarial role. Sellick Davies was the party's financial secretary.

The New Party executive tended to function in a very informal way. Meetings amounted to little more than discussions held in Mosley's office with whoever happened to be present. By mid-to-late 1931, this usually meant a combination of Mosley, Forgan, Nicolson, Box, Davies and Allen. Come the New Movement, formed over 1932 on the basis of the party's youth organisation, and Mosley was designated leader of

both the party and wider movement. In so doing, he was assisted by Forgan (director) and Cuming (assistant director).[5]

Approximate to the party executive was a slightly broader National Council (NC). In theory, the executive issued reports to the NC on a monthly basis; the NC, in turn, was responsible for ensuring that the work of the party reflected the 'general principles of the movement'.[6] In reality, the NC was a rather toothless body that never really functioned as intended. Its membership largely overlapped with the executive and comprised party officers hand-picked by Mosley and stationed in or near the party headquarters. As such, discussion mainly revolved around questions of finance, strategy and, on occasion, the appeals made by local branches and regional officers for representation on the party councils. Mosley, of course, gave short shrift to any such suggestion, and it appeared to be with much relief that the NC resolved to disband its regional offices in late 1931.[7] From there on, party meetings rarely warranted a designated title; the executive and NC all but merged into one as Mosley stripped down and realigned the party organisation in 1932.[8] At times, even some of the party leaders appeared unsure as to what they were attending, whether it was a meeting of 'committee or council or whatever the beastly thing calls itself'.[9] Come the party's end, however, and it was absolutely clear as to how authority was disseminated across the New Movement: 'the decision on all matters of policy is in the hands of Sir Oswald Mosley'.[10]

Given the small size of the party nucleus, responsibilities were shared amongst its leading members and through sub-committees appointed to develop aspects of policy or to oversee propaganda campaigns. Initially of great importance was the publicity committee, which pre-dated the New Party's formation. This originally comprised Mosley, Strachey, Allen, Brown and Young, alongside Dick Plummer, Marshall Diston, Francis Meynell, Peter Eckersley, Harold Nicolson and, fleetingly, Gerald Barry.[11] Following the party's eventual formation, Joad was appointed director of propaganda, while Mosley continued to employ a number of research assistants to provide the necessary detail to substantiate the prevailing party line. These included Mosley's long-time secretary, George Sutton, in addition to Catlin and C. F. Melville, an associate of Allen who wrote widely on European politics throughout the 1930s.[12] By the summer of 1931, a New Party Information Service had been established to distribute speakers' notes, the first of which, *The Crisis*, provided newspaper cuttings and an array of figures to demonstrate the extent of Britain's financial crisis and the Labour government's failure to deal with unemployment.[13] Elsewhere in Great George Street, Peter

Howard took up office as national secretary of the party's youth movement in the summer of 1931, while J. Stanley Egglestone – previously Sellick Davies' election agent in Evesham – oversaw the organisation of party meetings, employing a number of speakers to spread the Mosley gospel when and wherever possible. Nicolson, of course, became the editor of *Action*; Forgan was the party's parliamentary whip.

In terms of finance, the party leaders pooled their resources and tapped their wealthy contacts. The Mosleys reputedly invested £100,000 into their new venture, a substantial outlay that cut deep into their personal wealth. By November 1931, they were forced to give up their house in Smith Square and to let out their Denham country retreat. In Nicolson vocabulary, they were left 'pigging it' in Pimlico.[14] Bill Allen, too, contributed to the party coffers before the depression and a failing marriage helped take his financial priorities elsewhere. But even this was insufficient to establish, build and maintain a nationwide political presence. As it was, Mosley and Forgan worked to secure contributions from a number of sources. Meetings were arranged with City financiers; socialites such as Lady Houston and Sibyl Colefax were solicited to seek out willing donors to the cause; leading industrialists were invited to lend their wealth to ensure the enactment of Mosley's economic plan. Most famously, Sir William Morris donated £50,000 towards founding the New Party in January 1931, and continued to provide funds towards both *Action* and the party's youth movement thereafter.[15] According to Morris, who sought a strong cross-party government headed by a 'real leader' to confront the descending economic crisis, Mosley was by late 1930 the 'one bright spot on the political horizon'.[16] In addition, Wyndham Portal (paper manufacturer) contributed to the party and further worked as a fund-raiser for Mosley, while Hugo Cunliffe-Owen (tobacco manufacturer) and Lord Inchcape (shipping magnate) purportedly added to the party war chest.[17] In the lead up to the Ashton by-election, too, the party approached a number of cotton manufacturers to lend their financial clout to Young's campaign.[18]

As should be clear, the New Party was something of a scratch organisation with a structure so loose as to be barely defined. This should not lead us to conclude that the party's central offices failed to function. On the contrary, Great George Street was often a hive of activity, attracting a small but steady stream of recruits eager to take Mosley's lead or, as Jack Jones and Herbert Hodge noted, seeking some form of ready employment. Writing for the *Evening Standard* in April 1931, Nicolson described a party headquarters staffed by eager 'young men with fine foreheads' dashing 'from room to room carrying proof-sheets

and manifestos'. All around them, typewriters rattled and telephones buzzed amidst the 'throbbing [...] lust of battle'.[19] If the New Party was destined to fail, then it was not for lack of effort.

That said, the proposed architects of a managed economy evidently struggled to keep their own house in order. Although monetary incentive was used to entice many to the cause, the party's attempt to 'build up' soon gave way to the need to 'cut down'. Towards the end of 1931, the party recorded liabilities that exceeded its assets by approximately £2,000. This was hardly surprising. Within the New Party hierarchy, Forgan, Howard, Box, Davies and Egglestone commanded a wage bill that amounted to some £1,000-a-month, while a whole host of regional organisers, speakers, agents, advisers, researchers and members of Mosley's bodyguard were further paid for their services. The party's regional offices, too, quickly became a financial drain; on its dissolution, the Scottish regional office alone boasted a debt of £500. With regard to *Action,* Nicolson's offer to take only half of the £3,000-a-year salary offered did little to prevent its haemorrhaging even more of the party's capital. The costs of production combined with the wages paid to the paper's staff ensured that it was running at a loss of over £240-a-week by November 1931.[20] To make matters worse, Sellick Davies was eventually forced to resign his position as financial secretary on account of his rather wilful use of party money. The final straw, Nicolson recorded, came when £270 disappeared on account of Davies' 'vague' economic acumen.[21]

Despite all this, we should remember that Mosley's sights were always focused beyond the mechanisms of a formal party organisation. This, first, meant seeking influence in parliament and the far reaches of what may be called establishment circles (see Chapter 7). More practically, it tended towards the building of a modern movement that transcended the electoral politics of the mainstream parties in order to harness the more vibrant promise of a politicised youth. As we shall see, it was a decision that served to help propel the New Party ever closer towards its fascist end.

Springs in the desert

The New Party, Mosley wrote in late 1931, wished to distinguish itself from the parties of the 'old world', dependent as they were on 'women, buns and tea fights'.[22] As this suggests, the cultivation of a mass party membership organised in constituency branches and designed to form an electoral machine was never a priority. Indeed, the party put relatively

little effort into developing its apparatus outside of London; though money and printed material were sent, the centre soon appeared to view its scattered local bases as costly sites of irritation.[23] In the new political world envisaged by Mosley, there was little space for the formal niceties of most existing mainstream party organisations. Nor did the New Party appear to have much time for the whist drives and party socials so beloved of rank-and-file members in the Labour, Liberal and Conservative parties.[24] And yet, almost in spite of this, local New Party branches did form and did endeavour to play some role in the pursuit of Mosley's ambition. This section will develop a necessarily fragmented sketch of the New Party's local apparatus.

On its formation, the New Party asked for volunteers, prospective candidates and potential members to write to Great George Street. No membership fee was listed, though a minimum subscription of one shilling was later applied; donations, 'however small', were requested from 'the mass of patriotic men and women who are determined upon action'.[25] Local branches, it seemed, were expected to develop in the wake of the party's inaugural campaign as a rallying point for those committed to Mosley's programme. In addition, Cyril Joad quickly pressed the party leadership to pass a resolution on the formation of student sections, thereby allowing him and Nicolson to utilise their university connections to cultivate a ready pool of support that would serve the party well throughout much of its lifespan.[26] In the meantime, regional organisers were appointed to direct activity across London and five designated areas: the north west, north east, south, Midlands and Scotland.

Not surprisingly, given the ramshackle nature of the party's formation, progress was slow. According to Strachey, 'associations' existed in 'most of the big industrial centres' by June 1931, but actual party membership remained small.[27] Even the onset of the political crisis so long predicted by Mosley appears to have done little to bolster the New Party ranks. The party's rudimentary election campaign in October 1931 relied more on the enthusiasm of the appointed candidate and his agent than the mobilisation of a co-ordinated party apparatus. At no point did the party produce details of its membership figures and, as noted above, it refused to draw up a formal constitution. As such, the New Party's local organisations remained disparate and detached, prone to flicker in and out of existence, and always deemed of lesser importance than the youth movement developed from the summer of 1931.

Given the New Party's London-centricity, the most precise evidence of party organisation beyond its headquarters relates to the capital.

Thus, buried in Peter Eckersley's papers are details of the New Party's London Committee (LC) and its four designated 'regions'. The LC itself was initially presided over by Strachey, chaired by Eckersley, and comprised Marshall Diston (vice-chair), Mrs Putt (secretary), Cyril Joad, W. Peters, A. J. Hubert, James Stuart Barr, Francis Meynell, David Pollock, F. M. Box and Cynthia Mosley, who was further listed as chair of the women's committee. Regionally, London was divided into quarters (north east, north west, south east, south west), each with their own regional committee and officers.[28] Albie Smith, Jimmie Macdougall, G. Victor Smith and a Mr White were among the party's London and southern organisers.

If Nicolson is to be believed, then the London branches did not bode well for the party's future progress. They were, it seems, staffed by a somewhat dysfunctional mix of 'pseudo-intellectuals' and 'heavy, hearty Englishmen'. The wider London membership, meanwhile, appeared to Nicolson 'ignorant and foolish without the slightest real grasp of the party's policy or attitude'. At various times in 1931, Nicolson confided in his diary a desire to punch Howard Brown, the chairman of the party's north-east committee, and bemoaned an unseemly internal squabble involving the drunken indiscretions of the north-west regional chair, Crosby Thompson.[29] By the summer of 1931, moreover, discontent within the London branches was such that the entire south-west regional council resigned in advance of a widescale reshuffle of serving party officers.[30]

Outside the capital, the New Party hoped to inherit at least a semblance of organisation in those localities where its leading members had resigned from their respective parliamentary parties. In Stoke, where Cynthia Mosley had proven extremely popular amongst Labour members, the constituency party chairman predicted that a portion of the local membership would follow their MP into the New Party.[31] Accordingly, the constituency party secretary (Harry Miles) and vice president (H. J. Sutton) formed the nucleus of a New Party branch in the potteries, replete with a small but loyal core of local Mosleyites.[32] But although this was still functioning in time for the general election in October 1931 (and the BUF later inherited a ready-made base in Stoke), the party's campaign appeared to rely as much on imported help as it did the local contingent.[33]

Similar developments occurred in and around Birmingham, where Mosley endeavoured to rally at least a section of the local labour movement to the New Party, including most of the local ILP. He was to be disappointed. First, Mosley's Smethwick party immediately promised

to oppose his candidature at any future election, before his departure was made even more ignominious amidst allegations that he had sought to 'buttonhole' a number of local Labour officials. George Morris, the borough party secretary, claimed to have been offered a £600-a-year salary in return for his becoming the New Party's organising secretary, and similar allegations were made with regard to both Strachey in Aston and Baldwin in Dudley.[34] As such, the New Party's west Midlands' base was limited from the outset. A handful of loyal followers joined the party, among them Young, Sutton, Risdon, Dan Davies and James Stuart Barr, though most of these had already relocated to London by 1931.[35] In Wolverhampton, meanwhile, Brown's resignation from the PLP led to a damaging rift in the borough Labour Party, though he continued to resist joining Mosley despite the encouragement of certain local members.[36]

Information as to the development of the Birmingham New Party is sketchy. The local branch was twinned with the Midland regional office, which was opened – rather fittingly – on Birmingham's New Street in April 1931. Strachey's friend and former agent, Dan Davies, was appointed regional organiser with Lilian Adams as secretary. The Birmingham branch secretary was Captain E. J. Bartleet, a mining engineer from King's Norton who later stood for the New Party in the 1931 general election alongside Jesse Williams, a former Labour councillor. By 1932, however, only a handful of New Party members remained in Britain's second city, the bulk of whom – described by Howard as 'keen, serious young men' – were organised in a youth section under the guidance of W. S. Wood.[37] Come October, and the Birmingham BUF was formed around Arthur Ward, an ex-official of the BF and friend to Neil Francis Hawkins.[38]

In Scotland, where the red-haired Jimmy Steel was appointed regional organiser, Robert Forgan's secession from the PLP made little impact.[39] Although Forgan was personally popular and boasted an influence over a number of 'left-wing sympathisers' in the West Renfrew Labour Party, the local ILP lost only 'five members' to the New Party in March 1931.[40] In compensation, the party gained the support of Edward Rosslyn Mitchell (the former Labour MP for Paisley best known for his defeat of Herbert Asquith in 1924), and later claimed to have both a functioning national committee in Scotland and at least one active branch in Glasgow.[41] Mosley himself was nominated to contest the Rectorial elections at Glasgow University in 1931, though attempts by the local New Party student group to kidnap rival electors and leave them stuck out in the Highlands evidently failed to prevent their

leader from coming bottom of the poll with just 21 votes.[42] Links, too, appear to have been made with the Scottish Nationalist Party.[43] Meanwhile, in Belfast, Bill Allen set about converting his Unionist base to Mosley's plan of action, from where he assured the NC that the New Party had established a 'great hold'.[44] Little appears to have followed from Allen's boast.

Beyond the New Party's parliamentary seats, potted support emerged in suitably varied fashion. Most of the early New Party branches formed in response to the party's spring tour of selected industrial centres. So, for example, the Manchester branch formed in the wake of the New Party's Free Trade Hall meeting of 15 March 1931, with James Matthews (president), Harry Macks (vice-president), James Norbury (secretary) and George Clancy (financial secretary) appointed as its principal officers. The branch proved short-lived; in April, the local party executive resigned *en masse* following a dispute with the central party headquarters. Even so, a New Party rump remained in Manchester. According to Arthur Fawcett, a young sales representative for Baxendales who joined the New Party in its last few months, the Manchester branch numbered approximately 40 by early 1932, with a core membership of 15 to 20 who met regularly in the Imperial pub, Deansgate.[45] Not dissimilarly, a Liverpool branch formed around the erstwhile Labour 'prime minister' of the Liverpool Parliamentary Debating Society, W. H. Bell.[46] Indeed, the north west regional secretary, Philip Pritchard, described by Nicolson as 'sturdy, pasty, humorous and ambitious', oversaw a minor flowering of party branches in Rochdale, Oldham, Accrington and Ashton-under-Lyne during the first weeks of the party's existence.[47]

Thereafter, New Party branches developed primarily as a result of individual initiative. A notable example was Northampton, where Arthur Musgrave wrote to the party on its formation and arranged with Dan Davies to organise a meeting at the Wedgewood Café in April 1931. From this, a small local group was constituted with Musgrave as secretary and a local civil servant, J. W. Goulding, as chairman. Musgrave proved a keen activist, drafting policy suggestions, proposing means by which to dramatise party meetings (banners, stewards, gramophone records), and constantly seeking paid employment in the party.[48] Despite such effort, the branch remained small. Its eight original members were soon joined by a handful of new recruits, only for local subscriptions to fall to just three in August 1931.[49] More impressively, the Oxford branch led by Peter Howard and bolstered by Nicolson's Balliol connections numbered 53 dues-paying members by June 1931.[50] Elsewhere, Bill Leaper drew together a cluster of disgruntled ILP supporters to

launch a Bradford branch of the New Party in April, while further associations were dispersed across Huddersfield, Halifax, Sheffield, Nottingham and Derbyshire.[51] In the north east, where Risdon served as the regional officer, small enclaves of support formed in Hull, Newcastle and Gateshead. In the last, a relatively large party of some 50 members was chaired by Dr Gerald Newton, with Norman Harris acting as the party secretary.[52] Further south, Martin Woodroffe and Brian Niall helped oversee the formation of a 40-strong New Party branch for Rochester and Chatham, complete with youth organisation.[53] In Reading, a local branch grew up during the general election around J. Buckley and the party candidate, Eric Rider Troward. This, however, appears to have been rather small, given that Troward's agent was Walter Banfield, a former member of the right-wing People's League from Swansea who claimed to have grown 'sick' of the Conservative Party.[54]

The limited support engendered by the New Party's formation prompted some discussion within the leadership. At the party congress of June 1931, the centre's general pessimism was countered by the more optimistic prognoses of the party organisers.[55] In reality, the small returns registered by the local branches ensured that they soon became a drain on the party finances. As literature, letterheads and party cards were printed and distributed across the country, so little to nothing other than expense receipts and further monetary requests found their way back to Great George Street. In the meantime, those gathered around Mosley began to push for a more combative politics, thereby rendering local attempts to develop a sustainable grass-roots party apparatus of little consequence. With plans for a youth movement in the ascension, and with the party's composition and politics moving further away from the parliamentary mainstream, so the character and purpose of the local branches likewise evolved. According to Woodroffe, who stood as the New Party's electoral candidate for Chatham in October 1931, his own local branch took a decidedly sinister turn in early 1932. Consequently, Woodroffe chose to publicly distance himself from the 'childish' uniforms and 'Nazi' salutes redolent of the New Movement and later joined the League of Youth and Liberty (LOYAL) formed to combat both fascism and communism.[56]

Woodroffe's experience was not uncommon. Hodge, for one, would draw similar conclusions with regard to the London party.[57] Already, in the autumn of 1931, the proposed dissolution of the regional offices promised to further strip down the party's limited apparatus. From 1 January 1932, following a letter from Mosley dated 23 November,

party branches were made directly subordinate to the central executive; their brief was to carry out propaganda work and facilitate the formation of a disciplined youth movement.[58] Simultaneously, the party's London branches experimented with a new type of organisation modelled along paramilitary lines and extended across the national party in June 1932.[59] This New Movement essentially mirrored the youth movement apparatus (see below), with local branches reconstituted into 'groups' comprising ten members and a 'group leader'. Once more than ten members had enrolled, then the group would sub-divide into two groups and form a 'control', with the erstwhile group leader becoming a 'control leader' overseeing two newly-selected group leaders. The process would then be repeated in accord with further growth, providing a 'division' and a 'divisional leader' responsible for each control. Above all this, the maintenance and direction of the movement was to be overseen by a 'director' and 'assistant director' appointed to each designated area by Mosley. In particular, the local branches were to provide 'self-supporting' clubs committed to a range of political, social and sporting activity, including lectures, athletics, sporting events and regular 'club nights'. Subscription to the New Movement was set at 3d per week (1d for the unemployed).[60]

Again, little evidence remains as to the extent of the party's local organisation in 1932. We know that the London party continued to function through its two Nupa clubs (see below). By the summer of 1932, Great George Street had likewise been adapted to serve as a hostel for unemployed members.[61] We also know that a north-eastern variant of the New Movement was forged by Michael Jordan under the direction of Risdon and Leaper. This began with just three members. 'We met at weekly intervals,' Jordan later recalled, 'and in six weeks grew to eight.' Over time, he claimed to have established a series of branches in Gateshead, Newcastle, Durham, Middlesbrough and elsewhere, all of which fed into the BUF from October 1932.[62] In Northampton, too, Musgrave received instructions to prepare the ground for the publication of *The Greater Britain*, though his offer to form an unemployed section and, later, to organise 'storm troops' was politely declined.[63] Elsewhere, as in Manchester, little appeared to change. Although the local branch was by this time headed by Walter Dent, a 30-year-old war veteran who later joined the BUF, the party remained a rather lacklustre affair. According to Fawcett, there was 'nothing really active about the New Party […] it hadn't got off its feet, as it were'.[64]

As should be obvious, the New Party proved unable to develop either a stable or a co-ordinated political apparatus beyond its London base.

There was, from the outset, only limited interaction between the party centre and the local branches outside of London; the regional offices proved too thinly spread and too ill-equipped to properly maintain a national party organisation. Not surprisingly, this tended to breed either resentment or blind obedience. In Gateshead, the aforementioned party branch splintered in the lead up to the 1931 general election. Following an appeal by Risdon to prepare the way for Stuart Barr's candidature, several members resigned 'on the grounds that the organisation is a Fascist dictatorship not acceptable to working-class members'. According to J. Swanston, who served on the branch executive, 'the policy of getting up a mobile force to act as a bodyguard to satisfy persons who are looking for limelight in the political world does not appeal to me'.[65] Earlier, in Manchester, the local branch had been even quicker to object to the authoritarian structure of the New Party, complaining of the centre's 'continual discourtesy' and disinterest. The final straw, it seems, came when the local party was by-passed in the adoption of Allan Young as the prospective New Party candidate for the Ashton-under-Lyne by-election. Although a 'clear-the-air' meeting was held on 20 April 1931, at which Strachey and Cynthia Mosley represented the party headquarters, Norbury continued to bemoan the 'undemocratic' and 'unconstitutional' nature of the New Party, suggesting that it 'savoured of the dictatorship which has been mentioned in connection with the Mosley policy'.[66]

Such discord and division served only to reaffirm the limited potential of the New Party's original structure and approach. For all their claims to modernity, Mosley and his New Party rubbed against the grain of those wider developments transforming British politics in the wake of the Great War. Indeed, women, tea and buns were very much part of the immediate political future, not relics of a supposedly discredited past. Where Mosley looked to charismatic leadership and an overtly confrontational politics that spilled into violence, so the British public began to respond more to the canvassing of integrated local parties and new media as they served to construct a far more peaceable political culture over the course of the interwar period.[67] Given this, the demagogic and hierarchical nature of the New Party attracted only modest support, provoking Mosley to conceive a broader political movement that provided potential members with a purpose and a distinct identity. Thus, as Mosley procrastinated over his political future on the eve of the 1931 general election, at least one thing had become clear: 'the movement', he insisted to Nicolson, 'is more important than the party'.[68]

Youth youth youth

In October 1931, Mosley outlined what he called the 'fundamental task of new creation'. The objective was to construct a modern state 'more relevant to the modern age than the transient labours of a nineteenth century parliament'. To do this, he proposed a new and dynamic political movement built on the promise of youth and committed to the transformation of all aspects British life.[69] From here on, the New Party's stated aim was no longer to merely offset the economic crisis, but to rouse a reconstituted Britain befitting the 'strength, vitality and loyalty' that Mosley claimed to underpin the nation.

Integral to Mosley's schema was the formation of the New Party's youth movement, Nupa. Therein, young men who believed that words were 'no longer enough' gathered to 'wage war on the bunk merchants of all types, creeds and classes'. According to Peter Cheyney, the maverick journalist, actor and ultra-nationalist who helped develop the Nupa prototype, the New Party was unlikely to achieve power via parliamentary means. On the contrary, it would have to '"acquire" anything it gets'. Nupa was to provide the mechanism by which to do this; it would forge a 'shock movement' comprised of disciplined young men imbued with a 'vibrant nationalism' and ready to serve in the construction of the corporate state.[70]

The formation of Nupa proved controversial. Almost from the outset, the promise or presence of youth troupes raised concern as to the direction in which Mosley was taking the New Party. Despite the existence of ostensibly analogous organisations across the political spectrum – Labour League of Youth, Junior Imperial League, National League of Young Liberals, Young Communist League – the New Party's youth section immediately appeared set for a purpose distinct from simply rallying young people beneath a particular political banner. Even Strachey, who harboured grave misgivings about the proposed youth movement, insisted that it would constitute 'something much more' than the typical political youth group: by combining political work with recreation and athletics, New Party youth were to stimulate the nation's 'will to live'.[71]

What did this entail? The form and purpose of Nupa took time to develop. Arguably, the seed of its fruition was planted in the party's decision to develop a bodyguard and team of stewards to 'protect' party speakers at public meetings. Such a move was, in part, a response to the ill-feeling revealed at the party's early meetings and the tempestuous end to the Ashton-under-Lyne by-election.[72] Nevertheless, the

formal constitution of what the press labelled Mosley's 'Biff Boys' soon led to rumour of New Party 'toughs' being organised as 'storm troopers'.[73] Thereafter, the bodyguard become a staple part of Mosley's meetings (though not necessarily of New Party meetings *per se*), combining with the stewards organised by men such as Eric Hamilton Piercy, a special constable who later headed the BUF's infamous I Squad, to provide a rather intimidating – if also theatrical – presence at many a New Party occasion.

More often than not, the majority of New Party stewards were enlisted from the Oxford hearties brought into the party by Nicolson and Howard. Attracted by Mosley's verve and keen to 'have some fun', these 'plus four types' soon formed a significant portion of the party membership.[74] In time, the recruitment of Ted 'Kid' Lewis – the world boxing champion employed to lead and train Mosley's bodyguard – lent some proletarian muscle to the party armoury, bringing a pool of approximately 50 east end 'toughs' to its extra-parliamentary ranks.[75] Ultimately, however, as Mosley sought to channel such exuberance to the purpose of the New Party, it was the 'charming [...] but terribly immature' Howard who took charge of the fledgling youth movement.[76]

Debate as to how best deploy the youth movement moved to the centre of the New Party agenda during the summer of 1931. The party congress in June played host to a polyphony of ideas chiming in apparent discord with each other. Some, including Peter Winkworth, urged the party to appeal to the 'athletic side of youth', opening the way for those who envisaged a movement that related closely to the Nazi model progressing inside Germany. Others, including the Oxford Union treasurer, Mr Papineau, preferred that the party retain more intellectual appeal. Joad, meanwhile, humorously pondered as to the difference between 'Hellenism' and 'Hitlerism'.[77] As noted in Chapter 3, it was Papineau's view which prevailed, leading the congress to resolve that the youth movement should 'proceed with more caution'.[78] An Active Force Committee was formed under the chairmanship of Maurice Oughton and direction of Cuming and Paul, before plans to develop a 'pioneer movement' were fine-tuned behind the closed doors of Great George Street.[79]

Beneath such compromise, the division within the party was clear. As Young raised his concern that a youth movement committed to an avowed anti-communism would precipitate rather than forestall a revolutionary crisis in Britain, and with Strachey arguing that the movement should be geared towards the recruitment and betterment of the working class (rather than in opposition to the workers' movement), so

the shifting intellectual sands on which the party was built became manifest.[80] By July, two competing tendencies could be discerned within the youth movement. On the one hand, there existed a group gathered around Winkworth that comprised 'not an actual fighting force, but something in the form of cohorts, on a quasi-Hitlerist model, of young men (mostly from the well-to-do classes, including a number of Oxford and Cambridge undergraduates)'.[81] On the other, a more cerebral section of erstwhile ILPers continued to mistrust both the fascist overtones of Winkworth's group and the Oxonian presence of Howard.[82] The ideal, Mosley continued to believe, was a combination of the two: a 'Siamese connection' in which 'Kid' Lewis and Sachie Sitwell formed the physical symbiosis of the youth movement.[83]

Not surprisingly, the character of the party's youth section clarified in the wake of Strachey and Young's resignation.[84] Thereafter, as the balance of power within the party tipped further towards its 'incipient fascism', and as the party ranks were swelled by those attracted to its deepening anti-socialism, so the more combative wing of the movement gained prominence. Men such as Glyn Williams came to the fore, arguing that ritual, display and colour should be combined with local organisation in appeal to potential working-class recruits. Williams, it seems, was responsible for introducing the idea of clubs to the New Party, initially with regard to organising through the common rooms of local working men's associations. Simultaneously, the party began to attract members with a penchant for militarism and an ultra-nationalism already honed on Britain's political fringe, most of whom recognised in the New Party a means of ridding Britain of its 'red menace'.[85] Thus, Cheyney and Colonel Ralph Bingham began to exert greater influence over Mosley, helping to mastermind the formation of Nupa in September–November 1931. Partly as a result of such initiative, Howard toured the country in the autumn of 1931 to launch a series of 'pioneer' clubs in and around London, Birmingham, Stoke, Nottingham and elsewhere. He also edited a related journal, *Pioneer*.[86]

Not coincidently, the more concerted attention applied by the New Party to its youth movement occurred in the wake of the Labour government's collapse. With parliamentary democracy seemingly at an impasse, with unemployed workers taking to the streets in communist-led demonstrations, and with sailors resorting to mutiny in the face of public spending cuts, so the New Party prepared to confront the socio-political crisis it had long predicted. Amidst the wider party reorganisation outlined above, designs were made to better co-ordinate and

direct the youth movement. First, it was to develop its own distinct identity. Nicolson argued that it should be known as VOLT, standing for vigour, order, loyalty and triumph, while Williams preferred the term 'Ozzies'.[87] Eventually, the party leadership settled on Nupa sometime in late October 1931. Second, plans were drawn up as to the movement's structure and printed in *Action* in November. Thus, in typically excessive language, Cheyney wrote of Nupa 'shock' and 'youth' movements, wherein young men would train their minds and muscles to forge a disciplined comradeship that stood in contrast to the 'Red "comrades" of the sickly sickle'.[88] To this end, Nupa groups were to form in parallel to New Party branches. Both would help develop ostensibly non-political youth clubs to recruit members, but these would be run by Nupa members appointed by and answerable to the party centre rather than the local branch.[89] After much 'heated discussion', it was further decided that Nupa membership would be open to men only, with members forming into groups and, once sufficient numbers had been recruited, 'controls' subordinate to a designated leader.[90] The group leader was then to assign tasks to his members, training them in propaganda work and co-ordinating them into 'cells' – 'one of the few things that we can take from communist organisation' – so as to disseminate party policy in 'allocated organisations' such as political clubs, debating societies and factories. From 1 December 1931, Nupa group organisers were deployed from Great George Street to assist local branches in establishing youth sections.[91]

Prior to this, two prototype Nupa clubs were launched in London in late 1931. The first, eventually known as Nupa Club No. 1, was opened at 122 King's Road, Chelsea, on 12 October 1931, and contained the youth movement's headquarters; the second, Nupa Club No. 2, was opened in Greenwich soon after.[92] The clubs endeavoured to meet Cheyney's brief. Boxing and ju-jitsu classes were quickly arranged, fencing competitions were organised under the tutelage of C. L. de Beaumont, a rugby team was formed (symbolically, perhaps, its first game was called off due to fog), and a debating society organised alongside a lecture series centred on party policy and topics such as 'The March on Rome' (A. R. Bennett).[93] By 1932, as reported in *The New Times*, the clubs had forged a close-knit and active community for a small but apparently committed band of Mosley admirers, many of whom – Vincent Collier, Arthur Mills, Patrick Moir, Dick Plathen, E. D. Randall, Douglas Revett – would later become engaged in the BUF. To all extents and purposes, therefore, Nupa had become the New Party by mid-1932. From April, Nupa formed the bedrock of the party organisation and its members the

'nucleus of Britain's storm troops', replete in a uniform of grey shirts with black trimmings and a pair of flannel trousers.[94]

We should note, of course, that not all New Party members were convinced by this. Writing to *Action* on 24 December 1931, R. N. May celebrated the 'comic bunk' of Cheyney's shock propaganda groups working throughout Britain. 'N.U.P.A' was but a piece of 'girls high school abbreviation', he continued; or worse, an example of 'Hitler-cum-Soviet nomenclature [sic]'.[95] Within the party executive, too, concern over the influence of Cheyney and Bingham was registered from November 1931. According to Nicolson, who found Cheyney a 'most voluble, violent and unpleasant type', Mosley recognised that the 'saluting business' and 'orderly room atmosphere' could well make the party seem 'ridiculous'.[96] But although the party finally rid itself of Cheyney and Bingham in February 1932, the damage had been done.[97] Accordingly, as Nupa members began to look to Germany for inspiration, so a number of party members followed Woodroffe's example in resigning their membership and recoiling from the political extreme. Through Nupa, it seemed, *fascismo* had prevailed.

5
London Calling: Journeys Through and Around the New Party

For Ian Mikardo, the reasoning was simple. As a young 22-year-old Labour Party member in 1930, he had grown disillusioned with the 'blind groping' of the MacDonald government as it struggled to find a solution to the worsening problem of unemployment. What he wanted, Mikardo later remembered, was an assertive socialist policy; one that offered a 'way out of the gloom' and promised to improve the lot of the beleaguered working class. In Mosley and *A National Policy,* Mikardo believed to have found just such a 'shaft of light'.[1] In 1931, therefore, he joined the New Party in the firm belief that it was blazing a path for the rest of the labour movement to follow.[2] It was only later, when the authoritarian traits already evident in Mosley's policies found expression in a fully-blown fascism, that Mikardo realised the error of his ways. The whole episode, he recalled, knocked the political stuffing out of him. It would be some years before Mikardo refound his socialist ire, eventually becoming the Labour MP for Reading in 1945.

Was Mikardo's journey to and from the New Party typical? Yes and no. On the one hand, we could look to Vin Williams, the unemployed Derbyshire miner and sometime door-to-door salesman who similarly joined the New Party in 1931 under the impression that he had discovered a practicable path to socialism. Having tried and tired of the CPGB, ILP, Derbyshire miners' union and Labour Party, Williams turned to Mosley and stood as the New Party candidate for North East Derbyshire in the October general election. Like Mikardo, however, he eventually recognised that the New Party's pledge to 'ruthlessly' suppress anything that stood in the way of industrial reorganisation could just as well include the workers he appealed to on the hustings.[3] On discovering Mosley's fascist turn, Williams 'denounced the New Party for all it was worth', though he too took time to recover from the experience.[4]

On the other hand, those sending letters of application for New Party membership included men such as Eric Rider Troward, a former trainee barrister, journalist and maverick 'entrepreneur' who regarded the New Party as the means by which to prevent a 'massed attack by the unemployed on the people with property'.[5] Having previously served in the Organisation for the Maintenance of Supplies (OMS) formed to combat the 1926 General Strike called by the TUC in support of the mineworkers, Troward was instinctively and committedly anti-socialist.[6] Not dissimilarly, ex-military men such as Colonel Ralph Bingham entered the New Party in order to thwart the potential for 'red' revolution. He, too, had served in the OMS and boasted an ultra-nationalism that spilled into open fascism. Prior to his joining Mosley, Bingham had been a member of both the BF and its more violent offshoot, the National Fascisti.[7]

Quite clearly, the New Party found home for people with ostensibly conflicting political perspectives and objectives. If the party's initial base was founded on renegade ILPers and various friends and acquaintances known to the Mosleys' social and political circle, then it later opened its doors to erstwhile empire crusaders, frustrated Liberals, assorted military veterans, and a small band of young men enthused by the dynamics of continental fascism and keen to channel such political vigour into their own British surroundings. For one of these, known as E. C. W, Britain in 1932 was faced with a crisis of greater magnitude and severity than it had ever experienced before. The nation, he believed, would have to decide between communism and an 'opposite reality' born of youth, crisis and ordeal. As to what that 'reality' entailed, there was by this time little doubt. 'There is only one political force that can successfully combat the red menace', a fellow Nupa recruit insisted in the summer of 1932. 'It is Fascism. We are Fascists. We have a uniform [...].'[8]

Such divergent understanding of the New Party's purpose reveals much about both the breadth and the limitations of its appeal. It also demonstrates the transmutational nature of its development. This chapter will seek to explain what brought people into the New Party, considering the various milieus from which its small membership tended to be drawn and the myriad routes through the party experienced by its supporters. In the process, three methodological caveats need to be borne in mind. First, personal accounts of the New Party must always be read with respect to Mosley's eventual embrace of fascism. For socialists such as Mikardo and Williams, not to mention John Strachey, association with Mosley and the New Party cast a rather

unpleasant shadow over their lives, both publicly and personally. That they had been entranced by what, ultimately, became the antithesis of their supposed socio-political beliefs provided a 'hurtful' memory. As a consequence, recollections of New Party involvement are often defensive and self-justifying.[9] Second, the organisation of people into 'types' is a fraught and contentious business. As such, the sub-sections below should not be read in too fixed a way. They form a useful means of analysing the New Party membership but are by no means definitive or even self-contained. Finally, the turnover of New Party membership and association was fairly brisk. People flitted in and about the party; many close to the party may well not have actually joined it in the formal sense. Similarly, the transformation of the New Party over 1931–32 means that the composition and balance of forces within the party membership were constantly changing. People joined at different times and for different reasons; if the party was always a political hybrid, then it was a variable one. To state the obvious, the New Party repelled more people than it attracted. To some, however, Mosley and the New Party appeared – albeit briefly in many cases – to provide an answer to the severe political and economic problems of the time.

Oscillate wildly

Looking back in 1934, Bill Allen wrote harshly of those who had plotted with Mosley but ultimately baulked at joining the New Party. Such behaviour, Allen concluded, represented the 'oscillations of individuals who have since proved able to reconcile themselves with an environment which they then found intolerable and hopeless'. From the right, Allen insinuated that men such as Elliot, Stanley and Boothby had revealed themselves to be 'victims of the "bourgeois mentality"' endemic within the Conservative Party. On the left, he suggested that Bevan and the bulk of Mosley's Labour group had been gripped by a 'social democratic conscience' that proved ill-suited to the 'hard realities' of the crisis unfolding before them. All, Allen concluded, had succumbed to the 'mediocrity' that had ensnared British politics in the age of liberal democracy.[10]

Of course, the reality was far more complex. Throughout 1930, Mosley's policies attracted a great deal of interest. Inside the Labour Party, both his memorandum and manifesto provoked a serious debate as to the viability of their proposals and their relationship to socialism. Among Mosley's Conservative and Liberal friends, aspects of his evolving programme chimed with their own priorities and fed into the

broader sense of cross-party dissatisfaction directed towards the orthodox treasury opinion that held sway on both sides of the Commons. As the government continued to stall, and as the economic crisis continued to deepen, so widespread talk of national governments and cross-party initiatives found regular echo in the debates conducted in what Simon Ball has described as the 'rolling political salon' held at Mosley's London home in Smith Square.[11] Accordingly, it should be of no surprise that common cause was found between those contemplating the possibilities of economic planning and a more assertive response to the crisis. Nor should it be a surprise to find that men such as G. D. H. Cole and Keynes discussed and even found favour with aspects of the programme put forward by Mosley in the context of 1930–31.[12] There was, however, to be a significant difference between expressed interest and committed support. Mosley's mistake, and Allen's with him, was often to conflate the two.

Despite this, a distinct – if somewhat amorphous – Mosley group did come together in late 1930. At its centre were members of the PLP already close to Mosley, including Cynthia Mosley, Strachey, Bevan, Forgan, Baldwin and a cluster of west Midlands MPs who shared Mosley's disillusionment with the parliamentary process and wished to 'ginger things up'.[13] Among them was W. J. Brown, who with Forgan provided a link to the ILP rebels gathered around James Maxton. Indeed, Brown was the secretary of the ILP parliamentary group and worked hard to build a bridge between the two renegade factions inside the PLP. His efforts proved unsuccessful; the Maxton and Mosley groups generally kept their distance in 1930–31. Where Mosley had little sympathy for the disruptive tendencies of the ILP, so Maxton – along with other leading ILPers, such as Fenner Brockway – distrusted Mosley and dismissed his programme as lacking a sufficiently socialist core.[14] Although Brown endeavoured to rally ILP support for the 'Mosley manifesto', only John McGovern signed from the leading Clydeside group.[15] That said, a small but growing nucleus of dissident (non-parliamentary) ILPers had begun to gather behind Mosley by late 1930, most of whom were based either in Birmingham or London.

Nye Bevan's place in the midst of Mosley's Labour group provided at least a semblance of working-class support for the subsequent manifesto. According to John Campbell, Bevan's relationship with Mosley stemmed from his own isolation inside the PLP. Though a miners' MP, Bevan stood out from the crowd of mainly older and avowedly loyal trade union MPs who formed the bedrock of the PLP – the so-called 'mugwumps' in Mosley-circle parlance. Nor was he close to Maxton's

ILP group. As such, Bevan moved into Mosley's orbit via Strachey, with whom he visited Russia in 1930, attracted by his relative youth (Bevan himself turned 33 in 1930) and his desire to forge an assertive and practical policy in the face of the economic downturn.[16]

Beyond Bevan and Brown, the Mosley group remained short on trade union influence. Arthur Cook, the ailing miners' leader who had befriended Mosley and Strachey during the 1926 General Strike, lent his support. As an ex-communist and militant trade unionist, Cook had little time for the cautious instincts of the Labour leadership; in 1928, he had co-sponsored the Cook–Maxton manifesto that absorbed ILP and CPGB critiques of Labour to accuse it of reneging on its socialism.[17] As such, Cook saw the 'Mosley manifesto' as a constructive attempt to deal with the overriding problem of unemployment and duly offered his signature.[18] Other than this, however, only one further trade union sponsored MP signed the 'Mosley manifesto', Joe Batey, and he remained very much on the periphery of Mosley's political circle.[19] Similarly, if Mosley's 'salon' opened its doors to Labour intellectuals such as Cole, then it found favour with relatively few beyond the wilfully eccentric Joad and others on the outer fringes of the socialist movement.

All in all, Mosley's Labour group appeared a rag-bag of assorted parliamentary and intellectual malcontents. Most were young men from middle-to-upper class backgrounds who fitted uneasily into their Labour body. Few had been raised in the socio-political environment that spawned the wider labour movement and its culture; if an MP, they were nearly all newly-arrived at Westminster with the election success of 1929 and comprised members whom the prime minister dismissed in December 1930 as being distinctly 'tenth rate'.[20] As such, Boothby was surely right when he predicted that 95 per cent of the PLP opposed Mosley and would have little interest in following him out of the party.[21]

By contrast, the Tory visitors to Mosley's 'salon' came from more entrenched party stock. By 1930, Mosley had aligned – to varying degrees – with a cluster of young Conservatives gathered in and around two intra-party 'ginger groups': the so-called YMCA, comprised of progressive Tories such as Boothby, Stanley and Elliot, and the Defeated Candidates' Association led by Macmillan, Terrance O'Connor and John Moore-Brabazon.[22] Within such ranks moved men bred for power: they had been raised in established political or societal families; most had schooled at Eton and Oxbridge. They were, moreover, ambitious and critical of Baldwin's leadership, neither of which meant that their relationship with Mosley was subordinate. Prior to Mosley's decision to forge ahead with the New Party, much of the cross-party intrigue

on-going throughout late 1930 had borne more of a strategical than a secessional imprint. Once discussion moved beyond the ineptitude of their respective party elders and the desirability of a more managed economy, then the political differences between Mosley and his Tory friends became apparent. Although Macmillan, Stanley and Elliot toyed longer than most with the machinations of Mosley, they – like Boothby, Moore-Brabazon, Bracken and others – soon recognised that their political futures lay inside the Conservative Party.[23] Macmillan, cuckolded by Boothby and without a seat, took refuge in a sanatorium and cleared his head ready for the 1931 general election; Stanley and Elliot succumbed to party pressure before falling back into line. As Boothby explained to Mosley on the eve of the New Party's launch, 'our chaps won't play, and it's no use deluding yourself that they will'.[24]

Given all this, Bill Allen's bitter reminiscences about weak-willed and careerist politicians provide little insight into the evolution of the New Party. Nevertheless, it was an irony of the party's brief history that it became known as much for those who almost joined as for those who did. Come early 1931, and the bulk of those who had flirted with Mosley over the course of 1930 chose not to follow him into a direct battle with the existing political order. In this, their reasoning was clear. First, as most of those close to Mosley realised, the New Party did not represent practical politics. Mosley had support, but it was qualified and insubstantial on both sides of the Commons. With talk brewing of a national government, it made far more sense to remain inside the existing parties and stake a claim as one of the 'new men with new measures' prepared to confront the crisis.[25] Second, where most of Mosley's 1930 supporters welcomed the chance to 'ginger up' the government and the established party leaderships, they did not thereby wish to wholly overturn the political *status quo*. If many a young Conservative made controversial hay with personal and political ambition in mind, then Labour men such as Bevan, Batey and Simmons retained an affinity with the labour movement that transcended any sympathy they may have felt for Mosley and his programme.[26] Even Cook, who Nicolson (via Strachey) claimed was 'entirely in favour of the New Party', baulked at openly declaring his support until the MFGB had 'broken with official Labour'. Though courted by Strachey as he lay in a hospital bed whilst being stung by communist criticism that he had already 'hitched his wagon to the star of fascism', Cook refused to budge.[27] Third, as Boothby and Macmillan warned, the party machines were far too powerful to be overrun by a mix of personal appeal and a clever programme.

Finally, Mosley's attempts to forge alliances beyond Westminster aroused far more suspicion than they did excitement. If Boothby disapproved of Mosley's seeking funds through the City and industry, describing it as 'madness', then Bevan reputedly made the more prophetic warning that such funding combined with separation from the labour movement would lead only to fascism.[28] Not dissimilarly, Mosley's courting of Beaverbrook and Rothermere was deemed both unwise and impractical by many in his circle. Not only would such allies prove unreliable, Nicolson and Boothby warned, but the party machines remained a far more powerful force in the country than the press. The public response to any 'Bevan–Mosley–Rothermere–Macmillan–Stanley–Boothby' alliance, Boothby insisted, would be curt: 'By God, now all the shits have climbed into the same basket, so we know where we are'. 'The only game worth playing,' he told Mosley sagely, was to try and 'collar one or other of the machines and not ruin yourself by beating against them with a tool that will almost certainly break in your hand.'[29] Typically, Mosley failed to heed his friend's advice.

Five men in a crisis

Not all of those close to Mosley boasted the foresight of Boothby or Bevan. On its formation, the New Party contained a ready-made hierarchy comprised of its small parliamentary group and a fledgling apparatus based around Mosley's already-functioning publicity committee and the research contacts he had long employed to provide the detailed meat for his broader arguments.[30] Come March 1931, and Mosley's appeal for members provoked a steady stream of idealists, opportunists and genuine sympathisers to make their way towards the party. The following section will briefly sketch the 'stories' of five such New Party supporters. Their experiences will then be used as a means of exploring themes relevant to understanding just who joined the New Party and their reasons for doing so.

The disillusioned socialist

Herbert Hodge was a taxi driver. He was also, at different times, a bakery boy, tyre fitter, van driver, labourer, journalist and chauffeur. Born in 1901 to a religious mother and an often unemployed and alcoholic upholsterer, his childhood involved the family moving from London to Lincoln and back again before Hodge left England for Canada in the early 1920s. He returned a few years later, got married and dreamed of becoming a writer whilst driving his cab. Politically, he was a self-

taught socialist who had joined and left the CPGB and National Unemployed Workers' Movement (NUWM) on his way to becoming a disgruntled Labour supporter. In 1931, he signed up for the New Party.

The New Party, Hodge believed, provided a ready alternative to the 'rigid dogmatism' of the CPGB and the failing Labour government.

> Here, it seemed to me, was a chance to build up something new and clean and vigorous, a party of men and women determined to break away from the old doctrines and prejudices, from rigid orthodoxies of all sorts, both capitalist and communist, and re-plan Britain on a basis of human values – an opportunity for men and women of goodwill in both classes to work together for a classless society.

And although Hodge remained unsure about the 'practicalities' of Mosley's programme, its reasoning and vision impressed him enough to propagate it from party platforms and to stand as the New Party candidate for Stepney Limehouse in the 1931 general election. Predictably, he lost heavily to his Labour opponent, Clement Attlee.[31]

Hodge's experience on the hustings all but quashed his early hopes for the New Party. Already there were doubts. On meeting Mosley in person, Hodge found him distant and insincere. On attending the party congress in June, Hodge despaired of the divergent opinions on show and the subsequent resignations of Strachey and Young. Come October, with a scratch organisation and 'hireling' agents brought in to direct the election campaign, Hodge took to tramping the Stepney streets with a portable platform and, more often than not, just his wife and the party's branch secretary for support. Not surprisingly, he returned to his cab in the wake of his election defeat and finally left Mosley behind once he had confirmed that the rumours of young men drilling and saluting under the auspices of ex-officers in the Nupa youth club were true. Labour, with all its apparent faults, was where Hodge appeared destined to remain.[32]

The progressive intellectual

Cyril Joad also came to Mosley from the broad ranks of the Labour Party. Joad, however, was a philosopher born into a respectable middle-class family in August 1891. Having suffered a lonely and rather unhappy childhood, he cut his political teeth in Balliol College, Oxford, where he cultivated a liberal socialism informed mainly by the writings of Shaw, Wells and the Fabian Society. In so doing, he embraced a range of 'progressive' causes, from pacifism and feminism to naturism and the

abolition of bloodsports, eventually finding a rather uncomfortable home on the fringes of the socialist movement. By 1931, he had become head of philosophy at Birkbeck College in London, and was both widely published and a well-known radio personality. He was also an established part of the Mosleys' social circle, regularly spending his weekends in their company at Denham.[33]

The New Party appealed to Joad for three principal reasons. First, it was formed by his friends and allowed him to exert an influence denied him in the Labour Party. Second, its 'practical' approach chimed with his own Fabian sympathies, by which he believed that science, industry and work should and could be directed under the auspices of the state in the interests of the community. We should note, however, that Joad's socialism was always contentious and imbued with a technocratic elitism that found little echo in mainstream Labour opinion. Notions of class and democracy made little impact on Joad's worldview except in a pejorative sense. In his own words, 'I was a socialist […] not because I admired and liked the working classes, but because I despised them; and it was the strength of my contempt and dislike which impelled me to make the efforts necessary to change them.'[34] Finally, Joad empathised with Mosley's generational politics. His thought was forever imbued with an anti-Victorianism that tallied with the New Party's condemnation of the 'old gang' and those of a 'pre-war mind'.

As noted earlier, Joad's time in the New Party ended in July 1931. Having taken an active part in developing both its policy and perspective, he recoiled from Mosley's deepening interest in fascism.[35] This, perhaps, revealed the fuzzy logic of Joad's mind, given that he recognised fascism to be a modern phenomenon and hoped to channel its vitality towards the more progressive causes that he held dear.[36] Eventually, however, the violent undercurrents that bubbled to the surface amidst the formation of the New Party's youth movement served to trouble Joad's pacifist sensibilities. Though he was happy to prescribe the sterilisation of the 'feeble-minded', he baulked at the politics of confrontation.[37] By 1932, Joad had returned to Labour's socialist hinterland, from where he continued to irritate and agitate in equal measure long into and beyond the 1930s and 1940s.

The family friend

From the outset, the New Party drew support from its core members' family and friends. One such was James Lees-Milne, a 22-year-old relative of Mosley whose life by 1931 encompassed a typically post-Etonian round of parties, odd jobs and paternal conflict. Though he went up to

Magdalen College in 1928, Lees-Milne found Oxford a 'disappointment', providing him only with an entrenched anti-communism derived from the growing band of 'fellow travellers' he encountered within the university.[38] He did, however, become acquainted with Harold Nicolson and others close to the New Party, among them Randolph Churchill, Christopher Hobhouse and Peter Howard. Given such company, Lees-Milne had drifted – nonchalantly, of course – into the party's orbit by the summer of 1931. Come October, with his Oxford days behind him and a dreaded future ahead, he travelled to Stoke to join with his aunt Maud in attempting to rally voters to Mosley's cause.

As this suggests, Lees-Milne was a snobbish aesthete whose affinity to the New Party was always tenuous. Looking back on the party's election campaign, he remembered it primarily for the small but 'grotesque' band of candidates put forward under the Mosley banner. 'A bruiser from Whitechapel, a sorry solicitor from the Midlands, a rugby playing Buchmanite, a paradoxical undergraduate just out of his teens, and an ingenuous man of letters (albeit the noblest and best of men) were a cross-section of this motley army who knew less than nothing about the political game', he recalled. The party's rationale, Lees-Milne later proposed, was to provide a 'solution to the mounting unemployment and despair of the working classes, and at the same time a substitute for communism, which was being dangled like a succulent carrot in front of them by the intellectual leftists'.[39]

Predictably, Lees-Milne's experience on the campaign trail failed to enthuse him. He regarded Mosley as little more than an egoist, whose lack of humility presaged a zealotry that was at once overbearing and repulsive.[40] Even so, a mixture of family ties and friendship ensured that Lees-Milne was at least willing to lend his time to the party. We may assume, too, that he concurred with the general thrust of the party programme. Beyond this, the only lasting thing that Lees-Milne took from his journey into the New Party was a lifetime affection for Nicolson. With Mosley's turn to fascism in the wake of his election defeat, Lees-Milne cut his already loose ties to the party. Literature, not politics, would provide Lees-Milne with a vision of the future.[41]

The university hearty

In truth, Peter Howard was rather more than a simple Oxford hearty who joined with Mosley to engage in the 'fun' of bashing reds and jostling the lower orders.[42] He had been born into a staunchly middle-class family in 1908, from where he made his way to Wadham College

via a scholarship granted on condition that he become a teacher following his graduation. He excelled at sports, particularly rugby union, to which end he captained both Oxford and the England national team. He also earned a reputation for rowdy and boisterous behaviour whilst enjoying his time as an undergraduate. In addition to heckling the Christian Union and running up debts in the company of Randolph Churchill, one of his more amusing 'japes' involved canoeing along the Oxford sewer system. Simultaneously, however, Howard harboured ambitions to be a writer and conceived his politics to be those of the 'underdog'. Though hardly a socialist, he approved of Mosley's attempts to alleviate unemployment and was evidently affected by the poverty he witnessed during his travels around the country with the New Party. 'I began to envisage myself as a sort of latter-day Lenin,' he later wrote, 'inflaming the country by my voice and pen, getting power with public acclamation and at once by drive and initiative righting these shameful wrongs.'[43]

Howard was recruited to the New Party by the ubiquitous Nicolson, whose trips to Oxford saw him rally a number of young men under the Mosley banner. Once on board, Howard was employed to organise the party's fledgling youth sections and to gather up his fellow Oxonians to act as stewards at party meetings. As such, Howard was no doubt one of the 'half-baked undergraduates out for a lark' so despised by party members such as Hodge but beloved by Mosley.[44] Certainly, Howard became a regular presence on and around the New Party platform in 1931, and was usually caught up in the violent scenes for which Mosley would be renowned. 'I was mobbed at Reading,' he recalled, 'knocked down and kicked in South Wales, had my head cut wide open with a blow from a chair in the Birmingham Rag Market, and was slashed with a razor in Glasgow.'[45] As to the country's wrongs, he blamed the 'detested' politicians whom he would later harass in his column for Beaverbrook's *Sunday Express*. In the meantime, Howard held fast to what he regarded as Mosley's courageous lead.

Howard's way out of the New Party was both personal and political. As well as serving Mosley, Howard also began to train for the bar and work as a private tutor in order to pay off his university debts. The latter involved helping Sir John Dyer find a place at Oxford and meant Howard's living in St Moritz for part of the summer in 1931. Whilst there, Howard met Doë Metaxas and fell in love. On his return, therefore, Howard found his interest in the New Party compromised by a new passion. In September, he informed the absent Doë that: 'Everyone in the office is hunting for me and very cross because I have gone

off. But I can't go any longer without writing to you.' Even parental disquiet could not prevent love finding its way; Howard and Doë were later married in 1932.[46] Simultaneously, Howard found his authority as secretary of the party youth movement contested by the influx of members from beyond the university keen to transform Nupa into a more assertive anti-communist force. Although Howard overcame the initial challenge of Cheyney and Bingham, his loyalty to Mosley was finally doused by the turn to fascism in 1932. With his paid position in the party under threat amidst its reorganisation, Howard left with Nicolson to pursue a career as a political journalist and to seek spiritual sustenance in Frank Buchman's Oxford Group.[47]

The radical reactionary

Peter Cheyney was at once one of the most colourful and unpleasant characters drawn to the New Party in 1931. He was born in 1896 as Reginald Southouse Cheyney, the son of a fish salesman from London's east end. As his change of name suggests, Cheyney was something of a chameleon character. Having served in the Great War, he later passed through a series of 'careers' that ranged from bookmaking and journalism to broadcasting and theatre work. His politics were reactionary in the extreme. As one story goes, he responded to being introduced to a black friend of a club acquaintance by shouting 'how dare you' and storming from the room.[48] He was also ultra-patriotic and vehemently anti-socialist. In 1926, he volunteered for the OMS, working with Bingham to organise and dispatch their 'troops' to the requisite areas; soon after, he served as a special constable. At the very least, Cheyney was aware of Britain's fascist fringe by the end of the 1920s, though the extent of his political activity remains uncertain. In all probability, he worked for the Industrial Intelligence Board funded by business interests and linked to both special branch and MI5. Stephen Dorril has further suggested that Cheyney helped publish a pro-fascist journal for Ukrainian *émigrés* in the 1920s.[49]

Cheyney's support for Mosley appears to have become manifest some time after the Ashton by-election, perhaps stirred by stories of communist opposition to the New Party and Mosley's increasingly patriotic tone. On joining, he became involved in the stewarding of party meetings and reputedly did much to convince Mosley of the need to transform the fledgling youth movement into a more combative, military-style force. Cheyney clearly exuded a noticeable physical presence. He was well over six foot tall, keen on boxing and judo, and was known on occasion to sport a gold monocle, cape and red carnation. He also

nursed an interest in revolvers. By late 1931, he commanded sufficient influence within both the party and the London youth movement to present and detail the formation of Nupa to the readers of *Action*.

In Nicolson's account, Cheyney exerted a 'pernicious influence' on both Mosley and the New Party.[50] But Cheyney was a fantasist, forever looking for heroes to worship and scams to alleviate his basic hand-to-mouth existence. In this, Mosley and Nupa followed in a long line that led back at least to Captain Evelyn à Court Bergne, the man Cheyney served under during the war and whose first name he occasionally used. This time, however, Cheyney's initial aping of Mosley – he took up fencing in honour of the swashbuckling baronet – soon gave way to a clash of personalities. By the end of 1931, Cheyney's influence within the London youth clubs had already unsettled Howard and eventually proved too much for Mosley. Amidst the party's reorganisation in early 1932, both Cheyney and Bingham resigned in protest over attempts to rein in their more militaristic tendencies, though their proto-fascist influence remained imprinted on Mosley's psyche.[51] As to the future, Cheyney rerouted his fantasies in the form of the Cheyney Research and Investigations private detective agency before finally making his fortune as thriller writer.

Tangled threads

It would be naïve to see the above examples as wholly representative of the New Party. However, taken altogether they include a number of common themes that reoccur and cut across the party's limited membership. In general terms, the New Party exhibited a profile similar to that of Mosley's Labour group. It was overwhelmingly middle-to-upper class and predominantly male. As we shall see in Chapter 8, women were conspicuous by their absence from the New Party. Beyond Cynthia Mosley, whose role in the party dwindled over its duration, there were but few examples of women members. It was also a youthful organisation. Most New Party members were aged under 40; many had served in – or come of age during – the Great War and viewed their politics through the same generational lens as Mosley. This section will therefore examine some of the less readily apparent tendencies that helped define the party on its journey to fascism.

First, the bulk of the initial New Party membership was culled from those who perceived themselves to be on the left of the political spectrum, specifically from the ILP and the intellectual fringes of Britain's wider progressive milieu. This should not be surprising. Mosley, after

all, had been a Labour member since 1924 and a Labour MP since 1926; he had cultivated a base of political support inside the ILP and Birmingham Labour Party, and he would forever present his ideas as being progressive, modern and radical.[52] As such, the New Party's early membership tended to comprise those already close to Mosley or disillusioned socialists seeking an alternative to the Labour Party, ILP and CPGB.

With the exception of Bill Allen, who John Beckett remembered as 'dark, sensitive' and 'imbued with the new outlook and spirit', the original New Party leadership was dominated by former Labour and ILP members.[53] As we know, Mosley, Cynthia Mosley, Strachey, Forgan and Young each bore a Labour heritage, while a significant proportion of the party's initial personnel were ILPers sympathetic to Mosley and, simultaneously, unconvinced by either Maxton or the mainstream Labour leadership. So, for example, the New Party found home for Dick Plummer (former manager of the *New Leader*), Marshall Diston (treasurer to the ILP London and Southern Counties Division), Wilfred Risdon (Midlands organiser for the ILP), Leslie Cuming (propaganda secretary for the West London ILP federation) and James Stuart Barr (Labour college organiser). Similarly, outside London and the Westminster village, the first flush of New Party branches were formed as breakaways from the Labour Party. Alongside Birmingham and Stoke, where New Party associations were initiated amidst the fallout from the Mosleys' split from Labour, the Manchester party was inaugurated under the auspices of a small group of local socialists convinced by Mosley's programme.[54] In Bradford, Hull, Sheffield and Liverpool, too, branches were forged by erstwhile Labour members proclaiming what W. H. Bell described as the 'new gospel'.[55]

Of course, the bulk of the labour movement – from the trade unions and PLP through to the ILP and Labour's constituency organisations – rejected Mosley's appeal. Even those sympathetic to his manifesto, or at least his urging the government to act, tended to draw the line at splitting from the Labour Party. Nevertheless, those who did leave to join the New Party did not thereby see their defection as entailing a wholesale rejection of their previous beliefs. Indeed, a staple argument of the New Party's early speeches was that its members remained committed to Labour's 1929 election pledges. What was needed, they argued, was an immediate and practical solution to an economic crisis that the Labour government had proven itself unable to meet.[56] Just as lower-ranking recruits such as Hodge, Williams and Mikardo believed the New Party to exist within the wider socialist tradition, so Strachey's resignation

from the PLP saw him reaffirm his belief in the 'socialist conception of an ordered and just society'. Cynthia Mosley, too, insisted that 'I still believe that the only final solution of our economic problems is the socialist solution', going so far as to tell a lively crowd in Hull that 'I am as much of a socialist as I ever was'.[57] If the New Party appeared to place practical necessity before ideology, then it did not deny the desirability of the socialist objective. In Dundee, when a section of the crowd responded to the party's speeches with a chorus of 'The Red Flag' and 'The Internationale', Forgan, Strachey and Cynthia Mosley joined in.[58] More succinctly, as Marshall Diston informed the ILP in Dulwich, the New Party 'was not a socialist party, and did not pretend to be, but it had ultimate socialist ends'.[59]

A comparable perspective may be discerned amongst what may be called the New Party's intellectual milieu. The likes of Joad, Catlin and Meynell came to the New Party as self-professed progressive thinkers attracted by Mosley's seeking a practical means of reform. All were associated with the socialist movement, either as Labour or CPGB members, while Catlin had previously helped found *The Realist*, a magazine of 'scientific humanism' that featured beneath its orange cover articles by such future New Party members as Joad and Gerald Heard.[60] Not dissimilarly, Peter Eckersley – formerly the BBC's chief engineer and part of a social circle that included Strachey, Horrabin, Raymond Postgate, Aldous Huxley and Wyndham Lewis – joined the New Party just months after considering an offer to stand as an ILP candidate in Leeds.[61] Amongst the party's more artistic set, Wogan Philipps and John Cornford passed through the New Party on their way to communism; in Bloomsbury, Leonard Woolf – as a Fabian socialist – took a close interest in the party's progress, though he resisted any temptation to join.[62] Even Nicolson, whose snobbish demeanour should have appalled most self-respecting socialists, regarded himself as being caught somewhere between 'left Liberal' and 'right Labour' in his basic political views.[63] In 1929, he even approached Hugh Dalton as to the possibility of forging a political career on 'our [Labour's] side'.[64] More generally, however, Nicolson sought to disown labels of 'left' and 'right', preferring to see his politics as transcending such tidy pigeon-holes.[65] As for the Sitwells, they – like Nicolson, Eckersley, Joad, Melville, Wells and Shaw – combined a socio-political elitism with a penchant for all things modern that allowed them to conflate fascism and communism as but two examples of the post-liberal state.[66] As such, they regarded themselves as progressive and radical; they held no truck with Labour socialism, liberal democracy or 'old' Toryism.

Clearly, for those who wished to believe, the radical origins of Mosley's programme combined with the evident disarray of the Labour government, the marginalisation of the ILP and materialism of the CPGB to ensure that the New Party could – initially at least – be understood as a practical alternative with its roots still embedded on the political left. Disillusioned with MacDonald and caught in the midst of a political and economic crisis that rode roughshod over Sidney Webb's famous recourse to the 'inevitability of gradualism', there were many in the early New Party who concurred with Hodge's interpretation of its purpose.[67] This would change over time. The influence of Allen – in tandem with members such as Melville, Box, Major Phelps Hodges and Major Tabor – brought with it a hardened nationalism and an anti-communism that provided for an alternative reading of the New Party. From Nicolson, the party inherited both a sense of non-ideological *Realpolitik* and an influx of young Oxonians with little time for the leftist sensibilities of many a party founder. By as early as May 1931, Nicolson noted that the 'main response' to the New Party now came 'from the younger Conservative group' who he found 'distinctly fascist in character.[68] For the New Party's chastised socialists, the choice was clear. They could leave, as Strachey, Young and Joad chose to do in July 1931, or they could reapply their statist and collectivist instincts towards a more nationalistic and forcibly corporatist end.[69]

Second, the New Party attracted those whose previous political labels had been worn only tenuously or with some discomfort. This revealed itself in a number of ways. Most obviously, those who joined from the left were not generally representative of a British labour movement that had come, for better or worse, to dominate progressive politics. With mainly middle-to-upper-middle-class backgrounds and often literary aspirations, they did not share – and nor did they always understand – the life experience and labour movement culture that formed the bedrock of Labour's identity. In particular, they tended to baulk at the class implications of socialism, preferring to see it as a means of economic reorganisation rather than a process whereby socio-political power would be transferred to working people. Likewise, the democratic principle implicit in the socialist cause was often buried beneath their technocratic inclinations. As such, the likes of Joad and Eckersley developed their own cerebral variants of socialism in drawing rooms some way from the trade union halls and shabby committee rooms frequented by the Labour rank-and-file. Even those New Party members who did boast a proletarian background, such as Young, Leaper and Risdon, tended to have substituted journalism, tutoring or paid party

work for the more hands-on employment to which their families and birthplace had provisionally lent themselves.

Such disassociation brewed discontent. Indeed, many of those who turned to the New Party did so having spent much of their time trying to reform the parties of which they had previously been members. Among the New Party's extra-Tory recruits were men such as Martin Woodroffe and Ronald Braden, both of whom had been enrolled in Beaverbrook's empire crusade. Bill Allen was an Ulster Unionist rather than a Conservative, and his politics reflected the tensions contained therein. He was, all the same, to the fore in attacking Stanley Baldwin's leadership of the Conservative Party in 1930, while Randolph Churchill continued to make mischief in Conservative circles whilst appearing for the New Party.[70] On the left, the New Party provided a ready home for the disgruntled. James Stuart Barr, for example, came to Mosley via the ILP and as a former member of the National Left Wing Committee Movement formed with communist help in the mid-1920s to propagate a more militant Labour policy.[71] Like Jack Jones, Jimmie Macdougall had been 'in and out of every section of the working class movement' before joining the Liberals on route to Mosley.[72] Cuming, Risdon and Diston had all been vocal ILP critics of the Labour Party, while William Weir Gilmour combined a socialist temperament with a staunch Protestantism that saw him pass though the New Party on his way from the ILP to the Scottish Democratic Fascist Party. Less dramatically, Young's discomfort within the ILP had become manifest by as early as 1928. Writing to Cynthia Mosley from the ILP conference in Norwich, he bemoaned the 'pathetic' arguments and pusillanimity of the party leadership, complaining that 'those who have courage have no brains and those who have brains have no courage'. By its end, Young claimed to have lost all respect for socialists in 'high places' and all but given up the 'hope of anything ever being done by the socialist movement'.[73]

Of course, the New Party also attracted those who had flitted around the fringes of British politics. Some, such as Meynell, Jones, Hodge, E. D. Randall, Arthur Reade and Bill Brown, had been communists; others, including Bingham, Cheyney, Barnes, Banfield and, later, E. G. Mandeville Roe and Neil Francis Hawkins, had connections to the far right. All were keen to see a radical overhaul of the British polity. More complex, perhaps, was the impetus driving Mosley's ex-Liberal recruits. Thus, Sellick Davies could pay due reference to the 'first-class policies' that comprised the Liberals' 1929 general election campaign, but recognise more generally that the party was no longer a viable political force. It was, Davies believed, ridden with internal division and hamstrung by

its dogmatic attachment to free trade.[74] As such, he – like Patrick Moir and Cecil Dudgeon – felt isolated and out-of-place in their Liberal surround, hankering instead for a modern alternative to the Liberals' radical legacy.

Third, and perhaps linked to the above, New Party members appeared to harbour rather restless souls. Not only had they tended to drift from one political organisation to another, searching – like Mosley – for a congenial home to express their ill-fitting views, but they also displayed a wanderlust that led them far from their place of birth and through a variety of occupations. With regard to the party's election candidates, Hodges' sojourn to Canada was complemented by Copeland Snelgrove's civil engineering work in Sweden, France, Italy and Africa, by E. J. Bartleet's travelling across 'all parts of the world' in his capacity as a mining engineer, and even by 'Kid' Lewis's boxing career, which led him to fight in Australia and America on his way to becoming the world welterweight champion. Less dramatically, Cuming had tramped to London having been raised in a Welsh mining village, while Diston and Leaper were much-travelled journalists. Troward, moreover, had been born in India before living in London, Gloucestershire, Hampshire and Birmingham on his way to Reading in 1931. His occupational CV included stints as a trainee barrister, freelance journalist (writing cookery articles for women's magazines under the pseudonym Janet Cunningham), garage owner, motorcyclist, editor of *Austin* magazine and advertising agent. Just for good measure, Troward also claimed to have been an air pilot.[75]

As this suggests, an unsettled – or should that be exploratory – nature was characteristic of both the party leadership and membership. Just as Allen had spent most of his 20s travelling and writing about the far reaches of Europe, so Nicolson's reputation was largely built on his career in the foreign office and diplomatic service. Both Mosley and Strachey had by 1931 developed political outlooks that were informed, at least in part, by their travels abroad. By the same token, the lower party ranks included men such as James Strachey Barnes and Arthur Reade. The former had been born to Anglo-Indian parents, brought up in Italy and schooled in England (Eton and Sandhurst). Disenchanted by the 'decline' of his English motherland, Barnes returned to Italy in the 1920s where he joined Mussolini's Fascist Party and resolved to propagate the Fascist cause from within the Lausanne-based *Centre International d'Etudes sur la Fascisme*. According to Barnes, who Nicolson thought a prime example of the 'ninnies and bores' attracted to the New Party, fascism embodied the pre-eminent values of Catholicism

and Britain's lost 'Norman aristocracy'. In other words, it provided a means of projecting the spiritual values of the Catholic middle ages onto a modernised future.[76] As this suggests, Barnes was – like the Sitwells, who also spent much of their time travelling between England and Italy – a keen Italophile. By contrast, Reade was a 29-year-old old-Etonian who had previously been sent down from Oxford on account of seditious activities inspired by his membership of the CPGB. In between times, however, Reade had deserted communism with the dubious honour of becoming Britain's first Trotskyist, before travelling and writing his way around Europe to indulge his bohemian lifestyle. Given all this, combined with the fact that his politics led him through the CPGB, Labour Party, New Party and MacDonald's National Labour Party, Reade has some claim to being an archetypal New Party member. Certainly, he was perceived by at least one observer to be an 'extremely difficult' character, 'very intelligent, individual with a rather eccentric turn, and unfortunately a heavy drinker'.[77] Fittingly, perhaps, he worked as a barrister during the 1930s.

Fourth, New Party members often embodied the generational conflicts so resonant of the interwar period. In other words, the party's battle against the 'old gang' and 'grey hairs' was often played out for real in the lives of its members. Of our five 'types' outlined above, Cheyney and Hodge both set themselves against their alcoholic fathers, while Lees-Milne fought constantly with a blustering father whose landed ancestry and associated values led him to despair of his effete young son. Even Howard, who generally got on well with his parents, briefly fell out with his father whilst at university.[78] Joad, meanwhile, was to make his life's work a philosophical denial of all that his staunchly Victorian parents stood for. None of this was coincidence. At the very top of the New Party, both Mosley and Cynthia had suffered estrangement from their fathers. Mosley's 'hard-riding, hard-drinking, hard-living' father had long been disowned by his family, though he re-emerged in 1926 to publicly disavow his son's socialism before dying in 1928. Almost simultaneously, Cynthia's relationship with Lord Curzon had deteriorated amidst a family dispute over money; the two were far from close on his death in 1925.[79] We could go on. Arthur Fawcett, for example, came to Mosley having rejected the Labour politics of his parents in favour of a patriotism fed by his enthusiasm for books on the British empire.[80] At all levels, the New Party was a hotbed of political patricide.

Such family strife served to embolden the New Party's generational appeal. If Mosley was, by 1931, open to the same charge that Wyndham

Lewis levelled against the Sitwells, that he headed a 'middle-aged youth movement', then he could mount a reasonable defence.[81] As Jon Savage has made clear, the term 'youth' had lost some of its biological meaning by the late 1920s. To be 'young' meant to be receptive to new ideas and to embrace the modern age.[82] In such a way, the likes of Joad and Nicolson, not to mention Mosley himself, continued to see themselves as young in mind and temperament. Nor was the party's appeal to youth wholly rhetorical. The undergraduate ranks of Nupa were soon offset by such New Party enthusiasts as the 13-year-old Esmond Romilly, the 17-year-old John Boucicault de Suffield Calthrop, and the 17-year-old Joan Thorpe, a junior clerk from south-west London who found in Mosley an 'honesty' and the patriotic will to confront the social deprivations afflicting Britain.[83]

For many such members, Mosley appeared an inspirational figure. His relative youth and assertiveness cut against the grain of British politics; his landed background, handsome looks and athleticism lent a sense of vitality to his actions and speeches. Fifth, therefore, New Party members came to Mosley in direct response to his public persona and the logic of his programme. This was sometimes overtly political, as with Hodge and the aforementioned Thorpe, whose imagination was sparked by what she regarded as Mosley's patriotic and assertive reaction to the poverty and ignominy afforded to the war generation. Similarly, Mikardo's support for the New Party was largely derived from Mosley's 'electrifying' speech to the 1930 Labour conference.[84] Mosley's policies had substance, and this served to attract those looking for a practical solution to the on-going economic crisis.

For others, Mosley's appeal was more visceral. As noted above, Howard and Cheyney appear to have responded, in part, to Mosley's athleticism and the physical expression of his politics. Howard even suffered from a lame leg, which he no doubt compared to the injury carried by Mosley since wartime. And nor was Howard the only sportsman to join the party: 'Kid' Lewis, Rowe Harding (former Welsh rugby captain), Steve Trainor (an erstwhile defender for Albion Rovers) and Charles de Beaumont (fencing champion) all aligned with Mosley in 1931. Simultaneously, darker forces were at play. The militaristic overtones that had long accompanied Mosley's pronouncements since before the New Party were soon given substance in the form of stewards, youth clubs and the Nupa organisation. Talk of uniforms, party colours and the onset of political display at party meetings combined with a growing emphasis on service and discipline to facilitate an aggressive but defiant aura around Mosley. As a result, the party began to attract those driven

more by the allure of confrontation – the thrill of the fight – than the rationale of its original programme. The party's initial appeal to the 'war generation' was by mid-to-late 1931 given expression in a membership that blended ex-servicemen with an assortment of professional military types and would-be soldiers keen to enact their lust for battle on the British streets. Somewhat differently, it has been suggested that Nicolson and other male party members were sexually attracted to Mosley.[85] This may well have been so, and we may presume that Mosley, as a renowned sexual predator with honed skills of seduction, was capable of utilising his personal magnetism to attract gay men to his cause. Equally, the homosocial culture that enveloped the New Party and Nupa quite possibly stirred physical as well as political desires within the party ranks. However, to assume that it was homosexuality that drew Nicolson – along with Baldwin, Hobhouse, Lees-Milne, Reade, Osbert Sitwell and Francis Hawkins – towards the party is to suggest a shallowness that can only belie life's rich complexities.

Sixth, the example of Lees-Milne provides us with a rather less than profound way in and through the New Party. From the outset, Mosley drew on the help and support of those close to him and his wider social circle. Alongside Cynthia, who followed her husband's lead loyally but sometimes with difficulty, Strachey, Young, Sutton, Nicolson and Joad were all long-standing friends of Mosley. Come October and Mosley's mother was drafted in to campaign for her son during the general election; de Beaumont was Mosley's fencing instructor before being conscripted to supervise training sessions at the Nupa club in London. Mosley's calling on the Sitwells was more complex. Although Sachie and Georgia were regulars at Denham by 1930, Mosley's motivation in keeping them close was not wholly political. Indeed, it says much about the 'etiquette' of the British upper classes that Sachie remained supportive of the New Party despite his wife's on-going affair with the party leader. More productively, Nicolson filled *Action*'s pages with articles written by his long-list of contacts. This, as with Lees-Milne, should not necessarily suggest avowed support for the New Party. Vita Sackville-West loathed Mosley, while Christopher Isherwood wrote for the paper full in the knowledge that it comprised 'the rankest John Bull stuff'. As his friend Edward Upward told him, Mosley and the New Party were 'the dirtiest lot of scum in England', but 'provided they pay you properly and don't require you to make statements about communists I suppose no harm will be done'.[86]

This, then, leads us to a final route into and through the New Party: financial incentive. Jack Jones later admitted that his joining the party

as a propagandist was primarily mercenary, and he claimed to have been joined on his arrival at Great George Street by a wash of 'political flotsam and jetsam' – ex-agents and ex-candidates – looking for work. Hodge recalled similar, describing the plethora of job hunters attracted to the party as buzzing 'like blue bottles round a dropped cod's head'.[87] Certainly, 'Kid' Lewis's membership was settled more on a business arrangement than a meeting of political minds, as were those of the east-end 'toughs' that he brought to party meetings for £10 a go.[88] As for Rupert Trouton, he lent his Keynesian know-how to the party only on receipt of a £500 salary and on condition that he should not write to order.[89] Despite this, it would be wrong to assume that the pursuit of a financial position within the party proves insincerity. Peter Howard was grateful for his £650 salary, but he also showed a genuine commitment to the cause. Alternately, in the case of Arthur Musgrave, his regular requests for employment were always refused, yet his support for Mosley remained unabashed until 1935.[90]

The routes to, through and beyond the New Party were varied. People joined for a variety of reasons that were sometimes as personal as they were political. Not surprisingly, they left in similar disarray. Some, including Forgan, Allen, Box, Leaper, Cuming and Risdon, followed Mosley into the BUF, as did the core of newer recruits attracted to Nupa as 1931 turned to 1932.[91] Strachey, like Philipps and Romilly, found his way to communism; Eckersley continued to flit between his own idiosyncratic understanding of socialism and fascism; Joad, Nicolson, Catlin, Reade and Young each – in sometimes overlapping but different ways – proceeded to seek a means of political consensus within the mainstream.[92] Predictably, perhaps, many of the early New Party members returned to Labour, while Sellick Davies appears to have left formal politics in order to pursue his career as an accountant. Most bizarrely, Egglestone resorted to playing the banjo in a Pierrot troupe in Bournemouth before applying unsuccessfully to work as an agent for the Conservative Party.[93] As this suggests, any search for a single common factor in determining New Party membership is prone to disappointment. At best, we can say that most, if not all, New Party recruits shared a sense of impending socio-political and cultural crisis. This was sometimes personalised, but in most cases was exacerbated by the economic problems of 1930–32. In response, they aspired to forge a new means of political expression that sometimes drew from the past but was primarily concerned with the construction of a distinctly modern future.

In many ways, the character of the New Party membership reflected the party's ambiguous and changing nature. At the outset, the party

had been seen by most to be a Labour splinter, so much so that G. D. H. Cole would later insist that the New Party 'preserved something of a left-wing façade' up until the October election.[94] Certainly, the Conservative Party archived the New Party's election addresses under a 'socialist' heading. In truth, Mosley had all but expunged such (mis)understanding in the wake of Strachey's resignation. Talking to the party's north east London office on 24 July 1931, he suggested that the 'New Party had suffered from the fact that a small section of their movement which came in from the Independent Labour Party and other extreme sections of the Labour Movement had always tried to treat the New Party as if it were a fractional break within the Labour Party rather than a new national movement'.[95] From there on, a disciplined nationalism combined with an overt anti-communism to inform the New Party's main political platform; Mosley himself provided the party's public point of focus to an ever-greater degree. Consequently, the varied and often cerebral cross-currents that had originally responded to Mosley's calling were channelled towards a more virulent end. Programmes were accompanied by uniforms; disgruntled socialists were eclipsed by ultra-nationalists; and the appeal for consensus gave way to the dictates of a leader.

6
Going Into Battle: The New Party and Public Politics

The problems really began when the loudspeaker system was sabotaged. As Mosley's speech fractured amidst the odd jolt of feedback, so the crowd of some 15,000 people packed inside the Birmingham Rag Market became restless. From the back of the hall, a small contingent of Labour and CPGB members endeavoured to make themselves heard, interrupting Mosley's flow and attracting the attention of the New Party stewards stationed at strategic points throughout the audience. A nod was given and a whistle blown. To the front of the platform marched a flank of Mosley's bodyguard, led as always by the stocky figure of Ted 'Kid' Lewis. On order, the bodyguard then moved into the crowd with Mosley jumping down from the stage, climbing over the rail, and following in their wake. A tense lull ensued before Mosley set about confronting his most persistent hecklers. Blows were stuck; chaos reigned. All across the hall, fights broke out between New Party stewards and sections of the crowd as Mosley and his comrades battled their way back to the stage under a hail of fists, chairs and bottles. Once there, a chorus of 'The Red Flag' was met by a New Party platform rendition of 'Land of Hope and Glory'. Simultaneously, missiles continued to be thrown and the stage rushed before the police finally moved in to disperse the crowd and convince Mosley of the need to return to his hotel under escort. Reluctantly, and somewhat indignantly, he agreed.[1]

The events in Birmingham on 18 October 1931 have some claim to being a defining moment in the New Party's history. Although previous party meetings had been subject to outbreaks of disorder, the scale of the Rag Market riot, not to mention the summons issued to Mosley as a consequence, ensured that it became one of the most notorious incidents of an exceptionally bitter general election.[2] Mosley's stewards and bodyguard, already gaining an unsavoury reputation as the so-called

'Biff Boys', were projected onto the lead pages of the national press. The association of Mosley and political violence was cemented; it appeared, with hindsight, to set in train the subsequent battles between communists and fascists that now seem so resonant of the 1930s. Not only did the co-ordinated and communist-led attempt to disrupt his speech help convince Mosley that Britain's future would be decided by an evermore combative struggle between communism and its 'opposite reality', but he evidently enjoyed the frisson generated by such confrontation. The Rag Market, Mosley claimed with the adrenalin still pumping round his body, was 'the finest meeting he had ever attended in Birmingham'.[3]

But do the splintered chairs of Birmingham, not to mention the image of a blood-stained Peter Howard and a concussed E. F. Kendrick, really offer a true reflection of the New Party? Was the Rag Market meeting really the most high-profile example of a violent undercurrent running through the heart of Mosley's proto-fascist politics? Did it really mark the culmination of the New Party's drift to an extra-parliamentary extreme; the point at which a symbolic Rubicon was crossed? The following two chapters will seek to provide the means by which to answer such questions. The first will look at the ways in which the New Party presented its politics to the British people, focusing primarily on its public appearances and the responses they engendered. The second will examine the party's attempts to absorb and utilise influential opinion to achieve its aims. The objective is to locate the New Party within the shifting contours of Britain's interwar political culture, to assess the extent to which Mosley's pursuit of a suitably modern politics in fact led him to swim against the prevailing political tide.[4]

The New Party in public

The New Party hoped to hit the ground running. Provisional plans to promote *A National Policy* had already been discussed by Mosley's publicity committee in early February 1931, paving the way for the national tour undertaken by the party leaders immediately following its formation. To this end, copies of *A National Policy* were dispatched to newspapers, periodicals, publishers and interested persons. Bill Allen and Allan Young co-ordinated a national poster campaign, with designs produced under the art direction of Francis Meynell.[5] These, in turn, were posted across London and throughout the towns and cities visited by party representatives over the course of March 1931, namely Stoke, Birmingham, Liverpool, Manchester, Leeds, Glasgow, Dundee, Cardiff,

Hull and Newcastle. In each, the largest hall available was booked in expectation of the interest generated by Mosley and his assertive plan of action.[6] Back in London, Eckersley set about trying to find radio airtime for the party, while Strachey estimated the cost of procuring a talking picture van. More generally, plans for a literature campaign and weekly newspaper were brought to the forefront of the fledgling party's agenda.[7]

The objective of the New Party's inaugural campaign was clearly stated: to rally the 'ordinary men and women of Britain who have no political careers to lose, but who do love their country and are not willing to see her ruin and their own'.[8] According to Gerald Barry, Mosley urged his publicity committee to 'play on their fears'; that is, he proposed that the posters screaming 'CRISIS' be designed to make people 'feel they will lose their jobs if they don't get a move on'.[9] Of course, Mosley's pleurisy and W. J. Brown's dose of the proverbial cold feet soon compromised the party's foresight. Nevertheless, the New Party's early forays into the public arena attracted significant interest, if not always of the kind expected. For all the overspill meetings and packed halls recorded in local newspaper reports, the popular response to the New Party was mainly a mix of curiosity and, from the left, resentment at the split in Labour's ranks. As the party was quick to realise, big crowds did not necessarily provide the basis for ready support.[10]

Similar conclusions were drawn from the party's by-election campaign in Ashton-under-Lyne. Although Young spoke to a series of well-attended meetings, the party's initial impetus soon appeared to wane before Mosley's belated appearance brought a renewed sense of urgency to the contest. This was not for want of trying. In the fortnight leading up to polling day the town was plastered with New Party posters advertising a series of relatively large-scale public meetings to which Cynthia Mosley, Strachey, Allen, Sellick Davies and Barr each made their appeal in support of Young. Simultaneously, Dan Davies, Jack Jones, Jimmy Steel and a couple of unemployed but 'broad-minded' communists set about establishing regular street-level pitches outside the local labour exchange and in the market square.[11] They were helped, on occasion, by Cynthia Mosley and Esther Strachey, both of whom held 'in our street' meetings to woo Ashton's women electors to the party cause. At each New Party event, pamphlets outlining party policy were distributed alongside a specially produced election newspaper entitled *The New Ashton*.[12]

Given Ashton's demographic profile, the New Party campaign focused mainly on the problems of unemployment and the cotton industry. An

emphasis was placed on working-class living standards and the need to ensure that wages were not cut in response to the economic downturn.[13] Come the general election in October 1931, however, and Mosley began to realign his approach. The split in the Labour government ensured that the crisis envisioned by the New Party had not developed quite in the way predicted. Where, previously, Mosley expected the 'old gangs' to come together in some form of national government, or simply to nullify each other with opposing – but equally outmoded – policies, the Labour Party's return to opposition, not to mention its reassertion of socialism, had ensured that the New Party faced competition for its place as the main political alternative to the national coalition. Labour, Mosley believed, was attempting to turn the crisis into a site of class conflict. In response, he recommended that his party concentrate its attention on the 'upper and lower-middle classes' and 'hit the blackcoat vote'.[14]

As this suggests, the general election came too soon for the New Party to mount a serious political challenge. Although the party often discussed contesting by-elections in the wake of Ashton, it conspicuously failed to do so.[15] Come October and the party's list of constituency targets and prospective candidates continued to change from week to week. Even Mosley took up the fight for Stoke only when it became clear that his wife was too unwell to defend the seat she had won for Labour in 1929.[16] Thus, in September, Mosley had considered standing in Watford, keen as he was to escape the malevolent atmosphere emanating from his former constituency organisation in Smethwick. Not dissimilarly, Nicolson had originally intended to stand in Exeter, Sellick Davies in Bristol, and Peter Eckersley in Harrow, none of which came to pass.[17] With just a week to go to polling day, *Action* published a list of 26 constituencies and an incomplete contingent of candidates.[18]

The reasons for the New Party's apparent lack of preparation were numerous. Not only was the party limited in terms of finance and organisation, but its relatively small membership did not contain many suitable for the rigours of electoral battle. In an oft-quoted account of a fruitless trip to Manchester in pursuit of prospective party candidates, Nicolson recorded a roll call of applicants that ranged from 'an old lunatic called Holden to a boy of 21 called Branstead who scarcely knows what the House of Commons is'. Only one of those interviewed, 'a wild-eyed nymphomaniac' named 'Miss Macculloch', was deemed 'a possible candidate', though Nicolson hoped a few of those interviewed would yet prove themselves 'positive workers' for the party'.[19] Equally, Mosley's decision to redirect the party's focus onto the middle classes

served to complicate matters, especially as he continued to toy with the possibility of forging alliances within and without of the national coalition.[20] As time pressed and the moment of electoral reasoning came ever closer, so Mosley appeared to prevaricate over the New Party's purpose and direction. In Nicolson's words, 'it is distressing that with so little time before us our leader should in fact be so uncertain of his views'.[21] As such, the party leadership appointed who it could where it could in accord with the scattered nature of the existing party branches, often parachuting in candidates and hired agents to try and bring some sense of co-ordination to what was a ramshackle campaign.

In the event, the New Party put forward just 24 candidates in the 1931 general election. Many of its key members – including Bill Allen, Cynthia Mosley, Peter Howard and Peter Eckersley – failed to find a suitable constituency in time to raise the New Party's orange-and-black banner, while a number of those who did stand proved to be wholly out of their depth. In Reading, for example, Eric Rider Troward immediately upset the local electorate. First, he described the town as the 'sleepiest, the most old fashioned, the most correct, [and] the most proper' on the New Party list, before saying that his short time in the town had put 'nine years on his life'.[22] By the end of the campaign, during which Troward's speeches were regularly interrupted by people refusing to sit down or be quiet for fear of appearing 'sleepy', he was close to a nervous breakdown and was later summonsed for failure to declare his election expenses.[23] Not dissimilarly, 'Kid' Lewis' affinity with London's east end failed to transcend the novelty of a boxing champion standing for parliament under the Mosley banner.[24] The Whitechapel electorate allowed him just 154 votes.

Despite this, it would be wrong to conclude that the New Party's scratch organisation put forward only neophytes unable to hold their own in the political spotlight. Among the party candidates were three sitting MPs (Mosley, Forgan, Dudgeon), one erstwhile cabinet minister (Sir John Pratt), at least two former parliamentary candidates (Barr, Davies), an ex-Labour councillor (Jesse Williams), and an experienced diplomat in Nicolson. Even among those making their first foray into electoral politics, Cuming, Lowell and Weir Gilmour were sufficiently capable to win plaudits from the local press as a result of their public performances.[25] Nor should we conclude that the New Party's campaign lacked engagement on the part of its candidates and supporters. Again, local newspaper reports suggest that party members committed to an intensive round of electioneering.[26] Even Troward claimed to have spoken to some 30 open-air meetings in the week prior to polling

day.[27] Generally, however, the party was pushed to the margins of the wider election campaign, ignored by the national press and rendered all but irrelevant to the mass of the British electorate.

Of course, the New Party was not just an electoral organisation. It also hoped to promote a 'new spirit' and a 'new message' in British politics; it hoped to reveal as obsolete the ideologies of the 'old gang' in order to rally a new movement committed to transforming Britain from a pre-war to a post-war nation.[28] To this end, a series of smaller campaigns were undertaken by the party's relatively modest band of paid propagandists between March and October 1931. These, typically, were directed by Eggleston from Great George Street and organised through the five regional (and four London) officers who, in turn, did their best to facilitate a series of localised New Party meetings. According to Jack Jones, who was promoted to the position of 'national propagandist' following his contribution to the Ashton-under-Lyne by-election, these tended to be rather primitive affairs. Thus, the party's 'Greater London' campaign comprised mainly of Jones and a lorry driver called George undertaking a two-week tour of the capital armed with a loudspeaker and a set of gramophone records. This was followed by the similarly low-budget 'Rouse Britain' campaign over the summer of 1931, during which time Jones claimed to speak at some 200 meetings.[29] Intermittently, too, local meetings were organised to which more renown New Party speakers would make an appearance, as with Cynthia Mosley's visit to Northampton in July 1931.[30]

Mosley himself made relatively few public appearances prior to the party's general election campaign in October 1931. Beyond a series of rather low-profile appearances in London, he spoke to the Oxford University Conservative Association in June and gave the keynote speech to the large party rally held at the Sitwells' ancestry home in Renishaw Park, Derbyshire, on 1 August.[31] This was an impressively elaborate affair. Organised by Vin Williams, it hosted an array of sports events, a brass band contest, acrobatics, a fun fair, and a prize draw that saw the holder of the 'lucky programme' go home with a saloon car. It was also well attended. According to one local paper, some 40,000 people passed through the Sitwells' gates, many of whom came via a fleet of specially-arranged buses and trains from as far afield as Newcastle and Stockport. Not surprisingly, Mosley was the day's principal political attraction, to which end he delivered a harsh speech on the cowardice of the Labour government and the wrong-headed economies recommended by the recently-released May Committee report. Snowden, Mosley insisted, was the flunky of the bondholder and the banker, while the government

appeared far more concerned with problems on the continent than with those in Britain. 'If a man were drowning today,' Mosley joked, 'he would have to shout for help in German.' As such, Mosley used the event to raise the slogan of 'Britain First' and to promise a new movement based on British – as opposed to Russian or Italian – values and objectives.

A month later saw Mosley launch the New Party's 'autumn push' from the plinths in Trafalgar Square. This proved a more solemn occasion. Heavy skies and a 'fine driving Scotch mist' ensured that only a few hundred spectators gathered to see Mosley arrive under escort of the youth movement and in the guard of 'Kid' Lewis. Thereafter, to a sea of umbrellas and a coterie of protesting communists, Mosley compared the recently deposed Labour government's failure to take advantage of the capitalist crisis as being akin to the Salvation Army turning tail and running away from the Day of Judgement. Next to him, a damp Nicolson, Allen and Davies shivered in the cold as their marigold buttonholes grew heavy in the rain.[32]

The calling of the general election in October 1931 conspired to derail the party's planned autumn offensive. Even so, there was still time for Mosley to open his party's Scottish campaign before attention turned to the ballot box and the hustings. In this instance, Mosley began with a foray to the heart of Glasgow, speaking on Glasgow Green to a crowd of some 20,000 on 20 September. As we shall see, the response presaged the Birmingham events outlined above, as violence flared and blood was spilt in the wake of Mosley's decision to confront communist cat-calls with his own version of mob rule.[33]

On the ground, New Party members struggled where possible to establish a semblance of political identity. Initially, at least, this often took the form of exploiting pre-existing contacts and outlets. In Forest Hill, the New Party branch sent representatives to the local mock parliament and appointed a strong debating team to visit 'local organisations of all classes'.[34] Not dissimilarly, Marshall Diston put the New Party's case to a packed 'socialist forum' in Birmingham in early 1931, while other erstwhile ILPers made similar appeals to ILP branches in and around London.[35] In Shipley, Bill Leaper even succeeded in holding an open debate with the CPGB's George Brown in the weeks prior to the general election.[36] As imaginatively, the Northampton New Party branch planned to send a speaker to the local British Legion in addition to organising regular meetings at the Wedgewood café and sending letters to the local press.[37]

Increasingly, however, party members began to venture out into the streets in their attempt to rally support and find sustenance for their vision of impending socio-political crisis. This, in turn, created sites of potential confrontation. During the general election, the provision of motorcars enabled some party activists to at least provoke a response from a largely nonplussed electorate. Thus, as Leslie Cuming was driven around Battersea with a loud hailer inviting electors to 'vote for Cuming', so he was greeted with the odd cheer and the more usual boo or groan, to which his driver tended to reply with a curt riposte of 'you go and hang yourself'.[38] In Highbury, too, New Party members soon took their message to the street corners, whereat they reputedly had to call the police to protect their platform from a hostile band of local communists.[39] Certainly, by 1932, such street-level tensions were becoming manifest. As the Nupa clubs nurtured an increasingly militant and assertive party core, so reports of mass brawls in Hyde Park and anti-Semitic fly-posting campaigns began to find their way into the press.[40] Near to Nupa's Greenwich base, in what its members perceived to be the 'communist hot bed' of south London, the New Party's regular Thursday meetings soon became the focus of mutual CPGB–Nupa loathing. Consequently, as Richard O'Hagen reported to *The New Times*, teams of party stewards were dispatched to safeguard the local Nupa contingent, resulting in the predictable fist fights and the regular intervention of the police.[41] Similarly, in Streatham, Nupa members were arrested in response to their broadcasting anti-Semitic slogans from a loudspeaker van touring the area; further south, in Croydon, *The Times* reported a blackshirted contingent of Nupa members disrupting a communist anti-war demonstration in August 1932. Having arrived in a car declaring their New Party allegiance, the would-be shock troops set up a rival platform before insults, songs and blows were exchanged in a violent tussle that led to five arrests.[42]

As should be clear, the New Party's point of protest began to shift from the relatively regulated surroundings of the in-door public meeting to the more unruly context of the street over the course of 1931–32. This, in turn, reflected both the party's dwindling electoral potential and its mutating political analysis. As the New Party found itself squeezed onto the margins of British politics, so Mosley came to view his – and the country's – future in evermore extreme terms. If the ballot box could not deliver the means of salvation, then it would have to be fought for, literally, on the streets of Britain's economically-ravaged cities.

Circuses and bread

Ostensibly, the New Party attempted to rally the British people in two principal ways: from the public platform and via the dissemination of party literature detailing Mosley's evolving political programme and perspective. Simultaneously, however, the party began to envisage more imaginative means by which to express the modern spirit inherent in its worldview. The fact that a publicity committee pre-dated the party's formation suggests that Mosley understood the importance of presentation; he recognised that his party's success depended on the way in which its politics were displayed and understood. Thus, as Julie Gottlieb has argued with regard to the BUF, Mosley imbued his practical politics with a cultural dimension that helped give expression to his desired 'shock of the new'.[43]

This was revealed in a variety of forms. First, as we shall explore further in Chapter 7, the party sought to utilise the support of writers, artists and intellectuals as a means of promoting its cause. In forging a modern movement, Mosley looked beyond the relatively limited parameters of electoral politics to ensure that a shift in socio-cultural values accompanied those offered in the political and economic sphere. Second, great importance was given to the visual presentation of the party, particularly its poster campaigns. Thus, Francis Meynell and Edward McKnight Kauffer (known for his designs on the London underground) were approached to provide striking replications of the party's message.[44] Third, New Party meetings began to take on a sense of spectacle. Music, often jazz, and mechanically-generated speeches were broadcast from loudspeakers to attract public attention and to set the mood for the coming event.[45] In August 1931, Mosley promised that 'every modern contrivance' would be employed to propagate the party's message.[46] Come the general election, and New Party stewards resplendent in bright orange marigolds brought a sense of purpose and, perhaps, tension to the proceedings. This, in turn, would be reinforced with the arrival of Mosley and the formal procession of his bodyguard. By 1932, such display had been further embellished with the introduction of a uniform, military drilling in the Nupa youth clubs, and the singing of Patrick Moir's 'Greyshirt Anthem'.[47] Fourth, as newspaper accounts attest, the attraction of a New Party meeting for many was the chance to see – or come into contact with – what we now term a 'celebrity'. Not only were the Mosleys a perennial fixture of the gossip columns and picture papers of the time, but the party's cast of relatively well-known advocates, from 'Kid' Lewis

and Peter Howard to the Sitwells, provided a means of blurring class and intellectual boundaries. The subtext, of course, was one of status by association.

Not all were keen on such display. Box, for one, showed himself unwilling to encourage local members to experiment with the ways in which they propagated the New Party message.[48] Generally, however, Mosley and his party began to construct a spectacle by which to add a dynamism to their public politics, providing a space in which those present were bound into and participating in a potentially transcendent moment. More bluntly, as Nicolson put it in typically patronising fashion during a discussion on the youth movement, the party needed to quench the working class' 'great thirst for colour and for drama' as a contrast to 'their very drab lives'.[49]

Linked to all this, perhaps, were undercurrents of more carnal desire. Just as Cynthia Mosley's appearances were often reported alongside a description of her chosen outfit and reference to her 'tall, dark, slim [and] good-looking' figure, so Mosley's aristocratic and youthful demeanour injected a dose of sexual charge to a New Party meeting.[50] If some men rallied to Mosley's combative physicality, so certain women were presumed to swoon before the man Ellen Wilkinson nicknamed in 1930 'the sheik [...] a Valentino in real life'.[51] According to the Battersea *South Western Star*, Mosley appeared a 'tall very dark man of the sort beloved by ladies to whose heart romance is dear', going on to note the 'good sprinkling of women' gathered in the audience.[52] As we shall see in Chapter 8, the language of male sexual potency was regularly expressed from the New Party platform.

Finally, the party endeavoured to use a range of media as a means of propaganda. Alongside *Action*, the party produced a film entitled *Crisis* to give visual expression to its theories of parliamentary malaise and socio-economic decline. This was discussed at a meeting of the party organising committee in June 1931, after which the 'ultra-modern' Mr Cousins was employed to realise the storyboard drafted by Nicolson in August.[53] In this, Nicolson imagined a series of juxtapositions: shots symbolising 'the might of England' – Nelson's column, parliament, the banks and navy – were to give way to images of jobless workers queuing at the labour exchange; slogans exclaiming the problems of over-production were to be cut with stills of run down pits and mills; unemployed demonstrations and riots in India were to bleed into film of MPs talking on irrelevant parliamentary bills as the lions in Trafalgar Square fell asleep. To a soundtrack that included 'Land of Hope and Glory' and an ironic rendition of 'It's a Long Way to Tipperary', the

film was to end with both a rallying cry and a demand: 'England Wants Action'.

Unlike certain other New Party initiatives, the planned film was completed and produced in time for the October general election. Despite some concern as to its 'poor synchronisation', both Mosley and Nicolson gave *Crisis* their blessing and foresaw it as a central part of their forthcoming campaign.[54] In the event, however, the British Board of Film Censors moved to ban the film on account of its bringing parliament into disrepute.[55] As such, *Crisis* was shown to private audiences as a means of rallying the party faithful, but it failed to make the impact intended.[56]

Similar problems hampered the New Party's attempt to utilise the wireless as a means of disseminating Mosley's message. Some plans simply failed to be realised, such as those to establish a Sark-based radio station over which the New Party could exert 'political control'.[57] Alternately, the party appeared to boast notable connections with the BBC. Alongside Eckersley, who had left the BBC in 1929, Joad, Nicolson and Strachey were all relatively well-known for their broadcasts on the radio. To this end, Nicolson publicly praised Mosley's manifesto in late 1930 and talked corporate governments with Sir John Reith before losing his job at the BBC in a dispute over James Joyce's *Ulysses*.[58] Mosley, meanwhile, found his efforts to secure air-time thwarted at every turn. First, in February 1931, his scheduled appearance to talk on 'tradition' with Lord Eustace was cancelled due to the BBC's fear that it would prove too political.[59] In response, Mosley penned a series of scathing articles questioning the BBC's monopoly and old-fashioned approach.[60] Second, in October, his application to make a party political broadcast was rejected due to the New Party's fielding less than the required 40 candidates.[61] Not surprisingly, perhaps, Mosley and others in the New Party took this as evidence of a deliberate media blackout.[62]

The New Party clearly strived to make use of contemporary media. This, on the one hand, complemented the party's modern image and tallied with prevailing shifts in British political culture between the wars; Mosley's party was by no means alone in seeking to utilise the radio, film and cinema van to present a suitable public image.[63] However, it also fed into the New Party's separation from mainstream politics. By fusing modern technologies with the spectacle of public performance, Mosley all but rejected the less dramatic – but no less important – task of cultivating a sustainable political base. The medium really was part of the message for those at the heart of the New Party. In the words of one perceptive local journalist, Mosley appeared a

'man who has found ordinary politics boring' and sought new modes of excitement.[64] Add to this financial limitations and the unwillingness of the established media to cover Mosley's initiative, and the New Party found itself searching for political and cultural outlets that bypassed the mainstream and exacted a response from the public. The 'sensational activities' rejected by the party congress in June had, by the end of the year, emerged as the only way forward for Mosley and his evolving New Movement.[65]

A theatre of hate?

Even before he launched the BUF in October 1932, Mosley's name had become synonymous with the ugly spectacle of organised political violence. Disruption and a degree of disorder appeared to characterise the New Party's public appearances from the outset. During the party's inaugural meeting on 5 March 1931, the outbreak of a minor scuffle and cries of 'the breakers' party' all but set a precedent for much that was to follow.[66] Throughout the New Party's spring tour, local newspapers reported a catalogue of minor incidents as a rotating selection of party speakers struggled to make their case to an apparently sceptical public. In Liverpool, a small group of local communists constantly interrupted the platform and showered the hall with CPGB literature dropped from the balcony. In Aston, Manchester, Glasgow, Cardiff and Hull, regular and irreverent interruptions were reported, while Dundee saw two women come to blows amidst the crowd's angry response to Cynthia Mosley's request that the 'noisy fools' in the audience stop heckling the platform. In Hammersmith, meanwhile, a vocal contingent of communist hecklers combined to prevent Peter Eckersley from speaking before a scuffle broke out towards the back of the town hall. In the melee, it was reported that at least one communist was arrested.[67]

Of course, it was polling night in Ashton-under-Lyne that really provided Mosley with a sense of the bitterness that his secession from Labour had caused within the wider labour movement. As Labour's defeat was declared, so its supporters turned their anger on Mosley and the New Party. Boos and jeers greeted the Mosleys, Strachey and Young as they tried to speak to those gathered at the town hall and in the market square, before Mosley – 'white with rage' but 'a smile on his face' – stepped into the angry throng and made his way back to the George and Dragon Hotel.[68] Prior to this, the disturbances recorded at New Party meetings had been primarily verbal and confined to a

minority of those present. Throughout the Ashton campaign, moreover, the party held a series of often well-attended meetings with only very minor interruptions from the floor.[69] On polling night, however, the malevolence displayed in the wake of Labour's defeat combined with earlier instances of communist opposition to convince Mosley of the need to form a better drilled troupe of party stewards. 'Twice during my wife's tour of England', Mosley complained in May 1931, 'organised violence' had been used to prevent the New Party's message being heard, and though he admitted that such incidents were 'rare', he felt that the furore in Ashton justified his resort to the 'good old English fist' as an 'appropriate means' of response.[70] Thus, by the time the New Party made its way to Glasgow on 20 September 1931, Mosley came equipped with a band of stewards and a personal bodyguard led by 'Kid' Lewis. The result, somewhat predictably, was a violent free-for-all as razor blades slashed and stones rained down on Mosley, Davies, Lewis and others as they entered the crowd to confront a vociferous band of communist cadres.[71] Indeed, Nicolson's diary records that it was the Glasgow events that provoked Mosley to take a momentous decision. 'This', Mosley insisted the following day, 'forces us to be fascist and [...] we need no longer hesitate to create our trained and disciplined force'.[72] It was under the guise of defending free speech, therefore, that the New Party reportedly resolved to mobilise 'a squad of shock troops' ready to protect Mosley from 'organised communist opposition' in such a way as to ensure that 'our opponents will remember our lesson for the rest of their lives [...]'.[73]

The general election campaign that followed was similarly eventful. Beyond the Birmingham Rag Market riot described above, sporadic – though far less dramatic – outbreaks of disorder were regularly recorded. As crowds gathered to catch a glimpse of the infamous 'Biff Boys', so confrontation was always liable to occur; cries of 'where's the bodyguard' now accompanied the more common catcalls of 'traitor' and 'turncoat'.[74] Back in Glasgow on 19 October 1931, Mosley's appearance at the St Andrew's Halls was stewarded by police who battled to prevent the bulk of the queuing crowd from rushing the doors. Even then, Forgan's speech was hampered by the failing loudspeaker system before Mosley struggled to wear down a 'dissatisfied section' of the audience. Once outside, Mosley endeavoured to speak to the remaining crowd from his motorcar. Even then, however, he was drowned out by a mounting chorus of hisses, boos and slanders in prelude to the police escorting the New Party contingent back to their hotel.[75] Elsewhere, Ronald Braden's opening meeting was 'howled down' by communists

in Hammersmith, while Jesse Williams' first public meeting in Duddeston descended into farce amidst a mix of hostile and irreverent 'banter'.[76] In Merthyr, meanwhile, Sellick Davies was pelted with stones, tins, bottles and lumps of turf as he set about challenging the ILP's Richard Wallhead in what was a staunchly socialist constituency.[77] According to the *Merthyr Express*, Davies' agent – the 76-year-old W. H. Harris – even had his finger bitten as he tried to hold back a hostile crowd during a meeting at the local Drill Hall. On polling day, as the only candidate opposing Wallhead, Davies was received into a decidedly hostile atmosphere.[78]

Clearly, political violence informed the New Party's experience and the opposition shown towards Mosley helped convince him of the need to adopt fascism as a ready response.[79] That said, and with due consideration given to the possibility that a newspaper headline may not always accurately reflect the events described, it is important to place such episodes in context. Most obviously, the public reaction to the New Party was by no means uniformally hostile. At least a proportion of the heckling directed towards the New Party platform was decidedly humorous in nature, as spectators mimicked the 'posh' accents of the speakers or made jokes as to their wealthy lifestyles. In Glasgow and Dundee, much jollity was garnered from cries of 'heah heah'; in Leeds, the *Yorkshire Post* described the audience attending the New Party's meeting on 16 March as 'thoroughly good humoured', with much laughter breaking the attentive hearing afforded to the platform; in Reading, Mosley's arrival was met with a rendition of 'Why Was He Born So Beautiful'.[80] Among the questions received at the various New Party meetings were such pertinent inquiries as 'is the speaker in favour of policemen in the summertime going about in bare feet?'[81] More cruelly, perhaps, the public heckling of the New Party focused on the shortcomings of its proponents. So, for example, Eric Rider Troward's attempt to compare the 'crisis' in Britain to the recent revolution in Spain, replete with talk of 'machine gun posts on the house tops [and] cavalry charging through [Reading's] Broad Street', was met with cries of 'don't talk rot' and general incredulity. As we have already noted, Troward's campaign became a source of sport for the Reading electorate.[82] In Shettleston, too, William Stevenson's evident inexperience on the public platform prompted the crowd to respond not with anger but with 'Swiftian irony and loud laughter'. According to Jones, Stevenson's haplessness made him quite popular; the electorate promised not to hurt him, but not to vote for him either.[83] Arguably, therefore, the *Manchester Guardian*'s headline of 16 March 1931, 'Sunday

Night's Entertainment', provides a suitably salient expression of at least a section of the public's response to the New Party.[84]

Indeed, the heckling often stemmed from a relatively small number of people. According to the *Manchester Guardian*, the kerfuffle that interrupted the New Party's inaugural meeting on 5 Match 1931 was prompted by a single 'resentful Labour man' shouting from the balcony. True, the failed attempts of a steward to remove him led someone to call out: 'How do you like your Fascists now, Cynthia?' But the bulk of the 'decidedly middle-class' audience appeared to have come in support of the Mosleys, endeavouring to 'howl down' those offering protests from the floor and bookending the evening with cheers and applause.[85] Similarly, in Manchester, it was reported that most of those present at the New Party's March meeting expressed annoyance towards the small band of spectators interrupting the speakers and appreciated the persistence of Strachey, Baldwin, Cynthia Mosley and James Matthews in the face of such provocation.[86] The following day, in Leeds, an audience of 2,200 'listened with patience' to give Strachey, Forgan and Baldwin a 'good hearing' despite Cynthia Mosley's absence with a cold and amidst a critical but inquisitive question-and-answer session that lasted some 45 minutes.[87] In Scotland, too, a crowd that had initially promised to 'hang Oswald Mosley by the neck in the Gallowgate' ultimately gave him a hearing once he promised to leave his bodyguard inside the Parkhead town hall and a woman shouted from an upstairs window for the crowd to 'Lae the man alane. He's daein' his best.'[88] Nicolson himself admitted in late 1931 that a typical New Party meeting was subject only to interruption from 'one or two throaty and confused communists' and 'four or five […] carefully drilled socialists'.[89]

More typically, most of those present at the New Party's many meetings simply 'reserved judgement' and left 'unconverted'.[90] A number of newspaper reports that began with reference to heckling and 'lively scenes' also recorded the rounds of applause won by the New Party speakers and the valid questions asked (and answered) during and at the end of the meeting.[91] Indeed, many New Party meetings went ahead with little to no trouble. Cynthia Mosley's potentially acrimonious meeting with the Stoke Labour Party in March 1931, to which 3,500 people attended, was emotional but not thereby volatile. The *Evening Sentinel* even went so far as to suggest that the city's MP 'won over the vast audience'.[92] Even later on, following the formation of Mosley's bodyguard, it was far from inevitable that a New Party meeting would lead to confrontation. When Mosley appeared in

Manchester in support of Sir John Pratt, who stood for the New Party in Hulme during the 1931 general election, the *Manchester Guardian* recorded a 'quiet audience – almost entirely middle class' – that soon warmed to Mosley's rhetoric and rose to their feet in response to the New Party leader's 'tremendous voice' and 'striking' argument.[93]

Mosley's own campaign in Stoke was likewise more sprightly than vicious, with both he and his opponents appealing to their supporters not to disrupt meetings after a few early incidents had threatened to blight the election.[94] Subsequently, the *Evening Sentinel* reported 'large and orderly' crowds gathering to catch a glimpse of Mosley and his ever-changing roll-call of fellow speakers.[95] Less dramatically, Mosley offered his support to Robert Forgan in Port Glasgow and Johnstone with little interruption, while similarly 'polite' meetings took place throughout Mosley's tour of the east Midlands.[96]

The disorder associated with the New Party was certainly less in evidence when Mosley was absent from the scene. Throughout the general election, the vast majority of New Party meetings appear to have passed with little incident. Some, it is true, attracted hardly any response at all. Marshall Diston's talk at the Garratt Lane school in Wandsworth evidently went smoothly enough, though he did not receive a single question at its end.[97] James Stuart Barr, too, turned up to an election meeting in Gateshead to find just six people in attendance.[98] More comically, Vin Williams' talk to a half-full Clowne co-operative hall was abandoned when the lights fused and the remaining audience ebbed away with flickering matches in hand.[99] Elsewhere, however, New Party speakers attracted sizeable audiences and were apparently well received.[100] In Coatbridge and Airdrie, William Weir Gilmour was even reported to have become something of a 'minor political sensation' as he fended questions from a critical audience.[101] Over a series of busy meetings, Gilmour proved adept at answering hecklers and outlining the nuances of New Party policy to the extent that the local press described him as a 'fascinating personality' with the ability to present his argument with 'lucidity and forcefulness'.[102]

This generally critical but not thereby belligerent response to the New Party reveals much about both Mosley's own lack of political judgement and his party's place within the political landscape of 1931–32. First, it demonstrates the extent to which Mosley misread – or overstated – the nature and development of the economic 'crisis' afflicting Britain at the time. For all Mosley's premonition of deepening socio-economic and political doom, the belief – as Cuming reputedly put it – that the New Party must prepare 'for new methods in the

reorientation of political parties' was wholly exaggerated.[103] True, the CPGB was growing in late 1931, and the unemployed demonstrations of the time represented a combative challenge to conventional parliamentary politics. To those on the receiving end of a policeman's baton or plunged into the uncertainty of unemployment, so radical political change no doubt made some appeal. Even so, neither the CPGB nor the communist-inspired unemployed demonstrations provided a realistic threat to the political mainstream, even amidst the upheavals of August–October 1931. The CPGB remained a tiny organisation at this time, with a fluctuating membership of around 5–6,000; the NUWM-sponsored demonstrations of the early 1930s were impressive but limited in their objectives and capabilities.[104] As this suggests, Mosley's tendency to compare the situation in Britain to that unfolding in Germany was contentious at best.[105] Not only was the depression far less severe in Britain, but the notion that the uncongenial atmosphere and odd bout of fisticuffs that marred a minority of New Party meetings could be compared to the murderous politics accompanying the rise of Nazism on the Weimar streets was close to absurd.

Given all this, Mosley's decision to forge an increasingly disciplined extra-parliamentary force provided a stimulus rather than an antidote to political violence in Britain. If, as some historians have suggested, Mosley was the victim of a premeditated campaign that provoked conflict, then his wholly exaggerated response ensured that his appearances soon brought with them an expectation of trouble.[106] Just as communists (and others) chose to evoke the threat of fascism to legitimise their own position, so Mosley conflated the sporadic and often minor scuffles that dogged the New Party from the outset with the emergence of an assertive communist threat that reaffirmed his own sense of impending crisis. As a result, Mosley succeeded only in transforming verbal challenge into physical conflict and thereby helped formalise what became almost a ritual of confrontation.

Second, by confusing the vocal opposition of disgruntled Labour supporters with the rarer but more combative response of the CPGB, Mosley ignored (or showed himself unaware of) the broader and more peaceable trends in British political culture evident from at least the Great War. As Jon Lawrence has shown, the interwar years revealed a growing distaste for the unruly politics of the Victorian and Edwardian period. The impact of the war and the extension of the franchise combined with changes to electoral procedure – an end to 'rolling' elections, redrawn constituency boundaries, the free use of school halls – to facilitate a recasting of public political-cultural values and

expectations. Broadly understood, the expression of public opinion in the years after the war was to be seen less in the midst of the garrulous crowd, and more in the rational choices of a mass electorate. As such, Mosley's decision to meet 'force with force' appeared a 'reiteration of the "old ways" of Edwardian party politics' rather than a measured response to a genuine threat.[107] In fact, Mosley's embracing confrontational politics served only to further distance him from the 'party-building' approach adopted by the two principal mainstream political organisations. Where Labour and Conservative agents and activists set about knocking on doors to ensure that political allegiance was transferred into the homes of 'ordinary' people, Mosley combined a preference for the public platform with the appeal of the barrack room.

Ultimately, then, the public disorder associated with Mosley revealed an anomaly that lay at the heart of his politics: however much he sought to embody the 'new', he too often appeared drawn back to the past. As one reporter put it, it was 'hard to accept [Mosley] as a prophet or the herald of a new era' given that an 'aristocratic aloofness' continued to distinguish him.[108] In fascism, perhaps, Mosley found route to a primordial source that offered a remedy to such contradiction. Whatever, his chosen creed succeeded only in bringing a 'foreignness' to his politics that further alienated him from a public already unconvinced by his proposals to 'save' Britain.

7
Outside the Gate: Alternative Routes to Power

Even before the results of the 1931 general election had served to fling the New Party into the overflowing dustbin of history, Mosley and his fellow companions had long been concerned that the vicissitudes of parliamentary democracy might necessitate more imaginative political strategy. In particular, the technical detail, nuances and complexities contained within the New Party programme rendered doubts within the party as to how far the electorate would even understand Mosley's proposed plan of action. Amongst much talk of the electorate's preference for simple slogans and resort to intuitive rather than cerebral politics, Nicolson, writing in the week prior to polling day, recognised that 'our appeal cannot at present be addressed to the average elector; it can only be addressed to the elector who is above average; and as such to a minority [...]'[1] For this reason, New Party strategy extended beyond the hustings and polling booth. Despite Mosley's initial talk of standing 400 candidates, he consistently sought alternative means by which to realise his political objectives.

These took a variety of forms: the mobilisation of influential opinion, seeking support from the popular press, the manipulation of established political contacts in favour of the New Party and, from late 1931, the formation of an extra-parliamentary force ready to respond to 'the danger of a proletarian revolution'.[2] In one sense, the New Party aspired to a form of permeation analogous to that of the early Fabian Society or, more readily in the post-war context, Wells' notion of an 'open conspiracy'. In another sense, however, Mosley began to perceive his party's apparent lack of progress as paving the way for a socio-economic and political collapse to which extraordinary measures would necessarily have to be applied. If parliament was to fail, then more surreptitious methods – and more circuitous routes to power – would have to suffice.

Burning down the house

The New Party was, in large part, a product of Westminster. Its origins lay in the table talk held between a small group of MPs (and prospective MPs) from each of the three main political parties; its formation was newsworthy for the ready-made nucleus of New Party members already present inside the House of Commons. Indeed, one of the party's principal objectives was to apply pressure on the government and the mainstream party leaderships, building up momentum in favour of Mosley's proposals in order to force them onto the parliamentary agenda. In their youth and commitment to economic reform, those gathered around Mosley imagined a generational realignment of the nation's politics. They shared a frustration with the established party leaderships, impatience at the workings of parliament, and a conviction that Britain was heading into a period of acute crisis lest immediate action be taken. Given all this, the fledgling New Party hoped to cultivate its influence and authority from *within* the British seat of power, ensuring a ready-made parliamentary presence that potentially by-passed the need for a renewed electoral mandate.

The 'model' for the New Party's parliamentary strategy was to some extent that of a so-called 'ginger group', the modern variant of the 'tea room cabals' active from the nineteenth century.[3] Throughout the 1920s, ambitious backbenchers recognised that it was necessary to coordinate and plan their parliamentary activities if they were to make an impact on the Commons and within their respective parties. Thus, MPs would synchronise speeches, lend each other public support, and cross-reference policy points and political positions. In this, moreover, Mosley's Conservative friends had proven expert. Boothby, Stanley, Macmillan and John Loder each formed part of the YMCA snapping at the heels of Stanley Baldwin's premiership in 1929, publishing a treatise on *Industry and the State* (1927) that radically diverged from orthodox Conservative policy and complemented many of the themes taken up by Mosley and Strachey in the Labour Party. Not surprisingly, therefore, Mosley's Labour group joined forces with the young Tory rebels and a handful of Liberals in late 1930, converging their parliamentary appearances and ruminating after hours about the need for more effective government.[4] In fact, talk of national parties and national coalitions became almost *de rigueur* at the regular gatherings of young politicians attended by Mosley and his immediate circle towards the turn of the year.[5]

Such cross-party agitation began to push at the unwritten rules of the political game. Nevertheless, Mosley proved keener than most to

break on through, developing his plans for major parliamentary reform, seeking outside funding to propagate his ideas and, ultimately, forming a wholly new party organisation designed to fracture the existing political *modus vivendi*. In so doing, he provoked concern amongst many previously sympathetic to his programme, not least Boothby, Keynes, Garvin and those associated with the *Week-End Review*.[6] It was Mosley's methods, rather than his policies, that began to leave him isolated from early 1931.

According to John Beckett, the ILP MP for Peckham who later joined the BUF, it was W. J. Brown who first raised the question of forming a new political party based on the programme developed by Mosley over the course of 1930.[7] This may well have been so; Brown was renowned for his scatter-gun brain, firing off ideas in all directions to complement his perennial tone of indignation.[8] At the same time, Mosley's own growing disillusionment with the government suggests that he was already moving towards some form of schism in the wake of Labour's October conference. Whatever, the party's early months chimed to the rumour of potential new recruits, among them Macmillan, Moore-Brabazon, Hoare-Belisha, Stanley, Elliot and Boothby.[9] In the event, however, vague promises and late-night conversation did not a political movement make. As the dust settled and the New Party emerged from the brief furore that surrounded its formation, so its parliamentary presence remained limited to just five, falling to four in the wake of Strachey's resignation. True, Cecil Dudgeon – the Liberal MP for Galloway – joined the party in October 1931, but this really did prove too little too late. Without the shelter and prestige offered by an established party label, Mosley and his New Party colleagues were all too easily pushed to the parliamentary margins.

Not surprisingly, so small a group proved able to exert but a limited influence inside the Commons. The PLP soon closed ranks on its erstwhile members, while the Labour NEC mobilised the party apparatus to ensure that the fallout from Mosley's secession was quickly contained.[10] Those constituencies affected by the New Party's formation were instructed to receive an array of high-profile Labour leaders, each of whom proceeded to crush the Mosley butterfly beneath their labour movement wheel. In particular, Mosley's class background was used against him as Labour moved to present the New Party as little more than a personalised vehicle for a rich aristocrat and his well-connected friends.[11] Here was a man 'used to having his own way in everything he touched'; a man whose wealth and privilege made his betrayal 'infinitely worse' than that of any 'ordinary' Labour member who 'ratted' on

the movement.[12] Mosley was dismissed as someone who had never really understood the Labour Party, who in no way embodied its collective spirit or embattled history.[13] Best of all, perhaps, was the quip made by the Labour MP for Silvertown and namesake of Mosley's propagandist, Jack Jones, that if Labour was a party with a left wing and a right wing, then the New Party most surely represented its 'parson's nose'.[14]

Meanwhile, across the Commons, Mosley's Tory friends on the opposition benches were being swiftly brought to heel. If a few erstwhile and aspirant MPs continued to flirt with the New Party into 1931, then men such as Macmillan, Harmsworth, Thomas Cholmondeley and Randolph Churchill represented but a minority of those previously intrigued by Mosley's political scheming. For the vast majority of the Conservative Party, both in and out of parliament, Mosley had already revealed himself to be exactly what Stanley Baldwin said he was: a 'cad and a wrong 'un'.[15]

Other factors conspired to hinder the New Party's presence in parliament. Mosley's illness, not to mention the time and responsibility associated with developing a new political organisation, served to distract the New Party leadership's attention away from the Commons. For Strachey, Allen and Forgan, too, public meetings and preparing policy statements took priority over yet another day in the 'hideous chamber'.[16] Even so, the New Party members' isolation was mainly self-imposed. If the Commons provided a ready-made platform for Mosley to propagate his plan, then circumstances combined with a growing frustration in the day-to-day rituals of Westminster to dissuade the party from exploiting it. The New Party contingent seldom appeared in the Commons from March 1931, a fact that was noted by MPs such as Labour's Tom Williams. Having made caustic comment on occasion of a rare Mosley visit to the House in July 1931, he was informed by the New Party leader that 'I shall always be here on the rare occasions on which his government produce a measure of the slightest importance to the country or one that has any relevance to the national situation'.[17]

There was, of course, another factor preventing an effective New Party presence organising itself inside the Commons. As the political divisions within the party leadership became manifest, so its parliamentary contingent began to disagree as to both policy and strategy. Should the New Party continue to support aspects of Labour policy? Was the New Party now in direct opposition to the Labour government; on which side of the House should the party sit? Such debate came to head in the summer of 1931, specifically with regard to the government's Unemployment (Anomalies) Bill. In this, Strachey and

Young accused Mosley of failing sufficiently to condemn the government's proposed cuts in unemployment benefit, later suggesting that Mosley's ambivalence stemmed from a fear of losing potential City backing for the New Party.[18] In reply, Mosley sought to make clear his support for 'work or maintenance' and his opposition to any reduction in benefit, going so far amidst the rumour and rancour leading up to the October general election to publish a pamphlet containing his speech to the Commons of 8 July 1931.[19] As this revealed, Mosley's stance was critical but not unconditional; he recognised the state's right to protect against genuine anomalies and approved its asserting government power.[20] On returning to the Commons for the first time since March, the New Party group underscored its separation from the Labour government by taking its place 'en bloc on the opposition side of the House'. But while Allen, Forgan, Cynthia and Strachey joined with Baldwin, Brown and the ILP rebels in supporting innumerable amendments to the bill, Mosley simply voted against the government before taking his leave.[21]

All this is not to say that the New Party gave up completely on parliament. Mosley, for one, took the opportunity to present his ideas on government reform to the select committee on parliamentary procedure chaired by Ernest Brown in June 1931. In so doing, he ensured that the New Party programme was publicised in the daily press and beyond the relatively rarefied confines of a weekly (or monthly) periodical.[22] Similarly, in September 1931, before the election swept the New Party far beyond the realms of Westminster, Mosley returned to the parliamentary stage with a series of pointed speeches that at least reminded others of his potential.[23] As the New Party struggled to find its niche, so Mosley was courted by members of the coalition government keen to channel his ideas and utilise his anti-Labour vitriol.[24] Indeed, Mosley's equivocation with regard his relationship towards the national government provided a notable bone of contention during the party's election campaign. The New Party hierarchy debated whether to align itself with the MacDonald–Baldwin coalition, going so far as to seek agreement with the Tory whip (Neville Chamberlain) as to an electoral deal and to mix criticism of government policy with a promise to support any measures that it deemed practicable.[25] 'If the National Government produces constructive proposals in accordance with our policy,' Mosley explained in late 1931, then 'we shall assist them to carry through those proposals.'[26]

Taken generally, however, the New Party's approach to parliamentary politics remained somewhat clandestine. In other words, Mosley

continued to spend much of his time seeking out potential alliances within the wider political establishment, exploring the ways in which he could gain influence through schism and division across the existing party ranks. Most obviously, the possibility of his more cautious former allies coming round to the New Party in the event of a full-blown economic and political crisis continued to hover at the back of Mosley's mind. Not only did he and Nicolson keep in contact with Elliot, Boothby and others long into 1931, but the events foreseen by Mosley were based on the premise that none of the 'old gangs' would provide safe harbour for even the most ambitious young politician. Simultaneously, Mosley set out to align himself with two of the Commons' leading heavyweights, both of whom had forged a reputation that combined a maverick but brilliant political individualism with a prestige honed from government experience and countless political battles. By 1931, both Churchill and Lloyd George were – in differing ways – cut adrift from the political mainstream, at odds with their parties, and keen to reassert their authority.

Mosley had cut his political teeth standing up to Churchill. Between 1919 and 1921, he was among the fiercest critics of Churchill's tenure in the war office. He had, similarly, poured scorn on Churchill's chancellorship, particularly the return to the gold standard in 1925. Ironically, in 1924, he had even accused Churchill of 'strutting in a borrowed shirt – a black shirt – which he had begged, borrowed or stolen from Signor Mussolini'.[27] By 1930, however, certain similarities were being discerned between the two men.[28] Both had shown their ambition and potential from a young age, standing up to their elders and holding their own in the parliamentary hothouse; both had crossed the political divide, deferring to principle rather than party loyalty; both baulked at the direction in which their respective parties were heading by the turn of the decade. So it was that in 1930 Churchill welcomed Mosley into his exclusive Other Club and encouraged his parliamentary private secretary, Bob Boothby, to make common cause between Labour and Tory rebels keen to 'ginger up' the front benches on both sides of the Commons.

By contrast, Mosley had long admired Lloyd George as both a statesman and in terms of his political vision. Bound up in the Mosley memorandum and the New Party programme were policies informed by Lloyd George's wartime government, by his relationship with Keynes, by his interventionist unemployment policy, and by his pursuit of a consensual alternative to socialism and diehard Conservatism. This, in turn, led to comment inside the PLP prior to Mosley's secession. The

new 'left-wing creed', Morgan Philips Price joked, was based on a belief in 'one Lloyd George, the Father Almighty, the giver of political wisdom, and all his promises, possible and impossible. And in one Lord Oswald Mosley, the only Begotten Son of the Father, from whom all Yellow Books are made.'[29] Accordingly, and despite the fact that the Liberal leader regarded the New Party programme as an 'injudicious mixture of Karl Marx and Lord Rothermere', Lloyd George recognised something of kindred spirit in Mosley.[30]

The talks held between Mosley, Churchill and Lloyd George remained very general. A number of informal meetings were organised throughout 1931, apparently with the objective of forming a national opposition (and, eventually, a national government) headed by the two elder statesmen but including Mosley and whatever remained of his New Party.[31] Of course, nothing came of such scheming. If Mosley was able to count Randolph Churchill, Esmond Romilly (Churchill's nephew) and Shane Leslie (Churchill's first cousin) among his supporters, then he was unable to forge more meaningful agreement with either Churchill senior or Lloyd George. Rumours circulated: some predicted that Lloyd George would cut a deal with Mosley once the Labour government fell, something Nicolson believed Mosley would find hard to resist; others suggested that Churchill would lead an internal Tory opposition to which Mosley could affiliate.[32] At each turn, however, there appeared to be far more separating the three men than drawing them together. Each had their own agenda, and each risked losing more than they could gain from any such alliance. From Mosley's point of view, his position would inevitably prove subordinate to his esteemed colleagues, both of whom disagreed with key aspects of the New Party programme. Initially, too, Mosley feared alienating his 'left wing' – meaning Strachey and Young – from whom he kept his dealings with Churchill and Lloyd George secret.[33] Compromise, it seemed, would only mean the devil talking.

Mosley's attempts to provoke a fundamental realignment of Britain's political establishment from within failed on all levels. If his cross-party machinations at least caused waves whilst he retained a Labour membership card, then they fell to ruin once he left the conventional party fold. Similarly, at a grass-roots level, New Party members brought only limited returns from their attempts to win over existing Labour, ILP and, in Allen's case, Unionist branches to Mosley. Only in Merthyr, during the general election, did the New Party glimpse an alternative future. There, the local Liberal and Conservative associations agreed to allow Sellick Davies a clear run against the ILP's R. C. Wallhead.

Davies, who had previously been the prospective Liberal candidate in the constituency, reportedly pledged to support the constructive policies of the National government and met with both local associations to placate their residual concerns. In the event, after a lively campaign that rallied the local *Merthyr Express* to his cause but provoked a violent reaction from his socialist opponents, Davies lost despite polling more votes than Wallhead's previous Liberal (1929) and Tory (1924) opponents.[34] To permeate, Mosley and his comrades had to conspire openly and within the recognised – if ill-defined – rules of Britain's parliamentary-political game. Once those rules were broken, then Mosley's future was forever destined to exist in what he himself described as the political 'wilderness'.[35]

In the city

Mosley's disregard for the trappings of party politics extended beyond the organisational and the parliamentary. Integral to the New Party's *modus operandi* was its attempt to secure influential support from within the higher echelons of British society, be it intellectual, political or financial. Even before the party was formed, Mosley had courted the likes of Keynes, Shaw and Wells in search of approval for his ideas. By 1931, he had begun to look further afield. Beaverbrook and Rothermere, wealthy publishers and journal editors, beleaguered industrialists and City financiers, even members of the royal family were approached to lend gravitas and resources to the New Party cause. In such circles, a stamped party card was less important than the future potential engendered by mutual understanding. After all, the New Party was conceived in the context of a supposedly faltering parliamentary system. If the spectre of political, economic and social collapse was evermore coming into focus, then perhaps the normal electoral process would not provide Mosley's route to power? Perhaps a coalition government, coup or revolution would open the way for the New Party to take its lead? If so, then it was imperative for the New Party to remain flexible in its strategy and somewhat amorphous in its affiliations.

Without doubt, the most intriguing extra-parliamentary contact pursued by Mosley was that of the Prince of Wales. Mosley and his circle certainly had access to the prince. Cimmie's sister, Alexandra Curzon ('Baba'), was married to Edward 'fruity' Metcalfe, the best friend and confidant to the future king; the prince was a regular at many of the same country retreats and London clubs frequented by Mosley, Nicolson and others. To this end, Mosley claimed to Nicolson in July

1931 that the prince was indeed a New Party supporter, something he reasserted later in February 1932.[36] Nicolson seemed unimpressed, and the extent of Mosley's boast may be open to question. Nevertheless, his courting of the prince revealed much about his outlook in the midst of the New Party's evolution towards fascism. As someone then mugging up on Italian history, Mosley must have recognised the role played by the monarchy in Mussolini's accession to power. Simultaneously, of course, the prince's own latent fascist sympathies remain the subject of much conjecture.[37]

More immediately, Mosley hoped to secure popular press support for the New Party. This, again, offered a way of by-passing the need for extensive party organisation. By hitching the party programme to the distribution available via either Lord Beaverbrook or Lord Rothermere's press empire, Mosley felt sure he could win over public opinion and apply significant pressure on the government. Such belief related, in part, to a contentious and on-going shift in the relationship between press and party evident since at least the end of the Great War. As Colin Seymour-Ure has demonstrated, the highly politicised and party-centric press of the Victorian period was giving way to the more market-driven, irreverent variant of the mid-to-late twentieth century.[38] In amidst this, Beaverbrook and Rothermere – armed with such papers as the *Daily Express*, *Evening Standard* and *Daily Mail* – fed their own political ambitions, launching initiatives such as the Anti-Waste Campaign of 1920–22 and the empire crusades of 1929–31, to which end rival candidates were supported, new parties were formed (United Empire Party; UEP), and the news agenda skewed to reflect their own concerns. Ultimately, the conceit of the press barons was seen off by their principal target, Stanley Baldwin, in early 1931. Thus, the Tory leader borrowed from his cousin Rudyard Kipling to accuse them of seeking 'power without responsibility – the prerogative of the harlot throughout the ages'. Even so, their challenge shook the Conservative Party, particularly in the wake of an empire crusade victory at the Paddington South by-election of October 1930. Indeed, that this occurred just as the notion of a new party was beginning to formulate in Mosley's mind suggests more than coincidence. For those who wished to see it, the old political order was crumbling and the public had been mobilised by a self-proclaimed 'new movement' channelled through the power of the press.[39]

Most of Mosley's media plans came to nothing. His suggestion that the party ask the American newspaper magnate William Randolph Hearst for money was vetoed by Nicolson on account of it being too

'foreign' a source of potential income, while schemes involving the purchase of the *Sunday News* made little or no progress beyond the luncheon table.[40] Beaverbrook did at least consider aligning with Mosley. Having already provided space for Mosley to publicise his ideas in 1930, the two men met and maintained contact in the lead up to the New Party's formation.[41] Amidst the political intrigues of the period, talk of Mosley joining with the empire free traders was not unknown.[42] Come the New Party's launch, moreover, Beaverbrook assured Mosley that he would 'see that your manifesto gets as much publicity as possible'.[43] In truth, however, the press baron doubted the New Party's potential and showed little inclination to take anything other than a cursory interest in its progress. Not only did he advise Nicolson against joining the party, but he soon concluded that the Ashton by-election had all but 'done in Tom Mosley'.[44] More importantly, Beaverbrook was far too wrapped up in his own empire crusade to countenance transferring his support to another political venture. If anything, Beaverbrook was more inclined to see Mosley as a rival than an ally, with the New Party serving as a distraction from his own political objectives.[45] 'He lives only in opposition', Nicolson observed of his then employer, believing Beaverbrook to be a man forever likely to fall out with his allies.[46] As this suggests, the fact that Mosley's programme bore similarities to that of Beaverbrook should not obscure its differences. Even more than Garvin, Beaverbrook appeared to harbour concerns as to both Mosley's methods and character; any agreement would have had to come on the press baron's terms and following the press baron's lead.[47]

Mosley's dalliance with Rothermere was more successful. As is well known, the *Daily Mail* would later become an important champion of the BUF in the early 1930s. For our purposes, however, Mosley proved unable to cement his agreement with Rothermere until the twilight of the New Party's brief history. For much of the 1920s, Mosley's defection to Labour had made him something of a whipping boy for the Rothermere press. Despite this, Mosley remained close to Rothermere's son, Esmond Harmsworth, who in 1931–32 was young (33), the chairman of the Mail Group, sympathetic to the New Party programme and, as vice-president of the National Citizens' Union, tending towards fascism.[48] By 1931, too, Mosley regularly discussed his political options over dinner with Rothermere, usually in the company of Lloyd George and Winston Churchill. Even so, a number of obstacles served to prevent too formal a marriage of convenience.[49] Alongside Beaverbrook, Rothermere was pursuing his own political ambitions in 1930–31, thereby distracting both his money and his attention away from

Mosley's venture.[50] Even more problematically, joining forces with Rothermere had little appeal to the majority of those gathered around Mosley on the eve of the New Party's formation. Strachey, for one, would have baulked at the idea; Rothermere was anathema to anyone who seriously saw themselves positioned on the political left. Equally, Mosley's young Conservative friends remained suspicious of the press baron. Where Beaverbrook at least mixed his Conservatism with an interest in all things radical, Rothermere was cut from a far more reactionary cloth. As Boothby informed Mosley amidst an early debate on the viability of the New Party, 'in any decently organised community his [Rothermere's] papers would be suppressed; and he would be executed'.[51]

Things changed in the wake of the 1931 general election, by which time Mosley, Rothermere and Harmsworth were united in their belief that 'disaster' was descending over Britain. In response, Rothermere promised in December to place 'the whole of the Harmsworth press' at Mosley's disposal, thereby preparing the way for more concerted action from the autumn of 1932.[52] In the meantime, Mosley waxed lyrical on the achievements of Fascism in the *Daily Mail*, composed his *Greater Britain,* and set to transform the New Party into the BUF. Rothermere, meanwhile, talked of turning Lansdowne House into the *Braun Haus* of the New Movement.[53] Of course, this all came too late to save the New Party; Rothermere's fascist sympathies served only to ensure the party's demise and facilitate its transformation into something far more extreme.

Elsewhere, a number of less renowned contacts remained to provide a glimmer of hope for Mosley as he sought new allies and new means to pursue his political objective. Initially, at least, his bullish call for government action, national planning and trade protection, not to mention the imperialist overtones of his emergent programme, aroused some interest within industrial and financial circles. On the one hand, Mosley's talk of economic planning drew him into contact with others keen to revive the British economy and find an alternative to treasury orthodoxy. It was in such a context that Mosley co-opted Gerald Barry onto his publicity committee and contributed to the *Week-End Review* debate that led to the formation of the Political and Economic Planning (PEP) group in March 1931. In return, Mosley consistently quoted and made reference to the policies and concepts expressed by members of PEP, particularly Sir Basil Blackett and Sir Arthur Salter. Thus, Salter's vision of 'a system in which competition and individual enterprise […] regulation and general planning […] will be

adjusted so that the abuses of each will be avoided and the benefits of each retained' was used by Mosley in his *The Greater Britain*. Salter's simile for this, 'the arc of a great bridge, so designed that the stresses and strains of the separate blocks which constitute it – each pushing and thrusting against the other – support the whole structure by the interaction of the reciprocal pressure', was for Mosley 'the finest description yet produced in general terms of the Fascist State'.[54]

On the other hand, there were key aspects of Mosley's programme that resonated with less progressive advocates of economic and industrial reform. From within the NCIC, Morris, Portal, Lord Melchett and Sir Felix Pole lent varying degrees of support to Mosley. In return, the New Party gave due praise to the vaguely corporatist credentials of the NCIC, mirrored its talk of business government, and shared both its vision of imperial trade and fear of working-class revolt. It was, moreover, through such contacts that the BUF later recruited notable industrial support.[55] But although Mosley continued to chase such leads, addressing *soirées* such as that held at the Cannon Street Hotel in late June 1931, his talk of new psychologies and national renaissance remained of marginal appeal.[56]

The limited response to the New Party's canvassing for industrial and financial support are not hard to explain. Three things, in particular, served to block Mosley's progress. First, if Mosley's initial programmes were admired for their dynamism, then the detail of his proposals proved far more contentious. Most obviously, the overtly statist nature of the New Party programme conflicted with the more self-regulatory objectives of those in PEP, the NCIC and, indeed, the young Tories who later fed into the National Government and cross-party formations such as the Next Five Years Group and The Middle Way.[57] Second, the corporate tendencies expressed by many of Mosley's fellow proto-planners were, ostensibly, perceived to be politically unaligned. PEP and the NCIC were effectively pressure groups, political but – in Max Nicholson's words – 'anti-party'. Thus, when the New Party approached PEP to combine forces in 1931, its overtures were rejected on account of the latter being 'non-political'.[58] Third, the New Party's criticism of the banking system and financial interests obviously alienated many in the business world. A basic premise of the New Party programme was that the banks were ill-suited to drive the British economy and the self-interest of the City antithetical to the wider interests of the nation. Talk of 'banksters' and the need to subordinate the City to the requirements of the corporate state therefore did little to win the New Party admirers on Threadneedle Street.[59]

Of course, other factors worked against the New Party's cultivation of influential opinion. Its political isolation, combined with Mosley's ever-controversial character, ensured that the party received at best only qualified – rather than actual – support. Just as Keynes told Nicolson that he would 'without question' vote for the New Party, and felt that the party was sure to do 'an immense amount of good', so numerous others, from Malcolm Bullock, Gerald Barry and Lord Melchett to Leonard Woolf, Basil Dufferin and Leslie Hoare-Belisha, claimed to be with Mosley in spirit but never in soul.[60]

Art and language: Taking a cultural turn

The New Party launched *Action* on 8 October 1931. It was to be the 'New Weekly for the New Movement'; it cost 2d and was run by Nicolson from a 'luxurious and modern' office at 5 Gordon Square, London WC1.[61] Initially, Nicolson was assisted by Noel Josephs, an amiable sub-editor and self-proclaimed 'apostle of Lenin', and a troublesome general manager known as Hamlyn. As may be supposed, the paper sought to embody the New Party's broader character. Its first headline read 'Crisis!'; it endeavoured to be overtly modern and to act as a guide for those 'perplexed' by Britain's apparent 'lack of purpose'. Inside, pages were put aside for articles and reviews relating to science, architecture, film, radio, literature and travel; it utilised contemporary typefaces and promised to demonstrate that 'the Modern Adventure is not, after all, so terrifying, that the future is [...] filled with a hard bright interest'. According to its editor, *Action*'s 'watchwords' were: 'Truth', thus an appeal to thought rather than emotion; 'Courage', to 'say quietly and calmly what we feel'; 'Intelligence', to be high-brow but inclusive; and 'Vigour', to speak with a 'virile' accent whilst simultaneously packing a 'punch'.[62]

Such a remit was important. *Action* was designed to give sustenance to the broader interests and outlooks of the New Party. It served as a means of expressing the party's cultural vision, providing a medium through which those attracted to Mosley's modernism, vitalism and generational appeal could help form and shape the proposed New Movement. Certainly, the New Party was distinctive in so far as it attracted a small but notable collection of intellectuals, writers and artists not previously drawn to party or mainstream politics. Alongside the Sitwells, the party and *Action* found space for poets and critics such as Peter Quennell, Raymond Mortimer, Maurice Oughton and Alan Pryce-Jones, writers such as E. Arnot Robinson, Eric Muspratt, John Heygate,

Christopher Isherwood and Vita Sackville-West, and theatrical types such as John Boucicault de Suffield Calthrop and Freddie Lonsdale.[63] Even Marcel Boulestin contributed a suitably culinary article to *Action* on the joys of cooking with natural ingredients.[64] In so doing, the New Party's 'newness' may be understood both in its totality and in terms of its providing a blank cultural canvass onto which a newly-imagined future could be projected.

Not surprisingly, this provided for a mixed bag of loosely modernist thought. If musings on Nietzsche and the emergent Nazi movement gave a glimpse of the New Party's eventual transformation into the BUF, then ruminations on the impact of Marxism in Japan, the ignominy of Britain's occupation of Cyprus and the growing similarity of peoples across nations suggested, as noted in Chapter 3, that competing visions continued to exist within the party ranks.[65] The point is that the New Party, briefly but intentionally, regarded itself as the spearhead of a wholly modern movement in tune with the shifting plates of history. It sought to facilitate and shape a new civilisation, informed by science but invigorated by a vivacious cultural spirit. While Mosley provided the political solution to the ensuing economic and political crisis, then his vision of a modern state was underpinned by values that chimed with at least a section of the country's intellectual milieu. In its elitism, modernism and paeans to youth, *Action* sought – albeit rather clumsily – to capture the cultural *Zeitgeist* and assert hegemony.

Unfortunately, neither Nicolson nor Mosley produced an official New Party thesis on cultural policy. Implicit throughout *Action*, however, was a sense that western culture was passing through a process similar to that outlined by Mosley with regard to politics. That is, the cultural values of the Victorian and Edwardian period were under challenge, degenerating even, and that new cultural forms were emerging that tallied with a necessarily re-imagined future.[66] To this end, *Action* gave predominance to modern mediums and championed cultural innovation. Nicolson, for example, produced extensive book reviews that eulogised modernist texts, including Virginia Woolf's *The Waves*, and pointed readers toward such contemporary treatise as Julian Huxley's *What I Dare Think*, with its concept of 'scientific humanism', and Gerald Heard's *The Emergence of Man*, which argued that man's ascent was reliant more on the 'psychical' than the physical. Not dissimilarly, Francis Birrell's film reviews argued for a sense of purpose within the cinema, preferring films that were unsentimental and 'speedy' to those that were merely 'sloppy stories'. Though Birrell harboured reservations

about the advent of 'talkies' and colour film, he celebrated the experimental possibilities of cinema and its potential for communication. Hobhouse, meanwhile, wrote on architecture, applauding modernist methods of construction but deriding the 'Fabian daydream' of the uniformally dull Welwyn Garden City.[67] Less artistically, Gerald Heard and Robert Forgan both wrote extensively on the importance of scientific discovery. For Heard, human biology loomed large, embracing racial – though not racist – theories on the evolution of mankind; Forgan concentrated on health. Throughout, the advances of modern science, art and literature were related back to the New Party's own sense of spirit and originality.

As noted in our introduction, *Action* proved to be short lived. Its costs were too high, and it soon registered losses of some £340 a week.[68] Behind the scenes, too, trouble brewed. Even before the first issue found its way to the news stands, Nicolson admitted to Vita his concern that 'shaky' advertising interest did not bode well for the future. 'We have got six of our twelve pages but shall need six more […] it is said that one can always get advertisements for the first copy of a paper.'[69] The paper's pre-production also succeeded in provoking the wrath of Gerald Barry, who objected to the use of *Week-End Review* snippets in the dummy edition. This was soon resolved without recourse to legal action, with Hamlyn taking the blame for such a 'foolish mistake'.[70] Soon after, however, Hamlyn's misdemeanours took on a more serious form. Having already displayed signs of unreliability, he fell out with the paper's advertising agent, Bashford, and was sacked for 'misconduct' in early November. His qualifications, it seems, were not quite what he claimed on taking the job.[71]

As importantly, perhaps, *Action*'s commitment to modernity and reason were compromised by the peculiarly staid and, ultimately, jaundiced vision presented by many of its contributors and readers alike. Very soon, a central debate within the weekly revolved around the benefits (or not) of public school education and Oxbridge. Similarly, sections on gardening and forms of social etiquette suggested that its 'spirit' really lent as much towards rural tranquillity as it did the dizzy modernity of a burgeoning political movement. Its brief appeal to women centred on thrift and recipes; its readers seemed as distraught about the divorce laws and noisy children in the cinema as they did about unemployment and the deepening financial crisis. Thus, for all its talk of the 'old world' being 'dead' and the need to raise 'from its ashes […] a new world, more scientific, more human, and far more enjoyable', *Action* soon became immersed in what Mandle has described as a mix of 'shrill propaganda'

and 'knowing urbanity'.[72] Dry, often technical, articles on economic theory appeared alongside Mosley's weekly piece of determined prose; the extensive film and literary reviews ran into genuinely bizarre articles by the likes of Arnot Robinson on 'Emotional Bad Form – The New Shyness' and Muspratt's tales of tramping.

We should note that *Action*'s failings were clear to its editor. From the outset, Nicolson admitted that his first mailbag had included a 'torrent of criticism, some abuse, and a compensating measure of praise'.[73] By the paper's end, he surmised that the weekly had proven 'too high-brow for the general public, and too popular for the high-brow […] too technical for the superficial reader, and too superficial for the serious student […] too literary for the person who wanted politics, and too political for the person who was interested in books'.[74] Even then, of course, Nicolson chose to interpret such failings as revealing more about the British public than they did about his own editorial ability or cultural vision. 'The great public, though they are sometimes willing to swallow new information, are unwilling to swallow new ideas.' *Action*, it seemed, was simply too advanced for the simple British people.

With *Action*'s demise, the New Party's capacity to both circulate its policies and set a complementary cultural tone all but disappeared. On the advice of Brendan Bracken, an arrangement was secured with the sympathetic *Saturday Review*, whereby it was agreed that 'from time to time' Mosley would be allowed to 'discuss the aims and policy of his organisation from the standpoint of an independent contributor'.[75] But little came of this. An article by Nicolson and an advert for the Nupa No. 1 Club was all that appeared in the new year. In any case, Mosley's interest in – or tolerance of – the more cerebral leanings of his emergent New Movement was evidently wearing thin by late 1931. First the general election and then the establishment of Nupa ensured that his priorities were concentrated elsewhere, leaving Nicolson to conclude that it would not 'in practice be possible to ride two horses – mastering the young filly of the King's Road [Nupa] and at the same time driving the old cab horse of liberal intellectualism'.[76] Thus, as Melville began to assess the evermore limited basis of Mosley's support – a few existing and prospective MPs, intellectuals and students, those attracted to the youth movement – so many of the New Party's more 'progressive' advocates began to drift away.[77] As a consequence, perhaps, the cultural tenor of the New Movement soon became less that of high-brow progressivism and more one associated with a vibrant but combative masculinity. It is to the latter that we shall now turn.

8
Leaders of Men: Masculinity and the Promise of a New Life

Mosley regarded himself as a man of destiny. On closing down *Action* in December 1931, he revamped his resignation speech of May 1930 to declare:

> Better the great adventure, better the great attempt for England's sake, better defeat, disaster, better for the end of that trivial thing called a political career, than stifling in a uniform of blue and gold, strutting and posturing on the stage of Little England amid the scenery of decadence, until history, in turning over an historic page of the human story, writes of us in contemptuous script: 'These were the men to whom was entrusted the Empire of Great Britain, and whose idleness, ignorance and cowardice left it a Spain'. We shall win; or at least we shall return upon our shields.[1]

Such purple prose revealed much about Mosley and his New Party. Most strikingly, perhaps, it gave notice of his belief that there existed an on-going struggle for the soul of the nation. Looking out across a landscape of economic dislocation and supposed cultural decadence, Mosley perceived himself at the head of a fledgling army. He appeared, in Melville's words, an 'active adventurer'; a warrior equipped with a first-class brain and an idealism to match his ambition.[2] Britain, it seemed to Mosley, was caught in the midst of a devastating crisis. It awaited its saviour, an aristocratic hero born to cut a swathe through those too enfeebled – or too emasculated – to act.

Such oratory, in terms of both its imagery and its delivery, was integral to Mosley's self image and the myths that subsequently formed around him. As printed text, his words were often bookended by such flourishes, written more with the platform than the reader in mind. It

was, after all, as a speaker that Mosley gained his reputation. Harold Laski, writing in 1930, noted Mosley's 'charm' as a speaker. '[He] knows how to debate [...] he knows how to work [...] he makes his associates want to follow him'.[3] It was on the public stage, 'striding up and down [...] with great panther steps', gesticulating as his argument rose to a crescendo, that Mosley would be best – and often – remembered.[4]

We should qualify this. As already noted in Chapter 6, many of those who heard Mosley speak remained unconvinced by either his performance or his words. If Skidelsky can quote at length a *Manchester Guardian* article of 26 October 1931 detailing Mosley's charismatic presence and his ability to rouse his audience with a 'tornado' of powerful oratory, then we may also point to the *South Western Star*'s extensive report of ten days before. In this, amidst reference to oratorical fluency and forcible personality, Mosley's performance was described as more entertaining than convincing. The party leader was depicted as aloof, with a condescending manner that failed to move the vast majority of those present.[5] For some, however, Mosley undoubtedly did articulate and personify an idealised vision of an alternative future. To Florence Simmonds, who joined the BUF in 1933, Mosley appeared like 'one of those dashing Elizabethan courtiers or [a] swash-buckling sea captain'; for John Charnley, Mosley exuded a 'natural charisma and personal magnetism' that eclipsed all other politicians.[6] If new men were needed for a new age, as Mosley and those who followed him believed, then they were to be warrior-athletes moulded by their wartime experience and imbued with the virility to impregnate history in their own image.[7]

The new man

The New Party was, in many ways, an exercise in masculinity. Its leadership was uniformly male; its membership was predominantly male; its language, focus and approach all tended towards an overtly male-centric worldview. Even Cynthia Mosley, having headed the party's inaugural tour, played an ever-diminishing role thereafter. She took no part in the regular meetings held at Great George Street and spent much of 1931–32 in ill health, pregnant, and embroiled in a legal wrangle over monies relating to her late father.[8] Nupa, despite some reservations, was formally constituted on an all-male basis in late 1931, with Eric Hamilton Piercy insisting that women members would serve only to rob the youth movement of its 'manhood'. Even the Nupa club's

first monthly 'ladies night', held in June 1932, was given over to a fencing competition. Needless to say, all the contestants were men.[9]

The masculinity embodied within the New Movement formed the basis of a recognisable proto-fascist culture inside the New Party.[10] This, following much internal wrangling as to the point and purpose of the youth movement, amounted to the reassertion of a series of distinctly masculine qualities that purported to reflect the spirit and ethos of Nupa and, later, the BUF. The new man was to exude the discipline and courage of the soldier; he was a patriot, willing to make sacrifices for the greater good; he was to be assertive and resolute; healthy in body and mind; wholly committed to the cause.[11] He was, Mosley later explained in *The Greater Britain*, to combine a 'Spartan' morality with a sense of duty to king and country.[12]

To this end, Nupa members bonded together in clubs. The movement was organised into a strict hierarchy, with a uniform introduced to bind its members into a collective whole. This, in turn, was designed to make each member 'feel that he is in the ranks of an army in which all classes are combined with one purpose'.[13] The paramilitary tone was then set further by drilling exercises overseen by the steady influx of ex-officers attracted to the New Party, by salutes corresponding to rank, and by rules introduced to ensure members conformed to sartorial etiquette.[14] Physical exercise was also given priority. In particular, boxing and fencing classes were held inside the Nupa clubs, while cricket, rugby and, in Birmingham at least, football teams were initiated. Overall, the Nupa clubs represented a pseudo-barrack room of would-be soldiers in which the shock troops of the new Britain prepared to do battle.

Such military undercurrents were also evident in the language and imagery utilised by New Party members. Not only did party members make comparison between the on-going economic crisis and the war, when state intervention and common cause had been agreed across party and class lines, but reference to battles, fights, flags, steel, swords and similar soon peppered many a party speech.[15] Throughout the general election, the war records of party candidates were borne proudly, while military men became a conspicuous addition to the New Party platform.[16] In the words of William Weir Gilmour, the 'old parties were led by men who started the war, the New Party by men who fought it'.[17]

Not surprisingly, such militaristic language became more common as the New Party evolved towards its fascist end. This was a process in motion, and we must be wary of over-stating our case. Nevertheless,

where the early speeches delivered by Cynthia Mosley, Strachey, Young, Forgan and Baldwin had tended to concentrate on the details of policy and their reasons for leaving Labour, so Mosley's later – and more robust – pronouncements saw him draw heavily from his arsenal of military metaphors and similes. The New Party was a 'party of iron', he insisted, before urging an audience in Stoke to 'not self-surrender […] the greatest tradition of the ages, but raise and call up, fight and struggle to put Britain again at the head of the nations of the world'.[18] By October, the party conceived itself 'fighting on a restricted front', competing in an electoral 'battle' that was sure to prove 'intense and arduous'.[19] In public too, such rhetoric was accompanied by a parading bodyguard and uniformed stewards.

Of course, such expression lent itself to Mosley's sense of destiny. New Party members regarded themselves as pioneers; they were serving as a vanguard, poised on the brink of a new historical epoch. Most obviously, the social backgrounds of its leading members provided the party with an in-built sense of distinction. With Mosley's ancestry, not to mention the privileged social and educational backgrounds of his main lieutenants, the party appeared to represent the radical wing of Britain's establishment. Simultaneously, however, the party claimed a commitment to meritocracy; its elitism was supposedly defined by ability rather than birthright. Thus, *Action* could state that: '[we] do not believe in equality. We do not believe that every man and woman is potentially equal in brains and energy to every other man and every other woman. Yet we do believe in equality of opportunity. We wish to contrive an order of society in which merit will always be rewarded irrespective of class or privilege.'[20]

As this suggests, the New Party's leading advocates tended to insist that their own inherent sense of superiority was based on intellect and achievement. Like Hitler, they believed in the 'aristocratic principle'; meaning natural leaders imbued with an 'eternal will that governs the universe'.[21] In truth, many of those who stood alongside Mosley, such as Nicolson, Joad and Hobhouse, were social and cultural snobs who looked with disdain upon the less well-tutored ranks of the population. According to his son, Nicolson exuded an 'aristocratic temperament' that gave vent to a range of prejudices against 'all coloured or Levantine people, most American Jews, most women, and the great mass of the middle and working classes'.[22] Joad, as we have seen, harboured ill thoughts towards the 'common man', while Hobhouse claimed to both recognise and 'embrace' inequality.[23] As for those close to the party, attitudes such as those encompassed in Lees-Milne's assertion that 'the

middle and lower classes are horribly self-conscious when out of their own environment' no doubt permeated far beyond the diarist's own private ruminations.[24]

But the New Party's elitism was also presented in more discerning ways. Its members were portrayed as both products and arbiters of a new world still in the midst of creation. The New Movement was to comprise the 'hard' and 'realistic' types that Mosley had depicted earlier in 1930; they were, in Allen's words, men of 'blood and guts', a committed minority prepared to sacrifice themselves in order to forge 'a revolution in the life of the country'.[25] While the 'average' man and woman still searched for a way out of the crisis through Britain's existing political system, so those in the New Movement recognised the fallacy of relying on the old gangs and the moribund political structures of interwar Britain. The New Party, Mosley insisted in June 1931, sought to create 'a new political psychology' that projected a sense of 'new manhood and vigour'.[26] If, therefore, the New Party was forced in 1931 to aim its appeal at 'the elector who is above average', then the unfolding crisis would in time prove the wisdom of the party's position.[27]

To sum up, the new man envisaged by the New Party bore an uncanny resemblance to the self-image of its leader. In other words, Mosley could be seen to encompass all of the qualities referred to above. His ancestry gave substance to his adopting the role of an aristocratic hero, with supporters often referring to Mosley's lineage as somehow proof of his ability and integrity. Dr Mamourian, a New Party supporter from Ashton-under-Lyne, spoke admiringly of Mosley's belonging to the 'noble line of English aristocracy', while Mosley himself referred to his grandfather's representing Stoke when he stood for the constituency in October 1931.[28] John Proctor, meanwhile, related the New Party's spirit to the 'golden age' of the Elizabethan period, when Britain was led by a 'daring commander' and in which the 'common people' did not grumble but simply 'got down to it'.[29] Mosley's war record, though hardly startling, ensured that his calls for personal sacrifice and collective effort resonated with ex-servicemen and those in thrall to the military. Both traits tallied with his claims to patriotism, while his relative youth ensured that Mosley's generational appeal had credence. As the instigator of a detailed political programme and an accomplished fencer who represented his country and was runner-up in his London club's *épée* championship in 1931, Mosley appeared to combine both the intellectual and the physical prowess so revered by his New Movement.

Simultaneously, almost all of the traits outlined above were deemed to be under threat by the early 1930s. The restrictive mores of bourgeois morality, the dictates of DORA, the cult of individualism, the outmoded but pervasive influence of the old gangs, the levelling effects of democracy and the prevailing ethos of internationalism all served to restrain and emasculate Mosley's idealised warrior-male (and so himself). Just as liberal democracy provided for 'soft' and ineffectual government, so bourgeois individualism produced a limp and degenerate culture. 'The men who carried the British flag to the furthest seas were far from hag-ridden in their private lives', Mosley insisted, perhaps with an eye on his own reputation as a sexual predator: 'the companions of their leisure time were neither DORA nor Mrs Grundy'. For Mosley, as he surveyed those around him and the task ahead, the position was clear: 'We want men,' he said, 'not eunuchs, in our ranks.'[30]

Health and efficiency

The New Party's emphasis on masculinity and the body extended beyond reference to its membership. Personal health was linked to that of the nation, with a healthy populace being seen as a prerequisite for a healthy nation and *vice versa*. The party and the New Movement envisioned members who lived like athletes and a country committed to the physical well-being of its citizens. In a letter to *Action*, D. Barrington Hudson suggested that the New Party plan to construct national sports stadiums throughout Britain. He further recommended the establishment of a National Sports Committee under Peter Howard's chairmanship, insisting that the health of the community was integral to the future welfare of 'our race'.[31] Certainly, *Action* intended to encourage its readers to engage in a healthy and active lifestyle. Alongside Forgan's regular articles on health matters, Howard's sports column provided 'training rules for athletes' and offered insights into a variety of sports. That said, the New Party's healthy credentials may now be seen as somewhat compromised on account of Howard's insistence that 'not only in Oxford, but all over Great Britain, it is a recognised part of athletic ritual that if you play games you must get drunk'. Smoking, too, was deemed a useful means of freeing the athlete from 'that feeling of nervous restraint' experienced by those who had tried to give up such vices.[32]

Biological imagery also tended to inform the New Party's references to politics and society. As noted previously, Strachey and Joad understood parliament to be 'dying' by 1931. Mosley, meanwhile, talked of

the 'dry bones' of British politics, suggesting that the country was 'being asked to turn her face to the wall and give up like an old woman who knows that she has to die'.[33] By contrast, the corporate state was expected to be a vibrant expression of those who manned it. Such a state, the party leadership explained, was to be 'as organic as the human body'; it was to be a state 'in which there shall be no dead limbs and no parasites. A state in which each part is as dependent on the other part as the limbs are dependent upon the heart and arteries.'[34]

As may be expected, such metaphors and similes were often gendered in an overtly masculine way. 'The grandmother of liberalism,' Mosley wrote earlier in 1930, 'must give place to the virile paternity of a new movement which treats British citizens not as children, but as adults who have to remember that they carry in their hands not only their fate, but the fate of their country.'[35] Thus, where the New Party – meaning its policies, members and proposed state administration – was presented as resolute, healthy and assertive, so Mosley's political opponents tended to be dismissed in enfeebled terms. For example, Mosley's last speech to the House of Commons included reference to Britain needing to be more like an 'athlete' than a 'monk', a rather mixed analogy that nevertheless contrasted the physical 'effort' of the former with the subservient, closeted and sexless demeanour of the latter.[36] If the government was cowardly and full of 'old stiffs', as John Castell put it, then the New Party promised to govern with courage and with 'guts'.[37] Not dissimilarly, the New Party often derided its opponents for their displaying supposedly feminine characteristics. Randolph Churchill, for instance, reportedly spoke at a New Party meeting of the need to castrate 'political ineffectives', before suggesting that both Stanley Baldwin and Ramsay MacDonald were 'women already'.[38] The country was 'hagridden', Mosley insisted, ruled by a 'legislature of old women' to the extent that the 'natural impulses of man' were thwarted by the 'whining voice' of an 'omnipotent grandmother'. Philip Snowden, Labour's beleaguered chancellor of the exchequer, was dismissed as acting like an 'old woman in a fright'. In response, the New Party presented before the British public 'new men' with 'fresh minds', a 'policy of manhood', and a commitment to taking decisive action in government.[39] To this end, 'Kid' Lewis appealed to the east end not as a 'professional politician' but as someone wishing to use his 'punch' to put 'action into politics'.[40]

Such terminology tallied with – and further informed – the New Party's generational appeal. The party sought to contrast the exuberance,

idealism and potential of youth with the lethargies and physical limitations of old age. Indeed, youth was evoked as an agent of social, political and cultural change, with the tensions that flowed between the generations providing the stimulus for action. According to the 20-year-old Martin Woodroffe: 'Youth has never failed our country in her hour of need and with the splendid example we have before us in the accomplishments of youth in the war years, no task can be too great if thereby we may render a service of similar value in the interests of the people.'[41] Thus, while youth was stirring from its slumber and ready for action, the 'old gang' was embroiled in an 'idle game'.[42] If parliament was full of 'old men at sea', whose 'tired old hands' were 'stained with blood and disasters innumerable', then the New Party promised men of 1931, meaning young 'go-getters' who would 'scrap' for the national interest and 'blow away the cobwebs of Westminster and let a little fresh air in that sleepy assembly'.[43] Where the older generation of politician comprised little more than 'professional windbags', the New Party provided men of 'vigour and action'.[44] 'One old man is like another,' Mosley told the people of Sheffield, 'their brains and politics were developed in the long ago. Our generation has been betrayed by the old men.'[45]

Of course, the New Party's recourse to biological metaphor and concentration on the literal body politic was far from original.[46] Such rationale had emerged over the nineteenth century to become common currency in the wake of the Great War. The masculine tenor of such language, too, chimed with wider cultural currents. As Mosse's classic study makes clear: 'The ideal of masculinity was invoked on all sides as a symbol of personal and national regeneration, but also as basic to the self-definition of modern society.'[47] The notion that modern civilisation was degenerating lent itself easily to the language of health and efficiency, as Nietzsche, Spengler and others had long demonstrated. Furthermore, expressions of concern about the physical well-being of the population, alongside initiatives to promote healthy lifestyles, were legion.[48] Even so, Mosley's emphasis towards a form of body politics proved significant given his eventual conversion to fascism. The extent to which Mosley conflated the physical and the political ensured that his evolving New Movement forged a distinctive – if ultimately marginal – political presence and further compounded his drift towards a fascist politics pioneered on the continent. Having tried but failed to revitalise the nation's spirit through the existing structures of an apparently ailing polity, he turned instead to new methods expressed in a young and assertive movement that eulogised the physical prowess of an idealised male.

In search of the new women

Did women feature at all in the New Party's vision? There were glimpses. Cynthia Mosley was initially listed as chair to the women's committee of the New Party LC in early 1931, though there is scant evidence to suggest that this got beyond the preparatory stage. A Mrs Putt, too, was appointed secretary of the LC, while Lilian Adams served as secretary to the New Party in Birmingham. Beyond this, women appeared to play but a peripheral role in the New Party. True, Joan Thorpe claimed to have found a congenial and suitably patriotic home in the New Party before transferring with fellow party members to the BUF in 1932.[49] Equally, the lists of those willing to propose New Party parliamentary candidates for selection included a smattering of female signatures, suggesting that local party sections attracted support that was not of a wholly male character.[50] In Kent, the Rochester and Chatham branch of the New Party comprised 11 women and 29 men in December 1931; in Northampton, at least two women – Mary Twiselton and Selina Twist – signed up for the party.[51] According to Craig Morgan, the New Party branch in Stoke contained a 'significant' female contingent.[52] Generally, however, women remained absent from the party platform and, bar the odd article in *Action*, the party literature.

A survey of the New Party's 1931 general election campaign reaffirms such an impression. Although local newspaper reports sometimes made comment on the number of women in the audiences attending New Party meetings, Mosley's men made little effort to actively court the female electorate.[53] Sellick Davies addressed a women-only meeting in Merthyr. This was chaired by Mrs Morgan, who was described as the wife of an unemployed steel worker.[54] Eric Rider Troward, too, presented Reading's female electorate with an election address specifically directed at women voters and replete with a photo of his young wife. But such effort was rare and, in Troward's case, couched in rather condescending language. Indeed, Troward reaffirmed his blundering reputation by assuring the female electorate that he was 'not going to talk to the women electors about stabilisation, rationalisation or any other long-winded words, but just about two topics: FOOD and the DOLE'. The men, meanwhile, were directed towards the New Party's policy on parliamentary reform, economic planning and patriotism.[55]

There were also reports of the all-male candidate list drawing – where possible – on their wives' support to help bolster their electoral appeal. Mosley, of course, did so in Stoke, as did Bill Leaper in Shipley, who with his wife received a Jacobean oak clock and flowers at a social evening held

by friends and supporters in the wake of the election result.[56] Troward, again, assured the Reading voters that his wife would assist him in his parliamentary work, while Cuming and Hodge both called on their wives to help carry the burden of two weeks' electioneering.[57] More generally, however, there was little else in the party's campaign that sought to mobilise female support. On the contrary, Mosley's increasingly combative language and the aggressive atmosphere that sometimes surrounded the New Party's election meetings fostered an overtly masculine politics that deliberately sought to distinguish itself from the female electorate. According to Hamilton Piercy, who insisted he was 'no woman-hater', a 'thinking man knows that it is not a woman's job to have anything to do with the running of the country'.[58]

As noted above, *Action* articles written by or relating to women were rare. Olive Rinder, whom Nicolson described as 'sensible, quiet and alert', initially contributed a women's page entitled 'Listen Women', though this proved to be short-lived.[59] Having set out its stall with articles on cheap recipes and managing the household budget, it was an early victim of the paper's cost-cutting cull. In the final instalment, Rinder celebrated women's role as housewives and suggested that women who were not yet married undertake evening classes in domestic service and cookery.[60] Progressive, or modern, 'Women Listen' was not. And while Sylvia Lockwood did contribute an article celebrating women's superiority to men, and E. Arnot Robinson's supplied a series of pieces on shyness, humility and the horrors of Sherborne Public School for Girls, these were quirky articles that did little to raise the profile of women within either the party or the proposed New Movement.

As should be clear, the New Party's outlook and approach offered little space for a female membership. Mosley himself suggested that the early stages of building a political organisation were 'a man's job', before adding that '[we] have too much regard for women to expose them to the genialities of broken bottles and of razor blades with which our communist opponents have conducted the argument'.[61] For Cynthia Mosley, her withdrawal from the New Party frontline was both one of necessity and design. Not only was she pregnant and ill, but her relationship with Mosley was strained to near breaking point by late 1931. The couple's annual summer jaunt to the Riviera had been fraught with arguments and tears, culminating in Cimmie's being involved in a car crash as she returned home from a fancy dress party.[62] Simultaneously, she viewed her husband's shifting political perspective with growing concern. By December, it seems, she was even considering posting a notice in *The Times* to disassociate herself from Mosley's emergent 'fascist tendencies'.[63]

Ultimately, Cynthia retained her loyalty to Mosley up to the end. Although Mosley's table talk often sparked into political life only after the women had retired, Cynthia nevertheless campaigned for the New Party in Stoke (sparking fears of a miscarriage in the process) and reportedly turned her attention to designing party emblems in 1932 as Nupa morphed into the BUF and Mosley fell in love with Diana Mitford.[64] Cynthia eventually died in May 1933. The irony, of course, was that she was by far the most popular member of the New Party.[65]

Female friends and wives of other party associates also found reason to keep their distance. If Mosley had a personal magnetism that could attract both devoted support and sexual favour, then he could repel just as easily. For every Georgia Sitwell, 'Baba' Curzon and Diana Mitford, there were others, such as Ellen Wilkinson, who saw something sinister and distrustful behind Mosley's dashing good looks.[66] Vera Meynell described Mosley as a 'serpent', while Peter Howard's love, Doë Metaxas, reportedly took an instant dislike to the party leader's face.[67] Nicolson's wife, Vita Sackville-West, also loathed Mosley, though she did agree to write a gardening column for *Action*.[68] More seriously, perhaps, a party in which one of its supporters could declare 21-year-old women to be 'flippant, vulgar and empty-headed, seemingly incapable of sustaining a single theme for five minutes', would hardly provide the most propitious surroundings for a young female activist.[69]

As with the New Party's broader political approach, its failure to appeal to and cater for its actual and potential women members ran against the prevailing grain. Both the Conservative and Labour parties made concerted – if not always wholly successful – attempts to recruit women members and to win the women's vote.[70] In time, Mosley appeared to regret such oversight. Like 'Bluebeard', who suggested to *The New Times* that the decision to disallow women Nupa membership served to limit both the party's popular support and its revenue, Mosley claimed to recognise the important role that women had to play in his corporate future.[71] Consequently, in the BUF, Mosley provided room for a 'feminine fascism' that sought to complement the masculine ethos prevalent throughout the movement.[72] With regard to the New Party, however, women were cast very much in the shadow of an evolving cult of masculinity that combined the well-being and status of the British nation with the health, efficiency and manliness of its subjects. In the face of modernism's emasculating forces, the New Party called on Britain to stand strong and to 'brace itself as a man to face new thoughts, new sacrifices and new adventures'.[73]

9

Hurrah for the Greyshirts: The New Party and Fascism

Trying to discern the precise moment when Mosley and the New Party became overtly fascist is akin to searching for the proverbial needle in a haystack. Apocryphal stories are many. George Catlin later claimed that Mosley responded to his celebrated but fruitless Labour conference speech in October 1930 by telling those staying with him at the Grand Hotel that 'this means dictatorship!'[1] Strachey, of course, pinpointed Mosley's conversion to fascism as occurring on polling day in Ashton-under-Lyne in the spring of 1931.[2] In accord with Young and Joad's references to fascist elements finding their way into the New Party by the summer of 1931, Nicolson also made irregular mention of Mosley's growing interest in fascism over the course of the year. By July, he had concluded that Mosley, 'at the bottom of his heart, really wants a fascist movement'. Come the autumn, following the disturbances that pre-empted the party's disappointing general election result, and Nicolson could state definitively that 'he [Mosley] believes in fascism. I don't. I loathe it'.[3] Some deliberation continued thereafter, as Forgan and Nicolson raised concern as to getting 'muddled up with this fascist crowd'.[4] But Mosley's trip to Rome served only to confirm his decision to adopt the fascist label: on his return, with a head full of 'Mussolinian ideas', he oversaw the New Party's transformation into the New Movement and BUF.[5]

Looking back, the whiff of fascism surrounded the New Party from its gestation. As we know, Mosley had begun to make broadly affirmative reference to Fascism and National Socialism from at least November 1930.[6] By this time, too, his egocentric personality had begun to invoke dictatorial suspicions. In September 1930, Cuthbert Headlam passed

comment on Mosley's plotting with Oliver Stanley in preparation for the forthcoming parliamentary season.[7] 'He is ready,' Headlam noted:

> to ally himself with any party or body or persons who would accept him as its leader […], the eternal 'ego' is the only thing that interests him […] He is first and always an 'Oswald Mosleyite' – and he professes a policy which he thinks would enable him to become an English Mussolini, governing by Orders in Council rather than Parliament. The idea is picturesque – and to carry it through all that is required is that Oswald Mosley should have a party – what the politics of that party might be is quite immaterial – so long as he is its big noise.

Once the 'Mosley manifesto' was published in December 1930, such accusations became commonplace.[8]

Mosley initially denied these charges. In a note to Allan Young, sent in December 1930, he insisted that dictatorship was 'exactly the opposite of what I have in mind'.[9] Speaking in Manchester the same month, Mosley claimed that he had 'merely suggested introducing into parliament the methods of twentieth-century business instead of the methods of a nineteenth-century debating society'. Then, with a nod to his still valid Labour membership, he explained: 'The general secretary of a trade union was appointed to go on with his job subject to the control of his annual conference, which would dismiss him if he failed. He was not on that account dismissed as a dictator'.[10]

But if the New Party had fascist potential from the outset, it would be wrong to thereby conclude that its becoming the BUF was inevitable. Not only did the original New Party comprise members who regarded themselves as socialists and aligned to 'progressive' causes uncongenial to fascism, but Mosley himself prevaricated over his adopting *fascismo*. He refused to commit to fascism in the early summer of 1931 when pressured to do so by a section of the party, and he continued to explore the possibility of more conventional political solutions through until at least the 1931 general election.[11] Even in March 1932, having been approached by the government chief whip, David Margesson, Mosley contemplated the offer of standing as a National Independent candidate in order to reclaim a seat in parliament.[12] As noted in Chapter 3, there were myriad points in between the New Party's original programme of immediate reform and the overtly fascist politics embodied in the New Movement by 1932. The 'modern movement' remained loosely defined late into 1931. When asked if the party was 'Socialist or Tory; Fascist,

Hitlerite or Bolshevik', Nicolson answered that it was 'all of these things', taking from each anything deemed of value to Britain. Mosley, too, in the last edition of *Action*, described the modern movement as comprising 'new political forces born of crisis, conducted by youth and inspired by completely new ideas of economic and political organisation'. This, however, did not mean that the party wished 'to import Italian, German or Russian methods and practices into this country'.[13]

Ultimately, the evolving logic of the New Party programme and the circumstances in which Mosley found himself combined to lead him ever closer towards a fascist end. In particular, Mosley's conception of a corporate state and his reading of the political fallout that followed the Labour government's collapse convinced him that the future posed a stark choice between communism and its 'opposite reality'. As such, Mosley appears to have accepted the basic analytical and organisational concepts of fascism by September 1931, both of which he saw confirmed by the New Party's experience during the general election.[14] Following his visit to Italy in January 1932, moreover, the possibility of Italian finance may well have helped convince Mosley to adopt the fascist label.[15] Whatever, the Nupa clubs of 1932 marched to a fascist beat. For Mosley, his and the nation's future was clear: either 'destructive communism' or a 'constructive alternative' based on the corporate state.[16]

Finding fascism

Mosley and the New Party found their way to fascism via a mixture of accident and design. On the one hand, the policies, perspectives and ideals of the party began increasingly to coalesce with those of fascist (and proto-fascist) movements elsewhere in Europe. As Mosley's critique of parliamentary government hardened in line with his growing sense of impending socio-economic crisis, so his pleas for national unity and a corporate solution to Britain's 'decline' likewise found tougher expression. On the other hand, Mosley and his colleagues purposefully set about researching the 'modern movements' that they recognised as emerging on the continent. Consequently, the New Party's cultivation of the New Movement sought to balance both indigenous and external influences.

This was evident from the outset. Mosley, writing in November 1930, admitted that much of the impetus for his thinking came from abroad, describing the New Party's origins thus:

> The modern movement, like most movements, began on the continent and comes last to Britain. On this occasion, as so often before

> in our history, a new movement may find in these Islands the highest expression of its genius. The turmoil and bloodshed of the continent at the end of the eighteenth century found its British reflection in the calm disinterested sanity of the forces which carried the Reform Bill, and which no other nation could have conceived or produced. So today the movement which has thrown up the follies and the excesses of Bolshevism, Fascism, the Young Turk Movement and the Kuomintang should evoke in these Islands a force typical in its English character, and in its toleration, sanity, and executive ability far superior to its continental prototypes.[17]

In other words, the New Party bore 'the same relation to the great modern political movements of the continent – Fascism, Bolshevism, Hitlerism – as the English Reform Movement bore to the continental revolutionary movements in the early nineteenth century'.[18]

The eventual flowering of British fascism stemmed from similar reasoning.[19] Without doubt, the intellectual ingredients for fascism existed in Britain for some time prior to the BUF's formation in 1932, emerging in response to the varied challenges offered by liberalism, socialism, feminism and the wider socio-economic changes affected by the processes of industrialisation and urbanisation. Indeed, historians have dug deep to excavate the broader political and cultural currents that fed into the post-war fascist mindset.[20] Most obviously, Joseph Chamberlain's call for tariff reform and imperial preference combined with the various military leagues' paeans to empire to provide Edwardian precursors to much that the BUF would later hold dear. The late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries also saw many a rumination on the organic nature of society and the nation, on the degenerative effects of liberal democracy, and on the need for an aristocratic revival. These, in turn, were complemented by various youth movements and campaigns for national efficiency, by an upsurge in conspiratorial anti-Semitism, and by a rural revivalism that later fed into the fascist fringe via William Sanderson's English Mistery.[21] Simultaneously, as Dan Stone has made clear, such 'extremes of Englishness' found succour in the eugenics movement and the influence of Nietzsche, subjects as likely to be discussed in 'progressive' and socialist circles as they were on the right of the political spectrum, particularly in journals such as *New Age*. This was important. Mosley's reference to the nineteenth-century reform movement as analogous to his own New Movement was designed to show the radical and progressive roots of what would eventually become fascism. After all, Mosley never regarded himself as

a man of reaction, preferring instead to present his ideas as a synthesis of the progress associated with the left and the stability attributed to the right.[22] The influence of Shaw, not to mention that of Keynes and socialist-style planning, should do well to remind us that Mosley's fascism was not simply Toryism recast.

And yet, despite these numerous 'home-grown' influences, Mosley's understanding of fascism was undoubtedly informed by developments abroad. Interest in political trends on the continent was clear amongst the New Party membership; discussion revolved around the emergence of comparable post-war movements, economic planning, and the construction of new forms of government and state. To this end, visits were undertaken and inquiries initiated to help provide Mosley and the party leadership with information, policies and strategies applicable to the British context. So, for example, Strachey and Cynthia Mosley both made visits to Soviet Russia in 1930, from where they returned with mixed feelings as to the potential of the Bolshevik model. Strachey co-authored with Nye Bevan and George Strauss a small pamphlet entitled *What We Saw in Russia* (1931), which recognised the suffering and hardships experienced by the Russian people whilst admiring the long-term economic, social and cultural advances being undertaken in the Soviet Union.[23] By contrast, Cynthia Mosley returned from Russia with more entrenched doubts as to Bolshevism's possibilities. In April 1931, before an audience in Hammersmith, she insisted that Russia's transformation was born only from '15 years of tremendous hardship that Great Britain could not endure'.[24]

Tellingly, perhaps, Cynthia Mosley's analysis of Soviet communism tallied with that of her husband and others in and around the party hierarchy. As noted previously, Mosley could admire the planning principles of the Soviet state, but he consistently recoiled from the upheaval and class conflict experienced across the Soviet territories from 1917.[25] Bolshevism, Mosley wrote in January 1931, looked set to 'wade cheerfully to its objective of a Soviet State through the blood and starvation of a disgruntled society'.[26] Similarly, in *The Greater Britain*, he insisted that the Soviet example had served only to pursue class warfare 'to the destruction of all science, skill and managerial ability, until, when it begins to feel its feet, it has to buy these same qualities at enormous cost from foreign nations'. Transferred to a British context, 'half-a-million starving or killed' was deemed the probable scenario.[27] For Bill Allen, meanwhile, Bolshevism's youthful modernism was offset by a Soviet leadership that he described as 'gun men, hard-boiled, grim and cynical'; to Nicolson, the Russia he heard described over meals with jour-

nalists, diplomats and friends amounted to little more than an 'Asiatic ant-heap'.[28]

Given such objections to Bolshevism, the New Party's attention quickly focused elsewhere. Both Allen and Melville were well-travelled experts on eastern and central Europe who may well have boasted links to foreign nationalist groups.[29] Where Allen had served as a military correspondent during the Greco-Turkish (1919–22) war and published books on countries surrounding the Black Sea, so Melville took an interest in Nazi politics and wrote widely on the Balkans, commenting favourably on King Alexander's 'experiment towards the modern state' in Yugoslavia.[30] Nicolson, too, utilised his contacts to glean information, attending Anglo-German luncheons and meeting with diplomats and correspondents from the *Frankfurter Zietung* and the Italian *Lavoro Fascista* to learn more about political practices on the continent.[31]

As may be expected, the rise of Hitler in Germany and the emergent corporate state in Italy proved of particular interest to Mosley and his companions. The first appeared to offer premonition of the unfolding economic and political crisis in Britain. 'In Germany,' *Action* reported following the electoral gains made by the Nazis and the German Communist Party in Hamburg in September 1931, 'the bleating bourgeois block is dropping out of politics. The same phenomenon is certain, within a measurable time, to occur in England'.[32] Consequently, the party weekly gave much attention to events in the tottering Weimar republic, with particular emphasis on the potential for Nazi advance.[33]

Such reasoning led the party to take a closer look at the Nazi phenomenon. At least two New Party delegations made their way to Germany over the course of 1931–32, the first of which comprised Leslie Cuming and Major Thompson in June 1931, with Hobhouse following suit in late December.[34] Both, it seems, were organised through contact with Dr Hans-Wilhelm Thost, a journalist and Nazi member dispatched to Britain with orders to organise resident Germans into formal Nazi Party sections.[35] The delegations' reports, moreover, appear to have related far more to strategy than policy. Cuming and Thompson were charged with gathering information towards the formation of the party's youth movement, while Hobhouse's trip to Munich was specifically designed to learn something of the 'Nazi technique'. In due course, he returned to recommend that the New Party concentrate on the back streets and alleyways rather than the more refined social circles to which Mosley and his companions were typically *au fait*. 'We must be harsh, violent and provocative', Hobhouse reported.[36] If, therefore, the New Party's position was occasionally likened to that of Mussolini's Fascists in the immediate

aftermath of the Great War, then the German situation of 1930–32 began increasingly to resonate with Mosley's followers in the months prior to the BUF's formation.[37] Certainly, Mosley spoke to Nicolson of his desire to model Nupa along the lines of the *Schutzstaffel* (SS), while Lockhart recorded earlier in August 1931 that Mosley was 'very interested in Hitlerism and has made a close study of it'.[38]

Of course, Italian Fascism had by this time already alerted Mosley's programmatic instinct. Not only did the New Party contain informed Italophiles such as Barnes and the Sitwells, but Mussolini's burgeoning state provided Mosley with a working template. The more Mosley discussed and read about Mussolini's dictatorship, the more its basic concepts, particularly its state-directed corporatism and commitment to strong leadership and action, began to tally with his own reading of concurrent debates on-going in Britain. If Soviet-style communism was deemed inimical to British conditions, then Fascism appeared to provide an alternative model to protect against the ravages of untrammelled capitalism and the shortcomings of liberal democracy. Because of this, perhaps, Mosley's admiration for Fascism was cemented by his visiting Italy in 1932. Unlike Nicolson, who returned disheartened, Mosley found inspiration in the Italian capital. Though he thought Mussolini 'affable but unimpressive', he nevertheless began to daydream of the 'roll of drums around Westminster' and – Nicolson suggests – the chance to intern the likes of MacDonald and Thomas on the Isle of Wight.[39] He met, too, with Achille Starace, the Fascist Party secretary and choreographer of many a Fascist spectacle, witnessing first-hand a typically regimented Fascist parade.[40] If not quite an epiphany, then Mosley still felt able to inform the *Daily Mail*'s readership that Italy and its leader embodied a bright new future: 'every moment possible is wrung from time; the mind is hard, concentrated, direct – in a word, "Modern"'.[41]

As should be clear, the rather disparate origins of British fascism were given focus by the post-war examples of Italy and Germany. Mosley studied their politics and applied them to his own reading of the socio-economic and political situation on-going in early 1930s Britain. For Lockhart, writing on the eve of the BUF's formation, Mosley's fascism was self-evidently 'Mussolini in policy and Hitlerite in organisation'. That is, Mosley sought to build a corporate state via an extra-parliamentary movement designed to 'control the streets' in a period of socio-economic crisis and political paralysis.[42] Or, as the New Movement's own 'Greyshirt Anthem' put it: 'First the German and Italian/ One will win, the other's won/Shout the grey clad young battalion/ Britons do what they have done'.[43]

Blackshirt, brown or grey?

The New Party's adoption of fascism was not achieved without some difficulty. Most obviously, Italian Fascism and German National Socialism tended to be seen as related but distinct entities during this time, thereby provoking some interesting divisions within the party as to which creed provided the more useful template within the British context. There also remained some equivocation as to just how far the party should – and could – imitate its foreign counterparts. Nicolson, in particular, struggled to reconcile the New Party's objectives with those of fascism, for some time trying to persuade himself and others that the corporate state – as a concept – was not necessarily synonymous with repression and violence.[44] He regarded the 'petty intimidation and bullying' of Mussolini's dictatorship as 'unintelligent as well as inhumane', and remained harshly critical of Fascist foreign policy. 'Much as we admire all that *Fascismo* has done for the internal situation in Italy,' Nicolson wrote in late October 1931, 'and much as we welcome the contribution it has made to modern and social economic theory, we cannot praise the cant and jingoism of its foreign policy'.[45] Fascism, Nicolson concluded, led only to violence.[46]

Initially, at least, Nazism proved even more controversial, though a growing number of Nupa members found much to admire in the German variant of fascism by 1932. Not only were London's Nupa clubs decorated with pictures of Hitler by this time, but talks on Nazism had become a staple feature of the youth movement's more cerebral activities. As chillingly, expressions of extreme anti-Semitism were becoming more and more commonplace within Nupa by 1932, to the extent that the Jewish Board of Deputies wrote with concern to Mosley as to views expressed in *The New Times* immediately prior to BUF's official unveiling.[47] According to P. M. M., the same 'high principles, firmness and fearless determination' then bringing Hitler to prominence in Germany could 'carry the New Movement through in Britain'.[48]

For others, however, the Nazi road was problematical. John Heygate, while recognising that Nazi policies warranted close study, nevertheless felt that the German focus on race and the concept of *Blutsgefühl* had little to no relevance in Britain.[49] Similarly, Melville's comparison of the New Party and Nazi movement concluded that the latter's anti-Semitism was irrelevant to Britain, while Nicolson found in Nazism only a 'doctrine of despair'.[50] Even those wholly committed to fascism raised concern as to the influence and methods of Nazism. L. G. Waterman, for instance, argued that those members attracted to the anti-Semitic worldview of the Nazi-influenced IFL were in danger of losing sight of Nupa's real

purpose: the building of a corporate state.[51] Nupa had a choice, he believed, between the 'purposeful, ordered and disciplined violence' of Fascism during its 'revolution', complete with the 'dignified […], sincere, almost religious, fervour and noble restraint' of Mussolini, and the 'futile, provocative and disorderly violence' of Nazism that served only to complement the 'hysterical outburst[s] of Hitler'.[52]

Such distinctions were also evident following Mosley's invitation to merge Nupa with Britain's existing fascist organisations. As is well-known, this proved problematic. First, many in the New Party baulked at such a decision (verified in April 1932) and left the party as a consequence.[53] Second, Britain's small fascist bands proved resistant to Mosley and Forgan's charms, especially their insistence that Mosley be recognised as the undisputed leader of the proposed fascist union.[54] Both the BF and the IFL had previously been critical of Mosley's socialism, and both tended to treat Mosley's conversion to the corporate state and 'fascism in theory' with suspicion.[55] As it was, the BF was divided as to whether to accept the New Party's invitation, before the male contingent of its leadership broke rank to join with Mosley in forming the BUF. The IFL, meanwhile, when not arguing with itself over such issues as to whether Sir John Simon was or was not Jewish, retained its distrust of both Mosley and Nupa.[56] Although Nupa's London clubs organised joint meetings with the IFL, at which papers on 'The New Party's Approach to Fascism' were reportedly given a sympathetic hearing, it was the more Italophile members of the BF who first joined forces with Mosley.[57] Thus, Neil Francis Hawkins and E. G. Mandeville Roe both formed part of Mosley's circle some time prior to the BUF's official launch, bringing with them a membership list to which the party appealed in mid-1932.[58]

Despite such uncertainties, Mosley's decision to seek a merger with the BF and IFL represented a firm commitment to fascism.[59] By August 1932, as reported in the *Daily Herald*, the party's offices in Great George Street found home to men wearing black shirts keen to form the 'nucleus of storm troops'.[60] Their objective, *The New Times* insisted, was set: '[Our] work now is to gain supporters of our movement, and then to inculcate into every one that sense of discipline to authority, that spirit of self-sacrifice, that proud memory of the traditions of one's country and that faith in the greatness of its future which make the Fascist ideal of a good citizen'.[61]

Realising a fascist future

In the spring of 1933, 20 black-shirted men marched to the front doors of the BBC's Broadcasting House in central London. Minutes later, a

black car arrived from which Sir Oswald Mosley emerged. The waiting guard of honour offered a raised armed salute to their leader; their leader returned it. Without a word being spoken, Mosley entered the BBC and made his way to greet Megan Lloyd George, with whom he was scheduled to debate the fascist system of government and its relevance to Britain.[62] Less than a year after the New Party had been all but banished to the margins of British politics, the formation of the BUF in October 1932 appeared to usher in a period of 'respectable fascism' during which Mosley courted the establishment and strove to hone the fascist politics sired by Nupa.

Mosley's radio broadcast was designed to offer a concise synopsis of the ideas contained within *The Greater Britain*, the book he had worked on throughout the summer of 1932 and which formed the first real statement of the BUF's intent. Thus, Mosley defined his fascism as a 'new creed of the twentieth century'; it was based on principles of citizenship and an authoritarian state; it was forged by those who believed that 'an epoch of civilization has come to an end, [and] that we are witnessing the birth-pangs of a new civilization'. Though he recognised fascism to be a 'universal creed', Mosley insisted that it found 'practical national expression in each country in turn'. In other words, fascism 'introduces a new morality and a new sense of responsibility and citizenship to the world, but it also meets the facts confronting each nation by severely practical measures, and on those facts builds a national policy'. Fascism did not, therefore, offer a policy of 'academic theory or dreamy internationalism'. On the contrary, it comprised a constructive programme of 'hard facts' designed to prevent national disaster and to avert the on-going socio-economic crisis. In practice, this meant the building of a corporate state through which every citizen would work in the 'service of the British nation'.[63]

More recently, historians and social scientists have also sought to devise working definitions of fascism. Roger Griffin, for example, has pursued the 'fascist minimum' towards a 'new consensus', by which he presents fascism as a 'palingenetic form of populist ultra-nationalism' bound to the forces of modernism that swept through the nineteenth and into the twentieth centuries. This, he argues, built on the core myth of an organically conceived nation that, by the early twentieth century, was seen to be caught in a process of degeneration and, thereby, in need of cleansing and renewal.[64] For Griffin, fascism constituted an 'ideologically-driven attempt by a movement or regime to create a new type of post-liberal national community which will be the vehicle for the comprehensive transformation of society and culture, with the effect of creating an alternative modernity'.[65]

Griffin's thesis is contentious but persuasive, serving as a useful 'way in' to understanding what was a complex and diverse phenomenon.[66] It also allows us, in conjunction with Emilio Gentile's analysis of fascism's defining characteristics, to consider the extent to which the New Party pioneered a distinctly fascist politics in Britain prior to its transformation into the BUF.[67] Certainly, once the New Party's links to the labour movement were severed and its initial hopes of forging a broad political consensus were dashed, so the party's tendency to envisage itself akin to various 'modern movements' emergent on the continent intensified. This, as we have already noted, remained ambiguous in 1931. By August, however, Mosley felt willing to launch his slogan of 'Britain First' and to conflate his diagnosis of Britain's prevailing ailments with plans to reinvigorate the nation via a new psychology and a new conception of the nation state.[68] 'We Stand for the New England', *Action* informed its readers in October 1931: 'We Stand for the Future of British Purpose'.[69]

That said, fascism's contempt for 'windy rhetoric' meant that it was further defined by its commitment to action.[70] To this end, the fact that Mosley's attention shifted away from galvanising influential opinion and towards the formation of a regimented youth movement ensured that the New Party's original paean to consensual politics soon took on a rather different character. The party became less a 'centrum' in British politics and more a vehicle for a grass-roots overhaul of existing socio-political structures and conventions.[71] The forming of an extra-parliamentary organisation, combined with a willingness to countenance violence as part of the political process, simply gave substance to Mosley's evermore exaggerated analysis of the prevailing political situation. Not coincidently, the generational perspective that always characterised the New Party ensured that its scope widened beyond the economic premise of *A National Policy*.

By the end of 1931, therefore, the New Party and its fledgling Nupa appendage aspired in theory and in practice to be a populist-nationalist movement committed to preventing Britain's decline via the construction of a modern – corporate – state. This was to be achieved via an active, cross-class and cadre-based movement with a shared sense of mission and a shared sense of service to a new political faith.[72] Such a movement was designed to embody the characteristics necessary to build a 'new' nation; it was disciplined, hierarchical and expressed its ideals aesthetically as well as ideologically. It was ready to physically confront those forces deemed antithetical to the nation's well being; it claimed to represent the primordial spirit of the nation and venerated

both youth and the sacrifices of the war generation. All of this would be expressed more explicitly in the BUF. Even so, the relatively diverse ranks of the early New Party soon distilled within them those instincts, aspirations and prejudices so resonant of the fascist mindset. The reflexive patriotism that Mosley had long since brought to his politics took more pointed form in the context of speeches on imperial preference, impending socio-economic collapse and Britain's historic role as the custodian of progress and civilisation. By late 1931–32, union jacks and the singing of the national anthem had become part-and-parcel of the New Party spectacle, while Nupa members joined with Mosley and Allen to wistfully recall Britain's 'golden age' and to encourage their fellow countrymen to forge a 'dynamic patriotism' befitting of Britain's position.[73] Simultaneously, the casual prejudice expressed publicly and privately by New Party members transformed into a far more virulent form of racism once the likes of Cheyney and certain young Nupa recruits joined the party ranks. Where Mosley and Nicolson could make passing reference to 'niggers on bicycles' and the fear of a civil service 'flooded by clever Jews' without undue comment, then news of Nupa members driving through south London shouting 'Down with the Jews' and distributing anti-Semitic stickers raised broader concern.[74] In mid-1932, E. D. Randall warned his fellow members not to reveal their anti-Semitic hand too early. Once the movement had grown, Randall insisted in an article entitled 'Perish Juda!', then it would be possible to 'translate our hatred of the despicable parasites […] from futile words to deeds'. In the meantime, Randall pointed to the IFL's experience as proof that the British public had succumbed to the promptings of a 'Jew-ridden press'.[75]

As this suggests, the proto-fascist tendencies that many saw in Mosley at the outset of the New Party became evermore apparent as 1931 turned to 1932. With the formation of the BUF, Mosley believed he had laid the foundations for a movement 'led by men who came from the "left"' but comprising a 'rank-and-file [that] combined the conservative and patriotic elements of the nation with ex-socialists, ex-communists and revolutionaries who have forsaken the various illusions of progress for the new and orderly reality of progress'.[76] Where the New Party had sought to mobilise intellectual and influential opinion to alleviate a worsening socio-economic crisis, so the BUF took to barracks and waited for the chaos to ensue. In the process, the orange marigold faded first to grey and then to black, as the New Party flower became the fascist axe.

Conclusion
A Life of Contradiction: Mosley and the New Party

The New Party was an organisation riddled with contradictions, paradoxes and tensions. Some of these were apparent from the outset and no doubt contributed to the party's failure to register beyond the margins of British politics. Its programme seemed to pull in conflicting directions; its early supporters appeared to commit to a marriage of convenience rather than conviction. The *New Statesman*, writing in response to Mosley's December manifesto, described the basis for the New Party programme as a 'scrapbook of ideas and policies designed to rally pessimistic patriots of all parties, but likely to promote the greatest disagreement of the greatest number'.[1] Similarly, the *New Leader* predicted that any party 'basing its programme on an assumed identity of interest of capitalist and worker' would fail to be 'anything but a mirage'.[2] For the sympathetic *Week-End Review*, the attempt to 'reconcile discordant elements' promised to be the principal weakness of Mosley's new venture.[3]

Mosley, of course, would forever present the reconciliation of opposing – or disparate – forces as the defining characteristic of his politics. 'Synthesis, eternal synthesis,' he later stated in his autobiography, 'was the solution to many of the false dilemmas of our time'.[4] From his first election manifesto calling for 'socialistic imperialism' through to his fusion of Hobsonian, Keynesian and socialist economics, Mosley had sought to combine policies and ideas that he regarded as viable, practical and effective. The New Party was no different. If needs be, Bill Allen insisted, the party would happily take 'the protectionist eyeglass of Joe Chamberlain and screw it into its policy of National salvage and National planning'.[5] By 1933, Mosley was ready to present fascism as a synthesis of Christianity and Nietzsche; that is 'faith, service and self-abnegation' fused with 'action, achievement and will to power'.[6] As

this suggests, Mosley consistently strived to marry what he saw as the politics of 'dynamic progress' with a sense of 'order and stability'; a conjunction that he understood to eclipse and transcend notions of political left and right.[7]

Ultimately, it was those sceptical of Mosley's and the New Party's ability to forge consensus from differentiation who were proven right. Even erstwhile party members eventually came to recognise the folly of their initial objective. For Strachey, the New Party constituted 'an entirely utopian appeal for social compromise' that was forever untenable. Having committed to Marxism, he deferred to the irreconcilability of class interests throughout the 1930s.[8] Bill Allen, too, if from a rather different perspective, later bemoaned the diversity that characterised the early New Party. The 'very composition of the party', he recalled in 1934, ensured that it contained 'men who had agreed to agree in principle, but who were always unable to agree in detail'. Too many members, Allen suggested, proved unable to adapt themselves to the problems confronting Britain in 1931–32.[9] In other words, they remained immune to the allure of fascism.

Here, however, Allen began to hint at tensions that ran deeper than mere opinion. Allen's scorn was centred primarily on those he labelled 'intellectuals'; 'hyper-sensitive individuals' whose 'woolliness' prevented them from confronting 'hard realities'. These, in turn, differed from the 'harder element' of the party, meaning men 'steeled' both physically and mentally to confront the socio-economic crisis unfolding around them. Put another way, the early appeal that the New Party's programmatic politics held for 'Strachey and others of the Bloomsbury intellectuals who had first flocked into the New Party' soon paled once a more visceral and assertive politics began to reveal itself.[10]

Nicolson had begun to make similar observations from the summer of 1931. Tensions between what he termed the 'physical' and the 'intellectual' wings of the party became explicit during the summer congress discussion of the youth movement. Thereafter, Mosley's attempts to synthesise these two supposedly disparate elements in the form of joint public appearances by 'Kid' Lewis and Sachie Sitwell became evermore tenuous. As the party's focus began to turn to Nupa, so Nicolson recognised that he, along with other intellectuals, would 'become alien and even adverse to the whole movement'.[11] As should be obvious, such divergence may be read as an extension of the New Party's shift towards the confrontational politics and exaggerated masculinity characteristic of fascism. The intellectuals' cerebral politics jarred with the physicality

demanded of a movement dedicated more to deed, display and action than rumination and discussion.

That 'men' of brain and brawn were destined to embody competing political perspectives was obviously imagined, if still seemingly apparent to many a New Party member. More important, perhaps, were those contradictions and paradoxes in New Party theory and practice that served to undermine the validity of Mosley's political vision. These took a variety of forms. First, the party's reading of the economic crisis afflicting Britain in 1930–32 contained a mixture of insight and over statement. If the party could claim with some justification to have understood the reasons for the crisis, then it proved less perceptive in its analysis of both the immediate and long-term consequences. In this it would not be alone. Nevertheless, the increasingly apocalyptic scenario presented by the New Party soon began to diverge from any recognisable reality and the prognoses of those Mosley had previously relied upon. Keynes, for instance, having briefly succumb to thoughts of European war and American collapse in August 1931, soon resorted to a more positive outlook following the election of a National government.[12] Not dissimilarly, the spectre of 'proletarian revolution' raised by Mosley and his followers was always remote, even in the rumbustious atmosphere of 1931–32. The National government, armed with a 'doctor's mandate', soon showed willing to shed some of the shibboleths that had hampered its predecessors, going so far as to adopt policies reminiscent of the early New Party and to include members who had previously found solace in Mosley's political 'salon'. Even Labour, though in some disarray by the autumn 1931, retained much of its electoral and structural support; if anything, the trade unions' commitment to Labour was galvanised by the collapse of MacDonald's government.[13] Put simply, the economic crisis was less severe and more variegated than the New Party envisaged, while Britain's parliamentary democracy proved far more adept at dealing with the problems before it than Mosley believed possible.

Second, there appeared to be a notable gap between what the New Party claimed to represent and the immediate reality of the party in practice. Here, after all, was a party that called for 'new men', that began to venerate the strong and the powerful, and that claimed to provide a ready elite to galvanise the bulk of the British population in the service of the nation. Yet, the spectacle provided by the New Party fell some way short of its lofty rhetoric. Rather cruelly, Mosley's opponents began to refer to the New Party as a travelling circus.[14] Far from presenting the British people with an idealised image of the future, the party more readily appeared to comprise an array of misfits and malcontents,

providing home for the messianic zeal of a lame but titled Mosley alongside the wilfully unconventional and cowering Joad, the neurotic Strachey, the rarefied sensibilities of Nicolson and his coterie of young university hearties, the ageing pugnacity of Lewis, the awkwardly repressed stammer of Marshal Diston, the juvenility of Randolph Churchill, the eccentricities of Reade, the bumptious pomposity of Cheyney, and the Quixotic daydreams of Troward, Allen and others. Even the potentially intimidating presence of the 'Biff Boys' served to prepare the ground for the later parodying of the BUF as a glorified boy-scout movement.[15]

Such disparity between form and substance was arguably more important in other ways. For example, the party's claims to modernity were too often accompanied by a sense of peculiarly English Arcadia. Mosley's landed inheritance, Nicolson's recall to the public school spirit, the masculine – often rowdy – politics of the public platform: all of these appeared to rub against the grain of the New Party's call for meritocracy and a new form of inclusive – corporate – politics. Indeed, the party's futurist zeal for science, motorcars and machines was accompanied by a barely-disguised nostalgia for a fading rural England. Thus, Joad could combine his self-professed modernism with a 1931 essay bemoaning the 'horrors' of modern life in the countryside.[16] Mosley, meanwhile, lived his racy, urban life whilst conceiving a politics that spoke of the future whilst drawing inspiration from a feudal past. Certainly, his wistful reminiscences of life on his paternal grandfather's Rolleston estate lends a new dimension to Mosley's stated aim of securing 'the conscious control and direction of human resources for human needs'. With its 'medieval' socio-economic structures, Rolleston served to provide the baronet with a model for a 'classless society'.[17] As it was, the New Party looked more like a section of the establishment revolting against itself than a modern movement committed to overhauling the *status quo*.

Third, therefore, the New Party managed to capture the *Zeitgeist* whilst simultaneously appearing strangely out-of-time. Its understanding of the economic crisis ensured that its members were among the first to comprehend the depth of the 1930s depression. Mosley, moreover, was an early champion of Keynes and a pioneer of economic planning, initiating and contributing to debates that would shape Britain's economic future throughout much of the remaining twentieth century. His party sought to embody and give meaning to the generational tensions that helped define the post-war period; it also conspired to usher in the 'red decade' of the 1930s, with its false but widely-held conception of a post-capitalist future defined by the

competing ideologies of fascism and communism. In their reading of Nietzsche, Freud and Spengler, and in their courting of the Sitwells, T. S. Eliot and Wells, New Party members placed themselves in the intellectual orbit of those who helped define the era.[18] Yet, such cultural significance did not necessarily transfer to the political arena. Whilst emblematic of the interwar period, the New Party's brand of radical, confrontational and overtly masculine politics did not reflect the broader drift towards a more peaceable, rational and unassertive British polity; that is towards the cultivation of mixed-gendered dues-paying party memberships, canvassing and new media. British politics in the 1930s were dominated less by charismatic figureheads in the Mosley mould, and more by the sober party figures of Baldwin, Attlee and Chamberlain. Broadly speaking, public politics were giving way to the private; the physical to the virtual.[19]

In terms of the New Party's approach, a fourth contradiction emerged from the fact that it appealed to the mainstream but attracted mainly those drifting around the margins of British politics. Having originated in the shadow of Westminster, the New Party was destined to exist on the periphery. Where it believed its programme laid the foundations for a new 'centre' party, its impact was centrifugal. Far from rallying the 'best' elements of the existing parties to its cause, the New Party drew to its ranks the disaffected, the defeated and the disengaged. This may be a little unfair. Like the later BUF, many New Party recruits came to Mosley with a shared sense of idealism and a genuine sense of purpose.[20] Ultimately, however, Mosley swapped luncheons with Lloyd George, Keynes and Macmillan for the less distinguished company of Peter Cheyney and Neil Francis Hawkins. As such, the rarefied surroundings of the Commons were swapped for the seedy back room; cutting-edge economics gave ground to a poisonous anti-Semitism. Or, in Mosley's own words, 'the old soldier in me got the better of the politician'.[21]

Politically, too, the ways in which the New Party's programme appeared contentious changed over time. Initially, it was the relationship between the proposed state-directed economy and private ownership that remained unclear.[22] Was this a short-step to socialism or a means to save capitalism?[23] Not dissimilarly, there was some uncertainty as to the New Party's objective: was it a temporary organisation designed to avert an immediate crisis, or was it the starting point for a new movement geared towards the complete overhaul of Britain's socio-political, economic and cultural structures? Soon, however, such disparities became more acute. As the radical economic proposals contained in *A National Policy* were revised to provide space for the cor-

porate state, so the party's plans for imperial trading agreements became dressed in evermore nationalistic language.[24] As the remnants of Mosley's socialist past fell away, so the virtues of discipline and hierarchy were reasserted. In short, the New Party appeared – as was Mosley's intention – to be both radical and traditionalist at the same time. And while this did not lead inevitably to a contradiction in point and purpose, it served to exacerbate the potential for dichotomy. Most obviously, the party's commitment to personal freedom did not sit easily with its conception of a movement that invaded 'every sphere' of the nation's life and expected the individual to serve only in the interests of the state.[25]

Finally, the New Party was forced to wrestle with the same apparent contradiction that both its successor (BUF) and its principal opponent (CPGB) struggled to do battle; that is, it sought to present itself as a 'national' organisation despite the obvious debt that it owed to influences beyond the British isles. This, of course, would prove more difficult for an avowedly patriotic organisation than it would a proudly internationalist. As we have seen, the New Party acknowledged its relationship to the 'modern movements' on the continent whilst remaining coy as to its extent and defiant in its commitment to British interests and traditions. But although the party could insist that its 'central doctrine [...] will be British, framed to accord with the character and the high experience of this race', such reassurances did little to stop Mosley's opponents accusing him of borrowing black shirts and more from abroad.[26] If the patriotic appeal of the New Party and, later, the BUF proved integral to their winning support, then their 'un-British' connections no doubt did much to compromise Mosley's credibility in the eyes of many.[27]

Ultimately, then, the New Party may be seen as a victim of its own contradictions.[28] Here was a party supposedly ready for action with a modern, reasoned political programme. Yet, its formation was premature and ill-thought out; its policies appeared contrary to many and contained within them the seeds of division. As significantly, its strategy seemed to veer between the constitutional and the conspiratorial. It was as much Mosley's methods as his policies that prevented him securing influential support, a problem exacerbated once he chose to openly adopt the fascist label.[29] Of course, broader factors also conspired to ensure the New Party's failure. As Mosley himself later conceded, the crisis of 1931–32 was never so deep as to wholly undermine Britain's economic base, nor was it so severe as to wholly discredit Britain's prevailing socio-political structures.[30] Parliament rode the storm; the predicted descent into class warfare and social collapse

failed to occur. There was never a political 'space' into which the New Party could move other than to the right of the political mainstream.[31]

And yet, the short history of the New Party provided legacies that were not simply buried beneath its rather sorry demise. At the very least, the contradictions, inconsistencies and ambiguities that characterised the party reflected the shifting political contours of the 1930s, particularly in the immediate wake of the Wall Street crash and the onset of economic depression. As Mosley stumbled towards fascism, and as Strachey sought conversion to the CPGB, so the party provided a rather neat encapsulation of the political divide opening up across Europe by the 1930s. Without doubt, the New Party served as the political 'chrysalis' from which a fully-realised British fascism would emerge in October 1932.[32] Simultaneously, however, if in typically contrary manner, the policies presented by the New Party also fed into the cross-party, centrist current of British politics that evolved over the interwar period. The party's search for socio-political consensus, for a 'middle way' between liberal capitalism and socialism, tallied with such proto-pressure groups as PEP, the League of Nations Union and, eventually, the Next Five Years Group. As is well-known, national planning, Keynesian economics and what may be termed broadly corporatist ideas formed the basis of mainstream political thinking over the mid-twentieth century.[33] If, therefore, Mosley harboured neither the temperament nor the political nous to cultivate connections and to work within the shifting parameters of Britain's political structures, then the New Party helped provide the impetus for others to develop their politics in a more constructive direction. Fascism, then as now, was never the solution.

Notes

Introduction

1 C. Cross, *The Fascists in Britain* (London: Barrie and Rockliff, 1961), p. 67.
2 O. Mosley, *The Greater Britain* (London: BUF Publications, 1932), p. 5.
3 Upper-case 'Fascism' will be used to denote Italian Fascism; lower-case 'fascism' for generic fascism.
4 Cross, *The Fascists in Britain*, p. 67.
5 For Mosley's resignation speech, see O. Mosley, *Unemployment: Speech in the House of Commons, 28 May 1930, On His Resignation* (London: HMSO, 1930). For positive responses, see *Daily Mail*, 29 May 1930; *Daily Herald*, 29 May 1930. For Labour's second government, see D. Howell, *MacDonald's Party: Labour Identities and Crisis, 1922–31* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002); N. Riddell, *Labour in Crisis: The Second Labour Government, 1929–31* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1999).
6 Labour Party, *Report of the 30th Annual Conference of the Labour Party, 1930* (London: Labour Party, 1930), pp. 200–4.
7 For example, F. Brockway, *Inside the Left: Thirty Years of Platform, Press, Prison and Parliament* (London: Allen & Unwin, 1942), p. 212; E. Shinwell, *Conflict Without Malice* (London: Odhams Press, 1955), p. 136; I. Mikardo, *Backbencher* (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 1988), p. 47.
8 G. Catlin, *For God's Sake Go* (London: Colin Smythe, 1972), p. 84.
9 For examples of Mosley being talked about as a future prime minister, see *Sunday Express*, 18 February 1923; *Daily Express*, 12 July 1924; *Smethwick Telephone*, 28 February 1931; N. and J. MacKenzie (eds), *The Diary of Beatrice Webb: Volume Four, 1924–43: The Wheel of Life* (London: Virago, 1985), 24 December 1928.
10 The term is Nicholas Mosley's. See his *Beyond the Pale: Sir Oswald Mosley and Family, 1933–80* (London: Secker and Warburg, 1983).
11 For biographies of Mosley, see R. Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley* (London: Macmillan, 1975) and N. Jones, *Mosley: Life and Times* (London: Haus, 2004). Both S. Dorril, *Blackshirt: Sir Oswald Mosley and British Fascism* (London: Viking, 2006), and D. Lewis, *Illusions of Grandeur: Mosley, Fascism and British Society, 1931–81* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1987), combine biography and broader political history to explore Mosley's fascism. For fascist accounts from the time, see A. K. Chesterton, *Oswald Mosley: Portrait of a Leader* (London: Action Press, 1937) and J. Drennan [W. E. D. Allen], *BUF: Oswald Mosley and British Fascism* (London: Murray, 1934). Finally, alongside Mosley's autobiography – O. Mosley, *My Life* (London: Thomas Nelson, 1968) – Nicholas Mosley has written a two volume biography of his father: N. Mosley, *Rules of the Game: Sir Oswald and Lady Cynthia Mosley, 1896–1933* (London: Secker and Warburg, 1982) and the aforementioned *Beyond the Pale: Sir Oswald Mosley and Family, 1933–80*.
12 Cited in Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 127.

13 J. Strachey, *Revolution by Reason: An Account of the Financial Proposals Submitted to the Labour Movement by Mr. Oswald Mosley* (London: Parsons, 1925), p. x. Mosley's original but shorter essay is included in M. Quill (ed.), *Revolution by Reason and Other Essays by Oswald Mosley* (London: Edwin Mellen, 1997).
14 F. Brockway, *Towards Tomorrow: The Autobiography of Fenner Brockway* (London: Hart-Davis, 1977), p. 74. For a good insight into Strachey and his relationship with Mosley, see E. Wilkinson, *Peeps at Politicians* (London: Philip Allen, 1930), pp. 105–8. Wilkinson suggests that Strachey served as Mosley's 'right-hand', but exerted a 'considerable' influence over him. See also H. Thomas, *John Strachey* (London: Eyre Methuen, 1973); M. Newman, *John Strachey* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1989); N. Thompson, *John Strachey: An Intellectual Biography* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 1993).
15 Letter from Bevan to Strachey, 23 July 1931 (Strachey Papers). According to Bevan, Strachey was 'a much bigger man in every way than Tom Mosley'. My thanks to Elizabeth a Qaghi for allowing me access to Strachey's papers.
16 Strachey, *Revolution by Reason*, pp. 123–245.
17 For context and the wider planning debate, see R. Toye, *The Labour Party and the Planned Economy, 1931–51* (Woodbridge: Royal Historical Society, 2003); D. Ritschel, *The Politics of Planning: The Debate on Economic Planning in Britain in the 1930s* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1997); N. Thompson, *Political Economy and the Labour Party* (London: Routledge, 1996).
18 Mosley was by no means the only aristocratic or Tory recruit to Labour, but such members were relatively rare. See M. Pugh, '"Class Traitors": Conservative Recruits to Labour, 1900–30', *English Historical Review*, 113/450 (1998), 38–64; C. A. Cline, *Recruits to Labour: The British Labour Party, 1914–31* (New York: Syracuse University Press, 1963).
19 Quoted by Dalton in B. Pimlott (ed.), *The Political Diary of Hugh Dalton, 1918–40* (London: Jonathan Cape, 1986), 20 November 1930. Morrison made a similar comment, remembering Mosley speaking to him 'like a landlord addressing his peasantry'. Quoted in Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 189.
20 Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, pp. 224–5. For portraits of Boothby, Elliot and Stanley, see Wilkinson, *Peeps at Politicians*, pp. 99–101, 19–21 and 54–6 respectively.
21 A. Young, J. Strachey, W. J. Brown and A. Bevan, *A National Policy: An Account of the Emergency Programme Advanced by Sir Oswald Mosley M.P.* (London: Macmillan, 1931).
22 O. Mosley, 'Statement By Sir Oswald Mosley Announcing the Formation of "The New Party"', in J. Strachey *et al.*, *Why We Left the Old Parties* (London: New Party, 1931); *The Times*, 2 March 1931.
23 O. Mosley, 'Crisis', *Action*, 8 October 1931, p. 1; O. Mosley, 'Have We A Policy? – Yes!', *Action*, 17 December 1931, pp. 1–2.
24 M. Worley, 'What Was the New Party? Sir Oswald Mosley and Associated Responses to the "Crisis", 1931–32', *History*, 92/1 (2007), 39–63.
25 Labour Party, *Minutes of the National Executive Committee, 1900–39* (Wakefield: Microform Academic Publishing, undated), 10 March 1931. Baldwin preferred to remain an independent socialist, supporting the New

Party but not joining it. He then relinquished his support for Mosley after the Ashton-under-Lyne by-election, later saying he believed Mosley to have 'deserted socialism'. See C. Walker, *Oliver Baldwin: A Life of Dissent* (London: Acadia, 2003), p. 149; *The Observer*, 14 June 1931. According to Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 243, Strachey had initially argued for the Labour group to take just such an independent position prior to Mosley's decision to form the New Party.

26 W. J. Brown, *So Far* (London: Allen & Unwin, 1943), p. 159; Dorril, *Blackshirt*, p. 165.

27 Drennan, *BUF*, p. 157; Mosley, *My Life*, p. 283.

28 Moore-Brabazon had been Mosley's senior officer in the Royal Flying Corps. S. Ball, 'Mosley and the Tories in 1930: The Problem of Generations', *Contemporary British History*, 23/4 (2009), 445–60.

29 A. Chisholm and M. Davie, *Beaverbrook: A Life* (London: Hutchinson, 1992), pp. 299–305; A. J. P. Taylor, *Beaverbrook* (London, Hamish Hamilton, 1972). It was Neville Chamberlain who apparently talked Moore-Brabazon out of resigning from the Tory Party altogether.

30 R. Benewick, *The Fascist Movement in Britain* (London: Allen Lane, 1972), p. 77.

31 The results were Lieutenant-Colonel Broadbent (Conservative), 12,420; Jack Gordon (Labour), 11,005; Allan Young (New Party), 4,472. In truth, Labour's failing government and questions relating to Catholicism probably had more to do with Gordon's defeat than the New Party's intervention. See Riddell, *Labour in Crisis*, p. 113.

32 J. Strachey, *The Coming Struggle for Power* (London: Gollancz, 1932), pp. 161–2.

33 P. Williamson, *National Crisis and National Government: British Politics, the Economy and Empire, 1926–32* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992); R. Skidelsky, *Politicians and the Slump: The Labour Government of 1929–31* (London: Macmillan, 1967). See also M. Worley, *Labour Inside the Gate: A History of the British Labour Party Between the Wars* (London: I.B. Tauris, 2005).

34 O. Mosley, 'Why We Must Cease *Action*', *Action*, 31 December 1931, pp. 1–2.

35 *Action*, 29 October 1931, p. 11.

36 *Action*, 31 December 1931, pp. 4–5.

37 Mosley, 'Why We Must Cease *Action*', pp. 1–2.

38 M. Worley, 'A Call to Action: New Party Candidates and the 1931 General Election', *Parliamentary History*, 27/2 (2008), 236–55.

39 A. de Courcy, *The Viceroy's Daughters: The Lives of the Curzon Sisters* (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 2000); P. Corthorn, 'W. E. D Allen, "Unionist Politics and the New Party"', *Contemporary British History*, 23/4 (2009), 509–26.

40 Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', p. 2.

41 H. Nicolson, 'Diary', 11 September and 2 October 1931 (Nicolson Papers); N. Nicolson (ed.), *Harold Nicolson Diaries and Letters, 1930–39* (London: Collins, 1966), 22 September, 1 October and 11 December 1931, 15 March 1932.

42 Dorril, *Blackshirt*, p. 203; *The New Times*, June 1932, p. 8.

43 For just a few accounts, see Cross, *Fascists in Britain*, pp. 1–65; Benewick, *The Fascist Movement in Britain*, pp. 73–84; Thomas, *John Strachey*, pp. 96–108; Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, chapters 10–13; Lewis, *Illusions of Grandeur*, pp. 11–32; Mosley, *Rules of the Game*, chapters 17–19; Dorril, *Blackshirt*, chapters 10–11. Also W. F. Mandle, 'The New Party', *Historical Studies, Australia and New Zealand*, 12 (1965–7), 343–55.
44 M. Biddiss, *Age of the Masses: Ideas and Society in Europe since 1870* (London: Penguin, 1977), p. 20.
45 D. Powell, *British Politics, 1910–35: The Crisis of the Party System* (London: Routledge, 2004). For Britain between the wars, see C. L. Mowat, *Britain Between the Wars, 1918–40* (London: Methuen, 1968 edition).
46 *New Statesman and Nation*, 7 March 1931.
47 *New Statesman*, 13 December 1930.
48 *The Review of Reviews*, March 1931; *Week-End Review*, 7 March 1931.
49 *The Economist*, 13 December 1930 and 28 February 1931.
50 *New Leader*, 6 March 1931.
51 *Saturday Review*, 21 February 1931.
52 Young *et al*., *A National Policy*, p. 6; O. Mosley, 'Statement', p. 3.
53 W. E. D. Allen, *The New Party and the Old Toryism* (London: New Party, 1931), p. 2.
54 *Manchester Guardian*, 8 April 1931; E. Wilkinson and E. Conze, *Why Fascism?* (London: Selwyn and Blount, 1934), p. 58; F. Meynell, *My Lives* (London: Bodley Head, 1971), p. 199.
55 *Daily Herald*, 8 December 1930.
56 Quoted in Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 241.
57 Minutes of the Central Committee of the CPGB, 14–15 March 1931 (Communist Party archive). See also R. P. Dutt's 'Notes of the Month', *Labour Monthly*, April 1931, p. 197. In W. Rust, 'A Decade of British Workers' Struggles', *Labour Monthly*, July 1931, p. 429, the New Party is described as the 'first try-out of Hitlerism in this country'. For an excellent overview, see A. Thorpe, 'The Communist Party and the New Party', *Contemporary British History*, 23/4 (2009), 477–92.
58 See comments of Ralph Morley (Labour) and Frank Owen (Liberal) in *Hansard*, House of Commons Debates [hereafter HC Debates], vol. 244, cols. 577 and 789 (3–4 November 1930).
59 *The Review of Reviews*, March 1931; *Week-End Review*, 28 February 1931; *New Statesman*, 13 December 1930.
60 MacKenzie (eds), *The Diary of Beatrice Webb*, 1 March 1931; Pimlott (ed.), *The Political Diary of Hugh Dalton*, 10 March 1931.
61 *Birmingham Town Crier*, 19 December 1930, cited in Thomas, *John Strachey*, p. 91.
62 J. Strachey, *The Menace of Fascism* (London: Gollancz, 1933), p. 165.

Chapter 1

1 *The New Times*, June 1932.
2 For three distinct but detailed overviews of the interwar period, see R. McKibbin, *Classes and Cultures: England, 1918–51* (Oxford: Oxford

University Press, 1998); M. Pugh, *We Danced All Night: A Social History of Britain Between the Wars* (London: Bodley Head, 2008); R. Overy, *The Morbid Age: Britain Between the Wars* (London: Allen Lane, 2009).

3 J. Lees-Milne, *Harold Nicolson: Volume II, 1930–68* (London: Hamish Hamilton, 1981); N. Rose, *Harold Nicolson* (London: Pimlico, 2006).
4 J. Johnson, 'Birmingham Labour and the New Party', *Labour Magazine*, April 1931, pp. 534–6.
5 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 29 November 1930, 29 April, 6 May and 30 May 1931.
6 D. J. Taylor, *Bright Young People: The Rise and Fall of a Generation, 1918–40* (London: Chatto & Windus, 2007); M. Green, *Children of the Sun: Narrative and Decadence in Britain in England After 1918* (London: Pimlico, 1992 edition).
7 Green, *Children of the Sun*, p. 29.
8 For an excellent discussion, see Ball, 'Mosley and the Tories', 445–60.
9 *The Times*, 28 November 1930.
10 J. Carey, *The Intellectuals and the Masses: Pride and Prejudice Among the Literary Intelligentsia, 1800–1939* (London: Faber & Faber, 1992).
11 Nicolson, 'Diary', 11 and 15 September 1931. See also Rose, *Harold Nicolson*, p. 22.
12 Nicolson, 'Diary', 26 January 1931.
13 A. Wolrige Gordon, *Peter Howard: Life and Letters* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1969), p. 48.
14 Nicolson, 'Diary', 26 January 1931.
15 PRO 30/69/446, 'Report of the Unemployment Policy (1930) Committee', May 1930 (MacDonald Papers).
16 BBK/C/254, O. Mosley, Untitled Memorandum, 19 November 1930 (Beaverbrook Papers).
17 Sergeant A. M. Sullivan, 'The Reform of Government', *English Review*, July 1930. For the long-standing heritage of such views, see D. Stone, *Breeding Superman: Nietzsche, Race and Eugenics in Edwardian and Interwar Britain* (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 2002); A. Sykes, *The Radical Right in Britain* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2004).
18 M. Taylor, 'Labour and the Constitution', in D. Tanner, P. Thane and N. Tiratsoo (eds), *Labour's First Century* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000); S. Cripps, 'Can Socialism Come by Constitutional Methods?', in C. Addison, C. R. Attlee *et al.* (eds), *Problems of a Socialist Government* (London, 1933), pp. 42–3; S. Cripps, *Why This Socialism?* (London: Gollancz, 1934).
19 *Political Quarterly*, 3/1 (1932). See also R. Muir, 'What is Wrong with the British System of Government', *Nineteenth Century*, November 1930; H. Harrison, 'Crisis of Leadership', *Fortnightly Review*, April 1931; *Week-End Review*, 1 and 8 November 1930.
20 Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, pp. 227–8.
21 Williamson, *National Crisis*, pp. 135–7; R. Boothby, 'Can Democracy Survive', *Nation and Athenaeum*, 3 May 1930; R. Muir, 'Political Parties and the National Crisis', *Contemporary Review*, February 1931; *idem*, *How Britain is Governed: A Critical Analysis of Modern Developments in the British System of Government* (London: Constable, 1930); Lord E. Percy, *Democracy on Trial: A Preface to an Industrial Policy* (London: John Lane, 1931).
22 *The Observer*, 22 February 1931; *The Times*, 17 December 1930.

23 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
24 Nicolson, 'Diary', 15 February 1930.
25 C. J. Simmons, *Soap-Box Evangelist* (Chichester: Janay, 1972), p. 87.
26 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 2 July 1930.
27 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 29 November 1930.
28 C. E. M. Joad, *The Case for the New Party* (London: New Party, 1931), p. 4.
29 A. Hopkinson, 'The Twilight of Democracy', *English Review*, November 1930; H. Harrison, 'Crisis of Leadership', *Fortnightly Review*, April 1931; G. B. Shaw, *The Intelligent Woman's Guide to Socialism and Capitalism* (London: Penguin, 1928, reprinted in 1937 with sections on 'Sovietism' and Fascism), pp. 381–7.
30 Joad, *The Case for the New Party*, pp. 8–9.
31 C. E. M. Joad, 'Prolegomena to Fascism', *Political Quarterly*, 2/1 (1931), pp. 82–99.
32 Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 165.
33 *Birmingham Town Crier*, 24 January 1930; H. G. Wells, *The Way the World is Going* (London: Ernest Benn, 1928), pp. 35–50; G. B. Shaw, *The Intelligent Women's Guide*, pp. 381–7.
34 Joad, *The Case for the New Party*, p. 6.
35 J. Strachey and C. E. M. Joad, 'Parliamentary Reform: The New Party's Proposals', *Political Quarterly*, 2/2 (1931), pp. 319–36.
36 Strachey and Joad, 'Parliamentary Reform', pp. 321–31.
37 *Birmingham Town Crier*, 24 January 1930.
38 Young *et al*., *A National Policy*, p. 45.
39 Strachey and Joad, 'Parliamentary Reform', pp. 333–6; H. G. Wells, *A Modern Utopia* (London: Chapman & Hall, 1905); *idem*, *The Shape of Things to Come* (London: Hutchinson, 1933); R. Skidelsky, *John Maynard Keynes: The Economist as Saviour, 1920–37* (London: Picador, 1992), p. 228; M. Nicholson, 'A National Plan for Great Britain', *Week-End Review*, 14 February 1931.
40 O. Mosley, 'From Tory to Labour', *Labour Magazine*, May 1929, pp. 6–8.
41 Strachey and Joad, 'Parliamentary Reform', p. 330.
42 O. Mosley, 'A New National Policy', *Week-End Review*, 24 January 1931, pp. 103–4.
43 Young, *et al*., *A National Policy*, p. 8.
44 Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2.
45 Young *et al*., *A National Policy*, pp. 8–12.
46 Strachey, *Revolution by Reason*, chapter four.
47 Young *et al*., *A National Policy*, pp. 19–32.
48 Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, pp. 125 and 267–8.
49 Ritschel, *Politics of Planning*, pp. 20–49.
50 R. Boothby, H. Macmillan, J. Loder, O. Stanley, *Industry and the State: A Conservative View* (London: Macmillan, 1927); Chisholm and Davie, *Beaverbrook*, pp. 275–305.
51 Ritschel, *The Politics of Planning*, p. 50.
52 *The Times*, 19 September 1930; Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 226.
53 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
54 Young *et al*., *A National Policy*, pp. 19–32; Joad, *The Case for the New Party*, p. 8.
55 *The Times*, 24 April 1931.

56 'Letter from John Strachey MP [to Ramsay MacDonald]', 24 February 1931, in Strachey *et al.*, *Why We Left the Old Parties*, p. 5.
57 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
58 Joad, *The Case for the New Party*, p. 7.
59 Joad, 'Prolegomena to Fascism', pp. 82–99.
60 O. Mosley, 'A New National Policy II: A Reply to Criticism', *Week-End Review*, 31 January 1931, pp. 137–8.
61 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
62 Mosley, 'From Tory to Labour', pp. 6–8.
63 O. Mosley, 'What Are We Fighting For?', *Sunday Express*, 25 May 1930; also quoted in Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 225.
64 J. Macdougall, *Disillusionment* (London: New Party, 1931), pp. 4–8.
65 See R. Griffin, *Modernism and Fascism: The Sense of a Beginning under Mussolini and Hitler* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2007).
66 W. Lewis, *Hitler* (London: Chatto & Windus 1931); *idem*, *Apes of God* (London: Arthur Press, 1930). The latter critiques Mosley's circle and that of the Sitwells. Also Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 3 February and 6 October 1931; M. Eckersley, *Prospero's Wireless: P. P. Eckersley* (London: Myles Books, 1996), p. 328; Carey, *Intellectuals and the Masses*, chapter nine. For Lewis, see P. O'Keeffe, *Some Sort of Genius: A Life of Wyndham Lewis* (London: Jonathan Cape, 2000).
67 J. Pearson, *Façades: Edith, Osbert and Sacheverell Sitwell* (London: Papermac, 1989).
68 Edith followed a different trajectory. All but rejected by her parents, she carved her own intellectual niche over the 1920s and appears to have paid scant attention to the New Party.
69 S. Bradford, *Sacheverell Sitwell: Splendours and Miseries* (London: Sinclair-Stevenson, 1993), pp. 220–6.
70 Taylor, *Bright Young People*, pp. 230–2.
71 Shaw appears to have flitted between supporting and despairing of Mosley's split from Labour. At one point he even suggested that Mosley call his new party The Activists, before then recommending his friend stay inside the Labour Party. 'Oh, if Oswald had only waited', Shaw wrote soon after the New Party had been formed. See Mosley, *My Life*, p. 227; M. Holroyd, *Bernard Shaw: The Lure of Fantasy, 1918–50* (London: Chatto & Windus, 1991), pp. 110–14; G. Griffith, *Socialism and Superior Brains: The Political Thought of Bernard Shaw* (London: Routledge, 1993), pp. 250–73.
72 C. E. M. Joad, 'Introduction', in his *Shaw and Society: An Anthology and a Symposium* (London: Odhams Press, 1953); R. A. Wilford, 'The Federation of Progressive Societies and Individuals', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 11/1 (1976), 49–82.
73 *Action*, 24 December 1931, p. 12. The quote comes from Nicolson's review of Wells' *What Are We To Do With Our Lives* (London: Heinemann, 1931). Mosley's own relationship with Wells may have been hindered by an altercation that supposedly took place on the Riviera. According to Catlin, in *For God's Sake Go*, p. 85, Wells felt 'personally insulted' by the Mosleys.
74 Wells, *The Way the World is Going*, pp. 35–50; G. B. Shaw, *Man and Superman* (London: Penguin 1994 edition; written in 1903); *idem*, *The Apple Cart: A Political Extravaganza* (London: Penguin, 1975; originally published 1930). See also Shaw's 1932 lecture 'In Praise of Guy Fawkes', in D. H. Laurence (ed.),

Platform and Pulpit (New York: Hill & Wang, 1961); Holroyd, *Bernard Shaw*, pp. 110–14.

75 M. W. Messmer, 'Prince of Popularizers: The Life and Thought of C. E. M. Joad, 1891–1953 (Yale University, PhD thesis, 1977); Joad, 'Shaw the Philosopher', in *Shaw and Society*, pp. 233–49; R. Thurlow, 'The Developing British Fascist Interpretation of Race, Culture and Evolution', in J. Gottlieb and T. Linehan (eds), *The Culture of Fascism: Visions of the Far Right in Britain* (London: I.B. Tauris, 2004), p. 76. Thurlow specifies Shaw's *Back to Methuselah* (1922) as being especially influential on Mosley.

76 H. G. Wells, *The Open Conspiracy* (London: Gollancz, 1928). See also J. Partington, *Building Cosmopolis: The Political Thought of H. G. Wells* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2003).

77 P. Coupland, 'H. G. Wells's "Liberal Fascism"', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 35/4 (2000), 555.

78 Strachey, *The Coming Struggle for Power*, pp. 188–230.

79 Wells, *The Way the World is Going*, p. 50.

80 OMN/B/4/8, O. Mosley, 'The Philosophy of Fascism', lecture delivered to the English Speaking Union, 22 March 1933 (Mosley Papers); Drennan, *BUF*, chapters seven and eight.

81 Mosley, *My Life*, p. 172.

82 See Elliot's review of Ramsay Muir's *How Britain is Governed*, in *Political Quarterly*, 1, 3 (1930).

83 J. Stevenson and C. Cook, *The Slump: Society and Politics During the Depression* (London: Jonathan Cape, 1978).

84 J. M. Keynes, *The Economic Consequences of the Peace* (London: Macmillan, 1922).

85 Letter from Strachey to Andrew Rothstein, 10 October 1931; Letter from Strachey to Rajani Palme Dutt, 24 December 1931 (both in the Strachey Papers).

86 Letter from Strachey to Bevan, 17 October 1930 (Strachey Papers); Newman, *Strachey*, p. 21.

87 Mosley, 'From Tory to Labour', p. 8; Mosley, 'Statement', pp. 1–3.

88 Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, pp. 147–50.

89 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.

90 H. Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You – But Keep Your Eye on 1933', *Action*, 8 October 1931, pp. 10–11; C. F. Melville, 'A Balkan Monarch Takes A Chance', *Action*, 12 November 1931, p. 11. Interestingly, Mosley also discussed his ideas on a new movement with William Bullitt, an American diplomat and advisor to Franklin D. Roosevelt. Bullitt even raised the possibility of forming an American youth movement aligned to the New Party. In 1932, Bullitt further sought to establish links between Mosley and the former Hungarian premier Count Paul Teleki. See OMN/A/2/15 and 22, Letters from Bullitt to Cynthia Mosley, undated [1931 and 1932 respectively in the Mosley Papers].

91 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.

92 *The Times*, 15 November 1931. Addressing the Incorporated Society of British Advertisers, Mosley spoke of 'Continental' movements, but said '[they] would never see in England people walking about in black or red shirts or with feathers in their hats; but they would see a determined people coming forward

with realistic policies and putting them before the public in plain and explicit language'.

93 D. S. White, *Lost Comrades: Socialists of the Front Generation, 1918–45* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992). White looks at Mosley alongside Marcel Déat and Henri de Man, both of whom followed comparable political trajectories.

94 P. G. Edwards, 'The Foreign Office and Fascism, 1924–29', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 5/2 (1970), 153–61; R. J. B. Bosworth, 'The British Press, the Conservatives, and Mussolini, 1920–34', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 5/2 (1970), 163–82; C. Keserich, 'The British Labour Press and Italian Fascism, 1922–25', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 10/4 (1975), 579–90; B. Granzow, *A Mirror of Nazism: British Opinion and the Emergence of Hitler, 1929–33* (London: Gollancz, 1964).

95 Holroyd, *Bernard Shaw*, pp. 143–5; A. W. Wright, *G. D. H. Cole and Socialist Democracy* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1979), p. 109; MS 238, J. Beckett, 'After My Fashion' (unpublished manuscript, Beckett Collection), p. 281.

96 For a typical early account of Nazism, see 'The Rise of the Nazis', *The Times*, 18 September 1930.

97 T. Linehan, *British Fascism, 1918–39: Parties, Ideology and Culture* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2000), pp. 61–83; R. Thurlow, *Fascism in Britain: From Oswald Mosley's Blackshirts to the National Front* (London: I. B. Tauris, 1998), pp. 30–60. See also, D. Baker, 'The Extreme Right in the 1920s: Fascism in a Cold Climate, or "Conservatism with Knobs on"?', in M. Cronin (ed.), *The Failure of British Fascism: The Far Right and the Fight for Political Recognition* (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1996), pp. 12–28.

98 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.

Chapter 2

1 Mosley, *My Life*, pp. 90–1; Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, pp. 72–3. Mosley's 1918 election address called for high wages, a minimum wage, state control of transport and electrical resources, state direction of slum clearance and house building, imperial preference and 'complete unity' across the empire.

2 PRO 30/69/445, Letter from Sir Oswald Mosley to the Prime Minister [containing the memorandum], 23 January 1931 (MacDonald Papers).

3 Keynes and Hubert Henderson were shown copies of the memorandum prior to its being handed to the prime minister. However, there is no evidence to suggest that either economist contributed anything new to Mosley's final version.

4 'Report of the Unemployment Policy (1930) Committee'.

5 Strachey, *The Coming Struggle for Power*, pp. 155–7.

6 O. Mosley, 'Empire Unity – But No Food Taxes', *Daily Herald*, 7 July 1930; HC Debates, vol. 241, cols. 1347–50 (16 July 1930) .

7 Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 227; *Manchester Guardian*, 21 July 1930.

8 BBK/C/254, Letter from Lord Beaverbrook to Mosley, 17 July 1930 (Beaverbrook Papers); M. Adeney, *Nuffield: A Biography* (London: Robert Hale, 1993), pp. 122–30.

9 This was expressed via complementary speeches to parliament. See, for example, HC Debates, vol. 244, cols. 67–761 (29 October 1930).

10 Quoted in Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 228.
11 *The Observer*, 7 December 1930; *The Times*, 8 December 1930.
12 Allen, *The New Party and the Old Toryism*, p. 2. Such a formula was later developed by Mosley to explain the BUF. Thus, in a lecture to the English Speaking Union, Mosley described fascism as a synthesis of left and right adapted to the conditions of the modern age.
13 Barry/1, Gerald Barry Journal, 2 February 1931 (Gerald Barry Collection). Catlin, *For God's Sake Go*, pp. 71–7. Catlin, of course, was the father of Shirley Williams, later a Labour MP and co-founder of the Social Democratic Party.
14 S. Ball (ed.), *Parliament and Politics in the Age of Baldwin and MacDonald: The Headlam Diaries, 1923–35* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992), 25–28 September and 15 December 1930.
15 BBK/C/254, Letter to Lord Beaverbrook, 19 November 1930 (Beaverbrook Papers); Gerald Barry Journal;, 2 February 1931.
16 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, p. 5.
17 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, pp. 19–32.
18 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
19 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
20 The terms were often used interchangeably, but compare *A National Policy* (pp. 24–9) with *Action* ('Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2) and then *The Greater Britain* (pp. 133–9).
21 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 6 and 30 November 1930. See also Pimlott (ed.), *The Political Diary of Hugh Dalton*, 24 October 1930, for reference to Bevan informing Dalton that he had just talked Mosley out of forming a new National Party comprised of MPs from all sides, two national newspapers, and a fund of £25,000. Dalton's comment was telling: 'Lord Oswald has never understood *modern* political mechanics'.
22 Letter from Strachey to Bevan, 17 October 1930.
23 Williamson, *National Crisis*, pp. 521–2; 'Letter from Nicolson to Robert Forgan', in Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 15 April 1932. Partly for this reason, perhaps, some Labour members saw the seeds of a fascist economy in Walter Elliot's language of capitalist planning. See Wilkinson and Conze, *Why Fascism?*, pp. 69–70.
24 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum; Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2. In *The Greater Britain*, p. 98, Mosley suggested that each of the commodity boards would be represented on the NPC.
25 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, pp. 32–44 and pp. 62–3.
26 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*,, pp. 32–44 and pp. 62–3.
27 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, pp. 19–32. By the time of Mosley's article in October 1931, 'Have We A Policy?', the message was clear. The banking system would continue to exist, but would be 'subordinate to the over-riding purposes of the corporate state'.
28 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, pp. 19–32.
29 C. F. Melville, 'Political Upheaval: Sir Oswald Mosley', *Fortnightly Review*, May 1931, p. 663; MacDougall, *Disillusionment*, p. 5; 'A Mosley Manifesto', *Action*, 15 October 1931.
30 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, pp. 19–24. This, of course, anticipated the interests represented in the BUF model for a corporate state.
31 Ritschel, *The Politics of Planning*, p. 70.

32 See Letter from Keynes to Strachey, 5 January 1926 (Strachey Papers); 'The National Need', written by Sir Robert Horne, John Buchan, Elliot and Stanley, in *The Times*, 17 December 1930; Buchan in *The Times*, 9 January 1931; *Week-End Review*, 14 February 1931; Ritschel, *The Politics of Planning*, pp. 73–80 and pp. 146–57.
33 See, for example, *New Leader*, 27 February 1931.
34 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, pp. 24–9.
35 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, pp. 50–60.
36 R. Trouton, 'New Economic Policy No. 3', *Action*, 19 November 1931, p. 4. See also R. Trouton, *Unemployment: Its Causes and Their Remedies* (London: Hogarth Press, 1931).
37 See J. Campbell, 'The Renewal of Liberalism: Liberalism Without Liberals', in G. Peele and C. Cook (eds), *The Politics of Reappraisal, 1918–39* (London: Macmillan, 1975), pp. 88–110.
38 Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2; Nicholson, 'A National Plan'; D. Ritschel, 'A Corporatist Economy in Britain? Capitalist Planning for Industrial Self-Government in the 1930s', *The English Historical Review*, 106/418 (1991), 41–65; L. P. Carpenter, 'Corporatism in Britain, 1930–45', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 11/1 (1976), pp. 2–25.
39 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
40 *The Observer*, 7 December 1930; *The Times*, 8 December 1930.
41 *The Times*, 21 June 1930.
42 Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, pp. 45–8.
43 See, for example, *Daily Telegraph*, 8 December 1930.
44 *New Statesman*, 13 December 1930.
45 *The Economist*, 28 February 1931; Ritschel, *The Politics of Planning*, pp. 76–7.
46 Nicholson, 'A National Plan'.
47 *Punch*, 17 December 1930.
48 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum; Young *et al.*, *A National Policy*, pp. 45–8.
49 Strachey and Joad, 'Parliamentary Reform', 319–36.
50 Nicolson later suggested the formation of a National Council of Experts to guide the government. However, such a plan was overtaken by the party's adherence to the corporate state. See H. Nicolson, 'Can the New Party Survive?', *Saturday Review*, 9 January 1932, p. 35.
51 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
52 Mosley, 'Ancient Gentlemen at War', *Action*, 15 October 1931.
53 Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You', pp. 10–11.
54 Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2.
55 R. Trouton, 'New Economic Policy No. 1', *Action*, 5 November 1931; O. Mosley, 'Class Struggle Must End', *Action*, 26 November 1931, p. 1.
56 Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You', pp. 10–11; Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2.
57 For Italy, see P. Morgan, *Italian Fascism, 1915–45* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2003).
58 Strachey, *The Menace of Fascism*, p. 84.
59 J. Strachey Barnes, *The Universal Aspects of Fascism* (London: Williams & Norgate, 1928); *idem*, *Fascism* (London: T. Butterworth, 1931); H. E. Goad, *What is Fascism? An Explanation of its Essential Principles* (Florence: Italian Mail & Tribune, 1929); *idem*, *The Making of the Corporate State: A Study of*

Fascist Development (London: Christophers, 1932); H. E. Goad and M. Currey, *The Working of a Corporate State: A Study of National Co-operation* (London: Nicolson & Watson, 1933). Goad was the Italophile director of the British Institute of Florence from 1923 to 1938. In addition, articles by Mussolini were published in the *Saturday Review* throughout June and July 1931, and see also L. Villari, *The Fascist Experiment* (London: Faber & Gwyer, 1926); *idem*, *Italy* (London: Ernest Benn, 1929); C. Gini, 'The Scientific Basis of Fascism', *Political Science Quarterly*, 42/1 (1927), 99–115; G. S. Counts, L. Villari, M. C. Rorty and N. D. Baker (eds), *Bolshevism, Fascism and Capitalism* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1932). Sillani's book – T. Sillani (ed), *What is Fascism and Why?* (London: Ernest Benn, 1931) – was first published in Italy in 1930, and included a chapter on 'the corporative state'. Finally, see R. Griffiths, *Fellow Travellers of the Right: British Enthusiasts for Nazi Germany, 1933–39* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1983), pp. 13–15.

60 J. Jones, *Unfinished Journey* (London: Readers' Union, 1938), p. 264; *Manchester Guardian*, 9 June 1931; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 5–7 June 1931.

61 Trouton, 'New Economic Policy No. 3', p. 4.

62 Mosley, 'Class Struggle Must End', p. 1.

63 Mosley, 'Class Struggle Must End', p. 1.

64 Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2.

65 Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You', pp. 10–11.

66 Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2; O. Mosley, 'What Is Personal Liberty?', *Action*, 9 December 1931, p. 1. According to Marcus Collins, the New Party published a pamphlet entitled *The New Movement Fights for a Corporate State*. Unfortunately, I have been unable to locate this document. M. Collins, 'The New Party, 1931–32' (Emmanuel College, Cambridge, MA dissertation 1992).

67 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, pp. 147–58.

Chapter 3

1 Mosley 'Statement', pp. 2–3.

2 J. Strachey, 'The Progress of the New Party', *Week-End Review*, 20 June 1931.

3 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, p. 16.

4 Joad, 'Prolegomena to Fascism', 82–99.

5 Melville, 'Political Upheaval', 658–67.

6 Strachey, 'Letter from John Strachey MP', p. 5.

7 Strachey himself received rough passage when he spoke in Aston Park in early May 1931. Having fielded a series of hostile questions, Strachey left by car to shouts of 'traitor' and 'resign'. See *Birmingham Town Crier*, 15 May 1931. Such reception, along with a similar set-to in Hulme in June, no doubt did much to prompt his reappraising his political options. See *Manchester Guardian*, 11 June 1931.

8 Strachey, *The Coming Struggle for Power*, p. 338 and p. 383.

9 Strachey, 'The Progress of the New Party', pp. 909–10. Speaking at the Hulme Town Hall in June, Strachey responded to allegations that the New Party was a 'Hitler party' by stating that he would 'never belong to a party capable of using such a weapon against the workers'. See *Manchester Guardian*, 11 June 1931.

10 J. Strachey, 'The New Party and Russia', in Nicolson, 'Diary', 20 July 1931.
11 Letter from Rothstein to Strachey, 5 October 1931; Letter from Strachey to Rothstein, 10 October 1931; Letter from Strachey to Dutt, 24 December 1931 (all Strachey Papers). See also Strachey's KV 2/786 file in the National Archive.
12 *The Times*, 24 July 1931.
13 Strachey, *The Coming Struggle*, p. 163.
14 *The Times* 24 July 1931. This may well have been the unpublished memorandum drafted by Mosley in November 1930.
15 *The Times* 27 July 1931.
16 *The Times*, 24 July 1931.
17 C. F. Melville, *The Truth About the New Party: And Much Else Besides Concerning Sir Oswald Mosley's Political Aims, the 'Nazi' Movement of Herr Adolph Hitler and the Adventure in Political Philosophy of Mr. Wyndham Lewis* (London: Wishart, 1931), p. 31.
18 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum; Melville, 'Political Upheaval', 663–7; Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 45. Thus, Fascism, Bolshevism, Hitlerism and Mosleyism were all seen to be different facets of the same thing – political modernism.
19 See also *The Times*' reference to the New Party's formation on 2 March 1931. 'Sir Oswald Mosley announces that he is making a wider appeal on a new policy which has in it some scraps for everyone. He has, it is understood, collected a considerable fund – not, of course, from Socialists. He and a handful of followers have resigned from the Socialist Party. He may, therefore, run a few candidates in Socialist seats at the next election on a National-Socialist programme and so contribute indirectly to the return of a strong government of the Right.' Nicolson, meanwhile, who had been in Berlin in the late 1920s, initially understood Nazis to be 'red fascists' and 'left-wing jingos'. See Rose, *Harold Nicolson*, p. 156.
20 Nicolson, 'Diary', 12 September 1931.
21 Unless stated, the quotes in this section are drawn from: Nicolson, 'Diary', 5–7 June 1931; Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, pp. 263–4; H. Hodge, *It's Drafty in Front: The Autobiography of a London Taxidriver* (London: Michael Joseph, 1938), pp. 225–6; *Daily Herald*, 8 June 1931; *Manchester Guardian*, 9 June 1931. The *Manchester Guardian* reported that 'about seventy' people attended.
22 *Daily Herald*, 6 and 8 June 1931.
23 Drennan, *The BUF*, pp. 157–8.
24 *Daily Herald*, 8 June 1931; Nicolson, 'Diary', 5–7 June 1931.
25 Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, pp. 263–4.
26 Nicolson, 'Diary', 10 June 1931.
27 Mosley, 'Old Parties or New?', 27–32.
28 Mosley, 'A New National Policy', pp. 103–4.
29 See Young's letter to the *Week-End Review*, 4 April 1931.
30 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 4 September 1931. On discussing the youth movement, Mosley expressed his relief that since Strachey (the 'pathological element') had left it was possible to 'settle the question by enquiring not whether Germans, Italians or Russians have done the thing before, but whether the said thing is likely to attract the average Englishman or make him laugh at us'.
31 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 16 June 1931.

32 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 23 July and 12 September 1931.
33 *Action*, 15 October and 3 December 1931.
34 *Action*, 5 November 1931.
35 *Action*, 5, 12 and 19 November 1931.
36 Nicolson, 'Notes on the Future of the New Party', in Nicolson, 'Diary', 25 September 1931.
37 Nicolson discussed his ideas with Joad, who appeared to agree with their general thrust. 'Obviously,' Nicolson remarked to Joad, 'there is a centrifugal tendency developing a rapid flight to the extremes. Neither the Tories nor the Liberals nor official Labour fit into this scheme of opposites.' See Nicolson, 'Diary', 12 September 1931.
38 Nicolson would develop his thesis for an article published in the *Saturday Review* on 9 January 1932. This ruminated on the conservative nature of the British psyche, with its penchant for tidy pigeon holes and resistance to all things new, before endeavouring to present a definite ideology particular to the New Party. Thus, the New Party state would embody a new patriotism based on self-sacrifice rather than nationalism, duties rather than rights, and a corporate sense of identity rather than class consciousness.
39 Letter from Nicolson to Vita Sackville-West, 28 September 1931, in N. Nicolson (ed.), *Vita and Harold: The Letters of Vita Sackville-West and Harold Nicolson* (London: Phoenix, 1992), p. 229; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 22 September 1931.
40 Mosley, 'Old Parties or New?', pp. 27–32.
41 Mosley, 'Class Struggle Must End', p. 1.
42 M. Diston and R. Forgan, *The New Party and the ILP* (London: New Party, 1931), pp. 7–8.
43 Nicolson (ed.), 'Diary', 15 June 1931.
44 Joad, *The Case for the New Party*, pp. 7–8.
45 'Is Parliament Worth It?', *Action*, 22 October 1931, p. 3; Nicolson, 'Can the New Party Survive', p. 35; R. Trouton, 'New Economic Policy No. 1', *Action*, 5 November 1931, p. 4.
46 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
47 *Ibid*; OMN/B/48, Mosley, 'The Philosophy of Fascism', lecture delivered to the English Speaking Union, 22 March 1933 (Mosley Papers).
48 Mosley, 'What is Personal Liberty?', p. 1.
49 'Our Shabby Grandfathers', *Action*, 15 October 1931, p. 3. The author of the article is not given, but is presumably Nicolson.
50 Nicolson, 'Diary', 29 June 1931 and 'The Future of the New Party', 25 September 1931.
51 *Action*, 8 October 1931, p. 3; S. Davies, *Why I Joined the New Party* (London: New Party, 1931), pp. 5–6.
52 Mosley, 'Class Struggle Must End', p. 1.
53 Mosley, 'Class Struggle Must End', p. 1; Mosley, Untitled Memorandum; Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, p. 25.
54 J. Savage, *Teenage: The Creation of Youth, 1875–1945* (London: Pimlico, 2008), pp. 18–19.
55 Nicolson, 'Diary', 2 November 1931; *Action*, 26 November and 3, 10, 17 December 1931.
56 Drennan, *The BUF*, p. 43; Mosley, *My Life*, pp. 10–11.

57 Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 45. Melville is explicit in stating that the New Party was an expression of 'political modernism'.

Chapter 4

1 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum; Mosley, 'Statement', pp. 2–4.
2 Nicolson, 'Diary', 22 July 1931.
3 The exact reason for the party's adoption of the marigold is unclear. Among its many supposed meanings, the marigold – *Calendula Officinalis* – was said to represent prophecy and the future. It was often seen among the symbols of the arts and crafts movement, and was quite probably chosen by Nicolson following discussions with Vita Sackville-West, who was a keen gardener. See K. Greenaway, *The Language of Flowers* (London: Routledge, 1884). My thanks to Lavinia Hamer for both the reference and the information.
4 Nicolson, 'Diary', 25 June 1931.
5 *Daily Herald*, 20 August 1932.
6 Nicolson, 'Diary', 25 June 1931.
7 Nicolson, 'Diary', 29 July, 1 September and 6 November 1931.
8 We should note that party memorandums still referred to the National Council in the summer of 1932. See, for example, NRO/2003–36, O. Mosley, 'Future Organisation', 1 June 1932 (Musgrave Papers). My thanks to Philip Coupland for alerting me to the Musgrave papers.
9 Nicolson, 'Diary', 22 July 1931.
10 The quote is from Cuming. See *Daily Herald*, 20 August 1932.
11 S274/10/1, Minutes of the First Meeting of the Publicity Committee, 1 Great George Street on Tuesday 10 February 1931 (Eckersley Political Correspondence); Gerald Barry Journal, 17 February 1931; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 15 February 1931. Barry left almost as soon as the New Party formed. Brown, too, resigned from the committee following his decision not to join the New Party.
12 KV2/879, Letter from Scotland Yard to MI5 (National Archive). Although Catlin never formally joined the New Party, he 'supported the party line'. By October 1931, however, he was sufficiently removed from Mosley to stand as the Labour candidate in Brentford and Chiswick. As an internationalist, Catlin was put off by Mosley's 'incipient chauvinism'. See, Catlin, *For God's Sake Go*, pp. 85–6.
13 New Party Information Service, *The Crisis: Trade, Commerce, Industry, Current Politics and Conditions* (London: New Party, 1931).
14 Mandle, 'The New Party', 347. A financial statement, dated 15 July 1931, is contained in the Mosley papers (OMN/B/6/1). See also Nicolson, 'Diary', 13 November 1931.
15 Adeney, *Nuffield*, pp. 122–30; Nicolson, 'Diary', 19 August and 6 November 1931.
16 *Daily Dispatch*, 17 December 1930.
17 Mosley, *My Life*, p. 344.
18 Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 31; *Daily Herald*, 8 June 1931.
19 The description comes from Nicolson's 'London Diary' in *Evening Standard*, 22 April 1931.

20 Nicolson, 'Diary', 16 June, 12 August, 30 October, 24 and 25 November 1931 and 15 January 1932.
21 Nicolson, 'Diary', 5 and 6 November 1931.
22 Mosley, 'Old Parties or New?', pp. 27–32.
23 Nicolson, 'Diary', 29 July and 1 September 1931.
24 S. Ball, A. Thorpe, M. Worley, 'Elections, Leaflets and Whist Drives: Constituency Party Members in Britain Between the Wars', in M. Worley (ed.), *Labour's Grass Roots: Essays on the Activities of Local Labour Parties and Members, 1918–45* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2005), pp. 7–32.
25 Mosley, 'Statement', p. 2.
26 Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 40.
27 Strachey, 'The Progress of the New Party', 909–10. As should be obvious, Strachey was here overstating the party's progress.
28 S274/10/1, Members of London Committee (Eckersley Political Correspondence). The London regional party officers were: north east, Mr Brown (chair) and Mr Kendrick (secretary); north west, Mr Crosby Thompson and Mr Coxon; south west, Mr Phelps Hodges and Mr Agor; south east, Mr Kettle and Mr Hart.
29 Nicolson, 'Diary', 12 June, 14 July and 11 September 1931.
30 *Daily Herald*, 6 June 1931.
31 PRO 30/69/381, 'The Mosley Secessions' and 'Separate Constituency Information' (MacDonald Papers).
32 *Evening Sentinel*, 7 March 1931; C. Morgan, 'The British Union of Fascists in the Midlands, 1932–40' (University of Wolverhampton, PhD Thesis, 2008), p. 123. Among Mosley's core supporters was S. T. Dunn, later to become the foremost fascist leader in the city.
33 J. Lees-Milne, *Another Self* (London: Faber & Faber, 1984 edition); *Evening Sentinel*, 15 October 1931.
34 'The Mosley Secessions'.
35 Johnson, 'Birmingham Labour', pp. 534–6.
36 Wolverhampton Borough Labour Party, *Minutes, 1907–51* (Wakefield: Microform Academic Publishers, 1986), 'Introduction'.
37 J. Brewer, *Mosley's Men: The British Union of Fascists in the West Midlands* (Aldershot: Gower, 1984), pp. 61–4; Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, p. 263; 'Nupa News and Notes', *Action*, 26 November 1931, p. 21; Mosley, *Rules of the Game*, p. 210.
38 Morgan, 'The British Union of Fascists in the Midlands', p. 31.
39 Jack Jones spells Steel as Steele; newspaper reports of the New Party spell it Steel. Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, p. 255; *Airdrie and Coatbridge Advertiser*, 10 October 1931; *Coatbridge Express*, 14 October 1931.
40 These included the chairman, secretary and treasurer. See *The Scotsman*, 23 March 1931; ILP, *The Report of the Annual Conference, Held in Scarborough April 1931* (London: ILP, 1931), p. 122; 'The Mosley Secessions'.
41 *Coatbridge Express*, 14 October 1931.
42 *The Times*, 26 October 1931; Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, p. 267.
43 Nicolson, 'Diary', 7 November 1931.
44 Nicolson, 'Diary', 11 June 1931.
45 Transcript of Interview with Arthur Fawcett (Rawnsley Collection).
46 *Liverpool Post and Mercury*, 13 March 1931.

47 Nicolson, 'Diary', 22 July 1931; M. Worley, 'Who Makes the Nazis? North West Experiences of the New Party, 1931–32', *North West Labour History Journal*, 32 (2007), 7–16; M. McCarthy, *Generation in Revolt* (London: Heinemann, 1953), p. 156. McCarthy suggests that the Accrington branch comprised disgruntled members of the CPGB and Young Communist League, while the *Manchester Guardian* (29 July 1931) later reported the formation of a Withington New Party branch.
48 NRO/2003–36, Letter from Davies to Musgrave, 25 June 1931; Letter from Box to Musgrave, 7 July 1931; Letter from Box to Musgrave, 15 September 1931; 'Britain's Foreign Policy', unpublished manuscript, 10 August 1931 (Musgrave Papers).
49 *Northampton Chronicle and Echo*, 11 April 1931; NRO/2003–36, Letter from Davies to Musgrave, 21 August 1931; Membership list, application forms and membership cards (Musgrave Papers).
50 Nicolson, 'Diary', 16 June 1931.
51 *Yorkshire Post*, 23 April 1931; Trevelyan Scholarship Project, 'The British Union of Fascists in Yorkshire, 1934–40' (unpublished manuscript, 1960).
52 *Evening Chronicle*, 10 October 1931.
53 *Telegraph and Argus*, 23 April 1931; B. Barker, *Free But Not Easy* (Matlock: Derbyshire County Council, 1989), p. 37; D. Turner, *Fascism and Anti-Fascism in the Medway Towns, 1927–40* (Rochester: Kent Anti-Fascist Action Committee, 1993).
54 *Reading Mercury*, 10 and 24 October 1931.
55 Nicolson, 'Diary', 5–7 June 1931.
56 Turner, *Fascism*, p. 16; *The Times*, 23 June 1934.
57 Hodge, *Its Drafty*, p. 234.
58 NRO/2003–36, Letter from Box to Musgrave, 21 January 1932 (Musgrave Papers).
59 NRO/2003–36, Mosley, 'Future Organisation'.
60 NRO/2003–36, 'Organisation of the New Movement', undated (Musgrave Papers).
61 *Manchester Guardian*, 26 August 1932.
62 MSS/127/NU/GS/3/5A-5E, 'Extract from Notes Written by Mr Michael Jordan' (Modern Records Centre); J. Hope, 'Blackshirts, Knuckle-Dusters and Lawyers: Documentary Essays on the Mosley versus Marchbanks Papers', *Labour History Review*, 65/1 (2000), 46.
63 NRO/2003–36, Letter from Box to Musgrave, 21 January 1932; Letter from Forgan to Musgrave, 30 August 1932 (Musgrave Papers).
64 Typescript of Interview with Arthur Fawcett.
65 *Evening Chronicle*, 3 and 10 October 1931.
66 *Manchester Guardian*, 23 April 1931.
67 J. Lawrence, 'The Transformation of British Public Politics after the First World War', *Past and Present*, 190/1 (2006), 185–6.
68 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 22 September 1931.
69 Mosley, 'Crisis', p. 1.
70 P. Cheyney, 'Cutting Out the Bunk in Great Britain', *Action*, 12 November 1931, p. 5; *idem*, 'These are the Days of Political Surprises', *Action*, 26 November 1931, p. 5; P. Harrison, *Peter Cheyney: Prince of Hokum* (London: Spearman, 1954), pp. 209–35.

71 Strachey, 'The Progress of the New Party', 110.
72 *Manchester Guardian*, 16 May 1931; *Daily Worker*, 28 May 1931.
73 *Daily Worker*, 28 May and 31 August 1931.
74 Hodge, *It's Drafty*, pp. 234–5; *Daily Worker*, 24 March 1931. Rajani Palme Dutt later quoted a *Daily Express* article (18 May 1931), in which a Major Baker talked of young Oxford students and graduates gathering around the New Party equipped with motor cars and ready to 'form themselves into flying squads to descend suddenly on a place'. See R. P. Dutt, *Fascism and Social Revolution* (London: Martin Lawrence, 1934), pp. 266–7.
75 M. Lewis, *Ted 'Kid' Lewis: His Life and Times* (London: Robson Books, 1990), pp. 224–6.
76 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 11 July 1931.
77 *Manchester Guardian*, 9 June 1931. Joad feared that the party would attract members 'with the heads of athletes on the bodies of thinkers', rather than vice versa, as Winkworth envisaged.
78 Nicolson, 'Diary', 6 June 1931.
79 *Daily Herald*, 6 June and 3 July 1931; Nicolson, 'Diary', 17 July 1931.
80 Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 44; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 10 June 1931; *Daily Herald*, 3 July 1931.
81 Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 35.
82 Nicolson, 'Diary', 17 July 1931.
83 Nicolson, 'Diary', Letter from Mosley to Nicolson, 4 September 1931.
84 Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 35.
85 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 4 September 1931.
86 Wolrige Gordon, *Peter Howard*, p. 57.
87 Nicolson, 'Diary', 2 September 1931; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 22 September 1931; *Action*, 8 and 15 October 1931, p. 29.
88 Cheyney, 'Cutting Out the Bunk in Great Britain', p. 5.
89 Thus, the local New Party would consist of a party branch, a Nupa group, and a youth club.
90 P. Cheyney, 'Clubs to Toughen You in Body and Mind', *Action*, 19 November 1931, p. 5; Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 41.
91 P. Cheyney, 'These are the Days of Political Surprise', *Action*, 26 November 1931, p. 5.
92 'New Party Notes and News', *Action*, 8 October 1931, p. 29.
93 Cheyney, 'These are the Days', p. 5; 'Nupa News and Notes', *Action*, 26 November 1931, p. 21.
94 *Daily Herald*, 20 August 1932; *The New Times*, July 1932, p. 2.
95 *Action*, 24 December 1931, p. 17.
96 Nicolson, 'Diary', 17 November 1931.
97 Nicolson, 'Diary', 23 February 1932.

Chapter 5

1 Mikardo, *Backbencher*, pp. 45–9.
2 See Mikardo's letter in *Action*, 5 November 1931, p. 16.
3 A. V. Williams, 'Election Leaflet', undated [October 1931]. The election leaflets for all New Party candidates are housed in the Conservative Party Archive at the Bodleian Library, Oxford.

4 Barker, *Free But Not Easy*, p. 37.
5 *Reading Standard*, 31 October 1931.
6 WO 339/11646, '[Troward] Application for Registration in the Officers' Emergency Reserve' (National Archive).
7 Harrison, *Peter Cheyney*, p. 213; Dorril, *Blackshirt*, p. 184.
8 *The New Times*, June 1932, p. 6 and August–September 1932, p. 6.
9 The quote is from Mikardo, *Backbencher*, p. 49. The same may also be said for Jewish members, such as 'Kid' Lewis. See Lewis, *Ted 'Kid' Lewis*, pp. 221–4.
10 Drennan, *BUF*, pp. 142–61.
11 S. Ball, *The Guardsmen: Harold Macmillan, Three Friends, and the World That They Made* (London: Harper Collins, 2005), pp. 118–19.
12 Wright, *G. D. H. Cole*, p. 190; Ritschel, *The Politics of Planning*, p. 53; J. Scanlon, *The Decline and Fall of the Labour Party* (London: Peter Davies, 1932). Scanlon suggests that some intellectuals saw the Mosley group as their equivalent of the PLP's trade union group or ILP group (p. 215).
13 Simmons, *Soap-Box Evangelist*, pp. 78–92.
14 *New Leader*, 20 February 1931.
15 Brockway, *Towards Tomorrow*, p. 84. For McGovern, who noticeably fails to mention his brief dalliance with Mosley, see J. McGovern, *Neither Fear Nor Favour* (London: Blandford, 1960).
16 J. Campbell, *Nye Bevan: A Biography* (London: Metro, 1997), pp. 38–43. See also M. Foot, *Aneurin Bevan: Volume One, 1897–1945* (London: MacGibbon & Kee, 1962).
17 Riddell, *Labour in Crisis*, pp. 150–7; M. Worley, *Class Against Class: The Communist Party in Britain Between the* Wars (London: I.B. Tauris, 2002), pp. 127–8. On the eve of the New Party's launch, Cook was listed as one of the influential persons to whom a copy *A National Policy* was to be sent. See Minutes of the First Meeting of the Publicity Committee.
18 P. Davies, *A. J. Cook* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1987), pp. 174–6.
19 Batey, like Bevan, was sponsored by the miners' union.
20 Quoted by D. Howell, '"The Sheik … A Valentino in Real Life": Sir Oswald Mosley and the Labour Party, 1924–31', *Contemporary British History*, 23/4 (2009), 425–44, cited from MacDonald's diary, 7 December 1930. We should note that the 'Mosley manifesto' also bore the signatures of 66-year-old Henry Muggeridge and MacDonald's future National Labour allies Sydney Markham and James Lovat Fraser.
21 Letter from Boothby to Mosley, as reproduced in Mosley, *Rules of the Game*, pp. 151–3.
22 Ball, 'Mosley and the Tories', 445–60; Ball, *The Guardsmen*, pp. 107–25; L. Olsen, *Troublesome Young Men: The Rebels Who Brought Churchill to Power in 1940 and Helped to Save Britain* (London: Bloomsbury, 2007).
23 Elliot, fresh from writing on the importance of Tory unity, attended some early New Party meetings. See W. Elliot, 'In Unity Strength', *Week-End Review*, 11 April 1931; Nicolson, 'Diary', 16 June 1931.
24 Ball, *The Guardsmen*, p. 121; R. R. James, *Bob Boothby: A Portrait* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1991), p. 102; A. Horne, *Macmillan: The Making of a Prime Minister, 1894–1956* (London: Macmillan, 1988). Stanley's father was Edward Stanley, the seventeenth Earl of Derbyshire and a former Secretary of State for War.

25 Quoted in James, *Bob Boothby*, p. 102. See also, R. Boothby, *I Fight to Live* (London: Gollancz, 1947); *idem*, *Recollections of a Rebel* (London: Hutchinson, 1978).
26 Simmons, *Soap-Box Evangelist*, p. 87; Ball, *The Guardsmen*, p. 121.
27 Nicolson, 'Diary', 22 June 1931; Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 255; W. Rust, 'The Mosley Manifesto', *Labour Monthly*, January 1931, pp. 35–40; N. Fishman, 'Horner and Hornerism', in J. McIlroy, K. Morgan and A. Campbell (eds), *Party People, Communist Lives: Explorations in Biography* (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 2001), pp. 122–41; A. Horner, *Incorrigible Rebel* (London: MacGibbon & Kee, 1960), p. 107. Arthur Horner, a friend of Cook and a communist leader then under fire from his party, was also rumoured to have toyed with joining the New Party. 'I had no use for Mosley', Horner later insisted.
28 James, *Bob Boothby*, p. 102; J. Lee, *This Great Journey* (London: MacGibbon & Kee, 1963), p. 116.
29 Quoted in James, *Bob Boothby*, p. 102.
30 See Simmons, *Soap-Box Evangelist*, p. 68, for a description of Mosley's arrival in Smethwick armed with a van load of filing cabinets and press cuttings. Also Catlin, *For God's Sake Go*, pp. 72–8.
31 Hodge, *It's Drafty*, pp. 221–37; *The City and East London Observer*, 10 and 17 October 1931.
32 Hodge, *It's Drafty*, pp. 221–37.
33 For Joad, see Messmer, 'Prince of Popularizers'; C. E. D. Joad, *The Book of Joad: A Belligerent Biography* (London: Faber & Faber, 1939 edition).
34 Joad, *The Book of Joad*, p. 22.
35 Geoffrey Thomas suggests that Mosley 'stamped' on Joad's ambitions to shape New Party policy. See G. Thomas, *Cyril Joad* (London: Birkbeck College, 1992), pp. 92–3. My thanks to Philip Coupland for sharing this reference with me.
36 Joad, 'Prolegomena to Fascism', pp. 82–99.
37 Joad, *The Book of Joad*, pp. 96–7.
38 Lees-Milne, *Another Self* , p. 95.
39 Lees-Milne, *Another Self*, pp. 95–6.
40 Lees-Milne, *Another Self*, p. 97.
41 M. Bloch, *James Lees-Milne: The Life* (London: John Murray, 2009).
42 Hodge later recalled that the only time he saw Mosley 'humanly happy' was in a Birmingham hotel, surrounded by a group of Oxford undergraduates, telling them 'he hoped they'd have some "fun" at the coming meeting'. Mosley looked like a 'sixth form boy, the captain of his side', Hodge remembered. See Hodge, *It's Drafty*, pp. 234–5.
43 P. Howard, *Innocent Man* (London: Heinemann, 1941), pp. 1–14; Wolrige Gordon, *Peter Howard*, pp. 43–8.
44 Hodge, *It's Drafty*, p. 234.
45 Howard, *Innocent Man*, p. 12.
46 Wolrige Gordon, *Peter Howard*, pp. 43–8.
47 Howard, with Frank Owen and Michael Foot, was the author of *Guilty Men* (London: Gollancz, 1940).
48 Harrison, *Peter Cheyney*, p. 209.
49 Dorril, *Blackshirt*, p. 184.
50 Nicolson, 'Diary', 29 September 16 November 1931.

51 Nicolson, 'Diary', 17 November 1931 and 23 February 1932.
52 Mosley never saw himself as a man of the political right. See Mosley, *My Life*, p. 288.
53 Beckett, 'After My Fashion', p. 311.
54 *Manchester Guardian*, 23 April 1931.
55 *Liverpool Post and Mercury*, 13 March 1931. For Hull, see [Hull] *Daily Mail* , 24 March 1931.
56 See, for example, Cynthia Mosley's speech in *Daily Herald*, 9 March 1931; and Strachey in *Liverpool Post and Mercury*, 13 March 1931.
57 'Letter from John Strachey MP', pp. 4–10; 'Letter from Cynthia Mosley MP', in Strachey *et al.*, *Why We Left the Old Parties*, pp. 8–9; [Hull] *Daily Mail* , 24 March 1931.
58 *Dundee Free Press*, 20 March 1931.
59 *New Leader*, 27 March 1931.
60 Joad, *The Book of Joad*, pp. 21–2; Meynell, *My Lives*, pp. 188–99; Catlin, *For God's Sake Go*, p. 103.
61 S274/10/1, Letter from G. I. Compton to Eckersley, 10 February 1930 (Eckersley Political Correspondence).
62 P. Stansky and W. Abrahams, *Journey to the Frontier: Two Roads to the Spanish Civil War* (London: Constable, 1966), p. 183; A. Smith 'Of Fanciers, Footnotes and Fascism: Virginia Woolf's *Flush*', *Modern Fiction Studies*, 48/3 (2002), 614–36. Oliver Baldwin also became very sympathetic to the Soviet Union at this time, regarding it as the 'greatest economic experiment the world has ever known'. See O. Baldwin, *The Questing Beast: An Autobiography* (London: Grayson & Grayson, 1932), pp. 237–42.
63 D. Drinkwater, *Sir Harold Nicolson and International Relations: The Practitioner as Theorist* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005), p. 26.
64 Pimlott (ed.), *The Political Diary of Hugh Dalton*, 23 October 1929 and 30 May 1930.
65 Nicolson, 'Diary', Letter to Mosley, 20 August 1931.
66 Pearson, *Façades*, pp. 206–8.
67 Macdougall, *Disillusionment*, pp. 1–2; M. Diston, *The Sleeping Sickness of the Labour Party* (London: New Party, 1931).
68 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 28 May 1931.
69 P. Coupland, 'The Blackshirted Utopians', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 33/2 (1998), 255–72; *idem*, '"Left Wing Fascism" in Theory and Practice: The Case of the British Union of Fascists', *Twentieth Century British History*, 13/1 (2002), 38–61; M. Burrows, 'The Left Wing Road to Fascism: An Investigation into the Influence of Socialist Ideas upon the Political Ideology of the British Union of Fascists' (University of Sheffield, PhD Thesis, 1998).
70 *The Times*, 28 November 1930; *Action*, 24 December 1931; *Saturday Review*, 2 January 1932. See also, A. Leslie, *Randolph: The Biography of Winston Churchill's Son* (New York: Beaufort Books, 1985).
71 *Daily Worker*, 27 March 1931; N. Todd, *In Excited Times: The People Against the Blackshirts* (Newcastle: Bewick Press, 1995), p. 8.
72 *Daily Worker*, 26 March 1931.
73 OMN/A/2/21, Letter from Allan Young to Cynthia Mosley, 14 April 1928 (Mosley Papers).

74 Davies, *Why I Joined the New Party*, pp. 1–4.
75 *Reading Standard*, 17 October 1931; Worley, 'A Call to Action', 246–7.
76 Nicolson, 'Diary', 12 August 1931; J. S. Barnes, *Half A Life* (London: Coward McCann, 1934). Barnes and Nicolson had known each other for some time. Barnes – publicly at least – spoke fondly of Nicolson.
77 Much of the above detail comes from Arthur Reade's security service file and the records of the Special Operations Executive (KV 2/1540–1 and HS 9/1237/3) held at the National Archive. See also, J. McIlroy, 'The Young Manhood of Arthur Reade', in McIlroy, Morgan and Campbell (eds), *Party People, Communist Lives*, pp. 142–5 and 175.
78 Lees-Milne, *Another Self*, pp. 35–8; Howard, *Innocent Men*, p. 8.
79 Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, pp. 31 and 91.
80 Transcript of Interview with Arthur Fawcett.
81 Pearson, *Façades*, p. 188.
82 Savage, *Teenage*, p. 183.
83 K. Ingram, *Rebel: The Short Life of Esmond Romilly* (Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 1985); G. & E. Romilly, *Out of Bounds: The Education of Giles Romilly and Esmond Romilly* (London: Hamish Hamilton, 1935); John Boucicault de Suffield Calthrop's file in the National Archive, KV2/439; S. Cullen, 'Four Women for Mosley: Women in the British Union of Fascists, 1932–40', *Oral History*, 24/1 (1993), 245–67.
84 Mikardo, *Backbencher*, p. 47.
85 Collins, 'The New Party', p. 29; Lees-Milne, *Harold Nicolson*, p. 18; Rose, *Harold Nicolson*, p. 168.
86 P. Parker, *Isherwood: A Life Revealed* (London: Picador, 2004), p. 231. 'Whatever happens,' Upward warned, 'write nothing about politics – otherwise we shall never be able to meet again.'
87 Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, pp. 253–4; Hodge, *It's Drafty*, pp. 223–9.
88 Lewis, *Ted 'Kid' Lewis*, pp. 224–6. Lewis received £60-a-week plus expenses and car to train the party stewards.
89 Nicolson, 'Diary', 12 and 20 August 1931.
90 P. Coupland, 'Prologue to Fascism: The New Party in Northampton, 1931–32', *Northamptonshire Past and Present* (forthcoming). My thanks to Philip for allowing me to see this paper prior to publication.
91 Forgan and Cuming both returned to Labour following their spell in the BUF.
92 Romilly, of course, went on to fight with the international brigades in Spain, before returning to marry Jessica Mitford in 1937. He died fighting fascism in 1941. For Joad *et al*., the FPSI, National Labour Party and initiatives such as the Next Five Years' group provided them with political homes over the 1930s.
93 The information on Davies was provided by his daughter, Rosemary Bayley. For Egglestone, see CCO 4/1/51, Letter from H. J. Omerod to Miss Maxse, 13 September 1932 (Conservative Archive). Egglestone had previously written to the Conservatives in 1931 before finding work in the New Party.
94 G. D. H. Cole, *A History of the Labour Party from 1914* (London: Routledge, 1948), pp. 242–3.
95 *The Times*, 25 July 1931.

Chapter 6

1 *Birmingham Gazette*, 19 October 1931; *Birmingham Post*, 19 October 1931; *Evening Dispatch*, 19 October 1931; *Daily Record*, 19 October 1931; *The Times*, 19 October 1931; *Daily Mirror*, 19 October 1931; *Manchester Guardian*, 19 October 1931; *Birmingham Mail*, 10 November 1931.
2 A. Thorpe, *The British General Election of 1931* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1991).
3 *The Times*, 19 November 1931.
4 For a brilliant analysis of Britain's changing political culture, see J. Lawrence, *Electing Our Masters: The Hustings in British Politics from Hogarth to Blair* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009).
5 Minutes of the First Meeting of the Publicity Committee; Gerald Barry Journal, 17 February 1931; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 15 February 1931.
6 NRO/2003–36, Letter from Dan Davies to Arthur Musgrave, 27 March 1931 (Musgrave Papers).
7 Minutes of the First Meeting of the Publicity Committee.
8 The quote is taken from a letter handed out to all who attended the first New Party meeting at London's Memorial Hall on 5 March 1931. See *The Times*, 6 March 1931.
9 Gerald Barry Journal, 17 February 1931.
10 Some newspaper estimates of the crowds attending the New Party's early meetings include: 3,500 in Stoke, *Evening Sentinel*, 9 March 1931; 2,500 in Liverpool, *Liverpool Post and Mercury*, 13 March 1931; 10,000 in Glasgow, *Glasgow Evening News*, 19 March 1931; 4,000 in Cardiff, *Western Mail and South Wales News*, 23 March 1931.
11 Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, p. 258.
12 Worley, 'Who Makes the Nazis?' 7–16. For a contemporary account of the Ashton campaign, see *The Stalybridge Reporter*, 18 and 25 April 1931.
13 'Wages Must Not Be Cut', *The New Ashton*, April 1931, p. 2.
14 Nicolson, 'Diary', 26 and 31 August 1931.
15 See, for example, Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 5 May 1931. Nicolson hoped to contest a by-election in Brentford and Chiswick, where the sitting MP (Colonel Grant Morden) was rumoured to be standing down on account of going bankrupt. This, however, failed to occur. Interestingly, the seat was targeted – in part – because it was a safe Tory seat. Mosley, the *Manchester Guardian* reported on 8 May 1931, was keen to show that he was not out only to 'wreck' the Labour Party. An agricultural constituency was then supposed to provide the next site for the New Party challenge.
16 *Evening Sentinel* 8 October 1931. Mosley also had family links to Staffordshire. See Oswald Mosley, *My Life*, pp. 1–23.
17 Nicolson, 'Diary', 1 September 1931.
18 *Action*, 15 and 22 October 1931, both p. 29.
19 Nicolson, 'Diary', 22 July 1931.
20 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 22 September and 1 October 1931.
21 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 22 September 1931.
22 *The Reading Standard*, 17 October 1931; *Reading Mercury*, 17 October 1931.
23 *The Reading Standard*, 24 October 1931; *The Times*, 25 February 1932.

24 J. Jacobs, *Out of the Ghetto: My Youth In The East End: Communism and Fascism, 1913–39* (London: Phoenix, 1991 edition), pp. 76–7.
25 *South Western Star*, 16 October 1931; *Pontypridd Observer*, 17 October 1931; *Coatbridge Express*, 14 and 21 October 1931.
26 See, for example, Hobhouse's itinerary in Ashton-under-Lyne in *The Stalybridge Reporter*, 17 October 1931.
27 *Reading Mercury*, 24 October 1931.
28 *The New Ashton*, April 1931; *Evening Sentinel*, 19 October 1931.
29 Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, pp. 262–5.
30 *Northampton Daily Chronicle*, 2 July 1931. My thanks to Philip Coupland for this reference.
31 *The Times*, 11 June 1931; *Yorkshire Telegraph and Star*, 1 August 1931; *The Times*, 3 August 1931; *Sheffield Daily Telegraph*, 3 August 1931.
32 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 12 September 1931.
33 *The Times*, 21 September 1931; *The Scotsman*, 21 September 1931. *The Times* actually estimated the crowd to have been 40,000, though *The Scotsman* suggested it was more in the region of 15–20,000.
34 *Action*, 3 December 1931, p. 17.
35 *Birmingham Town Crier*, 3 April 1931. See also *New Leader*, 29 May, 12 June and 21 September 1931 for reference to Cuming's talk to the Welwyn Garden City ILP Guild of Youth, Marshall Diston's contribution to a St Marylebone debate on the question 'is socialism the remedy?' and Robert Forgan's participation in an Acton ILP 'socialist forum' with John Beckett, Jack Murphy, Tom Mann, Alex Gossip and C. J. Simmons.
36 *Shipley Times and Express*, 10 October 1931.
37 NRO/2003–36, Letter from Dan Davies to Arthur Musgrave, 22 July and 17 August 1931; Letter from J. W. Goulding to the *Northampton Chronicle and Echo*, 11 April 1931 (Musgrave Papers).
38 *South Western Star*, 30 October 1931.
39 *Daily Worker*, 30 May 1930.
40 *The Times*, 26 July and 19 August 1932. In both instances, a 19 year-old engineer named Jack Maddocks was to the fore.
41 *The New Times*, August–September 1932, p. 7. The Kingston branch of the BUF included at least three former New Party members: Ron Hargrave, previously of the National Fascisti, and two Mills brothers. Arthur Mills was later part of the BUF's I Squad.
42 *The New Times*, August–September 1932, p. 9; *The Times*, 29 August 1932; *Daily Mirror*, 29 August 1931.
43 J. Gottlieb, 'The Marketing of Megalomania: Celebrity, Consumption and the Development of Political Technology in the British Union of Fascists', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 41/1 (2006), 35–55.
44 Nicolson, 'Diary', 30 July 1931.
45 *The Stalybridge Reporter*, 2 May 1931; *South Western Star*, 9 October 1931.
46 *Manchester Guardian*, 15 August 1931.
47 OMN/B/8/2, P. Moir, 'The Greyshirt Anthem' (Mosley Papers).
48 NRO/2003–36, Letter from Box to Musgrave, 7 July and 15 September 1931 (Musgrave Papers).
49 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 4 September 1931.

50 *Glasgow Evening News*, 19 March 1931; *The Stalybridge Reporter*, 25 April 1931.
51 Wilkinson, *Peeps at Politicians*, pp. 38–9.
52 *South Western Star*, 16 October 1931.
53 Nicolson, 'Diary', 12 June, 30 July, 4, 7 and 10 August 1931. The four-page storyboard was entitled 'Draft Scenario of Film for the New Party'.
54 Nicolson, 'Diary', 10 September 1931.
55 *Manchester Guardian*, 2 October 1931.
56 *South Western Star*, 9 October 1931.
57 Nicolson, 'Diary', 20 July 1931.
58 H. Nicolson, 'The Mosley Memorandum', *The Listener*, 17 December 1930; Nicolson, 'Diary', 28 April and 31 December 1931; Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 240.
59 Letter from BBC Director of Programmes to Sir Oswald Mosley, 10 February 1931 (BBC Archive). My thanks to Shaun Ley for passing this reference onto me.
60 *Daily Telegraph*, 11 February 1931; O. Mosley, 'Shall the Old Gang Rule the Ether?', *Sunday News*, 15 February 1931; *idem*, 'Broadcasting and Controversy', *Popular Wireless*, 4 April 1931.
61 Letter from Sir John Reith to Major Glyn, 16 October 1931 (BBC Archive). My thanks to Shaun Ley for passing this reference onto me.
62 Nicolson, 'Diary', 12 March 1931. Strachey claimed to have 'definite evidence of a boycott; explicit instructions have been issued in certain quarters that no mention must be made of the New Party'. See *World's Press News*, 4 June 1931; Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 256.
63 A. Taylor, 'Speaking to Democracy: The Conservative Party and Mass Opinion from the 1920s to the 1950s', in S. Ball and I. Holliday (eds), *Mass Conservatism: The Conservatives and the Public since the 1880s* (London: Routledge, 2002), pp. 78–99.
64 *South Western Star*, 16 October 1931.
65 Nicolson, 'Diary', 5–7 June 1931.
66 *Daily Herald*, 6 March 1931; *Manchester Guardian*, 6 March 1931.
67 *Birmingham Town Crier*, 13 March 1931; *Liverpool Post and Mercury*, 13 March 1931; *Manchester Guardian*, 16 March 1931; *Glasgow Evening New*, 19 March 1931; *Western Mail and South Wales News*, 23 March 1931; [Hull] *Daily Mail*, 26 March 1931; *Courier and Advertiser*, 20 March 1931; *Dundee Free Press*, 20 March 1931; *West London Observer*, 18 April 1931.
68 Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, pp. 257–8; *Stalybridge Reporter*, 2 May 1931.
69 *The Times*, 22 and 28 April 1931; *Stalybridge Reporter*, 25 April and 2 May 1931.
70 *Manchester Guardian*, 16 May 1931.
71 *The Scotsman*, 21 September 1931; *The Times*, 21 September 1931.
72 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 21 September 1931.
73 *Daily Worker*, 25 September and 15 October 1931. For reference to free speech, see *Manchester Guardian*, 16 May 1931 and *Evening Sentinel*, 22 October 1931. 'My bodyguard is simply this: They are people drawn from those localities which are determined to hold up the right of free speech in Britain.'
74 *The Stalybridge Reporter*, 17 October 1931; *Birmingham Post*, 19 October 1931; *Daily Mirror*, 11 November 1931.

75 *Daily Record*, 20 October 1931.
76 *West London Observer*, 16 October 1931; *Birmingham Post*, 10 October 1931. See the *Sheffield Daily Independent*, 19 October 1931 and *Stalybridge Reporter*, 17 October 1931, for similar incidents in Sheffield and Ashton-under-Lyne. In the latter, an outdoor meeting of the New Party was curtailed when a section of the crowd tied a rope around the portable platform and tried to overturn it. See *Manchester Guardian*, 15 October 1931.
77 *Merthyr Express*, 24 October 1931.
78 *Merthyr Express*, 31 October 1931.
79 Interestingly, the ILP's John Beckett – an admirer of Mussolini who later joined Mosley in the BUF before co-founding the National Socialist League – also formed his own 'defence force' in response to communist opposition during the 1931 general election in Peckham. See F. Beckett, *The Rebel Who Lost his Cause: The Tragedy of John Beckett MP* (London: Allison & Busby, 2000), p. 104.
80 *Glasgow Evening News*, 19 March 1931; *Dundee Free Press*, 20 March 1931; *Yorkshire Post*, 17 March 1931; *The Reading Standard*, 17 October 1931. The Dundee meeting was particularly notable for the humorous interjections of the audience. See also *Stalybridge Reporter*, 24 October 1931; and the *Birmingham Town Crier*, 13 March 1931, which reported how most of those attending the New Party meeting held at the Astoria Theatre, Aston, on 8 March had done so to 'see the fun'.
81 *Daily Record and Mail*, 21 October 1931.
82 *Reading Standard*, 17 October 1931.
83 Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, pp. 268–9.
84 *Manchester Guardian*, 16 March 1931. During the Ashton by-election, the local paper – *Stalybridge Reporter*, 25 April 1931 – suggested many of the 2,000 people who attended the New Party's opening campaign meeting did so out of 'curiosity'. See also, *Birmingham Town Crier*, 13 March 1931.
85 *Manchester Guardian*, 6 March 1931.
86 *Manchester Guardian*, 16 March 1931.
87 *Yorkshire Post*, 17 March 1931.
88 *Daily Record and Mail*, 21 October 1931.
89 *Action*, 8 October 1931, pp. 10–11.
90 *South Western Star*, 16 October 1931.
91 *Manchester Guardian*, 16 March 1931; [Hull] *Daily Mail*, 26 March 1931; *Birmingham Town Crier*, 3 April 1931; *Evening Sentinel*, 5 October 1931; *South Western Star*, 16 October 1931; *City and East London Observer*, 17 October 1931; *Coatbridge Leader*, 17 October 1931; *Airdrie and Coatbridge Advertiser*, 24 October 1931. Even amidst the violent scenes in Glasgow on 20 September 1931, *The Scotsman* found room to report the generally good reception received by Mosley prior to his party's confrontation with the CPGB.
92 *Evening Sentinel*, 9 March 1931. There are more examples. In Glasgow, Cynthia Mosley's appearance at the town hall on 18 March won cheers from the crowd, while early New Party meetings in Cardiff,

Leeds and Hull brought a mixture of 'lively' heckling and applause interspersed with the odd bout of 'uproar'. See *Glasgow Evening News*, 19 March 1931; *Western Mail and South Wales News*, 23 March 1931; *Daily Worker*, 26 March 1931; [Hull] *Daily Mail*, 26 March 1931.

93 *Manchester Guardian*, 26 October 1931; Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, pp. 274–5.

94 *Evening Sentinel*, 17 October 1931.

95 *Evening Sentinel*, 22 October 1931.

96 *Daily Record and Mail*, 21 October 1931; *The Scotsman*, 21 October 1931; *Paisley and Renfrewshire Gazette*, 24 October 1931; *Derbyshire Times*, 24 October 1931. In London, Marshall Diston's October introduction to the Wandsworth electorate was reported to have been both peaceful and well attended, while Leslie Cuming's orchestrated campaign in South Battersea reputedly hosted 'model' meetings to which people queued four abreast to enter. *Borough News*, 16 October 1931; *South Western Star*, 16 October 1931.

97 *Borough News*, 23 October 1931.

98 *Evening Chronicle*, 23 October 1931.

99 *Derbyshire Times*, 24 October 1931. See also reference to E. Snelgrove's poorly attended meetings in Sheffield in *Sheffield Daily Independent*, 21 and 24 October 1931.

100 *South Western Star*, 23 October 1931.

101 *Coatbridge Express*, 14 and 21 October 1931; *Coatbridge Leader*, 24 October 1931.

102 *Coatbridge Leader*, 17 October 1931.

103 *Daily Worker*, 25 September 1931.

104 A. Thorpe, 'The Membership of the Communist Party of Great Britain, 1920–45', *The Historical Journal*, 43/3 (2000), 777–800; R. Croucher, *We Refuse to Starve in Silence: A History of the National Unemployed Workers' Movement, 1920–46* (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 1987).

105 *Sheffield Daily Independent*, 19 October 1931; *Action*, 8 October and 5 November 1931, pp. 10–11 and pp. 1–2 respectively. In Sheffield, on 17 September, Mosley noted Hitler's growing support in Germany and related this back to the New Party.

106 For examples of the debate over whether Mosley provoked or responded to violence, see S. Cullen, 'Political Violence: The Case of the British Union of Fascists', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 28/2 (1993), 245–67; D. Tilles, 'Bullies or Victims? A Study of British Union of Fascists Violence', *Totalitarian Movements and Political Religions*, 7/3 (2006), 327–46. See also, N. Copsey, *Anti-Fascism in Britain* (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 2000); D. Renton, *This Rough Game: Fascism and Anti-Fascism* (Stroud: Sutton Publishing, 2001).

107 J. Lawrence, 'Fascist Violence and the Politics of Public Order in Inter-War Britain: The Olympia Debate Revisited', *Historical Research*, 76/192 (2003), 240; Lawrence, 'The Transformation of British Public Politics', 185–216.

108 *South Western Star*, 16 October 1931.

Chapter 7

1 *Action*, 22 October 1931, pp. 10–11. See also Nicolson, 'Can the New Party Survive?', *Saturday Review*, 9 January 1932. For private comments, see Nicolson, 'Diary', 7 June and 4 September 1931.
2 Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You', pp. 10–11.
3 Ball, *The Guardsmen*, p. 104; J. Stubbs, 'The Impact of the Great War on the Conservative Party', in Peele and Cook (eds), *The Politics of Reappraisal*, pp. 31–5.
4 HC Debates, vol. 244, cols. 67–761 (29 October 1930).
5 See, for an amusing description, Ball (ed.), *The Headlam Diaries*, 25–28 September and 15 December 1930.
6 James, *Bob Boothby*, p. 102; *Week-End Review*, 14 February and 4 April 1931; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 29 April and 6 May 1931.
7 Beckett, 'After My Fashion', pp. 311–12. It has also been suggested that the New Party formed out of a discussion between Mosley and Forgan in Monaco, though this appears to be pure conjecture. See Labour Research Department, *Mosley Fascism: The Man, His Policies and Methods* (London: LRD, 1935), p. 9.
8 Wilkinson, *Peeps at Politicians*, pp. 80–3. Wilkinson called Brown 'the eternal exclamation mark'.
9 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 29 April and 30 May 1931; Gerald Barry Journal, 2 February and 22 July 1931.
10 Minutes of the National Executive Committee 1900–39 (Wakefield: Microform Academic Publishers, undated); *Daily Herald*, 16 March 1931. The headline ran: 'War Declared on New Party'.
11 Such a line would be honed over time. See, for example, Labour Research Department, *Who Back's Mosley: Fascist Promise and Fascist Performance* (London: LRD, 1934).
12 Johnson, 'Birmingham Labour', 535.
13 *Birmingham Town Crier*, 13 and 20 March 1931.
14 *The Stalybridge Reporter*, 2 May 1931.
15 K. Middlemass (ed.), *Thomas Jones: Whitehall Diary Volume II, 1926–30* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1969), 21 June 1929; S. Ball, *Baldwin and the Conservative Party: The Crisis of 1929–31* (London: Yale University Press, 1988), pp. 160–2.
16 Strachey and Joad, 'Parliamentary Reform', 82–99.
17 HC Debates, vol. 254, cols. 2141–3 (8 July 1931). See also the *Evening Sentinel*, 4 June 1931. This suggested that Cynthia Mosley went daily to Westminster, but never to listen to debates. She cut a 'lonely figure', the paper noted.
18 Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 261.
19 New Party, *The New Party Protest* (London: New Party, 1931).
20 Nicholson, 'Diary', 4–13 July 1931.
21 *The Times*, 9 July 1931; *Manchester Guardian*, 9 July 1931; HC Debates, vol. 254, cols. 2101–49 and vol. 255 cols. *485–715* (8 and 15 July 1931).
22 *The Times*, 5 June 1931.
23 HC Debates, vol. 256 cols. 77–82 and cols. 1319–23 (8 and 21 September 1931).

24 Nicolson, 'Diary', 11 September 1931; Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, p. 269.
25 Box tried to negotiate with Conservative central office, whilst Mosley made a personal appeal to Neville Chamberlain. Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 22 September and 1 October 1931; R. Self (ed.), *The Neville Chamberlain Diary Letters: The Heir Apparent, 1928–33* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2002), 26 September 1931; *The Times*, 21 September 1931.
26 *Evening Sentinel*, 21 October 1931.
27 *Daily Herald*, 17 May 1924.
28 S. V. Bracher, *The Herald Book of Labour Members, 1923–24* (London: Labour Publishing, 1924), p. 52; *Saturday Review*, 21 February 1931.
29 Pimlott (ed.), *The Political Diary of Hugh Dalton*, 1 August 1930.
30 Lloyd George quoted in C. Cook and I. Taylor, *The Labour Party: An Introduction to its History, Structure and Policy* (London: Longman, 1980), p. 120. Lloyd George remained in contact with Mosley even after the latter formed the BUF in October 1932.
31 Mosley, *My Life*, pp. 275–9; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 20 and 21 July 1931; K. Young (ed.), *The Diaries of Sir Robert Bruce Lockhart, 1915–38* (London: Macmillan, 1973), 27 August 1931.
32 Nicolson, 'Diary', 30 April; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 31 August 1931.
33 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 20 July 1931.
34 *Merthyr Express*, 10, 17, 24 and 31 October 1931.
35 *Sheffield Daily Telegraph*, 3 August 1931.
36 Nicolson, 'Diary', 20 July 1931 and 23 February 1932.
37 M. Bloch, *The Duke of Windsor's War* (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 1982); P. Ziegler, *King Edward VIII: The Official Biography* (London: Fontana, 1991).
38 C. Seymour-Ure, 'The Press and the Party System between the Wars', in Peele and Cooke (eds), *Politics of Reappraisal*, pp. 232–57.
39 Chisholm and Davie, *Beaverbrook*, p. 291.
40 Nicolson 'Diary', 23 June and 3 July 1931; Young (ed.), *The Diaries of Sir Robert Bruce Lockhart*, 23 June 1931. Lockhart recorded that Nicolson intended to approach Hearst for £1,500,000 to fund an evening New Party paper. Nicolson's diary states that he warned Mosley against the idea.
41 Letter from Beaverbrook to Mosley, 17 July 1930 (Beaverbrook Papers); Young (ed.), *The Diaries of Sir Robert Bruce Lockhart*, 25 September and 11 October 1930; Pimlott (ed.), *The Political Diary of Hugh Dalton*, 23 October 1930.
42 *The Times*, 30 October 1930.
43 BBK/C/254, Letter from Beaverbrook to Mosley, 28 February 1931 (Beaverbrook Papers).
44 Nicolson, 'Diary', 2 March 1931; Young (ed.), *The Diaries of Sir Robert Bruce Lockhart*, 1 May 1931.
45 Nicolson 'Diary', 24 July 1931; Chisholm and Davie, *Beaverbrook*, p. 305. The defection of Strachey and Young led Beaverbrook to suggest that young Tory rebels would be attracted more to the New Party than his own empire crusade. Lockhart also told Nicolson that Beaverbrook was jealous of Mosley. See Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 2 November 1931.
46 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 6 November 1930.
47 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 29 April 1931.

48 The National Citizens' Union was known to be anti-Semitic and had links to the British Fascists. S. Dorril, *Blackshirt*, p. 191.
49 Mosley, *My Life*, pp. 275–9.
50 S. J. Taylor, *The Great Outsiders: Northcliffe, Rothermere and the Daily Mail* (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 1996), pp. 270–5.
51 Quoted in James, *Bob Boothby*, p. 102.
52 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 4 and 11 December 1931, and 30 January 1932.
53 *Daily Mail*, 1 February 1932; Nicolson, 'Diary', 1 February 1931. See also G. Ward Price's exuberant review of *The Greater Britain* in *Daily Mail*, 30 September 1932. Its title sets the tone: 'Sir Oswald Mosley – Visionary or Future Leader?'
54 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, pp. 95–6.
55 Labour Research Department, *Who Backs Mosley?*, pp. 9–13.
56 Nicolson, 'Diary', 11 June 1931; *The Times*, 1 July 1931; *Manchester Guardian*, 1 July 1931.
57 A. Marwick, 'Middle Opinion in the 1930s: Planning, Progress and Political Agreement', *English Historical Review*, 79/311 (1964), 285–98; Ritschel, *The Politics of Planning*, pp. 1–16 and pp. 78–83; *Week-End Review*, 13 and 20 December 1930. Se also Keynes' critique in *Nation and Athenaeum*, 3 December 1930.
58 *Week-End Review*, 4 April 1931. The question of political affiliation would prove to be a contentious point within PEP. See Ritschel, *The Politics of Planning*, pp. 152–82.
59 *Action*, 8 October 1931, p. 4; Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2; Diplomaticus. 'The Old Gentlemen of Threadneedle Street', *Action*, 26 November 1931, p. 14; *Yorkshire Telegraph and Star*, 1 August 1931. It may be that Mosley's recourse to anti-Semitism served, in part, as a means of shifting his criticism of finance capitalism away from bankers *per se* and so away from a pool of potentially fruitful support.
60 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 29 April, 14 May and 28 July 1931.
61 Nicolson, 'Diary', 7 September 1931.
62 H. Nicolson, 'What This Paper Stands For', *Action*, 8 October 1931, p. 3.
63 Isherwood and Sackville-West contributed to *Action* but offered no support to the New Party.
64 M. Boulestin, 'The Earth and the Tin', *Action*, 31 December 1931, p. 7.
65 The examples cited can be found in *Action*, 15, 22, 29 October, 12, 26 November, 10, 31 December 1931.
66 As may be imagined, Spengler's concept of declining civilisation was making an impact in New Party circles by this time. Fascism, of course, endorsed much of Spengler's analysis but rejected his supposed pessimism and determinism. See O. Mosley, 'The Philosophy of Fascism', *Fascist Quarterly*, January 1935; W. E. D. Allen, 'The Fascist Idea in Britain', *Quarterly Review*, October 1933, pp. 223–33; Drennan, *The BUF*, p. 17 and chapter seven.
67 C. Hobhouse, 'Modern Architecture and its Development', *Action*, 8 October 1931, pp. 10–11; *idem*, 'The Art of Living at Close Quarters', *Action*, 3 December 1931, p. 6.
68 *Action*, 29 October and 31 December 1931. The paper was down to just 16 pages by its end.

69 Letter from Nicolson to Vita Sackville-West, 28 September 1931, in Nicolson, *Vita and Harold*, p. 229.
70 Nicolson, 'Diary', 16, 18 and 29 September 1931.
71 Nicolson, 'Diary', 7 and 26 October, and 3 November 1931.
72 Nicolson, 'What This Paper', p. 3; Mandle, 'The New Party', 352.
73 *Action*, 15 October, 1931, p. 18.
74 *Action*, 31 December 1931, pp. 4–5.
75 Mosley, 'Why We Must Cease *Action*', pp. 1–2; *Saturday Review*, 2 January 1932, p. 3; Nicolson, 'Diary', 19 and 22 December 1931; Young (ed.), *The Diaries of Sir Robert Bruce Lockhart*, 22 December 1931. Lockhart says the party also approached Major Colin Cooper for money.
76 Nicolson, 'Letter from Nicolson to Forgan', in *Diaries*, 15 April 1932.
77 Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 33. Taylor makes this point in his *Bright Young People*, pp. 230–2, pointing out that very few of the 'bright young people' associated with the New Party followed Mosley into the BUF. That said, Dorril has suggested that Mosley and his New Movement received some support from the *New English Weekly* established by A. R. Orage in the spring of 1932. See Dorril, *Blackshirt*, pp. 204–5.

Chapter 8

1 Mosley, 'Why We Must Cease *Action*', pp. 1–2.
2 Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, pp. 23–7.
3 *Daily Herald*, 24 May 1930.
4 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 27 April 1931. Leslie Grundy later recalled Mosley speaking in Manchester. He 'strode briskly' around the platform, Grundy wrote, hypnotising the audience with words that 'seemed to bounce off the hall like a golf ball'. MS 190, L. Grundy 'Don't Let Conscience Be Your Guide', unpublished manuscript (Sheffield University).
5 Skidelsky, *Oswald Mosley*, pp. 274–5; *South Western Star*, 16 October 1931. Ellen Wilkinson, too, later suggested that Mosley was 'too conscious of the impression he wants to make to be a great orator. His audience is chilled by his restraint.' See Wilkinson and Conze, *Why Fascism?*, p. 64.
6 Quotes from MS 180, J. Wallder, 'Blackshirts in Kingston Project: A Pictorial Record' (Blackshirts in Kingston Project); Anon., *Blackshirts Look Back: Inside the BUF, 1932–40* (London: Sanctuary Press, 1984), p. 39.
7 For a collection of essays on masculinity and British politics, see M. McCormack (ed.), *Public Men: Masculinity and Politics in Modern Britain* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2007). See also, T. Collins, 'Return to Manhood: The Cult of Masculinity and the British Union of Fascists', *International Journal of the History of Sport*, 3/1 (1999), 145–62.
8 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 15 February and 11 December 1931; de Courcy, *The Viceroy's Daughters*, pp. 159–87.
9 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, p. 41; *The New Times*, July 1932, pp. 3 and 7.
10 For its development, see J. Gottlieb, 'Britain's New Fascist Men: The Aestheticization of Brutality on British Fascist Propaganda', in Gottlieb and Linehan (eds), *The Culture of Fascism*, pp. 83–99.

11 This *Homos fascistus* has been recognised as a European-wide phenomenon. See G. L. Mosse, *The Image of Man: The Creation of Modern Masculinity* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999).
12 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, pp. 36–7.
13 *The New Times*, June 1932, p. 2.
14 *The New Times*, July 1932, p. 3. Members were instructed that 'no additional accoutrements, such as berets or leather shoulder straps, are authorised', and that 'fire-arms must on no account be carried'.
15 See, for example, the New Party speeches in *The Stalybridge Reporter*, 2 May 1931; *Paisley and Renfrewshire Gazette*, 2 May 1931; *The Scotsman*, 21 September 1931; *South Western Star*, 9 October 1931; *Manchester Guardian*, 26 October 1931. The party insisted that: 'We organised the country in the war; why not do it again for the greater purposes of peace?'
16 *Birmingham Gazette*, 10 October 1931; *Evening Sentinel*, 22 October 1931; *Shipley Times and Express*, 24 October 1931, Ronald E. Braden, 'Election Address' (1931); A. Marshall Diston, 'Election Address' (1931). Also Hodge, *It's Drafty*, p. 235. Of the party's 24 candidates, at least Mosley, Leaper, Braden, Diston, Troward, Bartleet, Davies, Snelgrove, Forgan and Dudgeon had served or had a military background of some sort. Hodge tried to join the RAF but was rejected, while Nicolson and Pratt served respectively in the foreign office and wartime coalition government. Several other candidates, including Woodroffe and Hobhouse, were too young to have served in the Great War.
17 *Airdrie and Coatbridge Advertiser*, 10 October 1931.
18 *South Western Star*, 9 October 1931; *Evening Sentinel*, 5 October 1931. See also *Evening Sentinel*, 26 October 1931.
19 *Action*, 15 October 1931, p. 2. Earlier, on the night of the Ashton-under-Lyne by-election, as the New Party platform stood before a seething crowd, Mosley reputedly turned to Risdon and said: 'we saw worse than this in the war Bill'. See Cross, *The Fascists in Britain*, p. 48.
20 'Our Shabby Grandfathers', p. 3.
21 Carey, *The Intellectuals and the Masses*, pp. 198–208.
22 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, p. 23; Rose, *Harold Nicolson*, p. 22. Rose suggests that Nicolson exhibited an ingrained prejudice that split mankind into two categories: on the one hand a racial, social and intellectual aristocracy; on the other, the philistine masses.
23 Hobhouse, 'The Art of Living at Close Quarters', p. 6.
24 Lees-Milne, *Another Self*, p. 77. Lees-Milne also felt it would be impossible for a man of his class to have an 'affair of the heart' with a member of the lower classes. Such a thing would, he explained, be as thinkable as riding a bicycle on a rope across Niagara falls.
25 Mosley, 'What Are We Fighting For?'; Drennan, *The BUF*, pp. 16–18.
26 *The Times*, 1 July 1931.
27 *Action*, 22 October 1931, pp. 11–12; O. Mosley, 'Well, What About It?', *Action*, 5 November 1931, p. 1.
28 *The Stalybridge Reporter*, 2 May 1931; *Evening Sentinel*, 8 October 1931.
29 *The New Times*, July 1932, pp. 4–5. See also Drennan, *The BUF*, chapter one.
30 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, pp. 39–40.
31 *Action*, 15 October 1931, p. 4.

32 *Action*, 15 and 29 October 1931, pp. 27 and 30 respectively.
33 Strachey and Joad, 'Parliamentary Reform', 321; *Evening Sentinel*, 5 October 1931; HC Debates, vol. 256, cols. 72–82 (8 September 1931). Earlier, in February 1931, Mosley told parliament that: 'These suggestions to put the nation in bed on a starvation diet are the suggestions of an old woman in a fright. The exact reverse is needed; a policy of manhood which takes the nation out into the field and builds up its muscles and its constitution in effort.' HC Debates, vol. 248 cols. 685–92 (12 February 1931).
34 Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You', pp. 10–11; 'Our Shabby Grandfathers', p. 3.
35 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum, p. 33.
36 HC Debates, vol. 256, cols. 72–82 (8 September 1931).
37 *Stalybridge Reporter*, 24 October 1931; *Sheffield Daily Telegraph*, 3 August 1931.
38 Quoted in Dorril, *Blackshirt*, p. 181.
39 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, pp. 39–40; *South Western Star*, 16 October 1931; Mosley, 'What is Personal Liberty?', p. 1; HC debates, vol. 248 cols. 685–92 (12 February 1931).
40 E. Lewis, 'Election Address' (1931).
41 M. Woodroffe, 'Election Address' (1931).
42 See Moir, 'The Greyshirt Anthem'; *The Times*, 2 March 1931.
43 *Evening Sentinel*, 9 March 1931; *Reading Standard*, 17 October 1931; *South Western Star*, 23 October 1931; *Manchester Guardian*, 26 October 1931.
44 *West London Observer*, 16 October 1931; *The Reading Standard*, 17 and 24 October 1931. Leaflets, entitled 'Man of Action', were distributed during the general election to explain Mosley's break from the Labour Party.
45 *Sheffield Daily Independent*, 19 October 1931. See also Joad, *The Case for the New Party*, p. 4.
46 I. Zweiniger-Bargielowska, 'Building a British Superman: Culture in Interwar Britain', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 41/4 (2006), 595–610.
47 Mosse, *The Image of Man*, p. 1.
48 For an interesting discussion on the reasons for this see Griffin, *Modernism and Fascism*, pp. 141–6.
49 Cullen, 'Four Women for Mosley', p. 52.
50 Examples include Maggie Kelly in Coatbridge and Airdrie (*Coatbridge Leader*, 17 October 1931); Catherine Connell and Emma Noyes in Hammersmith (*West London Observer*, 23 October 1931).
51 Turner, *Fascism and Anti-Fascism*, p. 15. For Northampton, see the membership cards and lists included in the Musgrave papers.
52 Morgan, 'The British Union of Fascists in the Midlands', p. 97.
53 *The City and East London Observer*, 17 October 1931; *South Western Star*, 23 October 1931.
54 *Merthyr Express*, 24 October 1931.
55 E. Rider Troward, 'Election Address' (1931).
56 *Shipley Times and Express*, 31 October 1931.
57 E. Rider Troward, 'Election Address' (1931); *South Western Star*, 30 October 1931; Hodge, *It's Drafty*, p. 230.
58 'Forum', *The New Times*, July 1932, p. 7.
59 Nicolson, 'Diary', 11 September 1931.

60 O. Rinder, 'Listen Women', *Action*, 29 October 1931, p. 24.
61 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, p. 41.
62 de Courcy, *The Viceroy's Daughters*, pp. 171–5.
63 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 11 December 1931 and 13 January 1932. Cimmie told Nicolson that she 'loathes all forms of reaction', and her continued support for Mosley was undoubtedly personal rather than political. See also Mosley, *Rules of the Game*, pp. 205–10.
64 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 6 May 1931; de Courcy, *The Viceroy's Daughters*, p. 188; J. Dalley, *Diana Mosley: A Life* (London: Faber & Faber, 2000), p. 153.
65 For warm and positive comments of Cynthia, see Simmons, *Soap-Box Evangelist*, p. 69; Jones, *Unfinished Journey*, p. 267; Wilkinson, *Peeps at Politicians*, pp. 39–40; Meynell, *My Lives*, p. 199; Shinwell, *Conflict Without Malice*, p. 136; L. Manning, *A Life for Education: An Autobiography* (London: Gollancz, 1970), p. 91. According to Patric Dickinson (Robert Forgan's son), Cimmie was a source of attraction for Forgan and many others in Mosley's circle. My thanks go to Patric for his hospitality and his fascinating insights into Forgan and others in and around the New Party. See also OMN/A/2/21, Letter from Allan Young to Cynthia Mosley, 10 March 1932 (Mosley Papers), which reveals an obvious fondness for his former comrade, and Allen's book, *The BUF*, which was dedicated to 'C. M.' Allen described Cynthia as a 'heroic figure' (p. 157).
66 Bradford, *Sacheverell Sitwell*, 184–95; Wilkinson, *Peeps at Politicians*, pp. 38–40. Later, after Mosley had left Labour, Wilkinson contrasted Mosley's 'considerable personal charm' with his 'irritable vanity and his continual preoccupation with himself'. See Wilkinson and Conze, *Why Fascism?*, p. 64.
67 Meynell, *My Lives*, p. 199; Letter from Peter Howard to Doë, undated [August 1931], in Gordon, *Peter Howard*, p. 66. Howard replied: 'You are by no means alone in disliking Mosley's face, even in disliking Mosley himself. He is probably the most unpopular person in England today. But you have to be rather a big person to be hated like that, especially in England. He is rather Mussolini-like, you know, when you talk to him. I must introduce you to him in London. He has rather shifty eyes. He is the most vindictive hater of anyone I know, even more horrible in real rage than I am myself. He is very courageous, and by a long way the best orator in England today. But what endears him to me (by this I do not mean I am devoted to him as a person. I am not, but I would never desert him while he needed me in politics) is that he is alight with his own cause. He really does believe he can save the British working classes and no-one else can.'
68 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 23 February 1932. Mosley gave his wife 'the creeps', Nicolson recorded.
69 *Action*, 24 December 1931, p. 16.
70 P. Graves, *Labour Women: Women in British Working Class Politics, 1918–39* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994); G. E. Maguire, *Conservative Women: A History of Women and the Conservative Party, 1874–1997* (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1998).
71 *The New Times*, June 1932, p. 9; Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, p. 41; Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 41.
72 For a sample of the literature, see K. Passmore (ed.), *Women, Gender and Fascism in Europe, 1919–45* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2003);

J. Gottlieb, *Feminine Fascism: Women in Britain's Fascist Movement, 1923–45* (London: I. B. Tauris, 2000); M. Durham, *Women and Fascism* (London: Routledge, 1998). Also, D. Renton, 'Women and Fascism: A Critique', *Socialist History*, 20 (2001), 71–82.

73 Nicolson, 'What This Paper Stands For', p. 3; also cited in Gottlieb, 'Britain's New Fascist Men', pp. 86–7.

Chapter 9

1 Catlin, *For God's Sake Go*, p. 85.
2 Strachey, *The Menace of Fascism*, p. 161.
3 *The Times*, 24 and 27 July 1931; Nicolson, *Diaries* (ed.), 28 May, 10 June, 17 and 23 July, 22 September and 2 November 1931.
4 Nicolson, 'Diary', 5 and 24 November 1931.
5 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 15 March, 5 and 19 April 1932.
6 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
7 Ball (ed.), *The Headlam Diaries*, 25–28 September 1930.
8 See, for example, *Daily Telegraph*, 8 December 1930; *New Statesman*, 13 December 1930, pp. 292–3; 'Moslini', *Punch*, 17 December 1930; W. Rust, 'The Mosley Manifesto', *Labour Monthly*, January 1931; *Time and Tide*, 21 February 1931.
9 OMN/B/4/8, Letter to Allan Young, 15 December 1930 (Mosley Papers).
10 *The Times*, 10 December 1930. See also Young (ed.), *The Diaries of Sir Robert Bruce Lockhart*, 25 September 1930.
11 *Daily Herald*, 8 June 1931; *Manchester Guardian*, 9 June 1931. Speaking at the congress, Mosley stated that the New Party 'did not stand for dictatorship' and was critical of Fascist economic policy. The party's link to the continental movements, he continued, came via its appeal to the post-war generation and in its commitment 'not so much to the salvation of an old nation as to the creation of a new one – the Functional State'.
12 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 15 March 1932.
13 H. Nicolson, 'Action Looks at Life', *Action*, 17 December 1931, pp. 4–5; O. Mosley, 'An Explanation by Sir Oswald Mosley', *Action*, 31 December 1931, p. 2.
14 Mosley, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2.
15 Nicolson, 'Diary', 8 December 1931; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 18 January 1932.
16 Mosley, 'Old Parties or New?', pp. 27–32.
17 Mosley, Untitled Memorandum.
18 Melville, 'Political Upheaval', p. 658.
19 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, p. 13 and p. 154. Fascism, Mosley insisted, was a 'general name for a worldwide movement', just as Liberalism, Socialism and Conservatism were worldwide creeds.
20 For just a few examples, see Stone, *Breeding Superman*, pp. 1–10; Thurlow, *Fascism in Britain*, pp. 1–30; *idem*, 'The Return of Jeremiah: The Rejected Knowledge of Sir Oswald Mosley in the 1930s', in K. Lunn and R. Thurlow (eds), *British Fascism: Essays on the Radical Right in Interwar Britain* (London: Croom Helm, 1980); B. Farr, *The Development and Impact of Right Wing*

Politics in Britain, 1903–32 (New York: Garland, 1987); Linehan, *British Fascism*, pp. 13–37; M. Pugh, *Hurrah for the Blackshirts: Fascists and Fascism in Britain Between the Wars* (London: Jonathan Cape, 2005), pp. 7–20; Carey, *Intellectuals and the Masses*, pp. 198–208; Sykes, *The Radical Right*, chapter one; Zweiniger-Bargielowska, 'Building a British Superman', 601–5; G. Love, '"What's the Big Idea?" Oswald Mosley, the British Union of Fascists and Generic Fascism', *Journal of Contemporary History*, 42/3 (2007), 447–68.

21 D. Stone, 'The English Mistery, the BUF, and the Dilemmas of British Fascism', *Journal of Modern History*, 75/2 (2003), 336–58.

22 Mosley, *My Life*, pp. 91 and 228.

23 A. Bevan, E. J. Strachey and G. Strauss, *What We Saw in Russia* (London: Hogarth Press, 1931). Joad also visited Russia in 1930. Though he claimed to admire the levelling effects of the revolution, the violence used to achieve them upset his pacifism. See Joad, *The Book of Joad*, pp. 94–5.

24 *Daily Worker*, 21 April 1931. For an account of Cimmie's trip, see Mosley, *Rules of the Game*, chapter 16.

25 *Manchester Guardian*, 10 August 1925; Dorril, *Blackshirt*, p. 95. See also Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You', pp. 10–11.

26 Mosley, 'A New National Policy', pp. 103–4. See also his speech at a meeting in Sheffield in October 1931, *Sheffield Daily Independent*, 19 October 1931, where he said that a communist revolution would mean 'slaughter and starvation for thousands'.

27 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, pp. 29–30 and 79–80.

28 *The Times*, 28 November 1930; Nicolson, 'Diary' 28 April and 12 August 1931; Rose, *Harold Nicolson*, p. 27. Keynes may also have helped inform such opinion: see Skidelsky, *John Maynard Keynes*, p. 234.

29 KV 2/879, Letter from Scotland House to MI5, undated but relating to a letter of 15 June 1931 from C. F. Melville to 'Lania' (National Archive).

30 See W. E. D. Allen, *New Political Boundaries in the Caucasus* (London: Royal Geographical Society, 1927); C. F. Melville, 'A Balkan Monarch Takes a Chance', *Action*, 12 November 1931, p. 11.

31 Nicolson, 'Diary', 9 and 30 May, 8 and 15 June, 27 November, 1 and 3 December 1931, 5 and 22 January 1932.

32 Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You', pp. 10–11.

33 C. F. Melville, 'The International Apple Cart May Be Upset', *Action*, 22 October 1931, p. 2; '*Action* Looks at Life', 12, 26 November and 10 December 1931, p. 3, pp. 2–3 and pp. 10–11; Isherwood, 'The Youth Movement in the New Germany', p. 18.

34 Nicolson also travelled to Germany in January 1932 and remained unimpressed by Nazism. See Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 22 and 24 January 1932. Melville, in 1931, wrote of 'various' New Party members visiting the Nazi's Munich *Braun Haus*. See Melville, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 34.

35 KV 2/879, Letter from Hobhouse to Thost, 7 December 1931 (National Archive); J. J. Barnes and P. P. Barnes, *Nazis in Pre-War London, 1933–39: The Fate and Role of German Party Members and British Sympathisers* (Brighton: University of Sussex, 2005).

36 Letter from Hobhouse to Thost, 7 December 1931; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 2 January 1932; Letter from Nicolson to Vita Sackville-West', 3 January 1932, in Nicolson (ed.), *Vita and Harold*, pp. 230–1. Interestingly, Nicolson

refers in the letter to 'We British Hitlerites', though he simultaneously expresses his distaste for Hobhouse's (and Hitler's) analysis.

37 Cheyney likened Mosley's election result in 1931 to that of Mussolini in Milan in 1919, whereat the future dictator's defeat was followed one year later by the return of 'thirty Fascist candidates'. See *Action*, 26 November 1931, p. 5. See also P. M. M., 'Our Leader', *The New Times*, June 1932, p. 5.

38 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 5 January 1932; Young (ed.), *The Diaries of Sir Bruce Lockhart*, 27 August 1931.

39 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 6–7 January 1932; Letter from Nicolson to Forgan, 15 April 1932. Mosley's fantasies no doubt contained a humorous edge, but they reveal much about his mindset at this time.

40 Dorril, *Blackshirt*, pp. 192–3.

41 *Daily Mail*, 1 February 1932.

42 Young (ed.), *The Diaries of Sir Bruce Lockhart*, 4 December 1931 and 29 September 1932. Strachey, now writing from a communist perspective, expressed very similar views in 1932. See Strachey, *The Coming Struggle for Power*, pp. 360–83.

43 Moir, 'The Greyshirt Anthem'.

44 '*Action* Looks at Life', *Action*, 17 December 1931, pp. 4–5 .

45 Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You', pp. 10–11; '*Action* Looks at Life', *Action*, 29 October 1931, p. 11.

46 Nicolson, 'Notes on the Future of the New Party'.

47 Advert for Nupa Club No. 1, *Action*, 24 December 1931, p. 24; L. G. Waterman, 'A Little More Mussolini' and E. D. Randall, 'Perish, Juda!', *The New Times*, August–September 1932, pp. 4–6; 'Letter to Oswald Mosley, Leader of the New Party', 3 October 1932, in Minutes of the Jewish Board of Deputies, Press Committee, November 1932. My thanks to Coleen Weedon for bringing this reference to my attention.

48 P. M. M., 'Our Leader', *The New Times*, June 1932, p. 5.

49 *Action*, 22 October 1931, p. 25.

50 Melville, 'Political Upheaval', p. 658; *idem*, *The Truth About the New Party*, p. 47. In a classic case of getting things wrong, Melville stated: 'We shall not witness in London the spectacle of young Mosleyites heaving half-bricks through the plate glass windows of, say, Messers Salmon and Gluckstein […]'. For Nicolson, see his *Diaries*, 24 January 1932.

51 L. G. Waterman, 'Quo Vadis?', *The New Time*s, July 1932, p. 8. We should note that Waterman claimed to understand Nupa members' coming to 'sympathise' with the IFL's anti-Jewish feeling. Later, in 1934, Allen also criticised the 'harsher' form of fascism that was National Socialism. See Drennan, *The BUF*, p. 221.

52 Waterman, 'A Little More Mussolini', pp. 5–6. Osbert Sitwell's fascist sympathies were also resolutely Fascist; he saw Nazism as barbaric. See Pearson, *Façades*, p. 303.

53 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 19 April 1932.

54 Cross, *The Fascists in Britain*, p. 65; Griffiths, *Fellow Travellers of the Right*, p. 91.

55 See, for examples, *British Fascism*, February and October 1932; *The Fascist*, January and September 1931. For an overview of pre-BUF fascist attitudes to Mosley, see S. Woodbridge, '"Fraudulent Fascism": The Attitude of Early

British Fascists Towards the New Party', *Contemporary British History*, 23/4 (2009), 493–508. Leese – as demonstrated in A. S. Leese, *Out of Step: Events in the Two Lives of an Anti-Jewish Camel Doctor* (London: Carmac Press, 1951) – would forever claim to sense the 'hidden hand' of a Jewish conspiracy about Mosley and, later, the BUF.

56 *The New Times*, June 1932, p. 8.

57 *The New Times*, June 1932, p. 3.

58 Mandle, 'The New Party', pp. 352–3; Griffiths, *Fellow Travellers of the Right*, p. 91; Benewick, *The Fascists Movement*, pp. 82–3.

59 We should note that Mosley's letter on the 'Future Organisation' of the New Party/New Movement did not use the 'f' word. Its stated purpose was 'to unite the serious-minded youth of the nation in clubs of political, social and athletic character, where they will prepare themselves for the time when the old game of party politics is superseded by a type of government that is more virile, more scientific, and more fitted to deal with modern social and economic conditions. Ultimately, the New Movement will have to direct its attention to obtaining control of parliament. The Movement's immediate objective, however, is not to secure the election of parliamentary representatives, but to convince the nation – and more particularly the young men of the nation – of the need to unite in a determined effort to establish the Corporate State in Britain, a State in which every interest and every class will be subordinated to the interest of the nation as a whole.'

60 *Daily Herald*, 20 August 1932.

61 *The New Times*, August–September 1932, p. 1.

62 *Manchester Guardian*, 16 March 1933. Letters relating to Mosley's invitation are kept at the BBC archive in Caversham.

63 For a transcript of Mosley's broadcast, see *The Listener*, 22 March 1933; Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, pp. 11–12.

64 R. Griffin, *The Nature of Fascism* (London: Routledge, 1993), pp. 44–5; *idem.*, *Modernism and Fascism*, pp. 181–2.

65 R. Griffin, 'God's Counterfeiters? Investigating the Triad of Fascism, Totalitarianism and (Political) Religion', in R. Griffin (ed.), *Fascism, Totalitarianism and Political Religion* (London: Routledge, 2005), pp. 1–31.

66 For just a selection of books that, among other things, offer and discuss definitions of fascism, see S. Payne, *A History of Fascism, 1914–45* (Madison: University of Wisconsin, 1995); R. O. Paxton, *The Anatomy of Fascism* (London: Allen Lane, 2004 edition); R. Eatwell, *Fascism: A History* (London: Pimlico, 2003 edition); G. L. Mosse, *The Fascist Revolution: Towards a General Theory of Fascism* (New York: Howard Fertig, 1999); Z. Sternhell, *The Birth of Fascist Ideology: From Cultural Rebellion to Political Revolution* (New Jersey: University of Princeton, 1995 edition).

67 E. Gentile, 'Fascism, Totalitarianism and Political Religion: Definitions and Critical Reflections on Criticism of an Interpretation', in Griffin (ed.), *Fascism*, pp. 32–81.

68 *Sheffield Daily Telegraph*, 3 August 1931; *Action*, 8 October 1931.

69 Nicolson, 'What This Paper Stands For', p. 3; Allen, *The New Party and the Old Toryism*, p. 4.

70 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, p. 16.

71 Melville described the New Party as a 'centrum' in British party politics in his 'Political Upheaval' (p. 665) article for the *Fortnightly Review* published in May 1931.
72 For New Party and Nupa references to its politics as faith see Mosley, 'Two Issues Facing You', *Action*, 22 October 1931, p. 1; *idem*, 'Funks of the Labour Party', p. 1; P. M. M., 'Our Leader', p. 5; 'Random Reflections', *The New Times*, August–September 1932, p. 6; Waterman, 'A Little More Mussolini', p. 5.
73 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, p. 5; *idem*, 'Have We A Policy?', pp. 1–2; Drennan, *The BUF*, p. 43; J. Proctor, 'The Collapse of Individualism', *The New Times*, July 1932, pp. 4–5.
74 Mosley, *Unemployment*, p. 7; Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 11 July 1931; Harrison, *Peter Cheyney*, p. 209; *Manchester Guardian*, 26 August 1932. For an overview of the changing nature of anti-Semitism in Britain, see C. Holmes, *Anti-Semitism in British Society, 1876–1939* (London: Edward Arnold, 1979).
75 E. D. Randall, 'Perish Juda!', *The New Times*, August–September 1932.
76 Mosley, *The Greater Britain*, pp. 14–15.

Conclusion

1 *New Statesman*, 13 December 1931.
2 *New Leader*, 6 March 1931.
3 *Week-End Review*, 28 February 1931.
4 Mosley, *My Life*, p. 78.
5 See, for example, Allen, *The New Party and Old Toryism*, p. 2.
6 Mosley, 'The Philosophy of Fascism'.
7 Mosley, *My Life*, p. 98.
8 Strachey, *The Menace of Fascism*, pp. 158–9.
9 Drennan, *The BUF*, pp. 157–61.
10 Drennan, *The BUF*, pp. 157–61 and pp. 238–9.
11 Nicolson, 'Diary', 6 June, 4 August 1931 and 5 April 1932.
12 Nicolson, *Dairies*, 12 August and 11 December 1931; Skidelsky, *John Maynard Keynes*, p. 379. Keynes predicted that Chamberlain would take over from Baldwin and MacDonald, going so far as to suggest that a government 'with brains' would bring prosperity within ten years.
13 Worley, *Labour Inside the Gate*, chapter three. Although Labour's parliamentary presence was reduced to just 46 in October 1931, the party still registered a vote of over 6,000,000 (approximately 30 per cent of the electorate).
14 *Daily Worker*, 31 March 1931; *Birmingham Town Crier*, 8 May 1931; *The Stalybridge Reporter*, 17 October 1931; *Western Mail*, 27 October 1931.
15 P. G. Wodehouse's parody of the BUF – the Black Shorts – is perhaps the most famous example of this. See P. G. Wodehouse, *The Code of the Woosters* (London: Herbert Jenkins, 1938).
16 C. E. M. Joad, *The Horrors of the Countryside* (London: Hogarth Press, 1931).
17 Mosley, *My Life*, pp. 8–11 and p. 172.
18 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 2 March 1932. Nicolson and Barnes discussed with Eliot the possibility of compiling a collection of essays on modern politics.
19 Lawrence, 'The Transformation of British Public Politics', 185–216.

20 See such reminiscences as those collected in L. Wise *et al.*, *Mosley's Blackshirts: The Inside Story of the BUF* (London: Sanctuary, 1986); R. R. Bellamy, 'We Marched with Mosley: A British Fascist's View of the Twentieth Century', unpublished manuscript (Fascism in Great Britain Collection); Grundy, 'Don't Let Your Conscience Be Your Guide'.
21 Mosley, *My Life*, p. 303.
22 Ritschel, *The Politics of Planning*, p. 83.
23 Diston and Forgan, *The New Party and the ILP*, pp. 7–8; Joad, *The Case for the New Party*, pp. 9–13.
24 New Party reference to the empire also became more imperialistic. See Mosley, 'We Must Not Surrender', *Action*, 10 December 1931, p. 1.
25 Mosley, 'What Is Personal Liberty?', p. 1.
26 Nicolson, 'Election Will Annoy You', pp. 10–11; *The Courier and Advertiser*, 20 March 1931; *Sheffield Daily Telegraph*, 3 August 1931; *Daily Worker*, 31 August 1931.
27 Transcript of interview with Arthur Fawcett; Bellamy, 'We Marched With Mosley'; J. Brewer, 'The British Union of Fascists: Some Tentative Conclusions About Membership', in S. Larsen, B. Hagtvet, J. Myklebust (eds), *Who Were the Fascists? Social Roots of European Fascists* (Oslo: Universitetsforlaget, 1993), pp. 542–56; S. Cullen, 'The British Union of Fascists: The International Dimension', *The Historian*, 80 (2003), 32–7.
28 There is a far wider literature on the general failure of British fascism. For a good place to start, see the essays collected in M. Cronin (ed.), *The Failure of British Fascism: The Far Right and the Fight for Political Recognition* (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1996).
29 Nicolson (ed.), *Diaries*, 29 April 1931; B. Boothby, *Recollections of a Rebel* (London, 1978), pp. 80–1.
30 Mosley, *My Life*, pp. 264–5.
31 If the CPGB and ILP occupied a space to the left of Labour, then the small and fragile nature of the BF and IFL allowed room on the right.
32 The term is David Lewis's. See Lewis, *Illusions of Grandeur*, p. 12.
33 Worley, 'What Was the New Party', 39–63; ' H. McCarthy, 'Leading from the Centre: The League of Nations Union, Foreign Policy, and "Political Agreement" in the 1930s', *Contemporary British History*, 23/4 (2009).

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